when i watch the world burn, all i think about is you

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28400202.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Hordak (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Vampire, Alternate Universe - Adora Remains with the Horde (She-Ra), Horde Adora (She-Ra), Princess Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora (She-Ra) is a Dork, Adora and Hordak brotp, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Human/Vampire Relationship, role reversal??, adora redemption, no beta we die like adora and hordak, Horde Lord Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), just two vampire besties overthrowing the tyrannical leader of their kingdom through assassination, nothing too crazy

Language:
English

Stats:
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by dummysapphic

Summary

They point to a small table across the banquet hall with four people sitting at it. There's a muscular blonde woman with large purple veins covering her exposed arms, a pale man with blue hair and pointy ears, a woman wearing a long robe and a mask that covers her entire face, and a man with white slicked-back hair that goes down to his shoulders. All four of them have red eyes and very sharp fangs.

It's then that Catra hears Double Trouble speak again, "Those are the Horde representatives. They're all vampires."

Catra turns back to them, "What's the Horde? And what's… a vampire?"

OR: Catra is the Princess of Halfmoon and Adora is in the Horde. Chaos ensues.

Notes

Hello! This is my new AU that I've been thinking about for a while now! If you're here from my other fic, then welcome back! If you're new to my work, then I hope you enjoy this! The fic title is from doom days by bastille.

I want to clarify a couple of things before we get into this, though:

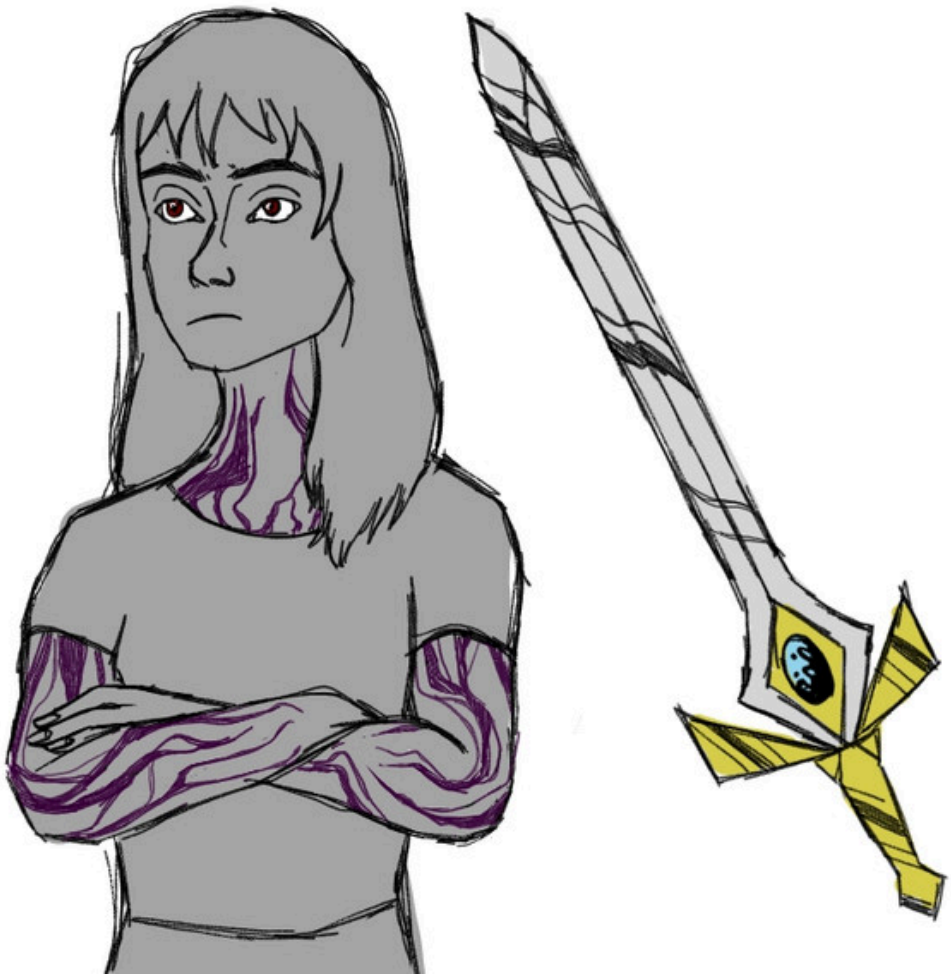
1. Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime will NOT HAVE redemption arcs. They might have a couple of nice moments where you might think it's going to happen, but it won't. Adora and Hordak will both have redemption arcs, though.

2. Every single character in this AU (except for Frosta) is above the age of 20. They are all consenting adults.

If you guys enjoy this, you could leave a kudo, a comment, or both! They're appreciated greatly and motivate me a lot to keep writing :)

my tumblr is @eloquentsapphic if you guys want to go check out what i post there (spoiler alert: it’s mostly lesbians and probably some sad poetry)

Oh! I also made some art for this fic! I'm better at writing than I am at drawing, so don't make fun of it too hard haha it's a very rough sketch. This isn't what Adora's wearing in this chapter, by the way.



gossip

Catra

The party guests filter into the room slowly as the night goes on. Most of them aren't particularly popular on Etheria, just attending for a night of fun.

Some of the guests' names, though, are known across the kingdoms. Due to their popularity among citizens, these people commonly fall victim to gossip. Some of the words whispered between guests are true, and some are completely off.

Three guests sit at a table and look around the large, elegant banquet hall. People from every kingdom have come to celebrate the new year in the kingdom of Salineas.

One of the guests, a green-skinned shapeshifter with a talent for acting, turns to one of their friends. "So, Catra. How are you enjoying the party so far?"

Catra, the Princess of Halfmoon, sighs, "I don't know. I mean, I just got here but it's pretty boring so far. I don't even know anyone here except for you guys and my parents."

As if on cue, Cyra and Milo Driluth, the Queen and King of Halfmoon, wave cheerily from their spot at their table across the banquet. Catra waves their way with an awkward smile.

The actor pats Catra's shoulder with a sly grin, "I can help with that, darling!"

Catra flashes them an incredulous look, "How are you going to do that? Nobody here even knows me."

This is the first party that Catra is attending and to say she's nervous is an understatement. Her parents are very… protective, to put it lightly. They rarely let her leave her kingdom in fear that

something will happen to their precious only daughter. She's only met the other princesses a handful of times. Scorpia, the Princess of the Scorpion Kingdom, and Double Trouble, a mercenary from the Crimson Waste, are two of her only friends. Well, Entrapta is too, but she's too busy conducting social experiments on the guests to socialize.

Double Trouble sighs, "Well, I can't get you to talk to people, but I *can* tell you everything I know about some of the guests."

Scopia joins the conversation, already intrigued, "Ooh, which guests?"

A grin reappears on their face, "Well, I do know a lot about the other princesses, and the Horde representatives, if you're willing to listen."

Catra groans and rolls her eyes at her friend's theatrics, "Fine. Tell us everything."

Scorpia scoots closer so she can listen as Double Trouble begins.

The first person they point to is a short, purple and pink-haired girl wearing a fluffy dress, "That is Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon. She's a bit spoiled if you ask me, and has a really high-pitched voice, but she's okay." They move their slender finger slightly to the left, "And that's Bow, her best friend. He's the Master Archer of Brightmoon and one of the best knights in the kingdom. He and Glimmer have been best friends since they were kids, but I doubt it'll be long before they're dating."

Catra raises a brow, "Really?"

Double Trouble nods, "Definitely. They're all over each other, way too much for two people who are *just friends*." They do air-quotes around the last two words.

"Oh, and that tall lady standing beside Glimmer is her mother, Queen Angella of Brightmoon," The actor adds.

They continue by pointing to a dark-skinned blue-haired woman who looks like she'd rather be anywhere but here, "That's Mermista, the Princess of Salineas. Her parents are hosting this party. She always looks bored out of her mind and has been known to be rude to guests who annoy her, but she's nice when she wants to be."

Their attention is brought off of the Princess by a man with a moustache singing loudly by her side. Double Trouble groans, "That, my friends, is Sea Hawk. Mermista claims that he's just her chauffeur, but everyone knows they're dating in secret. He loves to sing sea shanties, though, so watch out for that."

Catra can already tell she doesn't like Sea Hawk. Mermista, though, she could see herself being friends with her.

Double Trouble looks around the ballroom for a new person. Once they find one, they point excitedly, "Ooh, there! That's Perfuma. She's the Princess of Plumeria, and she might be the happiest person you'll ever meet. She loves meditating and all plants, but I heard a rumour that she absolutely hates cacti."

Catra laughs loudly at that, snorting slightly, "Cacti? Really? Where did you hear that?"

Scorpia blushes slightly, "Oh, I don't know, Wildcat. I think she's nice, even if she hates cacti."

Double Trouble shrugs, ignoring their blushing friend, "I never tell my sources, Kitten." Catra groans at the secretive response but lets them continue.

They hum as they search for another princess, "Hmm… You've already met Scorpia and Entrapta but… Oh! There, that's Princess Frosta of the Kingdom of Snows. There was a terrible accident with her parents a few years back so now she rules her kingdom by herself, with the help of her castle staff. From what I've seen, Frosta's a pretty strict ruler. She held Princess Prom a couple of years ago and the rules were *endless*!"

Catra frowns, “How old is she?”

Double Trouble looks over to her and, once noticing the look on her face, tones down their excitement at sharing all this information, “She’s eleven.”

Catra’s frown only deepens as she looks down at the intricate flooring. She could never imagine losing her parents at all, especially not at such a young age. She wonders how Frosta managed to keep going after losing her parents, how she manages to lead an entire kingdom without the people who raised her. Catra’s always had her parents with her. She can’t imagine a life without them by her side, guiding her in the right direction.

She’s brought out of her thinking by Scorpia’s voice, “Do you have any info on anybody else? You’ve covered all the Princesses.”

Despite not having any more princesses to gossip about, Double Trouble grins excitedly and claps their hands together, “Of course! I left the best for last, darlings.”

Catra looks back up at the eccentric actor, already curious as to who’s left.

They point to a small table across the banquet hall with four people sitting at it. There’s a muscular blonde woman with large purple veins covering her exposed arms, a pale man with blue hair and pointy ears, a woman wearing a long robe and a mask that covers her entire face, and a man with white slicked-back hair that goes down to his shoulders. All four of them have red eyes and very sharp fangs. Well, Catra assumes the masked woman has red eyes and sharp teeth underneath that mask. All of their fangs are definitely way sharper than Catra’s canines, though.

Catra’s brows furrow as she looks at the mismatched group. They all look absolutely miserable and like they’re about to drop dead at any moment. She’s never seen anyone who looks like them before.

It’s then that Catra hears Double Trouble speak again, “Those are the Horde representatives. They’re all vampires.”

Catra turns back to them, “What’s the Horde? And what’s… a vampire?”

Double Trouble laughs quietly, “How do you not know who the Horde are? And what vampires are? Have you been living under a rock?”

‘*No, I just have strict parents*,’ Catra wants to retort back. Instead, she blushes slightly and crosses her arms in embarrassment.

Double Trouble must know why Catra’s embarrassed as their chuckle dies off and they pat her on the shoulder, “It’s fine, darling. It’s much more fun if I tell you myself, anyway.”

Catra doesn’t get the chance to ask what *that* means before Double Trouble begins talking again.

“Okay, so the Horde is this group of vampires that are basically known for being bloodthirsty killers. From what I’ve heard, they’re all really disrespectful and love making people suffer. They don’t seem that bad when I talk to them but then again, the ones I’ve talked to seemed to like me. Oh, and vampires are people who are, essentially, dead. They don’t have heartbeats or any blood in their bodies. One way to recognize a vampire is by their red eyes or sharp fangs, which they use to suck all the blood out of people.”

Catra stays silent. Eventually, she regains her ability to speak, “Are you sure that’s not an over-exaggeration? That seems a little over the top.”

Double Trouble shrugs again, “That’s what my sources told me. And what they’ve told me themselves. ”

Scorpia looks over to the group, then back to her friends, “So, who are those four?”

Double Trouble seems to get excited at that, smiling, “Ooh, this is the best part.”

They rub their hands together in excitement. Then, they point to one of the vampires, “That creepy guy with the white hair is Horde Prime. He’s the ruler of the Horde. Apparently, he rarely actually kills humans. He gets his minions to do it for him so he never gets his hands dirty. Pretty lazy, if you ask me.”

They point to the other man sitting beside Horde Prime, “That’s Hordak. He’s basically Horde Prime’s minion. He just follows him around and does whatever he asks. He and Adora are pretty good friends, though. I heard from someone once that apparently, Horde Prime was experimenting on humans to try and make them into clones of himself, but the experiment failed and Hordak was one of the only results of it that survived."

Catra takes a closer look at Hordak’s arms and notices blue electricity-like marks covering his upper shoulders. She didn’t notice at first because they’re almost covered by fabric, but there’s a bit peeking out.

Double Trouble points to the next person at the table, the masked woman, “That’s Shadow Weaver. She’s really creepy and is always super condescending when she talks, as if she thinks she’s better than everyone else. She’s wearing that mask because there was this big accident hundreds of years ago that covered her face in scars. Because of her scars, she makes Adora do her chores for her, including killing any humans she asks her to. Oh, and she also uses dark magic.”

Catra pauses, “Wait, did you say hundreds of years ago? How old are those people?”

“Oh, did I forget to mention that? Vampires are immortal, meaning they never die. Everyone in the Horde is six hundred years old at the very least.”

Oh. Catra knows that Glimmer and her mother, Angella, are immortal but she's never heard of an entire kingdom of immortals.

Double Trouble continues nonchalantly, pointing to the now slightly smirking blonde, "Last but definitely not least is Adora Grayskull. She's the youngest person to ever join the Horde. It's rumoured that she's already killed at least ten thousand humans, though. Shadow Weaver's her mentor, but the two absolutely hate each other. I'm surprised Adora hasn't killed her yet."

Scorpia turns to look at Adora with a confused look, "So… what are those purple marks all over her arms? And those electricity-marks on Hordak?"

Double Trouble already seems to know the answer to that, "Oh, well there are two ways that a vampire is made. Either they're born as a vampire, like Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime, or they're killed and brought back, like Adora and Hordak. Shadow Weaver used dark magic to kill Adora, and Horde Prime used electricity to kill Hordak. There's this rumour that Adora used to be a really good person and some big hero on Eternia, her home kingdom, but then all the dark magic corrupted her and made her evil for the rest of eternity."

Catra scoffs as she looks at the blonde, "I don't know, Double Trouble. She doesn't look that powerful to me. Maybe your sources are wron-"

She trails off as Adora turns her head slowly to look directly into her eyes with a small smirk. As soon as her red eyes meet Catra's mismatched ones, she knows that the sources definitely aren't wrong. Any confidence that Catra has instantly vanishes under her confident gaze. Double Trouble laughs at her sudden nerves.

"Oh, I forgot to mention that vampires have heightened hearing. So, Adora definitely heard you say that. Hi, Adora."

The blonde gives them a small wave from across the banquet hall as her smirk widens. Catra gulps as her ears pin themselves to the

side of her head.

Scorpia looks over to Double Trouble nervously, “She’s not going to… kill us, is she?”

Double Trouble grins, “Well, that’s up to her, I guess.”

The three of them turn to look at Adora, who shakes her head slowly. Catra and Scorpia sigh in relief, while Double Trouble laughs loudly. The smirk on her face doesn’t leave, though, which only makes Catra more nervous. This whole situation seems to be amusing for Adora as she turns and says something to Hordak, who chuckles slightly.

Catra turns around and pretend to do something else as her brain replays what just happened over and over again.

Adora

She waves to the three humans from across the banquet hall with a smirk plastered to her face. This isn’t what she expected from this party, but it’s a welcome distraction from the boring conversations happening at the table. Humans really are so amusing sometimes, especially Etherians.

Hordak must see her waving as he asks with full curiosity, “Who are you waving at? We don’t talk to anyone outside of this table.”

Adora turns around to look at him, “Those three humans over there are gossiping about us.”

Hordak chuckles as he peers over to see the two very nervous women and one laughing lizard, “Was it accurate?”

Adora shrugs, “I don’t know, I wasn’t listening that well. All I picked up was ‘*bloodthirsty killers*’, so I’d say pretty accurate.” They laugh louder at the over-exaggerated rumour.

Their laughter is cut off by Shadow Weaver sighing, "Would you two stop gossiping about yourselves and *try* to act serious?"

Adora groans, "Would *you* just let us have some fun for once? We were just looking at the people attending this party, like that human over there." She points in the direction of Catra.

Shadow Weaver looks in the direction where Adora's finger pointed until she finds the hiding brunette. "That's not a human, Adora. She's a Magicat. Her name is Princess Catra of Halfmoon."

Adora raises a brow, "Really? She's a princess? Huh…" She looks back at the magicat again, noticing the fluffy cat ears and tail as she stares for a little too long to be considered normal.

Shadow Weaver's scolding voice cuts through her thoughts, "Don't even think about killing her, Adora. That would definitely start at least one war."

Adora whips her head around to look at her mentor, "Oh, come on! How do you know I was even planning to do that?"

The masked woman crosses her arms, "I know you too well, Adora."

This kind of bickering is extremely common between Adora and Shadow Weaver.

Adora mirrors her by crossing her arms, too, "Well, I wasn't. I was just looking at her, out of curiosity. Do you really think I'd be stupid enough to kill a princess?"

"Yes." The way she said it tells Adora that she definitely thinks Adora is *that* stupid. Hordak tries to stifle a laugh at the jab as Adora slides down her chair in annoyance.

She turns to Hordak, who is still grinning at the blonde, with a huff.

Adora shoves him a little too hard, "Oh, shut up."

fun

Chapter Summary

The Horde representatives attend a party held by the Queen of Brightmoon.

Adora decides to have some 'fun'.

Chapter Notes

Hello! I hope you guys enjoy this chapter! It's mostly just chaos and no plot, but still. This chapter basically just shows how the Horde characters act with each other and others.

If you wanted to know how the characters that are different from canon act, here's a helpful summary of each one:

Adora: Mommy issues multiplied by 2. Basically a 500-year-old with the brain of an angry, rebellious teenager. Reminds me a little of canon Catra.
Hordak: Just wants to get through the day, and make sure Adora doesn't get herself killed. He kinda gives me 'tired older brother' vibes.
Catra: Basically a nicer version of her canon-self. Loves her family a lot.
Glimmer: Spoiled brat with a heart of gold. Really doesn't like the Horde, though.
Double Trouble: Basically a more loyal version of their canon-self.
Bow: The best Archer in Brightmoon. Definitely has been in love with Glimmer for years now.
Adora and Hordak: The idiot sibling duo even though they aren't actually related by blood. It's a miracle they haven't accidentally blown up the Horde at this point, honestly.

And then everyone else is the same, I think.

Oh, and the technology in this AU follows canon. So no cars, and no phones. Think skiffs and tablets. This does have some Victorian era AU vibes to it, though.

Anyway, I hope you guys enjoy this! If you do, you could leave a kudo, a comment, or both! They are both greatly appreciated, and I read and reply to all the comments with a smile on my face :)

Ok, bye-bye.

TW: blood (Honestly, pretty much every chapter has blood in it. This is a vampire AU, after all. If that's a trigger for you or you just don't want to read about blood and/or violence, I would suggest either being cautious while reading this or not reading this at all. I'll still include the warning, no matter what, though.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The harsh sunlight shines through the large window in her bedroom. She squints her eyes open and sits up with a groan. Thankfully, the sun doesn't burn like it would for someone of her kind due to the ring she wears on her right hand. That doesn't make it any less annoying, though. Adora stands up slowly and checks the time on her clock.

Seven-forty five in the morning.

She groans again, louder, and looks into the aluminum mirror in her bedroom. Every other mirror in Etheria is made of silver, meaning that Adora can't see herself in it, but Hordak managed to figure out a way to make a mirror that works for them a few years ago. It was... strange, to say the least, when Adora first saw her reflection after hundreds of years of forgetting what she looked like.

Adora’s wearing a gray t-shirt over dark gray shorts that go down to the middle of her thigh and white socks. Her hair is a mess, and there are slight bags underneath her eyes. It’s way too early for this.

After combing her fingers through her hair, Adora leaves her bedroom and goes down one of the set of stairs which lead to the main foyer of the large house she lives in. As she descends the dramatic-looking staircase, Adora sees Shadow Weaver waiting at the bottom of the stairs and the front door open with Horde Prime and Hordak standing outside.

Shadow Weaver sighs as she looks at Adora’s outfit, “Is that what you’re wearing to the party today?”

Adora crosses her arms, “What party?”

Horde Prime answers instead of Shadow Weaver, “The Queen of Brightmoon is holding a small party for the leaders of each kingdom and a few others. Since I’m the ruler of the Horde, I am going and I have decided to invite you three as my humble guests.” Horde Prime never invites anyone as his ‘humble guests’ other than Hordak, Shadow Weaver, and Adora.

Adora turns back to Shadow Weaver, “Do I have to go?” She doesn’t bother trying to whisper since Horde Prime will hear her no matter what. He doesn't seem too offended, though.

“Yes.” It’s a simple response that doesn’t leave any room for argument. That doesn’t stop Adora, though.

“But why? What could I possibly miss at a party at Brightmoon? Some boring princess speeches?” The last party they went to, that party in Salineas, was only two or three months ago. These almost constant celebrations are getting annoying.

Shadow Weaver turns so she’s facing Adora fully instead of seeing her in her peripheral vision, “You’re going, no arguments. Besides, this will be a great opportunity for a good meal. Now, go change into something decent. You’re not going in your pyjamas.”

Adora thinks about it, despite knowing she has to go no matter what. She is pretty hungry right now, so maybe she could just kill one of the guards or something. She turns and goes back up the stairs, "Fine."

A few hours later…

Hordak stands alone near a wall as he looks at the person saying a speech on the stage with a bored expression. '*Looks like Adora was right about the boring princess speeches*," Hordak thinks glumly.

Speaking of Adora, Hordak hasn't seen her in a while. This is weird for the blonde since she usually just stands with Shadow Weaver at parties, but Hordak doesn't think about it too much. Adora is very capable of handling her problems.

As Hordak continues to look forward at the speaker, a quiet sound can be heard from the back of the banquet hall. None of the other party-goers notice due to their weak hearing compared to a vampire's sense of hearing. Not even Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime notice from their spot near the front. They're pretty far away, though, so it makes sense that they didn't hear the quiet sound. The only reason Hordak even heard it is because he's so far in the back of the banquet hall, so he's a lot closer to where the sound came from.

Hordak turns in the direction of the sound just as the speech ends, one of the doors that leads to a large hallway where all the washrooms are.

After a couple of seconds, Adora walks out of the door with a way-too smug grin plastered on her face. Soon after this, a brunette who looks to be in her early to mid-twenties stumbles out of the door with a blissful smile on her face. Adora waves goodbye to her before making her way over to her blue-haired friend.

Hordak crosses his arms with a sigh. Adora's going to be extra annoying today.

The blonde comes up to stand beside him with a grin on her face, "Hey! What's up, Hordak?" As she's waiting for a response, they hear a group of girls whispering and giggling near them. Adora turns to see the girl who just came out of the hallway door whispering with her friends, no doubt about what just happened there. Adora winks and gives them a small wave, which makes them blush and turn away to whisper more. Hordak rolls his eyes when Adora has her back turned to him.

When Adora turns back, he doesn't say anything, just glaring at Adora with a tired look in his eyes that reads '*Can you please shut up?*'

Adora crosses her arms, too. "Oh, come on! Why are you so grumpy today?" Hordak huffs at the accusation, "I'm not grumpy!" Adora gives him an incredulous look, which only works to put him in a worse mood.

"I'm just bored, is all. This party is terrible."

Adora looks around the banquet hall with a sigh. This party does seem a lot more disappointing than the one they went to in Salineas. She wonders if she can try to find that Magicat princess again. She turns to one of the mirrors placed on the wall and frowns when she can't see herself in it at all. A question she's been meaning to ask Hordak pops into her head again.

She turns to look at her friend, "Hey, how did you figure out how to make a mirror that works for us?"

Hordak seems surprised at the sudden change of subject, but answers anyway, "Oh, I just used aluminum instead of silver when making them. I got a lot of help from a… friend, though." He immediately regrets mentioning that last part when Adora gasps dramatically.

"You have friends other than me?!"

Hordak frowns as he looks at Adora, "Yes, I have other friends besides just you. Well actually, just one, but still."

Before Adora can say anything else, Horde Prime walks over and stands beside Hordak. "Oh, were you telling her about that princess that you've become acquainted with?"

Adora's jaw drops, "You're friends with a *princess*?!"

Hordak blushes slightly as Horde Prime continues for him, "Yes, he is. He talks about her all the time. Isn't that right, little brother?" Hordak doesn't respond.

Adora looks around the ballroom, "Oooh, which one is she?"

Horde Prime points to one of the princesses, "The one with the purple pigtails. Her name is Princess Entrapta of Dryl."

Adora looks around until she spots the purple-haired girl, "Aw, she's cute! Don't you think so, Hordak?"

Hordak blushes more and looks down.

Adora's smile turns mischievous, "I'm gonna go introduce myself." She quickly walks forward towards Entrapta. Hordak's head shoots up and, in his panic, he runs after Adora to make sure she doesn't say anything embarrassing about him. Adora reads Horde Prime chuckle loudly behind her as she moves.

The blonde smiles brightly when she reaches the princess, "Hi! My name is Adora. You're Princess Entrapta, right?"

The Princess looks over at Adora and inspects her for a second before shaking her hand strongly, "Hello there! Yes, I'm Princess Entrapta of Dryl. Are you with the Horde?"

That's a very blunt question, but Adora appreciates the straightforward question. Adora laughs, "Yes, I'm with the Horde, why? Is that a problem for you?"

Entrapta shakes her head, "Oh, no! I've actually been doing some really fascinating experiments about vampires with my friend-" Her sentence is cut off by the arrival of Hordak quite literally running into the conversation. Entrapta continues as if this interruption didn't phase her at all, "With my friend, Hordak, who just arrived."

Adora looks over to her friend who is still slightly out of breath from trying to run across a banquet hall without causing a scene. "Hordak! So great of you to join me and my new friend, Entrapta."

The Princess seems confused by Adora's words, "You two know each other? And you… you think we're friends?"

Adora elbows Hordak lightly on his arm, "Oh, Hordak and I? We're pretty close friends. I'd go as far as to call us *best friends*, even. And of course we're friends, Entrapta! If you want to be, of course."

Entrapta mumbles something into a recorder before looking back up at the two, "Fascinating. I didn't know that Hordak had a best friend. Also yes, I'll be your friend, Adora." Entrapta says that last part with a bright, excited smile.

Hordak pushes a grinning Adora off his arm with a huff, "Adora and I are NOT best friends! We're *acquaintances* at best."

Adora shoves him back, harder, "Aw come on, don't be like that. We've known each other for the past five hundred years, we're definitely not acquaintances. Just admit it, we're friends!"

Hordak pushes her again with a grumpy look on his face, "No, we're not, and stop pushing me!" Adora rolls her eyes and pushes back, "You stop pushing me first!"

They both push each other at the same time, trying to shove the other to the floor. It doesn't seem to be working, though, as the two are both just leaning on each other as they shove angrily while still arguing. They're not angry at each other, per se, but

they do both want to win. Entrapta watches in fascination as the two have a mini-fight in the middle of the banquet.

Their small pushing contest is abruptly ended a few minutes later by Shadow Weaver stopping Adora from pushing Hordak more by pulling her away. After Adora leaves and Hordak regains his footing after almost falling, he and Entrapta start talking.

Shadow Weaver lets go of Adora's arm when they're far enough away that no humans can hear them. Adora turns back to see Hordak and Entrapta talking with a proud smile, "Aww, look how cute they are."

Shadow Weaver sighs, "Are you done playing matchmaker now?"

Adora looks over and, once she sees the stern look on Shadow Weaver's face, turns around to face her fully, "Yeah, I'm done." It's obvious Shadow Weaver wants to tell her something important.

The masked woman points to a guard standing near a tall woman with large wings on her back, "That Brightmoon guard's shift is about to end. When she leaves, follow her outside and kill her where nobody can see you."

Now that Adora thinks about it, she is really hungry right now. Well, at least she won't be for long. Adora turns to her mentor with a grateful look, "Okay, thanks." Shadow Weaver nods.

Just then, the guard leaves the winged woman's side and leaves out the door which leads outside. Adora watches her leave, waiting for a few seconds before following her.

As Adora's walking towards the door, she hears Shadow Weaver's voice behind her, "Be careful!" She already knows that Shadow Weaver isn't referring to Adora's safety, but is telling her not to get caught and get the Horde in trouble. At this point, Adora knows not to expect Shadow Weaver to care about her at all.

Adora steps outside and immediately see the guard walking towards a skiff parked near the doors. This is way too much of an

open space to kill someone without getting caught. Adora sighs, knowing what she has to do.

She retracts her fangs and wills her eyes to turn back to their original blue-grey colour. It's a slightly painful process, but it's necessary for the situation. Adora walks up to the guard, acting scared.

Once Adora arrives in front of her, she forces her voice to sound shaky and afraid, "I need your help! A man just stole my purse and ran down that alley over there!" She points to an empty, dark alleyway beside the banquet hall. Nobody will notice her there.

The guard nods and the two of them run over to the alley.

The second that Adora and the guard are completely out of sight from anyone passing by, Adora pushes her against the wall. She finally extends her fangs back out as her eyes revert to red.

The guard's eyes widen at the sight, already knowing what the red eyes and fangs means, "Y-you're in the Horde?"

Adora grins, "Yeah. Surprise!"

The guard tries to get Adora to spare her. This proves to be difficult when she can't think of a reason for someone like Adora to not kill her, "Please, I have… I have a dog that I need to take care of!" It's a ridiculous excuse and they both know it.

Adora laughs, "You know, I've always been more of a cat person."

With that, Adora sinks her teeth into the guard's neck, already tasting the blood.

Adora walks back into the banquet hall, making sure there isn't any blood on her face anymore.

She feels a million times better than she did when she first arrived. The eye bags previously on her face have disappeared, and she looks like she's practically glowing. She takes a seat at the Horde's assigned table with a grin on her face.

Shadow Weaver looks up at her, "So, I take it the kill went well?"

Adora's grin widens, C'mon, when have my kills ever gone wrong?" Shadow Weaver chooses not to answer that, for Adora's sake.

Hordak looks over at Adora but then his eyes fall slightly downwards to her outfit with a smirk. He points to Adora's shoulder.

The blonde looks down at it to see a few drops of blood seeping into the silky fabric of her button-up shirt. "Aw, I got blood on my favourite shirt." Her shirt is a deep maroon colour and her pants are black, so any blood on her outfit isn't very obvious.

Shadow Weaver scolds her, "Don't be so reckless, Adora. You're going to get yourself killed if you're not careful." Adora knows Shadow Weaver is right. There are vampire hunters all over Etheria, waiting for an opportunity to strike. They usually don't target people in the Horde, though. Just lowlife vampires who are either too young or too weak to get into the Horde.

"You would love that, wouldn't you?" It's probably not a good idea for Adora to annoy Shadow Weaver like this, but she doesn't care. It's fun, and this party is boring.

"Yes, I would. At least then I wouldn't have to deal with your attitude."

Adora crosses her arms and leans back in her chair.

An hour passes before Adora can't take the boring conversations between Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime anymore. She turns to Hordak, "Hey, come on. Let's go." Due to her whispering and the

loud sounds in the background, Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime don't hear her.

Hordak turns his head to look at Adora, "Why?"

"Because I'm bored."

He has a conflicted look on his face, "Are you sure we won't get in trouble?"

Adora rolls her eyes, "Yes, I'm sure. Now, get up before I leave without you."

The blonde stands up. Shadow Weaver doesn't even glance over at her, too busy talking with Horde Prime about the most mundane things on the planet. Hordak watches their reactions, or lack thereof. Once he's sure it's safe to do so, he stands up. The two walk away from the table until they're out of earshot.

Hordak turns to Adora, now speaking in his regular voice, "So, what now?"

Adora looks around the banquet hall for something to do. After looking for what feels like an eternity, she finally spots something that will definitely be entertaining enough to pass by the time. She points to the bar located at the corner of the large hall with a mischievous smirk on her face.

Hordak follows where Adora's finger is pointing. His eyes widen when he sees what she's pointing at. He turns back to her with a nervous look on his face, "I don't know, Adora. That seems like a bad idea, and you *know* how easy it is for us to get drunk."

Adora does know how easy it is for them to get drunk. Due to vampires having practically no blood in their bodies, alcohol goes directly into their limited bloodstream and makes it so that they're wasted after a few shots.

"Yeah, but it would be fun," is the best argument Adora can come up with on the spot.

Hordak looks between the blonde and the bar, "I don't think Horde Prime would want me to be getting drunk at a party he invited me to."

Adora rolls her eyes again, "Aren't you tired of listening to Horde Prime, though? You've been listening to him for, what, five hundred years? I think he'll survive if you break the rules for once."

Hordak mulls this over. After a minute, he groans, "Fine, but if we get in trouble it's on yo-"

His sentence is cut off by Adora dragging Hordak across the hall to the bar by his arm. She has a determined and slightly terrifying look in her eyes as she leads the two of them to their demise.

This isn't going to end well.

Catra

She groans as her head drops down to rest on the table. `*This party is worse than the last one, and I don't even have Double Trouble to entertain me with gossip*,' Catra thinks sadly. Double Trouble decided not to come to this party, mainly due to the fact that this party is only intended for the leaders of each kingdom and a few guests. They knew this party would be boring and they spared themself the trouble. Catra wishes she had that option right now.

While Catra's moping at an empty table as her parents socialize somewhere else, Scorpia sits down in the chair beside her. "Hey, Wildcat!"

Catra jumps in her place but sighs when she sees her best friend, "Jeez, you scared me. You know, for someone so big, you really have a way of sneaking up on people."

Scorpia laughs, "Yeah, I've been told that before. Anyways, why are you sitting here so sad?"

Catra sighs, “This party is SO boring! Nothing exciting is happening, it’s just a bunch of old people talking about boring stuff like meetings and trading.”

Scorpia is about to reply when a loud giggle can be heard from nearby. Catra turns in the direction of the giggle to see a blonde and a blue-haired man stumbling towards them. Catra immediately recognizes them as Adora Grayskull and Hordak from the Horde.

Catra turns to Scorpia with a grin, “A couple of drunk vampires? This party is really starting to look up.” Scorpia looks nervous at the idea of interacting with Adora after what happened last time, “I don’t know if we should be talking to them, Wildcat.”

The brunette frowns, “Why not?”

Scorpia looks over at the two intoxicated Horde representatives to make sure they’re not listening in on their conversation. The two are currently arguing over whether the colour of a curtain on the wall is either lilac or lavender so… probably not.

“Because they’re evil! Everyone in the Horde is evil, but those two are like… the worst of the worst. They’re probably coming over here to kill you now. You heard Double Trouble yesterday, they’re bloodthirsty killers.”

Adora and Hordak finally make it to Catra’s table, both leaning on it for support. Catra and Scorpia turn to see what incredibly important piece of information they’ve come to tell them. Before Adora can say anything, she notices Shadow Weaver storming up to them with an infuriated look on her… mask.

Her eyes widen, and so do Hordak’s when he sees her, too. The two crouch down to hide under the table, but their legs give out and they’re both sitting on the floor now. They start laughing at their predicament as Shadow Weaver arrives.

Catra smirks, “So these are the bloodthirsty killers of the Horde?”

Shadow Weaver looks up at the Magicat with a scowl. How she manages to show that even with a mask on is a mystery to Catra. "Terrifying, aren't they," Shadow Weaver drawls out sarcastically.

Shadow Weaver looks back down at Adora and crosses her arms, "Are you drunk right now?" It's obvious she knows the answer to that question but wants to hear what Adora has to say for herself.

Adora looks up with the smug confidence of someone who definitely isn't totally hammered on a ballroom floor right now. She is somehow able to speak without stuttering or hiccuping once, which is a miracle in and of itself, "I don't know, *Mom*. Am I? Because I *thought* Hordak and I were having fun at the most boring party in the world, but I forgot that you have no idea what fun is. See, fun is when-"

Adora is cut off by Shadow Weaver's harsh tone, "I know what fun is, you imbecile." It seems like this whole predicament is giving Shadow Weaver a headache, as she brings a hand up to rub her temples from the open sides of her mask.

The blonde on the floor gasps theatrically, "You do?! Since when?"

Catra snickers, and Scorpia tries to hold in her laugh as best as she can. Shadow Weaver glances over at them and, upon seeing them trying to hide their laughter, sighs in annoyance. The masked woman grabs Adora by her wrist tight enough that Catra can see it reddening from here and drags her across the floor back to their table. The blonde waves animatedly to the two princesses from the floor as she's dragged away, "Bye, Kitty! Bye, Scorpion Girl!"

Catra and Scorpia laugh at the incorrect names, then look down at the almost-asleep Hordak on the floor in front of them.

Eventually, Horde Prime walks over to Catra's table and pulls Hordak up onto his feet. The blue-haired man is unstable on his feet, almost falling over again. Horde Prime wraps an arm around his shoulders and leads Hordak back to the table, too.

This boring party was *so* worth it just for this bizarre experience.

Chapter End Notes

No, I will not be telling you who was giggling when Adora and Hordak were stumbling to Catra's table. That will stay a mystery forever.

Also, HAPPY NEW YEAR!! I'm writing this at around 9 pm EST so I still have 3 hours before it's 2021. I hope it goes better than 2020, but I don't want to jinx it. So, I hope 2021 goes better for you than 2020 did :)

bye!

you can't force me

Chapter Summary

Adora has tried a lot in her life.

She's failed a lot, too.

Chapter Notes

Hello!! Ok, let me just start off by saying this chapter is DARK. Like just so depressing and heartbreaking. I made myself cry writing this. It's so sad and honestly really violent in my opinion. Please read the trigger warnings before reading this and make sure you're okay with them. I made the warnings really specific for this chapter so they're kind of a spoiler, by the way.

So I KNOW some people say that vampires don't breathe, but I disagree. If they didn't breathe, they wouldn't be able to speak (air needs to move past the voice box to work). So, that's why vampires can be choked in this fic.

Also, here's the ages of the Horde reps:
Adora: 561
Hordak: 643
Shadow Weaver: 926
Horde Prime: 2163

Oh, and a very tiny portion of this fic is inspired by THIS amazing Shera vampire AU fic so if you have any spare time I highly recommend reading it. Our fics are totally different, but some very tiny parts of this chapter are inspired by their fic.

I hope you enjoy this! A kudo, comment, or both are a great way to show your appreciation for this fic. I love the support this fic has gotten, even though I just started it, and any more support always makes my day!

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: choking (through magic), blood, violence, stabbing, beheading, death, torture

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Adora

Most of the night is a blur after she arrives back at her table. She hears Hordak sit down in the chair next to her, but doesn't turn.

Adora looks over at Shadow Weaver, "Why did you bring us back here? This party was just starting to get fun."

Shadow Weaver glares at her, "Your definition of fun always involves being a nuisance to me. You two aren't leaving this table until the end of the party."

Adora scoffs loudly, "You can't force me." She stands up while still wobbling slightly on her feet.

She's about to turn around and walk away when she feels all of the air leave her lungs. Adora looks back over at Shadow Weaver to see a small, dark purple circle of magic in front of the masked woman.

Adora *really* hates magic, especially sorcery.

She gasps for air, but it's no use. Adora continues trying to breathe, hoping it will work eventually. She sees spots in her vision and sits down with a shaking hand on her chest. Despite seeing Adora sitting down and still struggling, Shadow Weaver doesn't relent. The masked woman has used this spell on Adora a countless number of times, but it still hurts the same every time.

Hordak glances over at Adora worriedly then turns back to Shadow Weaver, "Come on, she's learned her lesson. Stop it, she's going to faint." Shadow Weaver doesn't stop. Instead, she makes the spell stronger. Adora gasps out louder at losing even more air as she raises a hand to her throat, desperately hoping it'll help.

She sends a pleading look to Shadow Weaver, hoping it'll make her end this.

A few seconds pass and Horde Prime sighs, "Alright, this has gone on for long enough. Let the girl go, Shadow Weaver." At Horde Prime's demand, Shadow Weaver finally puts her hand down, making the rune in front of her disappear.

Adora gasps out in relief at finally being able to breathe. She immediately begins coughing violently and leans her head downwards. A couple of guests look in the direction of their table at the hoarse coughing. The blonde bites back the snarky remark on her tongue, knowing it would just anger the masked women even more.

Adora spends the rest of the night sitting in her chair. There's no point in rebelling right now, it's just going to cause more problems for her. She and Hordak talk a little but it's obviously forced. It's difficult to talk when Shadow Weaver is sitting so close to them, waiting for Adora to screw up so she can punish her.

Adora already knows she hasn't received the worst of her punishment yet.

A few hours later...

Once the door of their house closes, Adora sighs. She turns to go up the stairs to her room, feeling exhausted from the night, but is stopped by Shadow Weaver's voice behind her.

"Where do you think you're going?"

Adora turns her head to look at Shadow Weaver over her shoulder, "To my room."

Shadow Weaver points to the stairs that lead downstairs, into the basement. "Did you really think you wouldn't get any punishment for your behaviour today?" She doesn't have to say the actual punishment for Adora to already know what it is.

The blonde turns fully and walks towards the basement stairs, "How long am I staying there?" Shadow Weaver thinks about this for a moment, "Ten days." Adora nods and forces herself not to groan at the thought of going ten days without any food.

Adora knows not to rebel right now. It would only end badly for her. Over the years of being hurt for rebelling in the smallest ways, Adora has learned when to fight back and when to just take what's given to her. Today isn't the day to fight back.

She descends down the stairs and turns to step into the small metal cell waiting for her. Adora sits down on the dirty, old mattress on the floor. The mattress is the only item in the cell since vampires don't need to use the washroom and she obviously isn't getting food any time soon.

Adora hears Shadow Weaver walk down the stairs, along with the clanging sound of keys. Shadow Weaver walks in front of the open door and closes it with a loud slam. As she's locking the door, she looks down at Adora with a disappointed look. "This is for your own good, Adora."

The blonde looks up at Shadow Weaver, "*Sure* it is." The sarcasm is practically dripping from her voice. Shadow Weaver turns and leaves up the stairs she came down from wordlessly, turning the light off when she does.

Adora shifts so she's lying down on the rock-hard mattress. There isn't a blanket, so she curls into a tight ball in hope that it'll warm her up. Due to there being almost no blood in her body, it doesn't.

It looks like this is where she'll be staying for the next week and a half.

Ten days later...

Adora awakens with a groan as she looks up at the bright lightbulb above her. She sits up on her mattress as Shadow

Weaver comes down the stairs with a ring of keys in her hand and something else Adora can't see.

Her time is up.

Shadow Weaver unlocks the door, but Adora doesn't move from her spot. Mainly because she doesn't know if she can walk without getting dizzy, and she doesn't want Shadow Weaver to see her in this weakened state. Adora's eyes have red veins coming out of them due to not eating for ten days, and she's exhausted. Sleeping on a rock for a mattress hasn't been very helpful, either. She's in an especially bad mood today.

Shadow Weaver throws a small bag of blood that looks like it's from a hospital onto the floor in front of Adora. "Drink that, then go get changed. Oh, and take a shower, too. You smell like a dead animal."

'Whose fault is that," Adora asks herself inwardly.

Instead, she slowly grabs the pouch and opens the spout. Despite how hungry she is right now, Adora doesn't drink all the blood in the bag in a rush. She takes her time, savouring the feeling of finally eating after ten days.

Just then, Adora remembers something Shadow Weaver said, "Where are we going?" Her voice is raspy from not talking for ten days and she practically has to croak out the question.

"Horde Prime and I are going to Halfmoon for a meeting to discuss undisputed land between our kingdoms. You and Hordak have to join us, but you won't attend the meeting."

Halfmoon is the closest kingdom to the Horde, so the two kingdoms regularly have meetings to discuss any issues that have arisen between the two. The meetings are… usually civil.

Adora squeezes the bag to get any more drops of blood from it. When nothing comes out, she stands up with a grunt, "Fine." She manages to walk past Shadow Weaver and up the two sets of

stairs to her bedroom without collapsing or shaking enough for the masked woman to notice.

She looks in the mirror of her room and sighs. The red veins around her eyes are still blatantly obvious to anyone who looks her way, her hair is full of dirt and knots, and her skin and clothes have a light layer of dirt and dust covering them. It looks like she was dug out of her grave moments ago.

With a sigh, she walks into the washroom and locks the door behind her. Adora undresses for her shower as she turns on the tap. She looks into the now slightly foggy mirror.

Most of her upper body is covered in the purple veins of the dark magic that killed her that fateful day over five hundred years ago. She tries not to think of that day too often, since she's not the only person that died that day.

Five Hundred and Forty-One Years ago...

Adora walked with her brother, Adam, and her parents, Randor and Marlena Grayskull, towards where someone reported a vampire.

Her family was famous for being the best vampire hunters in all of Eternia. They were known for their powerful swords that had just a touch of magic in them. While they're all very strong, Adora is known as the most powerful person in the family, having the most potential for success and the highest kill count. They were powerful and could defeat any vampire that came their way.

Well, almost all of them.

Adora turned to Adam, "Hey, what's this vampire's name, anyway?"

Adam grinned, "Light Spinner."

Adora laughed, “Wow, what a ridiculous name. Why do all sorcerers have such weird names, anyway?”

The twins laughed as their parents trailed behind them with smiles on their faces. The four of them didn’t usually go on missions together, but they didn’t really have anything else to do today.

The Grayskull family finally made it to the location. A dark, but small house in the middle of nowhere. *Classic* vampire hiding spot. Adora smirked, “This is going to be easy.”

Her mother scolded her gently, “Don’t get too confident, Adora. You never know what to expect with vampires.” She lifted a hand to gently ruffle her daughter’s hair, which made Adora laugh.

Adora smiled at Marlena, “I know, mom. I’ll be careful, okay?”

Marlena nodded and the four walked into the property. The door was wide open, which meant either the home was abandoned or this was all a setup. They had to check regardless since they couldn’t be certain.

Randor walked in first, then Marlena, then Adam, and finally, Adora stepped into the house. The group looked around the area. There wasn’t any dust on the surfaces, and the home definitely looked lived in. Randor walked over to a table in the kitchen where there was a cup of tea. He touched the small porcelain cup. His eyes widened when he felt heat coming off of the cup. Randor turned to his family, “Someone’s here.”

The four of them split up to go look for anybody in this house. Randor and Marlena checked the basement, Adam checked the rest of the first floor, and Adora went upstairs to inspect there.

In hindsight, splitting up while searching for someone dangerous probably wasn’t a great idea.

Adora walked slowly through the rooms upstairs, looking for anything out of the ordinary. She checked two of the rooms upstairs and found nothing. She stepped into the last room

cautiously, with her sword up and ready. The perfectly-blue gemstone gleamed brightly, even in the dark room.

She was about to leave the room after inspecting it carefully when the door slammed closed loudly, keeping her in the room. Adora ran towards the door and tried to pull it open to no avail. She was locked in.

Adora turned back around to look for who did it. As she was looking around in the dimly-lit room, a woman in deep purple robes and fabric covering half her face appeared out of thin air in front of Adora. Right before the woman could strike, Adora called out to the person closest to her.

“ADAM!”

The woman used a spell to hit Adora hard enough that she landed sitting on the floor, leaning on the wall to the left of the door. She then used another spell to restrain Adora’s hands behind her back.

Adora turned to the half-masked woman in front of her, who she assumed to be Light Spinner, “What do you want?”

Light Spinner stood over her, looking down at the blonde, “To see you dead.” It was then that Adora realized it was a bad idea to call Adam. Adora tried to keep on a brave face, “Why? We hurt someone you care about so now you’re angry? Big deal.”

chuckles slightly, “I think you misunderstood me. I don’t want you to die permanently, that would be too easy. I want to turn you into the very thing you kill every day.”

The dark sorceress crouched down in front of Adora, “You have been killing my kind for far too long, and I think it’s time someone gave you a taste of your own medicine.”

Adora’s eyes widened, “You-You can’t do that! You can’t force me.” She regretted saying that last sentence the moment it left her mouth.

The half-masked woman laughed darkly, “Are you sure about that?” She turned around, grabbing a cup and a small knife. Light Spinner placed the cup down next to Adora and cut her own hand open with the knife. Adora watched the dark, thick, almost-black blood drip down. Once the cup was filled to her satisfaction, she waved off the spell restraining Adora’s hands. Adora kept her hands behind her.

Instead of the restraining spell, Light Spinner cast a new spell that made Adora’s body feel like it was being electrified from the inside. With a flick of her wrist, Light Spinner forced one of Adora’s hands out from behind her back.

Shakily, Adora was forced to drink every last drop of blood in the cup. Once the spell wore off and Adora regained control of her hand, she threw the cup across the room with a loud clatter. It didn’t matter what she did, though. She was too late. Tears flowed out of Adora’s eyes, “No…”

Just as the cup clattered to the floor, Adam ran into the room, followed by Marlena and Randor. Quickly, Light Spinner cast the magical restraints back onto Adora’s hands. Once Adora’s family saw the state of her, they grew enraged at the dark sorceress in front of them.

All three of them pulled their swords out, ready to fight. Adam stepped forward first, “Don’t you *dare* hurt my sister.” Marlena and Randor stayed back, waiting to see how the fight would go.

What the three of them didn’t know was that Light Spinner was a sorceress *and* a vampire. This was their first time coming into contact with such a rare vampire. It's not often you find a vampire that uses sorcery. Especially one that practices dark magic. That kind of magic has been banned for years. They never thought anyone still used it.

They were wrong, it seems.

Light Spinner cast the same spell he cast onto Adora and sent Adam flying into the wall. It cracked slightly under the pressure. Marlena moved to go help Adam while Randor moved forward to attack Light Spinner. The dark sorceress pushed them both backwards, as well. The couple fell unconscious. Adora tried to call out for them, but it didn't work.

Light Spinner moved forward to stand in front of Adam. The blond tried to fight back, but he was too weakened. Light Spinner grabbed his sword from him. Adora's eyes widened at the sight.

"NO! PLEASE, DON'T," she screamed as loud as she could. Light Spinner looked straight at Adora as she plunged the sword into Adam's chest. Adora screamed again, begging Light Spinner to stop.

The dark sorceress moved towards Adora's still unconscious father. Adora tried again, "PLEASE! SPARE THEM!" Light Spinner grabbed Randor's sword and used it to chop his head clean off. Adora screamed louder at the sight of her dad's head rolling towards her. She'd started sobbing loudly at this point. It almost drowned out the sound of her entire family dying before her.

Light Spinner then walked in front of Marlena's unconscious body and grabbed her sword. Adora tried a different approach this time, "I'LL GO WITH YOU WILLINGLY! IF-IF YOU LET MY MOM LIVE."

The half-masked woman paused with the sword in her hand, "You will?"

Adora nodded as tears continued rolling down her face, "Yes, but only if you let her live."

Just as Adora was begging for her mother's life, Marlena opened her eyes slowly. Adora gasped at the sight, "Mom?"

Marlena opened her eyes fully as she looked around. Tears quickly pooled in her eyes and then fell down her cheeks as she looked at her dead husband and son. She looked back at Adora, almost relieved to see her still alive.

Light Spinner sighed, “You two get thirty seconds before I kill you, Adora.”

Adora didn’t even glance at Light Spinner, looking directly at her mom. Trying to memorize every single part of her.

Her smile. The way her eyes crinkled when she laughed. Her voice. Her hugs. Her soft hair. The way she could always make Adora feel better. When she’d ruffle Adora’s hair. Her laugh. How people always said Adora looks just like her. Her bright blue-grey eyes. The beautiful golden tiara she always wore on her head. The way she looked at her family with such love. When she would kiss Adora on the forehead as gently as she could. The way she would love so strongly and unrestrainedly.

Marlena crawled to where Adora was sitting and hugged her as tightly as she could, “I love you so much, Adora.”

Adora wished more than anything that she could hug her back, but her hands were still restrained, “I love you too, Mom. I don’t want you to leave.” Her voice cracked at the end.

Marlena ended the hug and placed her hand as gently as she could on Adora’s face. Adora leaned into the hand, knowing how much she’d miss this. “I’ll never leave you, Adora. I’ll always be with you. Be good for me while I'm gone, okay?”

Adora nodded with everything she could, “I will, Mom. For you. I promise.”

Tears were still pouring out of each of their eyes as they both tried to make their last few seconds together last as long as they possibly could.

Light Spinner walked over to stand behind Marlena, “Okay, time’s up.” She placed her hands on Marlena’s face as dark magic came out of her hands and into Marlena’s head.

Marlena held Adora’s hand from behind as she forced herself to say one last thing before she would forget her entire life, “I’ll

always love you.” Adora nodded and then, just like that, Marlena closed her eyes and fell backwards onto the floor. Her grip on Adora’s hand loosened.

Adora cried harder than ever as she looked at her mother for the last time. Sure, she’s not going to die, but she won’t even remember who Adora is. The woman in front of her isn’t her mom anymore. She’s a stranger.

Light Spinner sighed as she watched Adora cry, “Your time is up, too.”

Adora lifted her head up from where she was looking at her mom. She had a confused look on her face, but it soon turned into dread when she remembered what she agreed to.

Light Spinner definitely knew why she was terrified now, “You *do* still have to hold up your end of the bargain. Or I’ll have to kill the last family you have left. Is that what you want?”

Adora shook her head, knowing she’d burst into tears again if she tried speaking. Light Spinner stood up as Adora prepared herself for what’s coming.

No matter how much Adora could have prepared herself for what was about to happen, she never could have been ready for the unbearable onslaught of pain that hit her in the form of a huge beam of dark magic. A blood-curdling scream left her mouth at the pain, and she continued to hear herself scream throughout the whole process. She looked down at her arms to see large purple veins snaking their way down. She didn’t have to look at the gemstone on her sword to know that it was being corrupted just like she was. Eventually, the pain became too much to bear and Adora closed her eyes.

She knew she should have tried harder to fight back against her own death, but there was no point.

Adora died, and there was nothing she could do about it.

Present

Adora realizes then that she’s crying. She always does when she remembers that day.

With a shaky sigh, she wipes her tears and steps into the shower. The burning water feels nice on her cold, clammy skin. Adora’s thoughts quickly move from how nice the shower feels back to what it was like when she first turned.

She remembers trying as hard as she could not to kill anyone. Not to drink any blood. She asked if she could drink animal blood instead, but Shadow Weaver told her that it was toxic for vampires. She almost fell into a statue-like state because of how long she went without feeding.

She remembers crying the first time she had to kill someone, and Shadow Weaver telling her it’ll get easier with time.

She remembers getting punished by Shadow Weaver every time she showed compassion for any humans.

She remembers learning how to hide the crushing guilt that ate away at her whenever she thought about how many lives she's taken.

She tried to be good in the beginning. She tried with everything she had. But she couldn’t.

Adora tried to be good, but she failed.

She broke her promise.

friends

Chapter Summary

The Horde representatives pay a visit to Halfmoon.

Adora has a bad day.

One person makes her day infinitely worse.

Chapter Notes

Hello! I'm really sorry about not updating this as much as I'd like, I've been really busy with school and work and my mental health hasn't been doing amazing lately.

Regardless of my problems, I hope you guys enjoy this! This chapter mainly just talks about the friendship between Adora and Hordak and also talks about Halfmoon. I know we haven't seen a lot of Catra in this fic, but she does make a small appearance in this :) I PROMISE that Catra and the other princesses will be a main part of the story as of now!

Anyway, I hope you guys like this chapter! I actually like it a lot! If you do like this, a kudo, comment, or both are very, very appreciated. Seriously, your comments motivate me so much and they make me so happy.

Oh, and I know that in some vampire stories people want to be vampires and try to become one but in this story nobody chooses to be a vampire and it's a terrible fate.

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: slight violence

The rest of her shower is uneventful, except for some crying that Adora will deny she ever did.

She slides the glass door of the stand-up shower open and steps out, steam from her blistering hot shower following. Adora looks into the aluminum mirror and sighs. The red veins are still visible under her eyes and she has an almost permanent scowl plastered to her face. Paired with the large purple veins all over her upper body, Adora looks straight out of a child's nightmare.

She had hoped that the hot water would help to make her feel better, and it did, but it didn't make her look any better. Oh, well. Nothing she can do about it now. Might as well go get ready.

Adora wraps herself in a towel and walks back to her room, locking the door behind her. She doesn't really have to worry about Shadow Weaver while upstairs since the masked woman usually spends her time in the basement doing some kind of dark magic that Adora doesn't care to ask about.

She looks through her closet, which is exceedingly large given the fact that she's been the same size for the past five hundred years.

This is just a meeting, so she won't dress fancy. It's not like anyone will see her, anyway. She and Hordak will likely spend the time wandering around Halfmoon and scaring strangers for fun.

Adora takes out a grey hoodie and black sweatpants. Halfmoon is known for being a bright and sunny kingdom, and Adora already knows that the sun is going to irritate her. She makes sure to grab a pair of sunglasses while she gets changed, too.

After getting ready and doing her best to look 'presentable', Adora goes downstairs. She is greeted by Shadow Weaver standing by the door expectantly, as if Adora is going to make them late.

Shadow Weaver glances at Adora with a look that has an equal mix of smug superiority and disgust in it, "You look terrible."

Adora rolls her eyes, “I’ve eaten once in the past ten days. This is the best you’re getting.”

Shadow Weaver seems annoyed by Adora’s attitude but doesn’t argue for once, “Fine. Let’s go, we’re going to be late.”

Halfmoon is exactly what Adora expects from the kingdom.

She doesn’t come often, but when she does she’s greeted by familiar sights.

Magicats. The bright sun glaring down at her. The friendly King and Queen. An almost odd amount of regular cats. Halfmoon Palace. Street vendors selling huge varieties of meat. Fluffy, pointy ears. Tails. Sharp canines that are just a smidge shorter and duller than a vampire’s fangs.

Really, she should be grateful for their friendliness towards the Horde. Every other kingdom either looks down at vampires with disgust or is terrified of them. Rumours of the cruel monsters with razor-sharp teeth and a thirst for blood have scared off the rest of Etheria from the Horde. Except for the Magicats. They never seem to look at the vampires with fear *or* disgust.

Maybe it’s because the Horde and Halfmoon are the only two kingdoms that are made up of non-humans. Maybe it’s because the citizens of Halfmoon understand what it’s like to be shunned because of something they don’t have any control over. Maybe it’s because the citizens of Halfmoon understand what it’s like to scare humans away because of their sharp teeth and ‘unnatural’ eyes. Maybe the Halfmoon citizens just pity the vampires of the Horde who have been forced to spend the rest of eternity surviving off the blood of humans.

Whatever the reason is, Adora is grateful for one kingdom that at least tries to understand the Horde.

Adora and Shadow Weaver walk into the palace, finding Hordak and Horde Prime almost instantly. The four of them actually blend in exceptionally among the Magicats, who primarily wear darker shades of clothes. Well, the three of them do. Horde Prime is dressed in a stark white and grey outfit that even has a cape, so he stands out like a star in the darkness of the universe.

Horde Prime turns to them and smiles. Adora never liked his smile, she finds it creepy. The long-haired man strolls over to the two women, "Ah, so glad you two could make it. I would start some small talk but we have a meeting to attend. Shall we?" He points his arm in the direction of the meeting room doors, where the sound of shuffling chairs and muffled conversations can be heard from inside.

Shadow Weaver turns to Adora, "Meet back here in two hours. Don't break anything, and at least *pretend* to be happy that you're here instead of in a cell."

Adora holds back a groan of annoyance, "Fine. Have fun at your meeting." Her snarky tone lets Shadow Weaver know that she couldn't give two shits about what happens in the meeting.

With that, Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime turn and open the doors, entering the meeting room and joining in on the conversations.

Without saying a word, Adora walks in the opposite direction she came in from. Hordak follows with a slightly guilty look on his face. The two walk in silence until it's broken by the blue-haired man's voice.

"What was the punishment this time?"

Adora sighs tiredly, "A week in the cell with no food."

Hordak sucks air through his teeth, "Really? For getting a little drunk at a party?"

Adora nods with a blank expression, “Yup. I guess Shadow Weaver was in an especially bad mood that night.”

It’s a wonder how Hordak is always surprised to hear what new and cruel punishments Shadow Weaver gives Adora for just being happy, despite having heard all of these methods countless times over the past five centuries. Every time Adora gets an especially harsh or painful punishment, Hordak does everything he can to get Adora to feel better about it. Sometimes Adora does feel better, and sometimes she doesn't. Either way, Adora couldn't be more grateful to have a friend as good as Hordak for as long as she has.

The two continue walking in silence, but it’s not awkward or uncomfortable. They continue walking until they reach an outdoor garden. Usually, they would keep going until they got to a town and then start annoying strangers with harmless pranks. It’s funny and makes sure nobody gets hurt. Today, though, Adora isn’t up for that and Hordak knows this.

He turns to a large bench, “Hey, wanna go sit down?”

Adora glances over at the chair, grateful for a break for her tired legs. The two make their way to the bench and sit down swiftly. They look forward to the view in front of them.

Large bushes covered in colourful flowers wrap around a small field of freshly-mown grass that lays in front of them. The roofs of neighbouring houses peek over the horizon and some smoke from some chimneys can be seen flowing into the air. To Adora and Hordak, this type of weather would be considered warm and sunny. To the Magicats of Halfmoon, who have adjusted to the sun and heat of their kingdom, today is a brisk and chilly day.

Adora feels her eyes drooping closed slightly as she looks forward. Being starved for ten days isn’t exactly *amazing* for stamina. The almost overpowering fatigue has been near-impossible to fight, and she knows she won’t be able to keep her eyes open for much longer.

Hordak glances over and, upon seeing her half-closed eyes staring at the horizon, frowns in guilt. If he hadn't agreed to go along with Adora's plan, she wouldn't have been starved for a week and a half. He should've looked out for her more.

"Adora," he says quietly enough for her to hear.

Adora turns to look at him groggily, forcing her eyes to stay fully open. It's obvious she's trying as hard as she possibly can to avoid looking weak in front of Hordak, which only makes the blue-haired man's frown deepen. He hoped that, after knowing each other for over five hundred years, Adora wouldn't be afraid to show weakness in front of Hordak.

Hordak nudges his shoulder up, "C'mon, take a nap. I'll wake you up when we need to leave."

The blonde sighs, "Is it *that* obvious I'm tired?"

Hordak laughs. "Yes. You look a lot more than just *tired*, though. You look like you've just woke up from a hundred-year coma."

Adora groans as she leans her head down to rest it on Hordak's shoulder, scooting over so she's comfortable. Her eyes immediately flutter closed as she sighs again, this time in relief at the chance to sleep.

The comfortable silence washes over them again. Hordak continues watching the horizon as Adora dozes off on his shoulder. He thinks she's fallen asleep when he hears Adora's voice again after a few minutes of silence. It's a shaky whisper, but it's there.

"You're a really good friend, Hordak. I don't know what I'd do without you."

He's definitely worried about the shake in her voice as she says this but doesn't mention it, worried it'll only make her feel embarrassed. Instead, he glances down to see Adora's red-veined eyes glistening with unshed tears as she forces herself not to cry.

Hordak wraps an arm around Adora. He places his hand on the side of her arm, pulling her in tighter to show his support. He slides his hand up and down gently to try and make Adora feel better, "I have been looking out for you for the past five centuries, and I will continue to do so. We *are* friends, aren't we?" He already knows the answer to that last question but asks anyway in the hopes that it might make Adora laugh.

Hordak feels Adora grin on his shoulder more than he can see it, "Hey, I look out for you, too! And yes, we *are* friends."

Before Hordak can say anything, Adora yawns loudly, "As much as I would love to continue this conversation, I'm really tired right now. I'm just gonna take a little nap, okay?." Her voice trails off slightly at the end as her eyes close again and her breathing slows down.

It astonishes Hordak how quickly Adora can fall asleep, but he chooses not to question it. Instead, he chuckles and looks back at the horizon.

One hour and forty minutes later…

Adora is woken up by Hordak shaking her shoulder to get her to wake up. She groggily opens her eyes and squints at the still intensely bright sun above them. She lifts her head to look around, then turns back to Hordak.

"What is it?"

Hordak stands up, outstretching a hand for Adora, "We have ten minutes to get back to the meeting spot before Shadow Weaver sends the guards."

It's at that moment that Adora remembers why they came to Halfmoon in the first place. She grabs Hordak's hand and uses it to pull herself up. The two friends quickly make their way back in through the palace.

Any guards who see them on their walk seem to instantly move out of their way. Adora knows this is because of her less-than-optimal state right now.

Her eyes are puffy from just waking up and holding in her tears from earlier. That, paired with the red veins coming out of her eyes and the few purple veins peeking out from the top of her hoodie, makes her look very intimidating to anyone who sees her. The fact that she's still in a terrible mood, which definitely shows on her face, doesn't do wonders to make her and Hordak seem friendly, either.

At this point, her patience is hanging on by a thread. If anything even remotely goes wrong, all of Adora's pent up anger from the past ten days will explode out.

They're almost to the meeting room when the Princess of Halfmoon turns down the hallway Adora and Hordak are in, going the opposite way of them.

Looks like something's about to go wrong.

Catra doesn't seem to notice Hordak, but one of her eyebrows raises at the state of the blonde vampire.

Catra stops directly in front of Adora. That's the first mistake she makes.

She crosses her arms as a smirk makes its way onto her tan face, "Woah, what happened to you?"

Adora glares up at the Magicat, but Catra's only reaction is the twitch of her ear. "Get out of my way, Princess."

Catra frowns at the nickname, "If anyone's being a princess right now, it's you. What makes you think you can order me around like that, huh?" Calling Adora a princess is Catra's second mistake.

The blonde's gaze hardens, "Get out of the way, *please*." It looks like adding that last word physically strained Adora. Hordak

glances nervously between them. He's about to stop this from progressing any further when Catra speaks up again.

The Magicat's smirk only grows, "Maybe if you ask nicely, I will." Saying that was her third, and final mistake.

Adora practically roars in anger as she grabs Catra by her neck and pushes her into the wall beside them hardly. Any smug superiority that Catra had vanished as she panics at the sudden attack. Hordak's eyes widen at the motion but he doesn't move from his spot, knowing better than to interrupt Adora at a time like this.

The vampire tightens her grip, "I said get out of my way, mutt. Or did you not hear me?" Catra gasps for breath slightly.

Catra's eyes are wide as they plead with Adora to let her go. She scratches her claws up Adora's arms, but Adora doesn't show any signs of a reaction.

Apparently, Adora has had enough of Catra as she pushes her to the side roughly. The Princess lands roughly on her bottom as she coughs hoarsely. Bruises can already be seen blooming on the skin of her neck. The entire time, she continues staring up at Adora with eyes wide in fear.

Adora sneers at Catra as she turns and walks away angrily. Hordak turns back to Catra with a pitying glance. He extends a hand out towards the Magicat, "I am sorry for my friend's behaviour, she's not having a very good day." Just by his tone, Catra can tell he doesn't really care about whether or not she's okay.

Catra smacks his hand away from her and runs on all fours in the opposite way.

Hordak is shocked by the reaction for a moment, before relaxing his expression and running to catch up to Adora.

Adora is still stomping her way towards the meeting room doors when Hordak finally reaches her.

Hordak grabs her arm to stop her before they get to Shadow Weaver. Adora whips her head around, anger still in her eyes, and glares at Hordak, “What?”

“You need to calm down, or else Shadow Weaver will know something’s up. I don't think you want her to know you just attacked a princess.” He tries to keep his expression as calm as he can so that Adora can do the same.

Just like that, the anger burning in Adora’s eyes goes out just as quickly as it came. She nods and drops her head, “You’re right.”

The two stand there as Adora slows her breathing down to a calmer level. Hordak tries to get her to take deep breaths.

As the adrenaline of the moment passes, immense guilt replaces it. Along with fear.

What if the kingdom of Halfmoon rejects the Horde because of Adora’s actions? What if the Horde loses the only kingdom that supports them in the slightest? What if she seriously hurt Catra? What if Catra hates her now, just like all the other princesses do?

While Adora has killed and hurt thousands upon thousands of people in her centuries of existence, she’s never once hurt a princess. There's too much at stake by doing something that reckless. Adora knows that.

Or, she usually does...

Adora just choked Catra, the Princess of Halfmoon.

Halfmoon, the only kingdom to even remotely accept vampires.

And she just choked their leaders’ daughter.

She *really* fucked up this time, huh.

no matter how hard she tried

Chapter Summary

Adora makes a friend and takes another nap.

Catra is bored.

Chapter Notes

Hello! This chapter gives some backstory for both Adora and Catra but doesn't really have any plot in it. Sorry! I promise the next one has a plot and other princesses. Also, there is a Hordak-centric chapter somewhere in the future.

Despite not having much plot, this chapter has everything! Fluff, humour, angst, hurt/comfort, the whole gist! I realized I don't talk a lot about Halfmoon or how Catra grows up a lot in this fic, so I added a lot of information about her in this. I know that big info dumps are generally frowned upon in writing, but I don't really care. So, enjoy my paragraphs of information.

I think I'm going to start updating every Sunday/Monday, by the way.

I hope you guys enjoy this! If you do, you could leave a kudo, a comment, or both! They are so, so appreciated and I love reading everything you have to say.

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: mentions of killing/violence, mentions of bullying

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The guilt of what she just did seeps into her, but she conceals it well. She’s had over five hundred years of practice, after all.

Adora and Hordak continue walking in silence until they reach the tall double doors on the meeting room, which should open right now. The doors remain closed, almost as if they're taunting the two vampires in front of them.

Hordak turns to the guard posted in front of the doors, "Isn't the meeting meant to be over by now?"

The guard turns and, upon seeing an annoyed Adora and Hordak standing in front of him, stands perfectly straight. Despite trying not to show it, the guard is obviously a little afraid. It's rare that vampires ever come into the castle.

Adora sighs, having seen that scared look far too many times for it to bother her anymore, "Come on, we don't have all day." Her red-veined eyes only make the guard more frightened.

The guard stammers, "Uh- The meeting was pro-prolonged for an issue between our kingdoms."

Both Adora and Hordak groan loudly, annoyed. The guard shrinks down, worried they're going to kill him for the inconvenience. He's heard the rumours of how cruel the vampires of the Horde are.

He tries to help, "You-you are welcome to use our recreation room. It is open to all visitors of Halfmoon Palace." The guard points in the direction that leads to the room. Adora crosses her arms and walks down the hall the guard pointed to.

Hordak grins at the guard but stops when he remembers that his fangs might freak the guard out more. Instead, Hordak opts to nod formally towards him, "Apologies for my friend. She is having a *bad day*, to put it lightly." The vampire almost seems amused at Adora's behaviour.

The guard nods stiffly as Hordak follows Adora down the hallway wordlessly.

Adora

The doors all look the same as she storms down the halls. She wasn't angry at that guard, but she's definitely angry at herself right now. *How could she be dumb enough to hurt a princess?*

She hears quick footsteps behind her but doesn't turn, already knowing who it is. Eventually, Hordak appears behind her with an amused grin on his face. It's clear that he thinks this whole situation is *funny*.

Adora glares at him as they walk. Hordak's grin doesn't disappear. If anything, it widens at Adora's embarrassment.

After a while, they finally find the rec room and open the door. There are a few comfortable couches placed around the room, a pool table, a regular table with some chairs, and paintings on the dark burgundy walls.

Adora walks in first and immediately sprawls across one of the wider couches dramatically, her legs hanging off the edge. She groans as she covers her face with her hands.

Hordak laughs and sits down in one of the single couches across from the one Adora's currently lying on. "I don't understand why you're so upset about this, Adora."

Adora's hands on her face muffle her voice, "I hurt a *princess*, inside her own palace! What if she tells her parents? What if they start a war with the Horde? Oh man, if Shadow Weaver finds out, she'll *kill* me. What if Shadow Weaver finds o-"

Hordak cuts her rant off by laughing loudly and raising a hand to stop her from spiralling any further, "You didn't hurt her that badly, Adora. She might be a little shaken up, but she's fine. Besides, I don't think Shadow Weaver would be that upset. She doesn't like any of the princesses, and all she told you was to not *kill* one. You didn't, so she has nothing to be angry about."

Adora wants to refute that last part with the fact that Shadow Weaver has gotten angry at her for no reason many times, but

she decides not to. In fact, Hordak's words do actually make her feel a little better about the whole situation. Only a little, though.

She peeks an eye out from between her fingers, "Was she really fine after I choked her?"

Hordak nods, "Yes. She didn't even accept my hand to help her up, so she's probably doing alright."

Adora sighs in relief and takes off her hands, "Okay, that's good." Most of the guilt has disappeared by now, but she can still feel a tiny part of it nagging at her. Adora keeps remembering Catra's terrified face as she looked up at Adora, bruises blooming on her neck.

She hasn't felt this guilty for her actions in years. It's weird, but… she doesn't hate it. Feeling guilty is better than not feeling anything at all.

Adora shudders as she remembers the first couple of decades after Shadow Weaver turned her.

At first, she was terrified to kill anyone and always felt immense guilt at her actions, but that changed quickly as her anger at Shadow Weaver grew more and more each day. She tried not to let her anger get the best of her, but it was no use. No matter how hard she tried, she couldn't. Maybe it was because of her vampire nature, or maybe she truly is just a terrible person. She hopes it was the former, but she knows it's the latter.

She was so furious at having her life ruined and took her rage out on innocent Etherians. She killed anyone in her sight. It was basically a decades-long killing spree. She used her seemingly unlimited amount of anger at Shadow Weaver to kill as many humans as she could. Adora must have killed hundreds upon hundreds in just those years. It's not like she was counting, anyway. It was fun while it lasted, but all of that killing got boring after a while and Adora slowed down over the years. Now, she

mostly just kills when she has to or when Shadow Weaver tells her to kill someone specific.

She used to kill and kill and kill without a care in the world, driven only by the anger burning in her heart. Over the years, that anger went from a roaring fire to a small pile of smouldering ashes. The fire used to warm her frozen and cracked heart. Now that the flame has gone out, though, all she's left with is a heart that's charred black and crumbling apart. Now that the anger has simmered down, guilt has replaced it.

Adora's glad it has, though. She'd take guilt over anger any day of the week.

She's brought back to the present by the same guard from before appearing at the door, looking slightly less anxious than before. Hordak and Adora turn towards him, hoping they can finally get out of here.

"The meeting has ended. Horde Prime has requested that Hordak leave with him to handle an issue in the Fright Zone, and Shadow Weaver has requested that Adora stay here and wait for her to finish handling a sorcery issue with the Queen of Halfmoon."

Adora groans loudly, and her response is quick, "Well, I request that Shadow Weaver shut the fuck up for once." She hopes the guard didn't hear that, but he did.

The guard turns towards her, "Shall I tell her you requested that?" He seems genuinely curious, and not like he's joking with Adora. Hordak laughs as Adora panics, "No! Don't tell her I said that."

Hordak stands as the guard leaves and Adora complains while outstretching her arms in Hordak's direction, "No, don't leave me here. Who am I supposed to talk to now?" Her tone sounds like a child who's been told they can't have candy for breakfast.

Hordak grins, relieved to have something to do today, "Oh, come on. Don't be such a baby. You'll be fine, and Shadow Weaver

probably won't take that long, anyway." Adora drops her arms and groans again, quieter.

Before Hordak can leave, a medium-sized cat with mauve skin and a blue mane struts into the room like they own the entire palace. The cat walks up to the couch Adora is lying on and, before Adora can react, the cat jumps onto her stomach as the blonde lies there in surprise. This must be the cat's usual napping spot because they did not even hesitate to walk directly towards Adora and nap on top of her.

Hordak chuckles at the feline, "See? You can talk to the cat." Without another word, Hordak leaves out the door.

Adora peeks down at the cat and notices they're not asleep yet, just staring back at her with their vibrant blue eyes. It almost looks like they're looking for something on Adora's face as they stare blankly. Their eyes remind Adora of her own eyes from when she was still human. She notices a tag on the cat's neck and, upon inspection, figures out the cat's name.

She grins sleepily, still feeling tired, "Hello, Melog. That's a very nice name. How are you today, Melog?" She pets their ear and they purr loudly. Adora knows she looks insane talking to this cat, but she's sleepy and just a little delirious from having an inadequate amount of blood in the past ten days. The dull vibration coming from Melog's purring definitely isn't helping her stay awake right now.

Melog meows loudly, annoyed despite Adora's petting. The blonde knows that if this cat could speak, they definitely wouldn't be responding to her question. If she had to guess, Melog would probably say something like, "Shut up and go to sleep already."

Adora's grin widens as she watches Melog sleepily close their eyes and fall into a quick slumber. She listens to their advice and closes her eyes with her hand still on the cat's head. Almost instantly, she falls asleep with them.

This cat must have some healing properties or something because Adora hasn't fallen asleep that quickly and calmly in centuries. Whatever the reason, the blonde vampire is grateful for the relaxing slumber.

Catra

She looks in the mirror again, inspecting the bruises on her neck for what feels like the millionth time.

Since she didn't ice them, the bruises have only gotten darker and more prominent. Catra sighs as she grabs a tight high-neck two-toned maroon shirt with no sleeves and puts it on. It's not cold outside, and she won't leave the castle today, so she should be fine without the warmth of sleeves. At least it covers the bruising.

Catra leaves her bedroom and strolls around the castle with no real purpose. She has nothing planned for today, so she can spend it however she wants. Catra knows that Adora and her mentor are still here, so she tries to think of something to do that doesn't involve seeing either of them.

The best idea she can come up with is hanging out with her telepathic, magical cat named Melog. They're an extremely rare kind of cat that Catra was lucky enough to find one day while walking in the Whispering Woods as a kid. The second that Catra met Melog, the two formed a powerful bond and have been inseparable ever since.

Their kind is so rare, in fact, that Melog is the last of their kind. There used to be hundreds of their kind scattered all over Etheria, but the people of an old kingdom called "Horde Legion" hunted them all down until Melog was the last one standing.

The mauve-coloured cat has many magical abilities. They can read the emotions of others, turn invisible, change the colour of their mane based on Catra's emotions and their own, speak to Catra through their special bond, and they can also shape-shift.

They also share a strong connection with the Magicat princess, which connects them emotionally and allows them to communicate telepathically. Catra likes that she has someone that can relate to her about magic.

Every Princess has magic, and that includes Catra. While she doesn't have a runestone, she still has a magical ability just like the rest of the princesses and princes of Etheria. Catra's magical ability is the power of shape-shifting, like Melog. Unlike Double Trouble, Catra always keeps one of her features when she shape-shifts. No matter what she shape-shifts into, Catra always keeps her teal and yellow mismatched eyes. Her mother has the same magical ability as her.

Shapeshifters aren't exclusive to the Halfmoon royal family, as shown by Double Trouble. While there are other shapeshifters on Etheria, none of them have the cat-like features of Catra and Cyra of Halfmoon that can be incredibly useful in fights. Not that Catra can ever use her abilities, since her mom doesn't allow her to train, and only lets her leave the palace for parties and events.

Catra doesn't talk to the other princesses, or anyone, often. Sure, she hangs out with Scorpia and Entrapta frequently, but that's about it. Either the princesses don't know Catra exists because of how little she leaves her kingdom, or they don't talk to her unless it's a short small-talk at events.

She's tried talking to them, but she's never been very good at talking to people. Having grown up homeschooled and only having a telepathic cat and her parents for company, Catra never developed the social skills that the other princesses have.

She went to actual school at first, a really nice one in Brightmoon, but all the other kids made fun of her for her fluffy ears and tail. She tried to make friends, but it was no use. No matter how hard she tried, she couldn't. All they saw was a weird cat girl with a stupid power. Once Queen Cyra and King Milo saw their daughter come home crying from school every day, they kept her in the palace for school.

Catra's sure that they all hate her, thinking she's weak because of her useless magic. Or maybe they just think she's weird and don't want to talk to some half-animal freak. Whatever the reason, Catra's stopped trying to be friends with them, knowing how much they would hate someone like her. A freak with a useless magical ability like her.

Catra's pretty good at shape-shifting into anything she wants, but she usually only shape-shifts into a regular cat to play with Melog and run down the halls.

She decides not to shift as she walks down the halls.

What she does decide to do is use her telepathic connection to Melog to see where they are. Catra stops and closes her eyes. She can feel that Melog is relaxed and content, which usually means they're napping in a peaceful spot. She sighs, already knowing which spot they're in. Melog has this specific spot on one couch in the rec room that they love napping in.

Catra makes her way towards the recreation room, which she's already pretty close to.

She abruptly stops at the opened door of the room. Melog is in their spot, but there is a specific person in that spot with them. A specific person who hurt her just an hour ago.

The person who choked Catra and threw her to the ground…

… is now having a cat nap with Melog.

Catra slowly walks into the room, tiptoeing. She stands in front of the couch, watching the two of them sleep peacefully. Catra almost feels bad for disturbing Melog right now. Almost.

Instead of speaking, she yells at Melog through their telepathic connection. The cat jumps slightly at the yelling. They peek one blue eye open to stare at Catra. The brunette grabs Melog and pulls them up toward her gently.

Melog pushes away from Catra to not get pulled away, which just means they're pushing down on Adora's abdomen. Catra could feel how comfortable they were sleeping on Adora's stomach, and they can feel their annoyance at being pulled away now.

Adora voices her annoyance at having the cat pulled off her, too. She groans quietly in her sleep and wraps her arms around the cat. Melog purrs as they nestle into the arms wrapped around them. Adora smiles slightly at the sound of the purring.

Just before Melog goes back to sleep, they tell Catra one thing, "The vampire feels immense guilt for her actions towards you."

Catra lets go and pulls back to stand up straight again. Adora feels guilty for hurting her? Adora, the same person who's killed hundreds of thousands of innocent humans, feels guilty for hurting Catra? Maybe she overestimated how evil this woman really is…

Catra looks down at Adora. Now that she looks again, Adora does look really cute as she hugs Melog in her sleep. She can't help but smile at the sleeping blonde in front of her.

There is absolutely no way Catra could be afraid of Adora after seeing her nap while hugging a cat, not that she really was before. Sure, at the moment she was freaking out, but she relaxed after the adrenaline of the moment passed. She mostly feels annoyed at being forced to cover her neck now. She may not like Adora at all, but maybe she can tolerate her.

The extremely faint sound of tapping heels making their way down the hall towards the rec room door cut off Catra's thoughts. The brunette panics and runs out the door and down the hallway before they can see her.

Chapter End Notes

Just to clarify a few things:

1. Catra was a kid when she found Melog in the Whispering Woods, but she was only in the woods in the first place because she ran away from her parents while they were at a carnival near the forest. They found her eventually and took her back home along with Melog.

2. The other princesses don't actually hate Catra. They don't think she's a freak, and they don't think she's weak. They just never get the chance to talk to her, and if they do Catra always looks really anxious so they think that Catra doesn't want to talk to them.

3. There were two kingdoms that fell long before any of the princesses now were born. They were Horde Legion and Eternia. Horde Prime is from Horde Legion (that's not his real name), and Adora is from Eternia. There was a huge war between the two kingdoms, and nobody won because they both killed everyone in the other kingdom. Etherians now call the Eternians "First Ones". They don't have a name for the Hordians because the Eternians wiped out any information about them.

4. Hordak is a result of an experiment gone wrong. He doesn't come from a kingdom because he came from a lab. Everyone in the kingdom of Horde Legion looked identical (imagine a lot of Horde Primes, but they all have different styles). After everyone in that kingdom was wiped out, Horde Prime wanted to replicate them all with clones. The experiment failed, and the only two results to survive were Hordak and Imp (DT didn't mention Imp bc they didn't know they exist).

Ok, that's it! I hope you read through that all and like it, I know it's a lot.

nostalgic for the anger I once had

Chapter Summary

Adora visits Brightmoon.

She meets new people. They all like her, except for one.

Chapter Notes

Hello!! Look, the other princesses are finally in a chapter! I promise they'll show up more often as of now :)

I want to add that, while Adora and Hordak will 100% get redemption arcs, it will not be easy. I won't just brush off five hundred years of death and torment just for the sake of giving you guys more catradora content. There will be ups and downs, and it won't always be easy, but they'll get there eventually.

Also!! I made another AU!! It's called i'll never be sorry enough, but you look so beautiful and it's a Catradora chronic pain college AU. Wow, that's a mouthful, huh.

Anyway, I hope you guys enjoy this chapter! If you do, I always appreciate a kudo, a comment, or both! Reading all of your comments makes me unbelievably happy and I can't be more grateful for your support :)

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: panic attack, mentions of violence, mentions of death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Today, there's another meeting that Shadow Weaver has to attend, meaning Adora must go with her. Except, this time, Hordak doesn't come with her. It's just her and Shadow Weaver. In Brightmoon.

The two women walk down the brightly coloured halls of the palace, looking for the meeting room. Unlike in Halfmoon, the room is much more difficult to find here.

Adora groans after they walk down another wrong hallway, "This taking *forever*! The meeting's going to be over by the time we get there."

Shadow Weaver doesn't even glance over as they continue walking, "Don't be so dramatic, Adora. We've only been looking for a few minutes."

As they turn a corner into a new hall, they see two people walking in their direction. A short girl with fluffy purple-pink hair and a taller, dark-skinned boy wearing a cropped shirt that exposes part of his midriff. It's obvious they're close from their loud laughter as they walk down the hall. A stark contrast compared to Adora and Shadow Weaver, who don't speak or show any emotions as they walk side-by-side.

Shadow Weaver stops walking, "Go ask the princess of Brightmoon for directions."

Adora stops just a little further in front of her, "No, you ask her. Your meeting, your problem."

The masked woman is about to argue further when the short glittery princess and taller boy interrupt. The short girl speaks first, "Are you lost?" Her tone is friendly, but it gets on Adora's nerves already.

Adora and Shadow Weaver turn to look at each other, having an entire argument with only glares. Adora somehow loses the wordless argument and turns back to the purple-haired girl.

She puts a sickly sweet smile on her face, which looks more like a sneer, “Could you point us in the meeting room's direction, Princess Glitter?”

The princess huffs angrily and Shadow Weaver sighs as Adora looks around, confused. “What? What did I say?”

Glitter crosses her arms, “My name isn’t Glitter!”

Adora tries to remember her name, “Shimmer?”

“No.”

“Sparkles?”

“No!” She seems especially angry at that one, for some odd reason.

Adora groans as she turns to Shadow Weaver, “What’s her name?”

“Princess *Glimmer* of Brightmoon.” Shadow Weaver looks like she’s seconds away from killing Adora right now.

Adora laughs as she turns back to Glimmer, “Oh, come on, I was pretty close with Glitter.”

Glimmer glares at Adora as she turns to Shadow Weaver, “Come on, I’ll take you to the meeting room.” She abruptly turns and walks down the hall. Shadow Weaver follows.

Adora watches them leave with a grin, “Should I come, too?”

The response is immediate from the both of them, “NO!” Adora laughs as they turn down a different hallway.

Adora hears Bow attempt to stifle his laugh at the interaction. She turns towards him with an outstretched arm, “I’m Adora. It’s nice to meet you.”

Bow’s smile disappears as he looks anywhere but Adora, replaced by a conflicted frown. “I-I don’t know if I should talk to you.”

Adora frowns at that, “Why? Because Princess Shimmer told you not to?”

His silence is answer enough, and Adora sighs. She knew the princesses hated her, but she didn’t think they’d actually force other people not to talk to her.

Eventually, Bow actually answers, but it’s a quiet murmur, “That, and because you might… kill… me?” He moves backwards slightly, worried he’ll anger Adora.

Adora groans internally at that. She wouldn’t kill someone unless she had a reason to. It’s been decades since she’s killed anyone for no reason. “Don’t worry. I wouldn’t just kill you out in the open like this, anyway.” Her grin turns only a little sadistic.

Bow’s eyes widen, and he makes a noise that Adora can only describe as a terrified whimper.

Before Bow can run away screaming, Adora bursts into laughter. Bow’s fear quickly turns into confusion.

Adora wipes the tears of mirth from her eyes, “I’m kidding. I don’t kill mortals unless I have a reason to. I don’t have any reason to kill anyone today, so you’re fine.”

Bow sighs in relief, “Okay, that’s a relief. Well, my name is Bow. I’m the Master Archer of Brightmoon.” He points a thumb back towards the bow and arrows strapped to his back.

“Oh! You know, I’m pretty good at using a bow and arrow, too. One of the best archers of my time taught me everything they knew.”

Bow raises a brow at that, “And when was *'your time'*? Five hundred years ago?” Adora laughs loudly at that.

Once Adora’s laughter dies down, Bow smiles, “You’re not what I expected from someone in the Horde.”

"Oh? What were you expecting, an *emotionless bloodthirsty killer*?"

"Well, yeah. I never realized that vampires are still… people, to some extent."

Adora sighs, "Yeah, many people don't."

Most humans read about vampires from inaccurate horror books and assume every vampire is like what they read. Emotionless, cruel, incapable of love or kindness or any human emotions. Sure, Adora might not be the best person on Etheria, but she's still capable of having emotions. She still has feelings, even if she wishes she didn't sometimes.

A heavy silence falls over the two. Adora looks down at the floor, remembering all the times humans have attacked her unprovoked just because they thought she was a monster or a freak. Adora already knows she's both those things, she doesn't need Etherians yelling it at her with their pitchforks and torches.

Bow smiles at Adora, seeing her in a new light. He shoves her shoulder to get her out of her own head. It works as Adora lifts her head up quickly. "Some other princesses are coming to Brightmoon to hang out. Wanna join us?"

Adora fidgets with her fingers, anxious, "I don't think that's a good idea. They all hate me and we both know it." She really doesn't want a repeat of what happened with Catra.

"Okay, Glimmer might not like you very much, but you've never even met the other princesses. Glimmer's going to be busy at that meeting anyway, so it'll just be me and the others. Maybe they'll like you!"

Adora smiles weakly. She's not used to Bow's optimistic words. Not many people in the Horde are optimistic people.

"Is-Is Catra going to be there?"

Confused, Bow raises a brow, “Catra? You mean the Princess of Halfmoon?”

Adora nods.

He shakes his head, “No, she’s not. Catra doesn’t really enjoy talking to the other princesses.”

Oh. Well, in that case…

The vampire sighs nervously, “Okay, I’ll go.”

Bow jumps up and down while clapping his hands excitedly, “This is going to be so fun!” He opens his arms to pull Adora into a hug but hesitates at the last second. Adora’s eyes widen. She hasn’t gotten a genuine hug since… her mom. Hesitantly, she opens her arms out slightly. Bow smiles brightly at the opportunity and pulls Adora into her first hug in over 500 years.

Adora laughs as she hugs Bow back with the same strength. She can’t help the single tear that slides down her face. When was the last time a human showed her any kindness? Probably when she was a human, too.

Eventually, Bow pulls away. His smile quickly vanishes when he sees the tear and hears Adora sniffle. “What’s wrong? Oh, did I say something wrong? I’m so-”

Adora cuts him off with a raised hand as she wipes her face, “I’m sorry, I just haven’t gotten a hug in the last few centuries.”

Bow's jaw gapes open as he gets the saddest look in his eyes, “You haven’t gotten a hug in hundreds of years?” He seems so shocked by this as he practically tears up with Adora.

The blonde laughs quietly, “Yeah… I don’t know why I’m crying, I’m sorry.”

She’s pulled into another hug by the brunette, tighter than the first one, “You don’t have to apologize. I wish the world was

kinder to you."

Adora smiles sadly as she leans her head on his shoulder, "Me too."

With a pat on her back, Bow pulls away with a sweet smile. He glances over at a nearby clock and gasps, "Oh! The princesses are probably here by now! Are you ready to meet them?"

At that, Adora grimaces. Not being deterred in the slightest, Bow grabs Adora's hand and pulls her down the halls to a large door. Adora takes a deep breath before Bow opens the door.

There are five people lounging on the couches in the room, which Adora assumes to be Brightmoon's recreation room. Everyone in the room stops their conversations to look over at the door. They all smile at the sight of Bow and greet him before turning their focus onto Adora.

There's a dark-skinned girl with blue hair, a man with a mustache and a black bandana on his head, a blonde with a flower crown in her hair, a younger girl with a blue bob, and a girl with long purple hair put into pigtails who Adora recognizes as Entrapta. Adora sighs in relief at not seeing Catra, but can't help but feel a little… disappointed? It's for the best, though. The last thing she wants is to hurt Catra more.

Entrapta seems to recognize Adora immediately as she smiles and waves, "Oh, hi Adora. I didn't know you'd be here." She turns to mumble something into her recorder as everyone else in the room gawks.

Eventually, the blue-haired girl narrows her eyes, "Wait… *Adora*? Are you with the Horde?"

Adora already regrets agreeing to come here, "Uh… yes?" Everyone in the room, except Entrapta, gasps at this. The younger blue-haired girl is next to speak, "So… Are you here to kill us?"

Despite this definitely not being the best situation to laugh in, Adora does anyway. When nobody else laughs, Adora coughs awkwardly and stands up straighter, "No, I won't kill any of you. There's some meeting going on today and I had to come here. I was planning on wandering the halls until the meeting ended, but then I met Bow and he told me I could come here instead."

Most of them seem hesitant to talk to a vampire, especially one from the Horde. Well, except for Entrapta... and the long-haired blonde.

The tall woman stands up and walks over to stand in front of Adora with a warm smile on her face, "I'm Perfuma, the princess of Plumeria." Before Adora can react, Perfuma pulls Adora into a light hug.

Once she pulls away, a small red flower that matches Adora's eyes appears tucked behind her ear. Adora smiles and blushes slightly. She really isn't used to affection, even if it's only a friendly hug and a little flower.

She can almost feel everyone glance over at her fangs, but they don't mention it. Instead, Perfuma pulls Adora to sit down beside her on the couch she just got off of.

Adora sits down cautiously as she looks around at the others. They're all still staring at her, but their gazes have softened a bit. Bow has taken a seat on one couch beside the one Adora's on. Adora puts her hands in her lap and sits as straight as she can.

The blue-haired girl is the next to speak, "Geez, do you even know how to relax?" Adora sighs and relaxes her posture a little. The girl speaks again, "My name's Mermista, by the way. I'm the princess of Salineas."

Adora nods and outstretches a hand towards Mermista, "Hello. My name is Adora."

Mermista smirks as she shakes Adora's hand, "I already knew that, but okay."

The moustached man speaks next, "And my name is Sea Hawk. I am the greatest sailor in all of Salineas! Maybe even all of Etheria…" Beside him, Mermista groans and runs a hand down her face.

Adora laughs quietly as she reaches a hand out towards him, "Hi, Sea Hawk." It's an unusual name, but she doesn't comment on it. She lives with someone named *Shadow Weaver*, after all. Who is she to judge?

Last but not least for introductions is the younger girl with short blue hair, "My name is Frosta. I'm the princess of the Kingdom of Snows."

Adora grins at her, "Hello, Frosta. It's nice to meet you."

After that, the group falls into light conversation. Mostly, they're asking Adora questions about what it's like in the Horde, and they are all telling her stories of what it's like to live outside of the Horde, with both parties being surprised by the answers they receive.

After a few hours of talking, Frosta speaks up, "I-um- have a question." She mumbles this slightly, as if she's nervous to ask.

Adora sits up so she can hear Frosta better, "I'm all ears, Frosta."

"What happened to your arms? And-and that sword that you bring everywhere with you? It's just- I noticed them once at a party you attended a few months ago." It's at that moment that Adora's glad she wore a long-sleeved high-neck shirt today.

Everyone turns to Adora expectantly, as if they've all been waiting to hear the answer to this long-awaited question for months.

Adora pulls out her sword from her side where she always keeps it and sets it down in her lap.

Half of the gemstone at the hilt is its original light blue and the other half is such a dark purple it looks black. Adora places a

gentle hand on the corrupted gemstone. The group peers down at the gem questioningly.

"Well, as you probably know, either you're born a vampire or you're turned into one by dying and being brought back," she begins. They all know where this is going and immediately feel guilty for asking. Adora keeps going, "Well, I wasn't born a vampire. I actually used to be a vampire hunter when I was human. One day, when my family and I were responding to a vampire reporting, Shadow Weaver killed me using dark magic. It spread all over my body and went into my sword. This sword was a family heirloom and actually used to have some magic in it, but it was all corrupted with dark magic by the time I died."

Mermista asks what they're all wondering, after a few moments of silence, "What… What happened to your family?"

Adora doesn't need to say what happened for them to know, but she does anyway, "They, um- Shadow Weaver killed my dad and brother with my sword, and wiped my mom's memory completely. She was basically a stranger to me after that." Adora's not crying, but she's still sad as she remembers how much she loved her family. It might have been centuries ago, but they were her *family*.

Adora doesn't know why she's telling them all of this. Maybe it's because they're the first people to ask about her past. Maybe it's because they're the first friends she's made since she became friends with Hordak hundreds of years ago.

Despite having only met Adora a few hours ago, they're all tearing up a little at hearing her backstory. Other than Frosta, they all have loving families and couldn't possibly imagine watching them die in front of their own eyes and then being killed, too, and Frosta can also relate to losing her family.

Huh. Maybe these people could actually be Adora's friends…

They’re about to console her when the door to the rec room opens to reveal none other than Glimmer.

The purple-haired girl seems relieved now that the meeting’s over, but all that happiness quickly disappears as soon as she spots Adora sitting with her friends. She crosses her arms.

She turns to Bow, “What is she doing here? I thought I told you not to talk to her, and I definitely didn’t tell you to bring her to our friends. She’s dangerous!”

Bow tries to defend himself, and Adora, “Come on, Glimmer. She won’t hurt us. She just wanted someone to talk to while she waited for the meeting to end.” The other nod in agreement. Adora’s face reddens slightly as she looks down. She’s never had people defend her like this before. It’s… nice.

Glimmer takes a few steps forward so that she’s standing in front of her friends. “You guys are kidding, right?” She points a finger towards Adora, “She’s a *monster*! She’s just pretending to be your friend so that she can hurt you all later. Do you really think someone like *her* could be our friend?”

The words shouldn’t bother Adora as much as they do, she’s heard them for years. It doesn’t make them hurt any less, though. She shouldn’t have gotten her hopes up. She shouldn’t have come in here at all. It was stupid of her to believe that any humans could see her as anything other than repulsive.

It’s at times like these that Adora misses her anger. She used to have an endless supply of the stuff pouring out of her. Sure, it pushed people away, but at least she was safe. At least she didn’t get her hopes up only to have it crushed at her feet, along with her happiness.

Now, though, all she feels is guilt. And loneliness.

She lifts her head to look at Glimmer, hoping the shine of tears in her eyes isn’t visible. “I’m sorry, Glimmer. I’ll leave, okay?”

The rest of the people sitting down look guilty as Adora stands up and makes her way to the door. Right before her foot can step out of the door, Adora hears Glimmer's voice again.

"You know, you're just like Shadow Weaver."

Everyone except Adora and Glimmer gasp at that, knowing the inaccuracy of that statement.

Adora feels her anger burnt hot at the girl's words. She whips around to face her, "What the fuck did you just say, Glitter?"

Glimmer huffs angrily as Adora appears in front of her, but some of her anger turns into fear when she notices Adora's sharp fangs that could easily pierce into her skin and drain the life out of her.

She puts on a mask of false bravado, "I *said* that you're just like Shadow Weaver. You're just as evil as her, if not worse."

"I'm nothing like Shadow Weaver! And you know NOTHING about me!" Adora's anger only grows the more she looks at Glimmer.

"Oh, really? Well, I know how you've killed thousands upon thousands of innocent Etherians. That's more than Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime COMBINED. How can you say you're better than them when you've killed more than them?"

Just like that, all of Adora's anger disappears into thin air because…

"... You're right."

Her voice is a hushed whisper, as if she can't believe it. Judging by Glimmer's face, she can't believe Adora's agreeing with her, either. "What?"

Every shred of guilt Adora's been hiding deep inside comes crawling out until she's drowning in it. Every innocent person she killed. Every life she's ruined. Every drop of innocent blood that's fallen because of her.

She feels the combined guilt of over five hundred years hit her like a truck, with Glimmer in the driver's seat.

"Yo-You're right. I'm a *terrible* person."

The shock quickly turns into fear.

Fear that she's truly a horrible, irredeemable person. Fear that she's *exactly* like Shadow Weaver. Fear that she broke the promise she made to her mother all those years ago to be good.

It's then that Adora realizes that she's not breathing. And that there are tears pouring out of her eyes and down her face. Her vision is tunnelling, and she can hardly see in front of her. All she can see right now is Glimmer's panicked face.

Faintly, Adora can hear a few people speaking to her, telling her to breathe, but she can't hear them. Everything feels muffled and far away, though. Distant, almost like it's not there at all.

Through the raging storm of her thoughts, Adora only knows one thing. She has to do something about this. She has to talk to Hordak, now.

While still struggling to breathe, Adora takes a step towards Glimmer and tightly places her hands on her shoulders, "Take me to Horde Prime's manor."

Glimmer's face morphs quickly from fear, to shock, then to confusion, "What? But-but Shadow Weaver is waiting for you, and there's a rainstorm outside right now."

Adora quickly glances outside to see the rain aggressively slamming against the window. How did she not notice that before?

Adora's hands tighten, and Glimmer grimaces in pain, "I DON'T CARE! Take me there, NOW!"

Some small part of Adora’s brain knows she should relax and breathe, but she can’t find the strength to. Thankfully, Glimmer finally listens to her request, anyway, even though it was more of an angry demand.

Magic surrounds the two women as Glimmer teleports them outside of Horde Prime’s large and creepy-looking manor. It’s dark outside as the rain pours down angrily onto the path leading to the dark front door. The moons shines brightly above them.

Glimmer gives Adora one last nervous look before she teleports away. Adora stands in front of the Horde Lord’s manor, alone, in the night's dark, and soaking wet with rainwater.

Adora rushes up to the front door with enough determination to level the entire Fright Zone.

She knocks hardly against the wooden door until someone opens it.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry about the cliffhanger :(but not really though lol.

Don't worry, Glimmer and Adora will reconcile soon.

To make up for this rollercoaster of a chapter, I'll post the next chapter REALLY soon, okay? Probably sometime this weekend :)

Chapter title credit: Takuboku Ishikawa, tr. by Tamae K. Prindle, from The Selected Poems; “A Love Song to Myself

i thought there were no heroes left in this world

Chapter Summary

Adora convinces.

Hordak plans.

Maybe things will work out, after all...

Chapter Notes

Yay!! Early chapter time!! They're planning this chapter!

This chapter is mostly Adora and Hordak talking, but it's also pretty Hordak-centric for this chapter. I know I've made Shadow Weaver seem like a terrible person in this (and she is) and Horde Prime as this regular guy, but don't be fooled by his false kindness. That guy is cruel and manipulative, just like his Second-in-Command.

I don't know if I've made it clear by now, but Horde Prime is the Horde Lord and SW is the Second-in-Command. Adora and Hordak go to events because they're basically the wards of SW and HP respectively.

Oh, and by the way, vampires CAN die in this fic, but they always come back. So you could snap their neck and they would collapse for a few minutes, but they'd get back up soon. There are only a small handful of ways to kill a vampire: stake/Adora's sword to the heart, cutting off their head, and others but it would technically be spoiling if I told you them so I won't.

Also, here are the number of kills each Horde rep has:
Adora: ~10,000
Hordak: ~5,000

Shadow Weaver: ~500
Horde Prime: ~1,000
(They're all approximate since they don't keep count over the years.)

I really hope you guys enjoy this chapter! If you do, you could leave a kudo, comment, or maybe both! I love reading all of the comments and responding to them all, and I can't wait for you guys to see where this story leads. It might be a little different than you expected ;)

Ok, bye-bye!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

She doesn't stop knocking until the door finally swings open to reveal none other than Horde Prime himself.

The tall man opens the door with his signature creepy smile, which quickly turned into amused bewilderment as he takes in the state of Adora.

Despite not having run to the door, Adora is breathing heavily as the rainwater that's soaked into her hair, her clothes, her shoes, drips onto the small patio. She has a panicked look in her eye as she scans the inside of the house instead of looking at Horde Prime.

Horde Prime speaks in his usual calm voice, but it only annoys Adora, "Hello, Adora. It's a surprise to see you here at this hour. Is Shadow We-"

Adora cuts him off, "Can I speak to Hordak?" If Adora could, she would have just stormed past Horde Prime and gone directly downstairs into Hordak's sanctum, but Horde Prime hasn't let Adora in yet. Turns out, that's not just a rumour humans made up.

Horde Prime looks surprised at being talked over. Few people do that and live to tell the tale, but Adora's feeling reckless today. "Of course." His voice has venom in it that it didn't previously have.

He turns his head back to yell downstairs, "Hordak! Adora is here to see you, and she appears to be having some sort of…" He turns back to look Adora up and down with a raised brow, "mental breakdown."

Adora ignores his last statement. She has bigger problems than what Horde Prime thinks of her. The man's voice is far too quiet and relaxed for Adora's taste, so she makes sure that Hordak knows the urgency of the situation. She yells as loudly as she can from her spot, and it only sounds a little shaky, "HORDAK! GET YOUR ASS UP HERE NOW!"

Horde Prime turns back to Adora, amused at seeing her crumble apart before his very eyes. He's only ever seen the obedient little protégé of Shadow Weaver that Adora pretends to be at parties. Faintly, Adora can hear Hordak going up the stairs at a much faster pace than before. Once he makes it upstairs and finally gets a look at Adora, his eyes widen. He hides his surprised expression before Horde Prime can see it.

He stops a few steps behind Horde Prime, watching Adora anxiously, as if she could somehow get past the barrier on the door. "What are you doing here? Aren't you supposed to be in Brightmoon right now for that meeting?"

Adora is acutely aware of how they are both staring at her like she's gone crazy. She feels like she's gone crazy, and she probably looks like she has, too. "The meeting ended. I need to talk to you right now." She makes sure her tone is urgent, so he knows that this isn't some elaborate joke.

"Can it wait for tomorrow?"

"No."

Both Adora and Hordak look up at Horde Prime, silently asking him to let Adora in. Eventually, the taller man sighs, "Come in, Ador-"

Horde Prime doesn't even have time to finish before Adora quickly shoves past him with a huff, "Out of the way, old man!" Immediately, Adora grabs Hordak's wrist and basically drags him downstairs to his lab.

As Adora walks away, she knows that Horde Prime is getting annoyed with her attitude, and it shows in his words, "I could have you killed for speaking to your Lord that way!"

The problem is, she really couldn't give a flying fuck, "You should."

Hordak

Today was meant to be a regular day.

A nice day.

A day where, oh, I don't know, maybe Hordak could have some peace and quiet.

But, alas…

The universe has cursed him with an idiot for a friend.

Once he hears the words 'Adora' and 'mental breakdown' come from Horde Prime, he's rushing upstairs. He only goes faster once he hears Adora's furious-sounding and shaky voice echo out from the unnecessarily large house he lives in.

Hordak never understood why Horde Prime kept him, even after the experiment failed. He's a failure, a mistake, a defect. Why would this man keep him in his own home, of all places? Is it out of pity?

As much as he pretends not to know the answer to that question, he does. Hordak knows that Horde Prime just keeps him around because he enjoys having someone to order around. Someone to control like a puppet. That's all Hordak is to him. That's all he's good for. Just a mindless servant that's incapable of having basic emotions.

Well, that might be because that's all Hordak pretends to be around him. He never goes against his word, shows no emotions, does nothing to make Horde Prime want to throw him out like garbage.

Hordak's brought back to the present by Adora pulling him through the door into his sanctum. Adora's so caught up in her panic, she doesn't even notice Imp frantically flying off of some table once the door flies open and up onto a vent above them.

Adora finally lets go of his wrist and whirls around to look at him, panic growing by the second.

"What happened, Adora?" His voice is patient and kind, not wanting to scare Adora away.

Adora paces in a loop around the messy lab which Hordak's never gotten around to cleaning. "I went to Brightmoon for the meeting, and I ran into some princess, and her friend and then I met the other princesses, and it was really fun and we were having a great time but then the glittery princess came back and was all angry and she was calling me a monster and I tried to deny it but-but-she wa-" Her voice gets shaky near the end as the panic rises more and threatens to overwhelm her.

Hordak cuts Adora's rambling off by grabbing her by the shoulders and pushing her down into a chair beside her. He keeps his hands on her shoulders as he speaks, "Adora, you need to relax, okay? I can't understand a word you're saying. Take a deep breath and try again, but slower this time."

He leads Adora through a deep breath, which works well in calming her down. Once he's sure she won't go off into another nervous ramble, he lets go and sits down in a chair across from Adora.

Hordak asks again, "What happened at Brightmoon?"

Adora takes another deep breath before she says the last thing Hodak was expecting from her, "We have to stop killing humans."

His eyes widened, "... What?"

Adora explains, "We have to stop killing humans. We're just like them if we do."

Okay, Adora has officially lost her mind, "Who's *them*?"

"Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime."

Somehow, Hordak's eyes widened even further.

No.

He's nothing like Horde Prime.

Horde Prime did make him, though…

But he's… better than him, right?

Right?

Hordak's throat suddenly becomes dry but he continues, "N-No, you're wrong. You're nothing like Shadow Weaver, and I'm nothing like Horde Prime!"

Adora looks as disgusted by the idea of being like her sire as Hordak is of being like his. Despite that, she continues with her unbelievable theory.

"Think about it. How are we any better than them? We've killed thousands more people than both of them combined. We're worse

than them if we keep this up."

Hordak tries to refute the statement but, deep down, he knows it's true. "We're… better than them, aren't we?" His voice has gone down from almost yelling to a shaky whisper.

Adora's has, too. "No, we're not."

Hordak drops his head down to look at the dark metallic flooring. A heavy silence falls over the two friends as Hordak takes in this information.

Is Hordak that bad?

Is he just as bad as Horde Prime?

Is Adora just as bad as Shadow Weaver?

This entire time, they thought they were better somehow...

So far, it seems like he's taken it far better than Adora did. At least he's not crying, right? That's probably a good thing.

Eventually, he has a question. He looks back up cautiously, "What do we do now?" It's a big question that Hordak doesn't think Adora will have an answer to, but she does.

"Simple, we won't kill any humans starting from now." Hordak wishes it were that simple. There's one issue with that plan that Adora isn't considering, though.

"What are we going to do when we're hungry?"

At that, Adora actually pauses. She has a curious look on her face, "Do you think we could drink animal blood instead?"

Hordak scoffs, "What, are you *trying* to kill yourself? Horde Prime said that animal blood is poisonous for vampires."

The curious look doesn't fade. If anything, it grows stronger. "What if Horde Prime was lying?"

Huh. Well, that is definitely very possible.

“So how are we going to find out if he was? By hoping for sheer luck and not a painful death?”

Adora pauses before it appears as if a lightbulb goes off in her head, “We can ask Entrapta to experiment on some animal blood. You know how much she loves experiments.”

Hordak sighs and pinches the bridge of his nose. That is actually a pretty good idea, even if it involves him and Adora getting experimented on by the girl he lo-

This is how the two of them have come up with most of their plans for the past few centuries. Adora will suggest a risky and not-thought-out plan, Hordak will tell her everything that could go wrong, then Adora will change the plan to make sure it’s safe. This method of planning has probably saved Adora from a countless number of deaths. Hordak is just relieved that Adora hasn’t gotten herself into any real, dangerous trouble in a while.

He thinks of another issue, “What if Shadow Weaver asks you to kill someone? What are you going to do then?” It's common for the sorceress to ask Adora to randomly kill humans, whether it's so Adora can collect their blood in blood bags and bring it back to Shadow Weaver or so Adora can collect their organs for spells.

Adora struggles with an answer for that one. She clearly didn’t think of that. “Uhh… Not kill them, I guess?” Her tone is hesitant, as if she’s asking Hordak instead of telling him.

Hordak uses the hand that was previously pinching his nose to drag it down his face with a groan, “She’ll kill you, Adora! Or she’d lock you up. Either way, you won’t be able to be a good person if that happens.”

Adora grins excitedly, “Not if I kill her first.”

Wait.

What?

This is getting WAY off topic…

"Horde Prime would find out if you killed Shadow Weaver and have you banished or executed."

Adora's grin only grows wider, "Okay, then let's kill him, too."

Hordak outstretched his arms out in front of him as he begins to practically yell, "You're not thinking this through, Adora! You're being reckless."

Adora crosses her arms with a huff, "Stop treating me like a baby! I'm not being reckless, I've been thinking about this for the past five hundred years!"

"It's risky. What do we do after we've killed them both?"

Her grin morphs into a smirk, "We could rule the Horde, and make it good. Think about how much *better* the Fright Zone could be if we were the ones making the rules."

Hordak *does* think about it.

Maybe the Horde would benefit from a leader like Adora…

He concedes, "Fine, that sounds like a good idea. We still need a plan, though."

Adora uncrosses her arms and stands up, "Then let's make one."

Chapter End Notes

> This might not be the way you thought this fic was going to go, or it might have been. Either way, I hope the fact that Adora and Hordak are, in fact, staying with the Horde was a good surprise to you guys.
>
> Chapter title credit: #2 of this tumblr post

i wish you wouldn't look at me like that (like you could love me)

Chapter Summary

Adora helps Shadow Weaver.

Hordak helps Adora.

Something unexpected happens.

Chapter Notes

Okay, before you freak out, that chapter summary is a lot more dramatic than the chapter actually is. I just love being an over-dramatic idiot.

I really hope you guys enjoy this chapter. I like it, and I had fun writing it :) There's some angst at the start, some planning, and a dash of humour! I'm sorry for posting this a little late, by the way. I've been a little overwhelmed lately, and my mental health has totally spiralled downwards recently. (TW: Self-harm) If you've read my coffee shop AU, you know I've struggled with self-harm for a while now. I had a couple of relapses, but I'm doing okay now. Writing has been nice, though. Anyway, I hope you like this AU so far!

If you guys like this chapter, you could leave a kudo or a comment, or both! I appreciate all of your support so so much, you guys have no idea.

Ok, bye-bye!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Shadow Weaver calls out the name of a magical substance from the spellbook in front of her. Adora turns to the shelves behind her and searches for the right bottle.

Adora passes the vial filled with dark purple liquid to Shadow Weaver, who adds the substance to the large, black cauldron in front of her. A large plume of smoke rises from the cauldron, showing that the spell is working.

Shadow Weaver turns to Adora, who's now standing beside her, "Those are all the ingredients I need. You may leave now."

Mostly when she helps Shadow Weaver with spells, Adora will leave the second she's not being forced to help. This time, though, she has a plan. This time, she stays.

Instead of going back up the stairs of the basement, Adora goes and sits down on the small, comfortable armchair that sits in the room's corner. Usually, Shadow Weaver sits there to read books on magic or wait for her potions to finish brewing. Adora hands her legs off of the edge of the chair and rests her back on the arm of the chair.

Shadow Weaver simultaneously looks surprised and annoyed to see Adora staying and sitting in her chair. "What are you still doing here? Get out, I have work to do."

Adora groans as she rests her head on the arm of the chair, "I'm *bored*, though. I have nothing else to do today, anyway."

The dark sorceress crosses her arms, "So you've decided to annoy me while I work?"

"Yup." She pops the 'p' sound as she lifts her head back up to grin mischievously.

Instead of forcing Adora to leave, Shadow Weaver sighs and continues working on her potion, "Fine, but don't break anything."

After hours of trial and error, Shadow Weaver's potion still doesn't seem to turn out how she wants it to.

Adora is napping on the armchair in the same position as when she first sat. There's only so long you can watch someone throw random stuff into a cauldron and form some runes on top of it.

The blonde is awoken by a loud and very annoyed groan from her mentor. She opens her eyes to see Shadow Weaver reading a page in her spellbook with enough focus to burn a hole through the worn-out paper.

"What happened?" Adora rubs her eyes as she yawns.

Shadow Weaver turns to look at Adora with a slightly surprised expression, as if she forgot Adora was even there. After placing the book down on a table beside her, Shadow Weaver crosses her arms again, "I didn't realize you were so interested in dark magic." Her tone is practically dripping sarcasm.

Adora snorts, "Oh, don't worry, I'm not. Dark magic is a waste of time, and resources. I just have nothing else to do. Besides, maybe explaining the problem to me will help you figure out a solution."

Shadow Weaver doesn't seem offended by Adora's opinions on dark magic. Well, to be fair, she *has* heard them loud and clear for the past few centuries. The masked woman seems to ponder Adora's words for a moment, though. "Fine. There's one ingredient that I must add to the potion, light essence, but the substance isn't reacting well with the other ingredients. I changed the recipe to replace the light magic with dark magic, but the dark magic is going against that one ingredient."

Adora shrugs, "Easy, don't add the light essence, then."

The black-haired woman's eyes widened, showing that she never thought about that, "You can't just *remove* this ingredient."

"Why not?"

"It's one of the first rules of sorcery! Without light essence, the magic might become unstable."

Adora raises a brow, "Yeah, but that rule only applies to normal magic. You're *clearly* not using normal sorcery, so you shouldn't follow normal sorcery rules."

"It's dangerous and reckless."

"Oh, come on, what's the worst that could happen?"

"If this goes wrong, it's your fault." It surprised Adora when Shadow Weaver agreed so quickly. She must really want this spell to work.

With a sigh, Shadow Weaver turns back to the cauldron and dumps the liquid inside into a large drain on the floor. The dark sorceress turns back to Adora, "Go get me the same ingredients from before, but without the light essence."

Grinning, Adora goes to get the bottles from the shelf. It wasn't actually a part of her plan to help Shadow Weaver, but whatever distracts her for longer.

They go through the entire spell process but without one ingredient. Adora sits back down after she hands the ingredients to her mentor, hanging her legs off the edge again.

The plume of smoke rises again but, after a few minutes, the smoke changes from an ashy gray colour to a vibrant purple colour.

Shadow Weaver stands back, watching the purple smoke with wide eyes, "Huh. You were right."

Adora scoffs, "It was a pretty simple solution. I'm surprised you didn't think of it before."

Shadow Weaver turns her head to look at Adora with a look in her eyes that Adora's never seen before. Is that… pride? No way,

Shadow Weaver has never been proud of Adora before. “Hm… Maybe you should help me with spells more often.”

At that, Adora actually laughs, a rare occurrence when with the masked woman. “I think I’ll pass, thanks.” Shadow Weaver doesn’t seem disappointed in her words.

Adora glances at the clock on the wall beside the door. She’s late.

She stands up and stretches, “Well, this has been fun, but I’m going to go take a nap now.” They’ve been in the basement for so many hours that it’s dark outside by now. Napping is a good excuse, right?

Shadow Weaver doesn’t glance up at Adora, too focused on skimming through her spellbook and changing her spell recipes, “Alright. Good job, Adora. You did well today.”

Adora pauses at the stairs. That’s the first time Shadow Weaver has ever complimented her while nobody is around. Usually, she’ll give Adora fake praise in front of others so that she looks like a good mentor, but she’s never given her a genuine compliment for her actions.

The words remind her of her mother’s sweet voice as she congratulated Adora for anything she’d done. Sometimes she wouldn’t even need to do something for Marlena to give her support. She would just give and give every ounce of love in her human heart.

Adora shakes her head weakly as she continues walking up the stairs. That time is long over. She’ll never hear her mom’s voice again. She’ll never feel her hugs, or her forehead kisses, or hear her laugh, or be able to go to her for advice. That bridge burned over five hundred years ago, and now all she’s left with is Shadow Weaver. The woman who is the exact opposite of the kind, caring woman who raised Adora. Shadow Weaver wouldn't give Adora any love from that charred, black lump of coal she calls her heart.

Maybe, though, she can honour Marlena by trying to be a good person, even after all these years.

It's the least she deserves after everything she did for Adora. She was always so kind, so compassionate, and how did Adora repay her? By joining the Horde and killing thousands. By becoming a *monster*.

It's… *disgraceful*.

It's weak.

But maybe she can change. Maybe she can be strong for her.

Adora keeps walking until she reaches her bedroom. She opens the door and quickly locks it behind herself to ensure that Shadow Weaver won't come in.

Instead of going to bed, like she told Shadow Weaver, Adora goes under her bed to grab the rope ladder she hid yesterday.

The blonde vampire opens her window, looking down to see Hordak standing at the bottom expectantly. He crosses his arms as he looks up at Adora, "You're late."

The blonde throws down the rope ladder she found in the basement for Hordak to climb. One perk of being immortal is that you collect a lot of random junk over the years that might be useful one day. "I had to make sure Shadow Weaver wouldn't get suspicious."

Hordak makes it to the ledge of the window fairly quickly. It's a good thing he was genetically created to have stronger muscles, or else that climb would've been way more difficult for him.

Adora grabs his hand and practically pulls him inside. Once both his feet are on the floor, Adora pulls the ladder back up and closes her window. She turns back to see Hordak looking at her anxiously, "So there's no chance of her finding out about our plans?"

“There’s no way. She’s going to be busy doing spells for the rest of the week, at least.” She has a smug grin on her face as she says this, proud of herself.

Hordak nods, not questioning Adora’s methods, as he goes and sits down on the edge of Adora’s bed. Adora sits down in her desk chair as she pulls out some old papers from a drawer.

Hordak looks at the papers with scrunched brows, “You already planned all that? We only agreed to do this a week ago.”

Adora lays out the paper on her desk, “No, these are from a few hundred years ago. What, you think this is the first time I’ve planned to kill Shadow Weaver?”

Hordak’s brow raises, “So, why haven’t you succeeded yet? You’ve been planning for so long, how have you not killed her yet?”

At that, Adora sighs and puts down the last paper on her wooden desk, “It wouldn’t work. She could’ve killed me with dark magic again.”

“I thought you were immune to her magic, though.”

“I am, but that’s only because I’ve developed a tolerance to dark magic after being around it for five centuries. I’ve only been immune for a few decades, but Shadow Weaver doesn’t know her magic doesn’t hurt me anymore.”

Both of Hordak’s eyebrows are raised now, “You’ve been pretending to be affected by her dark magic.” It’s not a question, but a statement, as if he’s connecting the dots in his head out loud.

Despite Hordak not asking her, Adora nods.

After the initial shock passes, excitement quickly replaces it, “Do you know how easy it would be for you to kill her? She’s practically useless without her magic!”

Adora laughs, “Well, it’s touching that you’re so confident in my strength.”

Hordak scoffs, “What are you talking about? Of course, you’re strong. I would argue that you’re the strongest person in the Fright Zone.”

“Well, what about you? You’re strong, too. I wasn’t genetically modified in a lab to be extra strong like you.”

“Yeah, well, I wasn’t trained as a child to hunt vampires and use deadly weapons.”

The two friends laugh loudly, but try to stay quiet once they remember Shadow Weaver is two floors below them. Adora wipes the tears of mirth from her eyes, “Let’s just agree that we’re the two strongest people in the Horde.”

“Agreed. It’s a perfect tie.”

Their cheerful moods quickly disappear as they remember why Hordak’s here in the first place. Hordak sighs, “So, should we plan now?”

Adora nods, “Yeah. So, what first?”

Many hours later…

It was a painstakingly long process, but they finally came up with a plan that’s mostly safe (as safe as you can get while killing a tyrant) and ensures that nobody will become suspicious of them.

The plan is to kill Shadow Weaver first, then Horde Prime. If they kill Horde Prime first, Shadow Weaver will take the throne for herself. Also, Shadow Weaver is more likely to catch on to their plans than Horde Prime. The man is the ruler of the Horde, it’s not likely he’ll notice if Hordak is acting a little different after his Second-in-Command dies.

First, they'll kill Shadow Weaver at the very end of a party a few weeks from now. They'll do it after Horde Prime has said goodbye to her for the night, then they'll attack her while she's distracted. Adora will act all heartbroken over the death of her 'devoted mentor', and Horde Prime will be too busy dealing with the aftermath to focus on Hordak or Adora.

Killing Horde Prime will be an entirely different story. Guards almost always surround the ruler, especially in the daytime. Well, that's because the last person he expects to assassinate him is someone of his own kind. He'll never see it coming. Adora will meet with Horde Prime in his manor to discuss Shadow Weaver's death (she's already got her crocodile tears ready) while Hordak takes care of the guards. While Horde Prime and Adora talk, Hordak will strike when he least expects it.

Adora groans from her desk chair, "I don't understand why we can't make their deaths more painful, though."

Hordak sighs for the umpteenth time. He's been trying to convince Adora to keep their plan as safe as possible for at least an hour now.

"There's no point in useless theatrics right now. We need to make their deaths quick and as undramatic as possible, it's the safest method."

"You and I both know they deserve so much worse than what we're giving them."

Hordak knows there's more to it than that. The blue-haired man stands up and in front of Adora's chair, placing a hand on her shoulder, "I know you want to make Shadow Weaver suffer as much as she's made you suffer, but she's not worth the effort. Trust me, I *know* that Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver deserve deaths a million times worse than what we're planning, but we need to be careful. We need to succeed where they didn't."

Adora's eyes soften at Hordak's speech. She sighs as she puts her face in her hands, "I know you're right, but that doesn't make this any easier."

Hordak chuckles dryly as he pats Adora's shoulder, "Don't worry, we'll be fine."

Adora raises her head to give him an incredulous look, "Do you really believe that?"

He nods, confident.

The blonde places her head back into her hands as she rests her elbows on her knees. Hordak leans backwards until he's lying on his back on the bed and half of both his legs are dangling off the edge. They two sit in comfortable silence as Adora collects her thoughts.

Eventually, she remembers what she was thinking about while she was walking upstairs.

What's the point in all of this if she and Hordak are just as bad as *them*? They'd basically be the new Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime. She practically shivers in disgust and fear at being even remotely like the masked woman.

There's no point in doing any of this if they're going to continue being monsters. The Horde would just continue being a kingdom full of the angry and *alone* bloodthirsty killers that the rest of Etheria knows. Who decided that vampires are incapable of being regular, happy people? Nobody chooses to be a vampire, so why are the citizens of the Horde forced to live out the rest of their immortal lives in misery?

It breaks Adora's heart to think of all the wasted potential that was lost in the Horde. All of those doctors, scientists, artists, engineers, bakers, shopkeepers, and just… people that were robbed of the opportunity to live, forced to spend their years killing to survive.

Maybe if they got Entrapta to find an alternative to human blood, vampires could lead mostly normal lives and maybe even be happy.

Finally, Adora lifts her head up to look at Hordak, who seems to be taking a nap on her bed. She sighs and stands up to glare at him. The vampire grabs a pillow from her bed and slams it into Hordak's face. The man wakes up with a startle, jumping up into a sitting position with a terrified look on his face.

He whips his head around to look for what just hit him, "What?! What's happening?"

Adora dissolves into fits of laughter at the look on his face. Hordak glares at her angrily as he throws the pillow back into Adora's hands rather forcefully.

After Adora has regained her composure, she jumps up onto the bed and sits down with her legs crisscrossed. Hordak's angry glare slowly morphs into a curious look as he turns around to face her, "What do you want?"

Adora scoffs, "Okay, first, you were napping on *my* bed while we were planning." Hordak looks ready to argue at that, but Adora beats him to the punch. "Second, we still have one more thing to think about."

"What's left? We've accounted for almost any circumstances."

"What about us being, I don't know, good people?"

Hordak raises a brow, "What are you talking about?"

"We can't take over the Horde if we're going to keep being bad people. We might as well just let Horde Prime keep ruling the Horde if we do that."

Hordak seems to think about this for a second, before sighing in defeat, "You're right. We'd just be replacing them if we continue. I

don’t want to be like Horde Prime, and I know you don’t want to be like Shadow Weaver.”

They both grimaced at the thought of replacing their mentors and essentially becoming the younger versions of them.

“But what do we do?”

“Let’s just try and brainstorm some ideas.”

Way Too Much Time Later…

Hordak groans from his spot sprawled out on the hardwood floor, “This is impossible!”

Adora mumbles in agreement while she buries her face in a pillow on her bed. She’s considering just falling asleep here and letting Hordak find his own way of sneaking out without being noticed by Shadow Weaver.

She’s awoken by a throw pillow hitting the back of her head, ruining her hair, which has been out of its usual ponytail all day.

“If I'm not allowed to sleep, then you can’t either," he grumbles with a loud yawn.

Adora runs a hand down her face, “Hordak, we can’t do this on our own.”

Hordak seems surprised to see Adora giving up so soon. He’s never seen Adora give up before, and he’s known her for over five hundred years. “So, what are we supposed to do, find someone to teach us how to be good people?”

He was being sarcastic when he said this, obviously, but that’s exactly what Adora plans to do. She stares at her friend until understanding dawns on his face.

“No.”

“Hordak, come on.”

“I will not do that.”

“It won’t be that bad.”

“No, Adora. I refuse to ask the princesses for help!”

The next day…

The skiff drives through the Whispering Woods, leading Adora and Hordak to Brightmoon.

Adora has a smug grin on her face as she looks over at Hordak that reads, `*I win.*”

Hordak crosses his arms and pouts, “Shut up.”

“I didn’t say anything!”

Chapter End Notes

> So, now you guys know! Adora is totally immune to dark magic. Before you guys ask, Adora was affected by SW's magic in an earlier chapter because SW was choking her with the magic. No amount of experience would make Adora able to breathe without air.
>
> Chapter title credit: Sue Zhao, Dialogues on Love #4, "Maybe I already do"
>
> I would also like to clarify that the chapter title is talking about PARENTAL love!!! NOT ROMANTIC!!! GUYS DON"T SHIP ADORA WITH HER ABUSIVE MOTHER-FIGURE!!!

Adora and Hordak's Guide to Being Better People

Chapter Summary

Adora and Hordak get some assistance in learning how to be better people.

It goes as well as you expect it to.

Chapter Notes

Hey! This chapter is a total rollercoaster, but I hope it's in a good way.

I hope you guys enjoy this chapter!! If you do, you could leave a kudo, a comment, or both! I appreciate comments so so much and I love reading them all.

There's a map of Etheria at the end of this chapter, btw!

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: violence (mentioned), death (mentioned), panic attack

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The skiff drives through the Whispering Woods, leading Adora and Hordak to Brightmoon.

Adora has a smug grin on her face as she looks over at Hordak that reads, 'I win."

Hordak crosses his arms and pouts, "Shut up."

"I didn't say anything!"

"Well, you were thinking about it."

Adora laughs as she drives the skiff, "Oh, come on, stop being so grumpy. At this rate, Queen Angella will banish us from Brightmoon before we even step in."

Hordak turns in the direction the skiff is going, already seeing the tall palace looming above the trees. He sighs, knowing Adora's right but not wanting to admit it, "Fine. I'll be on my best behaviour." Adora chuckles again at his sarcasm.

Eventually, the two friends clear the thick forest and see Brightmoon Palace in all its glory. The Moonstone glows consistently above Brightmoon, casting colourful lights down onto the castle. There is a gigantic mountain directly behind the palace that pours bright blue water down underneath the castle via a waterfall.

Adora snorts, "It's very… bright."

Beside her, Hordak chuckles, "Maybe that's why it's called *Brightmoon*."

They sober up once they remember why they're here. To ask people who most likely see them as cruel monsters to help them become good people. Well, as good as two vampires who are about to overthrow their government can be.

They walk down the long bridge that leads to the front foyer of the palace. As soon as they make it near the castle, two guards run over to them frantically.

"Halt! Halt, I say!"

Adora and Hordak stop, as per the guards' requests.

The guards come to stand in front of them, looking out of breath. Adora can't tell if they're struggling to breathe because they ran here or because they're scared. Either way, Adora tries to smile as nicely as she can. The guards only seem more put off by her smile.

“What is your business in Brightmoon?”

Hordak answers instead of Adora, “We are here to discuss some matters with Princess Glimmer.”

The guards raise an eyebrow at that, “You are? Did Princess Glimmer request for your presence?”

The two vampires smile sheepishly at that. Adora answers this time, “Well, we were actually hoping to request for her presence…”

Both guards turn to look at the other with knowing looks, having an entire argument with only their eyes. This might be harder than they thought.

One guard turns back to them, while the other turns around to face the palace. “Come with us.” The guard turns, too, and both guards walk towards the castle. Adora and Hordak follow closely behind them, but not too close.

The four of them quickly make it inside of the castle. The guards walk stoically in front of them, while Adora and Hordak look around the elegantly decorated palace halls. There are bright pastel colours everywhere and decorative artwork scattered throughout the palace. It’s a stark difference from Prime’s lair, which is mostly boring white and green walls and empty halls with clones watching you at every corner.

It’s only once they reach the large extravagant doors which lead to Queen Angella’s throne room Adora gets nervous about this plan. What if Glimmer refuses to help them? It wouldn’t be surprising, given how Adora treated her the last time they saw each other.

The doors open and the guards step aside to allow Adora and Hordak into the room. Adora can already see Angella sitting confidently at her ornate throne hovering in the air.

Adora and Hordak glance at each other anxiously before walking in.

As soon as the ruler sees Adora and Hordak walking in, her eyes widen in surprise. Horde representatives rarely leave the Horde if they don't need to, and they definitely don't show up at Brightmoon Palace unannounced.

The two vampires reach the end of the throne room, standing awkwardly in front of the Queen. Adora goes to kneel but notices that Hordak isn't moving from his spot. She elbows him in the rib and he gets the hint quickly. They both kneel with their heads bowed for exactly three seconds.

While Adora's never respected Shadow Weaver, she tries to respect Horde Prime for the most part; the alternatives being execution or worse, banishment. Since Horde Prime makes it a rule for all of his followers to bow at his throne, she always does. Hordak never bows since he's almost always standing beside Horde Prime instead of in front of him.

Adora and Hordak stand back up to see the Queen looking at them with a conflicted face. Glimmer must have told her what happened. She must already be planning how to banish them as quickly as possible. Oh man, Shadow Weaver is going to ki-

Queen Angella cuts her thoughts off with the clearing of her throat, "What is your business in Brightmoon?" Her voice is sharp and to the point, while also having a touch of natural gentleness to it.

Hordak acts confident, but Adora knows he's just as nervous as her, "We would like to discuss some matters with your daughter, Princess Glimmer."

Angella raises a brow, "My daughter? What matters must you speak with my daughter about that you cannot speak to me about?" The previous gentle tone in her voice has disappeared.

Adora gulps and fidgets with her fingers, “Well, we could go to you, but we understand you might be very busy and that you have a lot to do so you might not want to-” The words tumble out of her mouth before she can stop them.

Angella is about to cut off Adora’s word vomit but is interrupted by her daughter’s voice at the doors.

“Adora? What are you doing here?”

The blonde looks like she’s about to faint in her own panic, and whips around to face the purple-haired princess, “Glimmer! It’s great to see you again! We were just asking for you, actually.”

Glimmer walks towards Adora with a confused look etched into her face. Her mother interrupts her before she can speak.

“We didn’t allow you to speak to her yet!”

The princess rolls her eyes, “Mom, it’s fine! I can handle a couple of vampires.”

Adora snickers. All eyes fall on her, and her smile instantly vanishes. “We won’t hurt a princess inside her own palace, or ever. How evil do you think we are?”

Angella looks anywhere but at Adora and Hordak, showing that she definitely thought they were evil enough to do that.

Glimmer looks at Adora instead of her mother, “Follow me. We can talk in the meeting room. There aren't any meetings for the rest of the day.” She turns around and walks out of the room. Adora and Hordak turn back to the Queen, smiling awkwardly before speed-walking out of the room as fast as they can.

They walk to the meeting room to see Glimmer sitting in one chair at a round table patiently. Adora and Hordak walk in and sit down in the chairs opposite her.

Glimmer intertwines her fingers on the table in front of her to look confident. It doesn't seem to work very well. "So, what did you want to discuss?"

Adora and Hordak, on the other hand, are the exact opposite of confident at the moment. The blonde vampire is fidgeting with her fingers and looking anywhere but at Glimmer, and the blue-haired vampire is visibly sweating as he looks down at the table. When they were making the plan to come here to ask for help, they never considered how many things could go wrong. Or how embarrassing this is.

Adora is the first to look at Glimmer, a conflicted look on her face, "We need your help." Hordak nods as he looks up, too.

Glimmer's eyebrows scrunch together. What could two vampires possibly need a princess' help for? She doesn't say that, obviously, opting for a nicer tone, "What do you need?" Normally, she never would've offered to help someone from the Horde so quickly, but she feels guilty for yelling at Adora the last time they talked.

"Can you help us be better people?"

The purple-haired girl's eyes widen as she stares at Adora and Hordak. That was the last thing she was expecting from them. "What?"

Hordak sighs, "We want to be… good people, but we don't know how."

Glimmer's eyes soften, "You want to be good people? Why?"

Adora and Hordak glance at each other, deciding whether or not to tell Glimmer their plans to kill Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver. It's agreed that Glimmer needs to know for her to agree. There's no way she'd believe them without knowing.

They both turn back to Glimmer, but Adora's the one who answers, "We're planning to take over the Horde, and we want to be good when we do."

Glimmer's eyes widened again, looking like they're about to pop out of her head, "You're planning to *overthrow Horde Prime* and you didn't think to mention that?!"

Hordak shrugs, "That's not why we're here. We don't need your help with that."

Adora nods, "Yeah, don't worry about that. What we need your help with is being better people. Can you help us?"

The two vampires wait for Glimmer to respond. The Brightmoon princess' jaw hangs open as she looks between the two vampires. Eventually, she regains some composure and shakes her head. She sighs, knowing this is going to be a challenge, "Yes, I'll help you."

Hordak and Adora cheer and high-five, surprised that Glimmer agreed to help. To be fair, Glimmer's surprised she agreed, too, but what does she have to lose by helping people be good?

Glimmer smiles at their friendly gesture. She really assumed the worst from these people, but maybe they're not as evil as she previously thought.

They turn back to Glimmer, both with bright smiles on their faces. Glimmer tries her best not to glance at their sharp fangs. Adora looks like she's practically vibrating with excitement, "So, where do we start?"

Glimmer hums as she thinks about it. "Well, if you're trying to be good people, you should start by acknowledging why you want to be good people, right? So, why do you want to be good people?"

Adora looks prepared for this question, sitting up straighter in her chair, "Well, when we kill Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver, we'll take over their roles as Horde Lord and Second-in-Command. If we act the same way as we have for the past few centuries, then we'll be just like them when we rule the Horde. There's no point in replacing them if we're exactly like them in the end. We want vampires to be happy without having to kill to survive. We want

the Horde to be better and, for that to happen, we have to be better."

Unbeknownst to Glimmer, Adora and Hordak have spent a lot of time planning for what to do once they've become the rulers of the Horde. They decided Adora should be Horde Lord, and Hordak should be her Second-in-Command. It was Adora's idea to even try this, and she's the one who's come up with a lot of the ideas for the new Fright Zone. It's only fair that she is the one to rule the kingdom. Besides, Hordak isn't suited for a leadership role like Horde Lord. He'd probably start a war across the planet within minutes.

Moments of silence pass as Glimmer processes everything Adora just said. After a few seconds, she pauses, "Wait, you want vampires to stop killing? But how are you supposed to survive?" As much as she doesn't want to admit it, vampires must kill in order to survive. It's common knowledge on Etheria.

Hordak sits up in his chair, "We want to ask Entrapta to run some experiments on animal blood to find out if we can drink that instead of human blood. If it works, we could stop killing humans entirely."

Glimmer sits back in her seat. Huh. She never thought about that. Glimmer is so busy thinking about the possibility of the Horde being good that she doesn't notice that she hasn't spoken at all in a couple of minutes.

Adora peers over at Glimmer anxiously after silence passes for far too long, "Princess Glimmer?" When the shorter girl doesn't answer, Adora turns to Hordak, "Oh no, we broke a princess."

That makes Glimmer snap out of her own thoughts with a shake of her head, "No, I'm fine, just thinking." The vampires sigh in relief.

Hordak nods, "So… what now?"

Glimmer rakes her hands through her hair as she thinks. She finally comes up with an idea eventually, "If you want to be better people, you should acknowledge why you're bad people. Once you know what you've done wrong, you can start changing your behaviour."

Adora and Hordak seem confused by the question, so Glimmer tries to elaborate.

"Okay, how many people have each of you killed? Let's start there."

Both vampires seem to think hard about the question. Adora even starts counting on her fingers as Hordak looks up at the ceiling while he thinks.

"You lost count?!" Glimmer already sounds exasperated, and they haven't even done anything yet.

Adora's face brightens, "Oh, I know! Well, I don't know the exact number, but I'd say it's about ten thousand-ish." The fact that she says this so casually only shocks Glimmer more.

The princess' eyes look like they're about to pop out again, "WHAT?! You've killed over ten-thousand people?!"

"...Yes?" Adora looks sheepish as she curls into herself.

Glimmer turns to Hordak, "What about you? How many people have you killed?" She tries to keep her voice calm, but it sounds shrill even to her own ears.

Hordak looks a lot more nervous now that he saw how Glimmer reacted to Adora's number. "Uh… Around five-thousand, maybe?"

Glimmer puts her face into both of her hands. This is going to be way harder than she thought it would be.

Adora and Hordak glance at each other nervously before turning back to an exhausted-looking Glimmer. Hordak frowns, "Are you

alright, Princess Glimmer?"

The princess' head rises again to face the two vampires, "We're going to need more help."

A few calls later…

The princesses (plus Sea Hawk and Bow) sit around the meeting table looking at Adora and Hordak, who have the decency to look embarrassed.

Mermista is the first to speak, "So… why are we here exactly?"

Glimmer stands up, grabbing the attention of everyone. She raises a hand toward the two vampires sitting beside her, "Adora and Hordak want to be good people, but they don't know how. Do you guys want to help them?"

Perfuma already looks excited to help, "Oh, that's wonderful! I'd love to help them."

Scorpia looks almost as excited as her girlfriend, "This is going to be so fun, guys! I'll help them, too."

Mermista nods, "Okay, I'll help, too." Sea Hawk raises two thumbs up towards Adora and Hordak to show his agreement.

Frosta creates a fist of ice on top of her own, "I want to help, but only if I can punch one of them in the face."

Glimmer is about to interject that Frosta is definitely not doing that, but Adora interrupts her, "Uh- you can punch me if you want." Her voice is sheepish and quiet, as if she's worried she's overstepping in a conversation about her and Hordak. Frosta's eyes flash with something just a little too violent for an 11-year-old. Adora's eyes flash with immediate regret at her own words.

Glimmer huffs, "Frosta, you are not punching Adora!" She turns to the last two people left at the table, "Bow? Entrapta? Are you

guys in?”

Bow nods with a bright smile, “Of course! I can’t wait to help.”

Adora smiles at Bow’s words. He was the first person he met in Brightmoon, and he’s been nothing but kind to her. Is this what all the humans in Brightmoon are like? Maybe she should’ve tried *talking* to them instead of killing them immediately…

Entrapta looks up from a tiny robot she was tinkering with. She looks around at the people staring at her expectantly until she finally remembers what they asked, “Oh, sorry! I assumed everyone knew I would help Hordak and Adora. Yes, I will help them.”

Hordak smiles for the first time since arriving as he turns to the purple-haired scientist, “Actually, Entrapta, we had an idea we wanted you to test out, if you want to.” Entrapta practically has stars in her eyes as she takes out her voice recorder, ready to listen. Glimmer sighs and stops Entrapta before she gets caught up in her work.

“Entrapta, can you leave the tinkering for later, please? As soon as Adora and Hordak are busy, you can work, okay?”

The Princess of Dryl nods but continues to tinker with her tiny robot, anyway.

Glimmer sighs, turning back to the rest of the group, “Okay, so we didn’t get far without you guys. How about we start with Adora and Hordak telling us the number of people they’ve killed?” She looks over to Adora and Hordak expectantly, awaiting their responses. The other princesses seem confused about the seemingly random question. The number probably isn’t that high, is it? Maybe like fifty, sixty...

Hordak tries to keep his voice monotone, but it already sounds meeker than normal, “Around five-thousand.”

Every person's jaw falls open at the admittance, except for Glimmer and Entrapta's. Glimmer turns to Adora. The blonde blushes awkwardly as she fiddles with her fingers, "Uh… Ten-thousand-ish."

A beat of shocked silence passes before everyone speaks at once.

"How did you kill so many people?!"

"They're *immortal*, Scorpia. They're probably like… thousands of years old, or something."

"Where do you put the bodies?"

"Does everyone in the Horde kill that much?"

"What do you kill them with?"

"Have you ever killed a princess before?"

Adora and Hordak sit awkwardly as they're bombarded with questions they don't have enough time to answer. Glimmer gets the room's attention with a loud yell, "GUYS!"

The overlapped talking cuts off as they turn to face the Brightmoon princess. "We can't all talk at once, and this isn't about asking Adora and Hordak questions about their killing. The whole point of this is so they can stop killing!"

They all nod, agreeing, and get to work planning how they're going to do this.

Some time later…

Adora and Hordak sit cross-legged side by side as they face Perfuma, who's sitting in front of them in the same position. All three of them have their eyes closed as Perfuma speaks.

"Now… I want you both to think of things you've done which you feel guilty for."

All they've been doing for the past half-hour is some breathing exercises as Adora and Hordak listen to Perfuma speak, but this is their first question from the flower princess.

Hordak speaks first, after taking a deep breath, "I feel guilty for listening to everything Horde Prime told me… and killing all those humans. I ruined so many peoples' lives."

After a moment of silence, Adora responds, "I feel guilty for killing so many humans and helping Shadow Weaver with her dark magic. I'm a monster." Adora also feels guilty for how she treated Catra and Glimmer, but she doesn't mention that, for their good and her own.

The two were initially hesitant to try meditating with Perfuma, but they quickly opened up after a few breathing exercises and calming conversations. It's crazy how much stress you can hold when you're living with over five-hundred-year-old burdens, and how nice it can be to ease some of that weight off your shoulders. The scented candles and dim lighting are relaxing, too.

Perfuma hums in acknowledgment, "Very good, you guys. You're doing great so far." Both Adora and Hordak smile warmly at that, despite nobody seeing them. Maybe there's a chance for them, after all…

"Okay, now I want you to say what you each want to do to become a better person."

The blonde vampire takes a calming breath, "I want to stop killing humans, be kinder to others, and I want to help other vampires become good people, too. I want to make the Horde a kingdom where good vampires are welcome."

Perfuma nods, "What about you, Hordak?"

The blue-haired man clears his throat, "I want to stop killing humans and be kinder to humans, too. I want to help Entrapta find a way for vampires to survive without having to kill humans. I want vampires to be happy."

"Those were some amazing answers, you guys should be proud." Adora doesn't know if she's blushing from the praise or from the faint heat of the candles.

Perfuma takes a deep breath, "Now… You two do understand that this won't be easy, correct? Becoming better people won't happen in one day or maybe even one year. It takes time and effort to change yourself for the better."

Adora and Hordak mimic Perfuma's breathing as Adora hangs her head, "Yes, we know. This is going to be difficult, but we want to see this all the way through."

Hordak adds, "We're willing to put in as much time and effort as we need to be better. It's the least Etheria deserves for all we've done." Adora nods in agreement, despite neither of them being able to see her.

Perfuma smiles warmly. It's so wonderful to see two people who have been so cruel in the past be open to such a big change in their lives. On the other hand, she's worried that Adora and Hordak don't know what they're getting themselves into, which is why she already knows what they're going to do next with Glimmer.

"You guys did great for your first time meditating! Let's do some breathing exercises, then we can go."

Perfuma guides them through a few more breathing exercises, Adora and Hordak filling up their old lungs with candle-scented air. It does wonders to make them feel more relaxed than they have in years.

Eventually, they all stand up, ready for Glimmer to help them with one last thing for the day.

Glimmer

The Princess of Brightmoon watches the door to the meeting room open to reveal a very calm-looking Adora and Hordak, followed by Perfuma. They're all smiling serenely and laughing as they practically float into the room.

Her mouth twitches as she's about to smile, but she doesn't. She's happy that Adora and Hordak had a calming session with Perfuma, but becoming good people will not be calming in the slightest. It's going to be tiring, and painful, and heartbreaking. They need to do this, though.

Perfuma slips out of the room once Adora and Hordak make it inside. Once the two vampires see Glimmer's stern facial expression, their smiles fade as they sit down opposite to the purple-haired princess.

Adora's voice cuts through the uncomfortable silence, already sounding nervous, "So… what's next?"

With a swipe of her hand, Glimmer makes a hologram of Etheria appear on the meeting table. After another swipe, what must be thousands of red dots bloom all across the entire map. Well, almost the entire map. There isn't a single dot in the Fright Zone. Adora and Hordak both know where this is going and immediately feel all of Perfuma's calming energy drain out of them.

Glimmer looks down mournfully at all the red dots. She lifts her head up to look at Adora and Hordak, who have similar looks on their faces, "These are all the documented places where someone has been killed by a vampire in the past few years." She focuses her eyes on a single dot in Brightmoon Palace. The dot that represents her father, King Micah.

Neither Adora nor Hordak look up at Glimmer from the screen, too engrossed with the sheer amount of dots below them. How many

of those were caused by them? How many of those humans did they witness die? Could one of them have killed her da-

Glimmer shakes her head to stop that thought in its tracks. It'll do nothing to think about that. All she can do now is try to honour him, and she can do that by helping the Horde become a better place.

The purple-haired girl opens her mouth to begin the speech she planned for Adora and Hordak that explains to them why murder is bad. She was expecting them to defend their action at least a little, but they've been completely silent this entire time.

It's only when she sees both of their eyes glistening with unshed tears that she clamps her mouth shut. Glimmer sits down and waits for them to say something or, you know, react at all. She's surprised all it took for them to start crying was seeing all the dots. Well, they've probably never seen all of their kills visualized like this before, living in blissful ignorance before Glimmer showed them the board. Glimmer can hardly imagine what they're going through right now, almost feeling a little pity for the vampires. All of that hidden guilt building and building for centuries only to snap one day and come pouring out at once.

After a minute of silence, a small whimper comes from Adora. Glimmer looks up to see Hordak visibly shaking from across the table. She tries to break the almost painful silence as gently as she can, "Guys? Are you okay?"

That was definitely not the right thing to say as the dam holding both of their emotions together explodes into a million tiny pieces. Adora lets out a sob, followed by quick tears rolling down her face. She hides her face in her hands and pulls her knees to her chest as her sobs wracked her body loudly. Hordak is crying too, but he has both his hands on the side of his head as he looks down at the dots with a horrified look on his face.

Could this get any worse?

Just Under Five minutes later…

It *definitely* could get worse.

After both Adora and Hordak began crying, Glimmer tried her best to comfort them. She tried talking, but both their brains seem to be going too fast to hear her. Also, Adora's crying way too much to speak right now. Hordak sits in the same position as before, obsessively staring at the board as quiet tears roll down his face and he murmurs unintelligible nothings.

Glimmer stands up and moves to kneel in front of Adora, who's taken to sitting curled up on the floor beside the table with her arms over her head, rocking herself as sobs continue to roll out of her. She looks like she's protecting herself from a hit. The blonde is barely breathing, gasping for every breath.

"Adora? Can you look up for me?"

The sight that greets Glimmer breaks her heart, despite only having met Adora a week ago. Adora's eyes and face are puffy and red from crying, and there's a mix of dried and fresh tears on her cheeks. Her breathing is still rough and coming out in gasps.

Glimmer raises a hand to touch Adora's shoulder but hesitates. She looks back up into red eyes, "Can I touch you?"

Adora nods, so Glimmer gently places her hands on Adora's shoulders, hoping it will ground the vampire to the present. The princess smiles, "I need you to breathe with me, okay? Let's take a deep breath together."

Glimmer inhales deeply and then exhales the same air. She looks expectantly at Adora, waiting for her to follow.

Adora tries, but cannot mimic Glimmer. She panics again, practically hyperventilating at this point.

Glimmer tries an alternative approach. “Okay, how about this. When I move my hands up your arms, we’ll breathe in together, and then when I move my hands down your arms, we’ll breathe out together, okay?”

She waits for Adora to nod, wanting her to understand what’s happening around her. Once she does, Glimmer’s arms slowly slide up Adora’s arm. While she does this, Glimmer inhales as deeply as she can. Adora tries and takes one large inhale, even if it is incredibly shaky. They hold their breath for a second, then Glimmer slides her hands downwards and they exhale at the same time.

They repeat this process until Adora has calmed down and can breathe normally, mostly. Once Glimmer is certain that Adora will be alright, she takes her hands off, “You did great, Adora.”

Adora looks at Glimmer as if she’s about to smile, but she falters, instead opting to look down shamefully. Glimmer, not wanting to interrogate Adora after seeing her so vulnerable, lets it go.

Suddenly, Adora seems to remember something urgent. She tries to stand up quickly, but she wobbles on her shaky legs. Glimmer is at Adora’s side in a second, pushing her to sit down after what just happened. “What’s wrong, Adora?”

Adora seems frantic as she scans the room, but her vision is limited from her spot on the floor, “Is Hordak okay? He just found out the same news as me.”

Oh, yeah. Glimmer was so worried about Adora’s panic attack that she forgot Hordak was there. He didn’t *seem* in as bad of a state as Adora, though. She stands up to see how the blue-haired man is doing, only to see him asleep at the meeting table. The crying must have exhausted all his energy. Glimmer kneels back down to an anxious Adora.

“Well? Is he okay or not?” Adora looks ready to get up and help her friend at any moment, despite her tired state.

Glimmer grins as she remembers Hordak sleepily drooling on the table, “Don’t worry, he’s fine. He’s actually asleep at the table right now.”

Adora sighs in relief, sagging further into her spot on the floor. Glimmer goes and sits beside Adora, mimicking her sitting position, with her knees pulled up to her knees and her head resting on the top of her knees. The two girls sit in silence, but it isn’t uncomfortable like earlier.

Adora breaks the silence.

“T-Thank you, Glimmer.” She leans her head on Glimmer’s shoulder.

“You’re welcome, Adora.” Glimmer smiles down at her.

Chapter End Notes

> Here's a map of Etheria to help you visualize everything happening in this fic!! I tried to make it as accurate as possible to canon, and I also used a reference pic from He-Man. So, before you get mad at me for the map being geographically or canonically incorrect, blame He-Man (or me, I don't mind). By the way, the Northern Reach and the Kingdom of Snows are meant to be switched. I spent a maximum of five minutes making the map, but whatever. Doing a shitty job is better than doing no job.



Ok, I KNOWW this looks like it was drawn by a 4-year-old, and that the colours are annoying, but at least you can read it, right? It's too late to change it, anyway.

If you guys are ever curious, I can make a map that also includes Eternia and Horde Legion because that one is entirely different.

Just so you guys know, Horde Prime did eventually figure out the whole cloning thing in the end. That's why he has clones at his lair. Hordak was his second attempt (first if you forget about Imp) at cloning, and he figures it out soon after.

Ok, bye-bye!

the princess and the lonely vampire

Chapter Summary

Glimmer is curious.

Hordak and Entrapta do an experiment.

Catra forgives.

Adora saves a life.

Chapter Notes

Hey! I'm really excited for you guys to read this chapter! It has a lot of POV switches in it because it's pretty much just a group of one-shots. I don't really want to talk a lot about Adora and Hordak's good people lessons because they're pretty uneventful in my opinion. If you want more info on it, you can check out the endnotes, but this chapter goes over the important stuff.

I really hope you guys enjoy this chapter! I had a lot of fun writing it and may have cried a tiny bit at one point (I won't spoil it)! If you do enjoy this, you could leave a kudo or a comment, or both! They are both so appreciated and any comments (even constructive criticism ones) bring a smile to my face.

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: panic attacks, violence, mentions of blood

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day 1: Glimmer

And so that's how Glimmer ends up sitting on the floor with one vampire napping on her shoulder beside her and another asleep at her meeting table.

Glimmer glances down at the sleeping blonde beside her. Adora's eyes are puffy and red, but her face is relaxed and peaceful. The purple-haired girl sighs as she notices the faint tear tracks still visible on Adora's cheeks.

She knew Adora felt guilty about her actions, but she didn't know to what extent. Well, it has been… a really long time. Of course, she feels guilty, but enough to have a panic attack so suddenly?

Glimmer was always under the impression that vampires are unfeeling monsters, knowing nothing other than the taste of human blood. What else was she meant to think? She'd grown up with her mom, telling her all about how vampires were monsters and evil, and then she had to find out a vampire had killed her father.

She'd never known that vampires could feel emotions, much less have emotions as strong as the ones Adora just had. Glancing down at Adora, Glimmer doesn't see a monster, she sees a friend. A friend who needs her help.

Glimmer is so distracted while looking down at Adora that she forgets Hordak is there, too, until she hears his voice over the wave of silence that had washed over the three of them.

"Is she alright?"

Glimmer smiles warmly as she looks down at Adora for one more second before turning her gaze upward. It's sweet that the first thing both Adora and Hordak did after their own guilt mostly subsided was asked how the other is doing. She's glad they both have had someone to look out for them over the years.

"She's doing okay now," Glimmer debates adding what just happened, "She- um- she had a panic attack earlier."

Hordak sends a sad look towards Adora as his eyebrows bunch together in concern.

The Brightmoon princess raises a weak brow, "You don't seem very surprised at that. Does Adora get panic attacks a lot?" Glimmer doesn't know where this sudden curiosity came from. Maybe she just wants to know what emotions vampires feel.

At that, Hordak gives Glimmer a conflicted look. Eventually, he sighs, "It's not my place to tell you this, but… yes, she does. Life has not been very kind to Adora, and it has taken a toll on her."

That's a very… cryptic answer, but Glimmer lets it slide with a nod. It's the best she's probably going to get from him. Maybe she can ask Adora later…

Before she can even plan how to ask Adora about her past, Hordak's voice cuts in again.

"Don't ask her what happened." While his voice was calm and even a little gentle earlier, it now has a sharp, warning tone to it.

Glimmer attempts to lighten the mood, "I mean, can you blame me for being a little curious?"

Hordak sneers slightly at her, "I'm warning you, Princess Glimmer, don't ask her. I don't think you want to know, and I know she doesn't want to tell you." Glimmer is almost certain now that Hordak knows what Glimmer said to Adora the first time they spoke. Those two are practically best friends, of course Adora told him. Glimmer gulps and nods, nervous.

With that, the two fall into a silence. The tension in the room is so thick someone could cut it in half with a sword.

After what feels like an eternity, Hordak stands up slowly and walks to stand in front of the two girls sitting in front of the floor. The blue-haired man kneels down and outstretches an arm. Glimmer flinches instinctively, but Hordak's hand moves to Adora's

shoulder instead. He sends her a glare as he lightly shakes Adora's shoulder to wake her up.

"Adora, wake up. We're leaving now, come on." Glimmer almost does a double-take upon hearing his voice. She's never heard him sound half as gentle as he does now.

Slowly, but surely, Adora peeks her eyes open to look at Hordak. She rubs her eyes despite the tears having dried long ago. Glimmer notices Adora's hands shake slightly, and turns away, feeling like she's intruding on a vulnerable moment. She hears the two vampires' voices.

"Are you alright, Adora?"

There's a pause.

"Yeah, I'm okay." Adora's voice is weak and hoarse from the crying, barely above a whisper.

"Come on, let's go."

Glimmer turns to see Hordak grab Adora's hand and pull her up. Neither of them are standing as confidently as when they first walked in. Glimmer stands with them just as the double doors open to reveal the others.

They all cautiously walk into the room wearing awkward smiles. Bow is the first to break the awkward silence, waving at the vampires, "Hey guys… Wh-What's up?"

"We're leaving," Hordak deadpans. As soon as he says this, he and Adora rush towards the door. Hordak makes sure Adora's behind him before turning down the corridor that leads to the front of the castle. Adora stumbles a couple of times as she glances at the others for a split second before she makes it to the door and walks down the same corridor.

Everyone turns to Glimmer.

“So… I’m assuming it didn’t go well?”

Glimmer sighs, “I think it could’ve gone better, Bow.”

Day 1: Adora

Her shaky legs lead her to the front of the palace, where their skiff lays waiting for them. Hordak’s already waiting for her on the machinery, looking… angry?

Adora boards the skiff and moves to grab the steering handle of the skiff. Before her hand can contact the metal, Hordak grabs her wrist gently and stands to take over the controls.

“I can drive, it’s fine.”

“It’s not fine, Adora. *You’re* not fine, so go sit down, okay?”

Adora nods at his aggressive kindness and goes to sit down opposite of Hordak. The frigid chill of the metal on her hands helps ground her to the present.

The skiff comes to life as Hordak ignites the engine, and they fly back into the Whispering Woods. Neither of them speaks, letting the rustling of the leaves be the only sound they hear.

Eventually, Adora looks up at Hordak.

His face is stoic, but there’s a slight quiver to his lip that gives him away. His knuckles are white from gripping the controls so tightly. He’s shaking so badly that Adora can see it from her spot on the floor of the skiff.

“Hordak?” She says this as gently as she can.

The man turns his head to the side to glance at her, “Yes?” His voice is shaking.

“Are you okay?” It’s more of a rhetorical question that Adora already knows the answer to, but she asks anyway.

That single question breaks any walls that Hordak had built up. Tears quickly pool in his eyes and slide down his face, dripping onto his arm. He quickly shuts his eyes to quell his feelings, but that only makes more tears come. A small sob escapes him before he can stop it.

Adora quickly stands and takes the controls from Hordak as the blue-haired man stumbles backwards until he’s sitting in the same spot Adora was moments ago. Adora drives the skiff, ensuring they reach their destination and not a hospital, as Hordak sobs into his hands.

She says nothing as she lets Hordak feel the emotions he’s been burying for however many years, knowing Hordak won’t have a chance once they reach Horde Prime’s manor. Adora listens to make sure he isn’t having a panic attack while trying to give him the space he needs.

After some time, Hordak’s weak voice rasps out, “I’m sorry.”

Adora turns to look at him for a moment, “Don’t be sorry for having emotions, Hordak. You don’t have to hide them with me. We’re friends, remember?” The ghost of a smile traces Hordak’s face but disappears as quickly as it came. He nods, so Adora turns back around.

The blonde assumes Hordak will stay quiet now, but she hears his voice from behind her again.

“ I should help you, not the other way around.”

Adora doesn’t turn around this time, “It wouldn’t be fair if you got to help me, but I didn’t help you. You’re not my *babysitter*, and I’m very capable of helping you.” It makes her frustrated sometimes when Hordak treats her like some helpless baby, but she tries not to let it annoy her too much. She knows it comes from a place of care.

That pulls a weak chuckle out of Hordak, "You *are* very capable of helping me, Adora. Thank you."

Adora smiles, "You're welcome. Now, do you want to talk about what we just saw, or do you want to keep sitting in silence?" Her offer might have been a little inspired by Perfuma's meditating sessions. Maybe talking about your feelings is actually a good thing…

"Okay. Let's talk."

Day 5: Hordak

Entrapta runs around her castle laboratory carrying an assortment of vials containing fresh animal blood. Hordak considers warning her to be careful but knows she's way too busy right now to focus on her safety.

Entrapta places a drop of one blood onto a microscope tray and inspects it. After recording her inspections, she takes the vial and shoves it toward Hordak with her hair.

"Drink this!"

Hordak takes the vial cautiously, "Can you tell me what it is before I drink it, please?" He and Adora have been working on saying 'please' and 'thank you' more often with Perfuma.

Entrapta explains as she works on the next vial, "It's cow blood! I checked it to make sure it's safe, so there's an eighty-five percent chance you'll be fine."

Eighty-five percent? That's good enough, Hordak supposes. Besides, this is for a good cause.

He drinks the contents of the small vial, expecting it to taste terrible or maybe hurt a little, but nothing happens. In fact, the cow's blood tastes almost exactly like human blood, and he feels

fine. If anything, he feels better than usual after drinking human blood.

Entrapta turns back to him, “So, how do you feel? What did it taste like?”

“I feel… great! The cow blood tastes exactly like human blood, and I feel better than I usually do when I drink human blood.”

“Fascinating…” Entrapta takes out her recorder again and mumbles the recent information into it, but Hordak can’t hear her over his excitement.

He doesn’t have to drink human blood anymore. He can live without killing. He… He has to tell Adora about this! This is revolutionary! This could change the way the Horde functions forever! They could actually make the Horde good!

Hordak stands up and goes to the door, but a thick strand of Entrapta’s hair stops him.

“Where are you going? The experiment isn’t over yet.”

Hordak turns back to her, “What’s left? We know we can drink animal blood, so let’s go tell Adora.”

“Yes, but just because the cow's blood hasn’t hurt you yet doesn’t mean it won’t later. You have to wait here until your body digests it, then we have to try the other blood samples I have.”

Sighing, Hordak reluctantly moves back into his seat. He knows Entrapta’s right, but that doesn’t make the wait any more unbearable.

“So, how long will it take for my body to digest the blood?”

Entrapta hums as she considers it, “Hm… around four hours!” Hordak groans at the time he must wait for.

Many, Many Hours Later...

After what felt like an eternity, Entrapta finally went through all her blood samples and recorded all the side effects of each of them.

Hordak feels like a guinea pig at a laboratory, but he's just glad it's over, and that he didn't get hurt at all during the process. They have their results, and now they know that Horde Prime was indeed lying when he told the Horde that animal blood is toxic to vampires.

Entrapta grabs a piece of paper from a desk, skimming over it.

"Okay, so we tested cow, chicken, pig, boar, deer, cat, and dog blood. Cow and boar blood have healing properties, chicken and pig blood are the closest to human blood based on taste, cat blood has hallucinatory properties, and dog blood has no benefits to it."

Hordak grimaces, "Do I even want to know where you found all that animal blood?"

Entrapta looks up at him from the paper, "Oh, I went to animal shelters and farms asking for test samples!"

Hordak sighs in relief, though the thought of Entrapta going around Etheria asking for blood almost makes him laugh. He's glad nobody had to suffer for this experiment, or lose their life for the sake of curiosity.

"We should go find Adora and tell her the news. Come on, Hordak!" Entrapta practically runs out of the laboratory, eager to show off her victory of an experiment. Hordak follows her with a bright smile on his face.

Maybe there's hope for them, after all.

Day 15: Catra

She walks down the castle halls confidently, with Melog by her side. Her hair feels so much lighter now that she's cut it from her mid-back length to a messy pixie cut.

Catra doesn't know what inspired her to cut her hair. Or to cut it herself without telling her mom. She almost laughs as she remembers the look of horror on her mother's face when she saw Catra holding a pair of scissors in her washroom, surrounded by her own hair on the floor. That huge mane was unnecessarily difficult to clean, and Catra hates water. Her shower time has nearly been cut in half without the need to wash her hair for as long.

Today is a relatively uneventful day, with nothing planned for Catra or her parents. Any meetings planned today are already over, seeing as how the sun is setting on the horizon.

Catra strolls down the halls hoping to go to the rec room or maybe just annoying her parents for the day. As she's walking down the hall with Melog, Catra sees a figure walking towards her quickly, looking down. Catra pauses.

That person looks familiar…

Blonde hair, red eyes, purple veins covering their arms…

Oh!

Catra considers running, but her feet don't move an inch from their spot. Melog turns a deep shade of grey to represent her anxiety. The Magicat stays rooted in her spot in the hallway, hoping beyond measure maybe Adora won't notice her and keep walking. She telepathically begs Melog to make her invisible, but the cat refuses with an annoyed meow.

Catra looks behind her for something to help her escape and, when she turns back, she finds Melog is not beside her anymore.

She calls out to them telepathically. Catra glances back at Adora to see Melog trotting their way over to the vampire happily. Catra groans internally.

Of course, Melog had to take a liking to the one person who choked Catra. All it takes is one nap and now they're practically best friends.

Melog pokes their nose on Adora's stomach to get her attention. Adora stops walking and turns to them. She smiles brightly as she pets them behind their ears, Melog taking it all in like the little attention seeker they are. Catra rolls her eyes at the cat's little show as Melog leans into Adora's embrace.

Adora looks up, likely looking for Melog's owner, and her eyes quickly land on Catra. The Magicat slowly makes her way over to Adora and Melog.

Once Adora recognizes Catra, the same look of anxiety Catra wore mere seconds ago appears on her face. There's another emotion underneath the fear, Catra notices, but she can't pinpoint what it is.

Catra reaches the two of them and, upon closer inspection, can see the light pink dusting Adora's face. "Hey… Adora."

The anxiety Adora appeared to have all comes tumbling back now that she's in front of Catra. She fidgets anxiously with her hands, "Hi, Catra. I-I mean, Princess Catra! I like your- um- your hair. It looks pr-pretty on you."

Catra smiles warmly at Adora, which only seems to make Adora more nervous. The blonde vampire's entire face turns bright red as she stammers more, "I came here to- uhh- I came here to- to-"

Catra interrupts Adora before she embarrasses herself further. "Adora, you need to slow down. Take a deep breath and try again."

Adora complies with Catra's request. She tries again after exhaling, "I came here t-to apologize to you."

Catra's eyes widen. That was the last thing she was expecting from Adora.

"What?"

"I came here to apologize, so can I? Please?" Adora fidgets with her hands again.

Once the surprise wears off, Catra raises a brow, "What, did you plan a speech, or something?"

Catra was being sarcastic when she said that, laughing, but the humour dies out quickly when Adora nods weakly.

She planned a speech. To apologize to Catra. For something that happened weeks ago. That Catra had forgotten had happened.

That's so… cute.

Catra nods, "Okay, you can say your speech."

Adora stands up taller, perfecting her posture, and clears her throat, "I'm sorry for how I treated you. I was angry, and I took it out on you, but you didn't deserve that. I'm sorry for hurting you and scaring you. That was unkind of me, and I shouldn't have done it. I hope you can forgive me, but I understand if you don't. I'll leave you alone, if that's what you want. You'll never have to see me again." There's a sad gleam in her eyes as she says the last sentence, but her voice stays steady.

Catra places gentle clawed hands on Adora's shoulders. A red tint returns to Adora's cheeks at the touch as a surprised look paints her face.

"I don't want to never see you again, Adora. I forgive you, okay? If you want, you can stay and hang out with me."

The surprise on Adora's face morphs into hope. "You… forgive me?"

Catra nods.

"And… you want me to stay?"

With a small laugh, Catra nods again.

"Why?" Adora's voice shakes slightly as she stands in front of Catra. She wraps her arms around her waist and looks down at the floor.

Catra's smile turns sad at the question. It breaks her heart to think of how little Adora thinks of herself, even if she only met Adora a few weeks ago. She's reminded of a story her mother told her when she was younger.

Most children are told stories of the heartless vampires who ravage Etheria and are nothing but cruel, but not Catra. When Catra was just over seven years old, Queen Cyra told her the story of the lonely vampire.

The story goes that there was once a vampire who just wanted a friend, a family, anyone who would care for them. They searched all of Etheria for anyone to love them, but found only pitchforks and torches held by angry humans. Eventually, they gave up their search for a friend and hid alone in their cave, destined to a life of misery. The heartbreak and loneliness was too much for their old heart, and they didn't know what to do other than hide and hurt. One day, a princess from a nearby kingdom wandered into the vampire's lonesome cave and found the vampire. At first, the vampire tried to hurt the princess, but the princess didn't attack them. Instead, the princess saw how the vampire only wanted a friend and smiled at them. She befriended the vampire and gave them a hug, their first hug in years. The princess' kindness softened the vampire's old heart enough for the curse of his vampiric nature to be cured.

Obviously, Catra knows Adora will never be human again, but maybe she can help soften Adora's heart. Adora is trying to be better, so maybe Catra can help her.

Catra brings a hand up from Adora's shoulder to place it on her cheek. Instinctively, Adora leans into the touch. Catra still has the same sad smile on her face, "Because… you're trying to be good, and I know you won't do anything like that again."

Adora's eyes gloss over as a single tear trails down her face. Catra's quick to catch the stray tear with her thumb, though.

"But I'm a m-monster. You shouldn't forgive me."

"I don't think you're a monster, Adora. I think you're just someone who's been a little too lonely for far too long."

Adora closes her eyes as more tears spill out, with Catra rubbing them away. Adora pulls Catra into a light hug, loose enough that Catra could escape if she wants to.

But Catra doesn't leave. She hugs Adora back with the same kindness.

Catra hears Adora's shaky voice behind her, "So… Can we be friends?"

Catra laughs, "Of course we can be friends, Adora."

At that, Adora practically sags with relief.

"Okay, that's good."

Day 30: Hordak

There's a light knock on the tiny window in his bedroom.

Hordak had already been awake, so he's able to hear it. He walks up to the high window and opens it to see Adora kneeling down

on the floor to peek in.

"What are you doing here, Adora?"

Upon closer inspection, Hordak can see that Adora's shivering from the cold. It's getting colder as they approach winter, but at least it isn't snowing.

"Shadow Weaver kicked me out for the night because I refused to help her with a spying spell. Can I stay here?"

Hordak sighs and helps Adora in. Since Horde Prime let her in once, Hordak doesn't have to allow her to come in anymore.

Once Adora's inside, Hordak leaves the room and goes to his sanctum. He hears the light sounds of Adora's footsteps behind him, so he keeps walking down the short hallway until he reaches the lab.

He turns to Adora, "There's a couch in the corner of my sanctum. If you look under the couch, you should find a blanket and pillow."

Adora smiles gratefully, "Thank you. Goodnight, Hordak."

Hordak pats her on the shoulder lightly, "Goodnight, Adora."

He turns around as the lab door opens and walks back to his small bedroom. There are other rooms upstairs, but the other clones sleep there. The normal clones. The ones who aren't defective and useless.

Quickly after his head reaches his pillow again, Hordak falls asleep.

His slumber doesn't last long before he's awoken by faint screaming.

Hordak shoots up and waits for another sound, hoping beyond everything that he just imagined the sound of screaming in his own house.

No other screams follow, but Hordak can just about hear someone sobbing loudly and gasping for breath. He'd recognize that voice from anywhere.

He jumps out of bed and, after turning on the light in the corridor, hurries to his sanctum. The sound of crying and laboured breathing is much more apparent here, confirming what Hordak already knew.

The automatic door swooshes open and, even in the dim lighting, Hordak can see Adora sitting curled up in a ball on the couch, shaking as she looks down at her own hands. He hurries to her side.

"Adora?" He keeps his voice as quiet as he can muster to not scare Adora in her vulnerable state.

Despite his whisper, Adora still jumps at his voice. Her eyes are wide and panicked as they flicker from Hordak to her hands. More sobs come out of her, and her breathing quickens somehow. Adora looks back down at her hands in fear, repeating 'no' under her breath repeatedly as she focuses on them.

Hordak sits beside her, "Adora, look at me."

Adora doesn't look at him, still too focused on her shaking hands, "D-Do you see it?" Hordak has never heard Adora sound so scared.

"See what?"

"The blo-blood. It's- There's blood on my hands."

Hordak quickly stands up and turns the lamp on Adora's side of the couch on. Adora flinches at the sudden bright light as Hordak

goes and sits back down. He grabs the underside of Adora's hands lightly so she can see her clean palms.

"See? There's no blood, Adora."

Adora stares at their hands for a long time as tears pour out of her eyes again. Her breathing is still quick from her panic attack, but at least she isn't hyperventilating anymore. She looks up at Hordak with tears still coming out. The look she gives Hordak breaks his heart.

"There's nothing there?"

"No, there isn't. You were just imagining it."

She nods, thinking through that piece of information. "Okay…"

Hordak sets Adora's hands down onto the couch but still keeps his gentle hold on them. The touch seems to ground her to the present.

"Come on, take a deep breath with me. It'll help, I promise." The two vampires go through deep breaths, just like Perfuma taught them. Adora's are shaky in the beginning, but gradually smoothen out as they keep going.

Eventually, they stop taking deep breaths and sit in silence. Hordak lets go of Adora's hands to give her space. Sometimes, when Adora has a panic attack, she and Hordak will talk about what's bothering her, and sometimes they'll just sit in complete silence together without moving. Today seems like it's going to be the latter.

Adora leans her head on Hordak's shoulder after a while of them sitting in silence. Hordak smiles down at her and wraps an arm around her still shaking shoulders.

He's grateful to have a friend like Adora in his life. They've known each other for so long, and they both always help each other.

Despite how much Adora will annoy him sometimes, he still cares about her so much.

Hordak's never had a family, but he imagines Adora is the closest thing to a family he'll ever have. Hordak looks out for Adora and makes sure she's okay, and Adora brightens Hordak's life with her jokes and antics. Without Adora, Hordak would likely still be a lifeless servant to Horde Prime. Without Hordak, Adora would probably be dead by now.

Hordak expects Adora to be asleep until he hears her hoarse and weak voice from beside him, "Do you… Do you think we'll ever be good people?"

"I think we'll try our best with the lives we've been given, and we'll see how far we go."

Adora pauses before asking, "Do you think Etherians will ever not hate us?"

Hordak sighs. That's a much harder question to answer.

"I don't know, Adora. They're fools to not see you as anything other than amazing, though." He keeps his tone joking, so Adora doesn't notice the fact that Hordak didn't actually answer her question.

Adora laughs at that. Hordak smiles, glad he could make Adora laugh after what happened.

"Even if all of Etheria hates us, Hordak, I'll stay by your side, no matter what."

Hordak leans his head on Adora's, "Thank you, Adora. You already know I'll always be by your side, I don't have to tell you."

Adora giggles quietly beside him, "Adora and Hordak, besties forever."

Hordak takes his head off Adora's, "Nope, you ruined it."

Adora laughs loudly as Hordak pouts, "Oh, come on, Hordak! Admit it, we're best friends."

"No, we are not. Friends, yes, but *best* friends? Absolutely not."

He's lying, but Adora already knows that.

They're best friends, and they both know it. They have for decades.

Day 60: Adora

The front door closes behind her as she walks into Shadow Weaver's house.

She'd spent the entire day with Catra, going around Halfmoon and laughing every step of the way. Adora's never met someone quite like Catra, someone so fun, yet so kind. Her laugh and her smile have a way of igniting something deep in Adora that she'd thought had died by now. She just can't for the life of her remember what that feeling is.

Despite being in a good mood today, Adora keeps her face stoic and angry. Shadow Weaver can't know where she was. Her excuse this time was that she was going to kill a human in Brightmoon. When Shadow Weaver asked why she was going so far just to kill one human, Adora claimed Brightmoon blood tastes better than other human blood. Shadow Weaver shrugged it off as regular Adora weirdness and let it slide.

Adora's excuses won't always work, though, and she's terrified for the day they don't. Shadow Weaver hasn't asked her to kill anyone in front of her yet, but it's only inevitable. It's only inevitable until Shadow Weaver asks her to kill a human who's wronged the sorceress in front of her. There's no getting out of that one.

The blonde makes her way to the front of the staircase and her foot is about to contact the first stair when a voice booms from the basement.

“Adora! Get down here, now!”

Dread fills every part of Adora as she pauses. Did Shadow Weaver already figure it out? Is this the day Adora will kill her? She grips her sword tightly as she turns and walks down the stairs to the basement instead.

As soon as she makes it to Shadow Weaver’s spell room, she finally understands why Shadow Weaver called her down.

There’s a woman with black hair in a tight bun wearing purple robes sitting on the floor, tied to the floor and gagged. Two chunks of hair are separated from the bun and hang in front of her face, and there’s a gold circular crown atop her head with a star in the middle. She’s trying to say something through the fabric covering her mouth, but it comes out as incoherent mumbling.

Shadow Weaver sighs, “This sorceress has been causing a lot of trouble for me. Kill her, Adora.” Her voice is filled with disgust as she looks down on the black-haired woman.

Adora gulps. This is exactly what she didn’t want to happen. She doesn’t want to kill the sorceress. She doesn’t want to kill anyone ever again. She won’t.

She forces herself to keep a neutral face as she pulls her sword out from its sheath. Adora comes up with a good enough excuse in the few seconds it took to take out her sword, and turns to Shadow Weaver, “You should go, unless you want to get blood all over your clothes.”

Shadow Weaver glances between Adora and the sorceress before sighing, “That *does* seem rather annoying. Fine, I’ll wait upstairs. There’s a bucket and mop in the corner, clean up the mess after you’re done.” She points to the old rusty bucket and falling apart mop in the room's corner. She leaves the room quickly, her cape flowing behind her dramatically.

Adora turns her focus back onto the sorceress below her, waiting for Shadow Weaver's receding footsteps to disappear. She grips her sword tightly in her hand as she lifts it up to the woman who flinches slightly and… cuts the rope bounding her to the floor.

The woman's eyes widen at the sight, fully expecting Adora to kill her. Adora crouches down and unties the piece of fabric tied to her mouth. Once the woman's mouth is uncovered, Adora stands and extends a hand to the sorceress.

"Wha-What are you doing?"

"What does it look like? I'm helping you. Now, get up before Shadow Weaver comes back."

The black-haired woman grabs Adora's hand and lets her hoist her up. She wipes her dark purple robes, her magenta cape flowing behind her. The woman looks back up at Adora as a lightbulb goes off in her head, "Oh! You're Shadow Weaver's pupil, right?"

Adora scoffs, "You know Shadow Weaver, does she seem like the teaching type?"

The woman grins, "Yes, she's never been very good at that. So, why are you staying with Shadow Weaver, then?"

"You think I have a *choice*?"

That silences the woman quickly. Adora turns to peek outside the door but doesn't see any sign of the dark sorceress. She tries to think of a plan to get the sorceress out of here without Shadow Weaver noticing.

As she's thinking, she remembers one key part of the basement that Shadow Weaver's likely forgotten about by now.

Adora turns back to the sorceress, "Follow me, I'll get you out of here."

The woman complies wordlessly as Adora leads them outside the spell room. They both stay quiet, hoping Shadow Weaver won't hear their walking. Instead of walking to the stairs leading upstairs, Adora turns to go down a small corridor that leads to a different door with a large latch on it.

Adora pulls the latch open and cold mists of air immediately flow out of the room. Adora hears the sorceress' voice from behind her, "What is that room?"

"It's the cold room. It's basically a giant fridge. Houses don't have them anymore, but this place is centuries old. There's a staircase that leads outside in here."

Adora tries not to shiver at the freezing temperatures of the room as she walks in. She hears the clacking sound of the sorceress's heels on the floor behind her, showing that she's following Adora.

She turns to another door with a large lock on it. Adora unlocks the old rusty door and pulls it open to reveal a set of stairs. The sun peeks through the old cellar door at the top of the stairs. Adora goes up the stairs and unlocks the last lock standing in the way of the sorceress's freedom.

Adora pushes the doors open to reveal the bright blue sky above them and the sun shining down on them. Adora steps out of the cellar and onto the dying grass of the lawn. The black-haired woman follows soon after.

The sorceress sends a grateful look to Adora, "My name is Castaspella. Thank you for helping me." She outstretches a hand to Adora. The blonde's eyes widen. She remembers Castaspella from when she used to live in Mystacor with Shadow Weaver, Light Spinner at the time, before she joined the Horde. Adora's surprised it took hearing the sorceress' name to remember her from all those years ago.

Adora shakes her hand with a disheartened smile, "I'm Adora Grayskull. If you keep walking north, you'll reach a street that

leads to a shop a few minutes away. You can probably get back to wherever you came from through there. Don’t tell anyone I helped you and don’t let Shadow Weaver find out you’re alive or she'll ill kill me.”

Castaspella looks surprised, too, "Oh! You used to live in Mystacor, right? I remember you when I was a child! You were always so nice to me, I always wished you could've stayed after Shadow Weaver left. Don't worry, we'll keep this between us. Shadow Weaver won't find out about this."

Adora nods, nervous, "I'm glad you remember me, you were always a sweet kid. I hope you're right about her not finding out." It’s nearly impossible to keep things from Shadow Weaver, though. She fidgets with her hands.

The black-haired woman grabs Adora’s hands. Adora looks up at Castaspella to see her looking down at her with a sweet smile. It reminds Adora so much of her mother, she can’t help the way her vision clouds with tears. She feels so childlike, crying in front of this stranger. It's even stranger given the fact that the last time Adora saw Castaspella, the black-haired woman was a child.

“If you ever need somewhere to go, Mystacor will have its doors open for you, alright? Just because Shadow Weaver was exiled doesn't mean you were, too.”

Adora nods as the tears finally slide down her face. Castaspella pulls Adora into a tight hug, which Adora reciprocates immediately. Adora closes her eyes and pretends she’s hugging her mom as more tears slide out. Castaspella gently strokes the top of Adora’s head, which only makes Adora feel like she’s hugging her mother more. When was the last time she got a hug like this?

“I wish there was more I could do for you, Adora.”

They pull apart as Adora sniffles and wipes her eyes, “It’s okay. There’s nothing you can do. Now, go before Shadow Weaver gets

suspicious.”

Castaspella nods with a sigh and turns to leave. Adora turns in the opposite direction to go down the cellar again. As her foot touches the first step, she hears Castaspella’s voice behind her.

“Goodbye, Adora.”

Adora turns to look at Castaspella with a weak smile, “Goodbye.”

She shuts the cellar door behind her and descends back into her house.

Back into her cave.

Chapter End Notes

And Shadow Weaver was none the wiser...

Yay! Vulnerability! Kindness! Friendship! Family! We're just covering all the bases today, huh.

A little more info on their lessons (which aren't really lessons):
- Perfuma does meditation with them to help them process their emotions, especially their guilt.
- Glimmer helps them volunteer at local villages to help families who need it. They both have to hide their fangs, eyes, and scars.
- Scorpia helps them with the friendship portion of being good people. Mostly just how to talk to people, and helping them build social skills.
- Catra doesn't really help Hordak, but she does help Adora indirectly. While she doesn't technically teach her like the other princesses, just being with Catra makes Adora want to be a good person.
- Catra and Adora become good friends quickly after Catra forgives her. They hang out as often as they can, and really enjoy their company.

Also, Adora and Catra have last names (Grayskull and Driluth) but nobody else in this AU does. Only people from a strong family lineage, like some royalty (in Catra's case) or famous vampire hunters (in Adora's case). Kind of like how in ATLA, Toph has a last name but nobody else in the show has a last name.

Ok, bye-bye!

i wanna fight (but my hand’s been broken, one too many times)

Chapter Summary

Adora and Angella talk, which leads to a shocking realization.

Catra, Bow, and Adora go on a little trip.

Adora sees an old friend again.

Chapter Notes

Hey! Super sorry for not posting last week, but to make up for it here's a 7k-word chapter! There are not one, but two major plot points in this! I'm super excited for you guys to read this.

Fair warning, the last portion of this chapter is pretty violent, so read with caution.

I hope you guys like this chapter because I love it!! If you do like it, I would love it if you left a kudo and/or a comment! They are both so so appreciated and I love reading all the comments and responding to each one.

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: blood, violence, choking, electrocution, torture, stabbing, suicidal thoughts

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Glimmer and Bow lead her down the large halls of Brightmoon.

“Come on, Adora! We still haven’t shown you the dining room, yet!”

Adora groans, “What’s the point, though. I can’t even eat food!”

Glimmer turns around and drags Adora down the hall faster by the hand, “We’re giving you a tour of Brightmoon Palace, and that includes the dining room.”

Adora chuckles at Glimmer’s determination, “Fine.”

The dining room is exactly what she expects it to be. An ornate table surrounded by tall chairs, a large cabinet likely filled with cutlery and fancy plates, and vast windows that overlook a beautiful view of the Whispering Woods.

The three don’t stay there for long, given Adora’s revulsion for food. Bow showed Adora a perfectly cut piece of cake he got from the kitchen and, while it was a pretty cake, Adora felt disgusted at the thought of putting it in her mouth.

To be fair, Adora *did* love food… when she was human. She would eat practically anything given to her by the Eternian chefs with excitement. Her twin brother, Adam, often made fun of her for her enormous appetite. Now, after five hundred years of never eating, Adora can’t fathom actually putting food into her mouth and chewing it. She’d probably throw up, if she’s being honest. Blood tastes way better, anyway.

As the three friends are leaving the dining room, something beeps loudly in Bow's direction. The dark-skinned boy takes out his tablet and sighs. Glimmer and Adora turn to him, stopping in their tracks.

“I have to go help my dads organize the library. Sorry, guys!”

Glimmer smiles, “Don’t worry, Bow. We’ll just hang out another time, okay?”

Bow grins back at her. Adora feels like she’s intruding on something personal. “Yeah! You’re right, we can just schedule another *Best Friend Squad* hangout. Next time, we'll invite Catra!” He looks excitedly between Glimmer and Adora for their reaction to the group name.

Adora laughs, too, “Totally, but we’re not calling ourselves that.”

Glimmer crosses her arms, "Yeah, let’s call ourselves the Glimmer group.”

Bow shakes his head as he walks backwards, “Nope, we’re the Best Friend Squad. Bye, guys.”

Adora and Glimmer laugh and wave as Bow leaves.

“Bye, Bow!”

“See you later!”

Once Bow turns left down another corridor, Glimmer turns to Adora.

“So, what do you want to do, now?”

Adora tries to think of something, anything, for them to do, but comes up blank. It’s already late outside since Adora only got to Brightmoon around an hour ago. Shadow Weaver got suspicious of her again, so Adora helped her with some spells to put her in a better mood, then came up with yet another excuse. Adora doubts that she’ll have enough excuses to last much longer.

The blonde hums, “I don’t know. Whatever you want to do, I guess.”

Glimmer smiles brightly, “I know what we can do! Let’s have a sleepover. I haven’t shown you my room, yet. Come on!” She grabs Adora’s hand again and drags her back down the hallway.

Adora is about to tell Glimmer how impossible that is but pauses when she remembers what Shadow Weaver told her while Adora helped her with a spell earlier.

"I must visit the other kingdoms for some meetings tomorrow, and I'll stay there for two nights and three days. You are not to leave this house at all until I get back."

Adora grins as she's dragged down the halls. She hasn't had a sleepover since she was a teenager, and that was centuries ago. She'll finally have fun without the worry of Shadow Weaver finding out looming over her.

As they're running down the halls of Brightmoon, laughing, they bump into something and both coming to an abrupt stop. Adora looks up to see none other than Queen Angella looking stoically at the wall, undeterred by the two girls bumping into her. Her eyes are slightly red and puffy, and Adora can immediately tell she's been crying.

The blonde looks anxiously to Glimmer, who has a look of concern on her face as she faces her mother. Adora looks to the wall Angella is looking at to see a large mural of a bearded man holding an intricate staff, with angry vampires about to attack surrounding him. The man looks familiar to Adora, but she can't figure out where she remembers him from.

Glimmer looks between the mural and her mother with a look of grief. Adora's been around long enough to know a grieving person when she sees one.

Angella doesn't turn as she speaks to the two girls, "Glimmer, may you go for a moment so I can speak with Adora, please?" Her voice is emotionless, despite her obvious crying.

Glimmer sends a comforting glance to Adora before walking down the corridor wordlessly. Adora gulps, nervous, as she looks up at the Queen of Brightmoon.

Instead of continuing to stare, Adora turns, so she's looking at the mural with Angella. Neither of them speaks, but Angella eventually breaks the silence.

"That is my husband, King Micah. He was killed… by one of your kind when Glimmer was just a baby."

Guilt seeps into Adora, despite her not being the one who killed him. She looks down at the ground, unable to look at Micah's face anymore. Adora knows the grief of losing a parent, and she wouldn't wish it on her worst enemy. She especially wouldn't wish it on someone as kind as Glimmer.

"I'm… I'm sorry."

"Are you apologizing for the actions of my husband's killer or your own?"

Adora doesn't look up, despite feeling Angella's eyes on her.

"Both."

Angella's voice takes on a stricter tone, "If you really are sorry, you will not hurt or kill anyone ever again. Prove to me you will change."

Although she doesn't want to, Adora looks up at Angella. Her gaze is fierce and stern, but there's the tiniest sliver of trust in those pale purple eyes. "I will, I promise you. I want to prove to you that the Horde can be good."

Angella doesn't seem too thrilled at the idea of the Fright Zone actually being a good kingdom, but the tiny piece of trust in her eyes grows. The Queen nods, "Alright. We'll see about that, Adora. You may go, now."

Adora bows, for some odd reason, and hastily makes her way down the hallway Glimmer went down earlier. As she's desperately looking for a door that looks like it could be the door to Glimmer's bedroom, the door beside her opens and a hand pulls her in.

Glimmer looks concerned as she lets go of Adora's hand, "What happened? Sorry about my mom, she can be a little intimidating sometimes."

That is the understatement of the century.

Adora shrugs, "We just talked, Glimmer. You don't have to worry."

Glimmer sees right through her as she levels her with an incredulous look. Maybe Adora's not as good of a liar as she previously thought…

"What did you talk about?"

"I- uh- you- it's not important."

Glimmer narrows her eyes. Intimidation must run in the family, or something.

Adora sighs in defeat, "We talked about… your dad."

A long silence passes.

"Oh."

Glimmer's eyes are slightly glossed over, and Adora moves to place a gentle hand on her shoulder. The princess turns around and sits down in a plush seat behind her before Adora's hand can reach her. Adora goes and sits in the chair beside Glimmer's.

Adora sits with perfect posture and her hands wrapped around her waist, "I'm sorry, Glimmer. I didn't know about what happened to you dad."

Glimmer sighs as she looks down at the floor, "It's okay, there's no way you could've known. I don't talk about it with the princesses since, you know, they wouldn't really understand. All of their parents are alive and it wouldn't be fair of me to talk about my dead dad." Adora winces at the blunt statement.

Adora places a hand on Glimmer's shoulder, and this time Glimmer doesn't move.

"I would understand."

Glimmer's head shoots up to look at Adora in confusion, "What?"

Adora chuckles, but there isn't much humour in it, "What, did you think vampires don't have families? I used to have parents, too."

"Used to?" Curiosity leaks into her face.

It's then that Adora remembers that Glimmer never heard Adora say what happened to her parents when she told the other princesses. Adora takes her hand off Glimmer's shoulder but keeps eye contact with her.

"Yes, used to. Shadow Weaver killed them in front of me before she killed me." This time, it's Glimmer that winces at the bluntness of Adora's statement. Glimmer continues looking at Adora with a sense of sympathy in her eyes.

"I'm so sorry that happened to you, Adora. I didn't think Shadow Weaver was that horrible when I met her."

Adora laughs louder at that, "Yeah, manipulation and lying are kind of her thing."

Glimmer laughs weakly, but looks down again, "You know, my dad was killed by a vampire, too. They came into the palace and attacked him, unprovoked. We still don't know why they did it."

That makes Adora pause. That makes no sense, though. Unless…

"Glimmer, was your father a sorcerer, by any chance?"

"Wh- How do you know that?"

"Was he?"

"Yes, he was. One of the best in Etheria."

It can’t be…

“And do you know how he was killed, exactly?”

Glimmer’s eyes gloss over again, and Adora feels guilty for causing her pain, but she has to know, “Why do you want to know?”

“Because I don’t think your father was killed.”

The Next Day…

Adora and Glimmer stand beside each other in front of the meeting table, which is illuminated by the glow of a hologram of Etheria. The red dots showing any vampire kills are on the map, and Adora can now see the single red dot in Brightmoon's palace.

Angella looks down at the dot mournfully, before turning her gaze to Glimmer, “What is the meaning of this meeting, Glimmer?”

Glimmer turns to Adora, “Tell her what you told me.” Angella turns to look at Adora expectantly.

Adora clears her throat. “Well, um, you mentioned yesterday that a vampire killed your husband, King Micah, in this very palace,” Angella narrows her eyes at Adora, warning her not to say anything she’ll regret. “When you showed me his mural, I recognized Micah, but I couldn’t remember from where until Glimmer told me he was a sorcerer. I recognized Micah because I’ve met him before, when he was just a kid.”

Angella’s eyes widen, “You met Micah when he was a child? But how?”

“Before Shadow Weaver was exiled for using dark magic, I used to live with her in Mystacor. Her name wasn’t Shadow Weaver then, though. It was Light Spinner. One day, while we were living there, Shadow Weaver told me about this young boy who had ‘high potential.’ She told me she was teaching the boy magic, and

that his magic was incredibly powerful. Micah was always such a fun kid, though. Whenever I would talk to him, he would always either want to show me his new spells or ask me to prank the other sorcerers with him."

Angella smiles warmly at Adora's depiction of her husband as a child. Adora realizes this is the first time she's seen the Queen smile since she first visited Brightmoon.

"That's when the incident happened, the one that scarred Shadow Weaver's face. She and Micah were trying to use a powerful dark magic spell, but Micah left at the last second and all the dark magic went into Shadow Weaver." Adora suppresses a shudder at the thought that she would have looked like Shadow Weaver if she had been hit with just a little more dark magic.

"After that, the Sorcerer's Guild banned shadow Weaver from Mystacor and we left to go join the Horde, but she'd still talk about how powerful Micah was, and she was always angry at Micah for 'ruining her life.' I think that Shadow Weaver was the one that you think killed Micah."

Angella processes everything just said to her to the best of her ability. It is a lot to take in at once. Eventually, the Queen regains the ability to speak.

"But I thought you said that you didn't think she killed Micah."

Adora nods, "Yes, I don't think he was. Shadow Weaver was the only person who would want to get rid of Micah, as an act of revenge, but I don't think she would kill him. Shadow Weaver is obsessed with power, and I don't think she would just throw away all that, how'd did she put it, *magical potential* just like that."

"Alright, so what do you think she did to him?"

"Shadow Weaver would most likely take Micah to a place where nobody could find him, and somewhere she thought he could survive. The only place I can think of is Beast Island, a small island off the coast of the Fright Zone. It used to be an old

garbage disposal for Eternia's wasted technology, but Horde Prime started sending prisoners there to make them suffer longer."

Angella sits down as her hardened stare shifts from the red dot in Brightmoon to the small island beside the Fright Zone.

Angella sighs, "And you think he could have survived there for over eighteen years?"

Adora nods, "I saw Micah's abilities, and I think he definitely could've."

The Brightmoon Queen places her head in her hands. Her hands muffle her voice, "My husband could still be alive." Her shoulders shake, and it's obvious that she's crying.

Glimmer quickly stands up in her chair to comfort her mother, and it's then that Adora realizes Glimmer's crying, too. Adora, not knowing what to do, starts to slowly back away from the mother and daughter.

Angella looks up at Adora with a teary smile, "Thank you, Adora, for giving us a little hope."

Adora nods and smiles weakly back. She leaves the room in silence.

The Next Day...

Adora, Catra, and Bow aboard Sea Hawk's ship.

"Welcome aboard, crewmates! Are you prepared for the harrowing journey we are about to take?" Sea Hawk yells from the front of the ship.

Catra groans, "Are you going to be *this* loud for the entire ride?"

Sea Hawk gives her a thumbs up, "Absolutely!"

Adora laughs as she pats Catra's shoulder, "Don't worry, Catra, I'll keep you company. It'll be fun!"

Angella's voice boom from the dock in Halfmoon, where Sea Hawk's boat has been docked and ready to go, "BE CAREFUL, YOU THREE! MAKE SURE YOU STAY SAFE, AND GOOD LUCK!" Behind her, Queen Cyra stands worriedly as she watches her daughter on the boat. She calls out, "DON'T GO RUNNING INTO DANGER, OKAY, CATRA? YOU'RE GROUNDED IF YOU DO. I LOVE YOU!"

Catra rolls her eyes, "I won't, Mom! Love you, too, and don't worry so much!"

Adora, Bow, and Catra look down at them from the ship. Angella stands expectantly for them to answer her. They all yell down simultaneously, "We will, Angella. Thank you!" It's almost instinctual now, responding to Angella's worry for this trip. The woman has done practically everything she can to ensure everything goes to plan.

Glimmer stands beside her mother, worried and a little angry. Angella refused to allow Glimmer to go to Beast Island to keep her safe, so the princess has been angry about it all day. Adora tried to reassure her that the trip probably won't be too exciting if all goes well, but the sparkly girl refused to listen.

The four friends set sail quickly, heading for the small island off the coast of the Fright Zone. The ride there isn't very interesting. They occupy the time with arm wrestling (which Adora always wins), listening to Sea Hawk's stories of the sea, and comforting Catra as she deals with seasickness; though, Adora's usually the one to comfort Catra when she looks like she's about to vomit.

Catra leans on the edge of the ship, looking down at the dark seawater in disgust with her arms hanging off the edge. Adora walks over to stand beside her.

"You doing okay, Catra?"

The Magicat turns to glare at Adora, "Yes, I'm actually doing great right now, Adora. Thank you so much for asking."

Adora laughs as she pats Catra on the back, "Don't worry, Catra. We'll reach the island soon, then you can cool it with the sarcasm."

Catra sighs as she leans down to rest her face on the side of the ship, "Sorry. I just really don't like boats."

Adora rubs her hand up and down Catra's back soothingly, "It's fine, don't worry. My brother used to hate going on boats, too, and he used a lot more sarcasm than you. I'm used to this by now."

It still surprises Adora that she can mention her family with Catra so nonchalantly and not worry about her pitying the blonde. Catra is so… casual about everything, Adora's never met anyone like her.

"Well, at least you have some experience dealing with sea-sick people."

Adora grins, "Hey, that's the spirit! Now, do you want to watch me beat Sea Hawk at an arm-wrestling match?"

Despite her sickly state, Catra smirks, "I bet *I* could beat you at an arm-wrestling match easily."

"Oh, really?"

Catra's tail lashes slowly behind her, "Absolutely."

Adora smirks, "Well, in that case, let's go, Princess." The blonde leads Catra to a table and they fight. Bow cheers for Adora, while Sea Hawk cheers for Catra.

Catra is obviously struggling to keep her arm upright as Adora uses most of her strength. Adora smirks, knowing she's already won this game.

When Catra's arm is almost horizontal, Catra smiles smugly at Adora, "Hey, Adora." Adora looks up at her. Catra moves forward and presses a kiss to Adora's cheek. Instantly, Adora's arm loses all its strength and Catra pushes Adora's arm flat.

Sea Hawk cheers, while Bow yells that Catra cheated. Adora's shocked face resembles a tomato as Catra smirks. To be fair, Catra's blushing, too, but it's not as noticeable under the thin fur on her face.

Did that really just happen?

Adora, Bow, and Catra navigate through the vines of Beast Island, avoiding the broken machinery. Walking through Beast Island feels like walking down memory lane for Adora, who recognizes most of the thrown-out technology on the island from her old life in Eternia.

They haven't run into any problems yet and have spoken little throughout the walk. Adora's about to mention how easy this is when they hear rustling in the bushes in front of them.

All three of them stop, not daring to move a muscle. Through the shadows of the bush, two glowing yellow eyes appear. Then another pair. Then another pair. The amount of eyes keeps growing until the three feel like they're surrounded by these animals.

"Run," Catra whispers. They all run in the only direction that doesn't have any eyes in it. The sound of tiny little feet running and angry and angry screeches are heard behind them as they sprint to safety. The little animals are faster than them, though, and they're quickly surrounded again.

Adora takes out her sword, Bow takes out his bow and an arrow, and Catra unsheathes her claws. Before the three can begin fighting the small monkey-like animals, a bright purple light

explodes in front of them and several of the animals go flying, many others running away in fear.

The light dissipates to reveal a man with shoulder-length salt-and-pepper hair and a beard. The man isn't wearing a shirt but has a ripped piece of fabric that he's fashioned as a skirt. He's holding a dark purple stick with light purple spheres stuck to it and is attacking the animals with it.

The group takes that as their cue to fight alongside him against the small, but angry, monkeys. It doesn't take long for them all to have either died or run away in fear. The four stand alone, panting, as they look around for more. Once they see no more of the animals, the man stands up straight and smiles at the three people in front of him.

"Hello, there! I'm Micah."

Bow gapes, "*You're* King Micah of Brightmoon?!" It's hard to recognize the man in front of them as the fancy mural in Brightmoon.

Micah drops his smile, "You recognize me?"

Adora crosses her arms, "Well, the entire reason we're here is to find you."

Micah turns to her and gasps. He walks over to her and pulls her into a tight hug, lifting her feet off the floor, "Adora, it's so great to see you again!" Adora laughs, but it almost sounds like a wheeze given how tightly Micah is hugging her.

Catra raises a brow, "You two know each other?"

Micah puts Adora back down on the dirt underneath her, turning his head to a very surprised Catra and Bow, "Adora used to live in Mystacor with Light Spinner, her guardian. Light Spinner used to teach me sorcery, and Adora used to watch over me while I practiced my spells to make sure I didn't accidentally break

something. She left after Light Spinner was exiled from Mystacor, though, and I always missed seeing her around."

Adora smiles, “You remember me?”

A matching smile falls on his face as he turns back to her, “Of course! All Light Spinner used to talk about was my power and abilities, but you were always so kind to me. You haven’t aged one bit!” Catra and Bow raise a brow at the last sentence, but both Adora and Micah laugh loudly.

“Well, I *am* immortal, Micah. Not ageing is kind of the whole point.” Micah is probably the only human on Etheria who can understand what immortality is like, given the fact that his wife is immortal.

Micah is about to say something else when Catra cuts him off, “I know you guys are having your little reunion moment, but we should really get back to the ship before Sea Hawk burns it down.”

Micah turns to Catra and raises his eyebrows again, “I recognize you, too. You’re Princess Catra of Halfmoon! The last time I saw you, you were just a baby.” His brows furrow as his sentence trails off. Adora already knows what puzzle pieces he’s trying to piece together in his head, and sighs, “King Micah, we should really go-” Micah interrupts her as he connects the dots in his head.

“If you’ve grown up since I last saw you, and you and my Glimmer are around the same age… then that means I missed Glimmer’s entire childhood. I thought I was only gone for a couple of years…” His eyes are widened as he takes in that fact, tears forming in his eyes.

Bow moves to place a hand on Micah’s arm, “You might have missed out on Glimmer’s childhood, but your daughter’s at home, right now, waiting to find out whether you’re alive. So, why don’t we go tell her the good news, okay? Just because you weren’t there for her before doesn’t mean you can’t be now.”

Micah nods and wipes his eyes, sniffling, "Yes, I want to be a part of my daughter's life now."

With that, the group makes their way back through the thick forest of broken machines and tall trees. Adora trails back from the three, looking down as she walks.

Catra moves to stand beside her, "Hey, you okay?"

Adora looks up at her with a nod, "Yeah, it's just… I always used to feel bad for Micah when he was a kid. Shadow Weaver put so much pressure on him to be this perfect and powerful sorcerer, and all Micah wanted to do was be a regular kid. He deserved to have fun and live his life, not be manipulated for his power by Shadow Weaver."

Catra smiles sweetly, "That sounds a lot like someone else I know."

"What?" Her brows furrow in confusion.

"Micah didn't deserve to be manipulated by Shadow Weaver, and neither do you. Both of you deserved to live your lives, without that bitch annoying you."

Adora laughs at Catra's colourful description of her mentor, "You really think so?"

Catra shoves Adora's shoulder with her own, "I know so, dummy."

One Week Later…

Adora stands beside Catra at the welcoming festival for King Micah.

Catra turns back to Adora and smiles warmly at her. Adora feels star-struck as she looks at the Magicat.

There are warm lights behind her, illuminating her short mane and mismatched eyes Adora could get lost in. From this close, Adora can count the freckles dotting Catra's nose. Her smile warms Adora's icy heart, and the vampire smiles back at the princess.

Adora's not sure when her feelings for Catra began, because even she can admit at this point that she has feelings for Catra.

Maybe it's because Catra doesn't see her as a monster.

Maybe it's because Catra can always make Adora laugh or feel better.

Maybe it's because Adora feels like she doesn't have to always be strong with Catra.

The reason doesn't matter, though, because Catra doesn't feel the same way. Friends, maybe, but there's no way Catra could ever love someone like her.

Adora smiles at her before turning back to see King Micah waving at the cheering crowd. He, along with his wife and daughter, all have bright smiles on their faces. Adora feels her eyes gloss over slightly with tears as she looks at the reconnected family. What she would give to see her family again…

Catra must notice Adora's teary eyes because she places a gentle clawed hand on Adora's shoulder. "You wanna get out of here for a minute?"

Adora nods, grateful for the distraction. Her tears only come faster as she looks into the kind eyes of the princess. Catra grabs Adora's hand and pulls her to the door that leads to the now-empty outdoor gardens. She leads them to a balcony that overlooks Brightmoon.

Catra turns to Adora, "What's wrong?"

Adora wipes her eyes with a sniffle. For anyone else, she would've come up with an excuse about being fine or just being tired, or

something. But, despite only knowing her for a few months, Catra already knows all her tells.

"It's just… I wish I got the chance to see my family again, one last time." Her voice cracks as a couple of tears slip out from her eyes.

Catra pulls her into a loose hug, but Adora tightens it by wrapping her arms around Catra's waist. She leans her head on the brunette's shoulder.

Despite being friends with all the princesses, Adora doesn't feel like she can really show them her emotions, maybe with the exception of Glimmer and Bow. They might get scared she'll hurt them, or they might think she's faking her emotions to gain their sympathy. After all, they've been taught to fear and hate vampires.

She doesn't feel that with Catra, though. Instead of holding in her emotions, Adora keeps crying in Catra's arms. The Magicat runs her hands up and down the blonde's back soothingly.

Eventually, the tears run out and Adora lifts her head. Her eyes are puffy, and her face is blotchy-red. She definitely isn't going back into the palace soon.

Catra smiles that same warm smile as she wipes the tears from Adora's cheeks with her hands. She keeps one hand resting on Adora's cheek, which Adora leans on.

"Feeling better?"

Adora nods, "Thank you. You're too kind to me."

"Or maybe you're just not kind enough to yourself."

Adora looks at Catra to see her still smiling, but now there's a playful hint to it. She laughs tearily, "How poetic, Catra."

Catra laughs in that squeaky way Adora loves, "I know, I should be a poet. But I mean it, Adora. You should be kinder to yourself."

The two fall into a comfortable silence, filled only by the faint sounds of music and Adora sniffling.

Once Adora doesn't look like she's been crying, Catra turns to Adora with a smirk.

"Hey, wanna go prank some guests?"

Adora grins, "How could I not?"

The two walk back into the palace side-by-side and giggling loudly.

Once they make it inside again, Glimmer comes up to them almost immediately.

"Hey, Adora, you okay?" She must have noticed Adora and Catra rushing out of the ceremony.

Adora nods, smiling, "Yeah, I'm fine. The ceremony was beautiful, by the way."

Glimmer grins, "Thanks. My mom spent forever planning it." The princess turns to Catra, "Can I talk to you, privately?"

Catra raises a brow, but nods. Adora gives her a comforting smile before leaving to find Bow. While she's definitely curious about what they'll talk about, Adora knows to give them privacy.

Catra

Glimmer leads her back outside to the same balcony she and Adora were standing at minutes ago. The two friends lean on the edge of the balcony, looking down at all the twinkling lights below.

"I'm… sorry, for never trying to be your friend."

Catra sighs.

A month ago, when Adora had told her about Micah being at Beast Island for all this time, Catra volunteered to go with Adora to find him. Catra couldn't imagine that happening to her own father, and she wanted to help Glimmer, even though the sparkly princess had never made an effort for her.

Adora told the rest of the princesses about Catra's volunteering, and they were all surprised she would do that. Catra got the chance to talk to them again, really talk to them, and she even thought of them as her friends. Who would've thought that all Catra needed to become friends with the princesses was a King stuck on an island?

"It's fine, Glimmer. It's not like I tried, either."

Glimmer turns to her, "It's not fine. You *did* try to talk to us, but we all thought you were being mean and didn't like us. I didn't even try to get to know you, none of us did. We should have put in more effort, but we didn't. We assumed you didn't like us, and we gave up on you. I'm so sorry, Catra. You didn't deserve that."

Catra turns her head to look at Glimmer, only seeing truth in her eyes. She can feel her vision blur with unshed tears. She's been waiting years for the princesses to take notice of her, to put even the slightest effort into getting to know her. Catra spent her childhood alone, with only the company of Melog, while the other princesses were best friends. Every night, she would wonder what was wrong with her to make the other princesses hate her when, in reality, they never hated her in the first place.

"I forgive you, and the other princesses. We're friends now, and that's what matters. Let's leave the past in the past, and just be friends now. Besides, I was *way* too cool as a kid to be friends with you and the other princesses. You guys wouldn't stand a chance against me and Melog." She crosses her arms and smirks playfully.

Glimmer laughs and shoves Catra's shoulder as the Magicat laughs with her, "Shut up, Catra, we were having a moment!"

Catra uncrosses her arms and walks towards the door, "Come on, let's go back inside. I bet I can beat you to the punch table."

"Oh, you're on!"

The two princesses run back into the palace, laughing.

Being friends with the princesses is nothing like Catra thought it would be like.

That's a good thing, though, because this is better.

Adora

She closes the front door of her house as quietly as she can, despite knowing that Shadow Weaver isn't even home right now. The masked woman told Adora that she'd be getting some ingredients for spells for the entire day and that she wouldn't be back until later in the light. Shadow Weaver should still be busy in the night-time marketplace, so Adora should still be safe.

Should being the key word here.

Adora's blood turns to ice when she hears the clacking of heels coming downstairs. She turns to see Shadow Weaver standing at the bottom of one staircase with a blank face. Adora tries to stay calm, but she knows she's really fucked up now.

"Wha-What are you doing here? I thought you had to get those ingredients for your spells."

Shadow Weaver laughs darkly, and Adora's face pales. "That was a *ruse*, Adora. I was testing you, and you failed."

Adora takes a step back, but Shadow Weaver takes two steps forward. "Wh-What are you talking about?"

"I told you not to leave the house while I was away, but you did anyway. Where did you go?"

“I went to go kill in Sali-”

“And enough with the excuses, Adora. I know you’ve been lying to me for months. So, where were you?”

Adora stays silent, looking down at the floor. Shadow Weaver sighs theatrically in front of her. She hears clicking heels come closer to her, but she doesn’t move an inch.

Shadow Weaver places a scarred hand on Adora’s cheek and lifts her head up to look her in the eyes. Adora is shaking with fear but tries to keep her face as neutral as possible. Shadow Weaver’s never done this to her before. It reminds Adora of her mother, in some sick, twisted way. She wills herself not to lean into the touch, like she used to do with her mother’s.

“You can make it up to me, though.”

Adora’s eyes widened, “How?”

Shadow Weaver drops her hand from Adora’s face. Adora misses the feeling and is disgusted by it simultaneously. Instead, the dark sorceress grabs Adora’s arm tightly and drags her into the basement. Dread fills every inch of Adora, already knowing what’s coming.

The small cage which usually holds Adora now holds a terrified-looking young woman. The woman is chained to the ground and has obvious tear tracks down her cheeks.

Shadow Weaver unlocks the door and, after unlocking the woman’s chains, throws her out of the cell and in front of Adora’s feet.

“Kill her, Adora.”

The woman at Adora’s feet cries again. Adora looks at her mentor pleadingly, “Why?”

Shadow Weaver sneers, “Because I told you to. Now, do it.”

Adora tries, one last time, to save herself and the woman, "Maybe you could wait upstairs, and I'll clean up the mess myself."

"No, I'm going to watch you." Shadow Weaver crosses her arms and doesn't move from her spot. Adora should've known this would happen, eventually. She should've been more careful.

Shakily, Adora takes her sword out. She raises it to rest the tip of the sword of the woman's neck.

"Please… don't," the woman pleads. A teardrop drips onto the shining sword.

She can't do this. Adora drops her sword back down to her side, clutching it so tightly that her knuckles turn white.

Shadow Weaver takes a step forward, "Kill her, now." Her tone is sharp and leaves no room for discussion, but Adora makes room.

The vampire stays rooted in her spot, looking directly at Shadow Weaver, "No." If Shadow Weaver's going to kill her, anyway, she might as well go down fighting. There's no use in fighting her fate now. She's going to die.

"Fine, I'll do it myself."

Shadow Weaver steps forward and casts a dark purple spell on the woman. Instantly, a dark light comes out of her and she floats up into the air, her neck directly in front of Shadow Weaver.

Adora watches as Shadow Weaver removes her mask and drinks every drop of blood in the woman's body violently until she's a lifeless husk. The woman screamed until she died. There's blood everywhere; covering Shadow Weaver's face and robes, the floor, and even some splattered on Adora's clothes.

Shadow Weaver turns to Adora, her scarred face covered in the innocent woman's blood. She walks over and places a rough hand on Adora's cheek. It's then that Adora realizes she's crying, her

tears mixing with the blood on Shadow Weaver's hand. The bloody woman pulls Adora's face until she looks at her.

"When did you get so *weak*?"

More tears pour out of Adora's eyes. Subconsciously, Adora shakes her head weakly.

Shadow Weaver tightens her grip, sharp nails digging into Adora's face. "Oh, you don't think you're weak?" Her tone is a mix of amusement and pure rage.

Again, Adora shakes her head.

A dark, lifeless chuckle leaves the sorceress. Adora closes her eyes, not wanting to see the unmasked woman's face anymore.

"So, what are you, then? A good person?"

A sob cuts through Adora before she can stop it. Shadow Weaver laughs again, this time louder.

Adora tries to fight this time. She's tired of hearing Shadow Weaver's voice. Adora pushes Shadow Weaver's hand away. Shadow Weaver watches Adora push her hand away in surprise. "You're really still trying to fight back? What's the use?"

"Le-Leave me a-alone."

Before Adora can react, she's being pulled into Shadow Weaver's spell room. The dark sorceress throws Adora down onto the ground roughly. Adora's sword lands on the concrete floor with a loud clang. She casts a dark spell towards Adora.

"How *dare* you disrespect me like this!"

When she casts the spell, it goes through Adora with no effects. Shadow Weaver's eyes widened. Adora laughs, "Your magic doesn't work on me anymore."

Shadow Weaver casts an even bigger spell and pushes it onto Adora. Instead of the rune passing through her, a huge ray of purple light shoots out from her hand and into Adora. Again, the blonde doesn't react, only smiling darkly.

"You can't kill me with dark magic twice, you know."

"SILENCE!" She casts a dark rune which makes all the air leave Adora's old lungs. Adora gasps for breath, but she's still smiling weakly.

"You… won't… kill me," she gasps out through her last remaining bit of air.

"You're right. I won't kill you, I'll make you wish I killed you."

Shadow Weaver casts another rune onto the blonde which makes her move into the air, just like the other woman. She throws her down with a hard thud between two metal rods with handcuffs attached. She makes Adora put the handcuffs on, then drops her body.

"Horde Prime gave me this new machine to experiment with. You can be my first test subject."

She grabs a metal device from a table beside her and presses one button. Immediately, painful green lightning courses through Adora's body. Screams come out of her against her will as her body convulses with the shocks. Shadow Weaver increases the voltage, and the pain of the electricity is overwhelming. Her body convulses more, and her screams get louder.

After what feels like an eternity, the electrocution stops. Adora still shakes and twitches with the aftereffects as her body hangs lifeless on the handcuffs.

"Tell me, who has been influencing you to think you can be anything but evil?"

Adora shakes her head, unable to speak.

"If you tell me, I'll stop this torture."

Again, Adora shakes her head. She's not about to sell out her friends just so she won't be in pain. She's learned better than that.

Shadow Weaver sighs, "You've become such a disappointment, Adora." The disappointment in her voice almost hurts as much as the electricity.

Adora sobs as the machine roars to life again with the press of a button. Her screams echo through the room as Shadow Weaver increases the voltage again.

She keeps this pattern of switching from electricity to degrading words for what feels like hours until, finally, both stop. "I've had enough of this."

With another press of a button, the handcuffs keeping Adora upright open and Adora drops to the floor with a thud. She can't hold her body up enough to move an inch. Shadow Weaver does it for her, though.

A dark purple light comes from Adora as Shadow Weaver raises her near-lifeless body into a standing position.

"Enough of this, Adora. If you agree to never disobey me like this again, I'll spare you."

Adora finds the strength to speak. Her voice is rough and weak, but it's there, "I'll *never* kill for you, again."

Shadow Weaver's eyes widen in rage and she throws Adora's body into the wall. The blonde lands on the ground, panting.

"You will NEVER be good, and you know it!"

"You're wrong," Adora rasps.

Shadow Weaver moves to stand in front of Adora. “You’re wrong,” Adora repeats, louder.

Before Adora can prepare herself, Shadow Weaver kicks her roughly in the abdomen. And again, in her chest. And again, in her face. “Nobody. Will. Ever. See. You. As. Anything. But. A. Monster.” She punctuates each word with a kick to Adora, varying in location on her body. By the end of the attack, Adora lies, bruised and bloody, on the floor. Tears are pouring out of her eyes, but no noise comes from her bloody mouth. Adora’s blood, near-black and thick, drips onto the concrete as Shadow Weaver looks down at her.

“Tell me who told you you could be a good person, now!”

Adora peeks an eye open, “Never.” Blood spurts out of her mouth and onto Shadow Weaver’s bloody shoes, the blood being a mix of the woman’s and Adora’s. In response, Shadow Weaver kicks her directly in the face again. Adora closes her eyes again.

Somewhere in her head, Adora knows she could get up right now. She could get up, grab her sword, and fight the maskless woman. She’s been in worse circumstances and gotten back up. Her sword could easily kill Shadow Weaver with one stab anywhere. That’s what makes her sword so dangerous to vampires; the magic in it that can kill any vampire, even Horde Prime. Would the magic even work now, given the dark magic infused into it? Adora’s not sure.

Knowing this, though, Adora doesn’t move from her spot lying on the floor. Does she really deserve to live after everything she’s done? She’s killed so many people, so why should she get the chance to live? Mothers, fathers, friends, daughters, sons, doctors, farmers, good people died all because Adora was angry, or hungry. She doesn’t deserve to live, so why not let the woman who made her into a monster kill her for a second time?

Adora opens her eyes, “Come on, kill me. I know you want to.” She grins weakly, but it fades as soon as it appears.

Shadow Weaver smiles, stretching the scars lining her face, "You're really giving up that easily?"

"Yes, now get it over with."

She laughs, "I never thought I'd live to see the day *Adora Grayskull* gives up."

At that, Adora closes her eyes as tears fall again. She knows that, if her family saw her now, they'd be nothing but disappointed in what she's become.

By sheer will, Adora forces her eyes open one last time, "*You* made me this. You're the one who turned me into a *monster*." Her voice sounds angry despite her weak state.

Instead of kicking Adora again, Shadow Weaver turns around to grab Adora's sword off of the floor. The corrupted gemstone and the shining metal glint in the light. "I didn't make you into anything you weren't already. You've always been evil, Adora, and you'll be the cruel monster I made you for the rest of your life." She moves to stand in front of Adora again.

Shadow Weaver crouches down to pick Adora up by the collar of her blood-stained shirt with the hand not holding Adora's sword. Adora can't find the strength to do anything but hang, only being held up by Shadow Weaver's hand.

"Your mother would be so disappointed in you."

With a loud sob, the sword pierces through Adora's gut, coming out of Adora's back. Black blood pours out of the spot, albeit much less than the amount of blood the woman had. Adora gasps as the sword leaves her body.

"You've been nothing more than a nuisance to me, and you will never amount to anything more than that." She tosses Adora's lifeless body back onto the floor with a thud. The sword, dripping with its owner's blood, clatters beside her.

Adora looks up at the woman who has been her mentor for over five hundred years.

"I *hate* you."

Adora has never hated anything, but she hates Shadow Weaver more than anything.

Shadow Weaver uses the same spell from before to drag Adora's lifeless body and her sword upstairs. She opens the front door and throws both of them outside like garbage. The dark sorceress looks down at her protégé in disgust as she slams the door shut.

Adora looks at the closed door with a lifeless stare. Shadow Weaver left her to bleed out alone. She can't believe she really thought she could be a better person, that she could make a difference in Etheria. What an idiot she had been. She could get onto the skiff outside and get help, but what's the use. There's no point to living if she'll never win.

The vampire coughs weakly, and more blood spurts out of her mouth. The pain in her abdomen is gradually getting worse, and she knows that's the magic of her sword taking effect. She likely won't have much longer until the magic has done its job and killed her.

It seems, after five hundred sixty-one years, that this is the end for Adora Grayskull…

Chapter End Notes

I'M SORRY!! That cliffhanger was rough, though, right?

Anyway, so now you know more about Adora's backstory. She lived in Mystacor for a few hundred years with SW, and the only reason they allowed her to stay as a non-sorceress was because she was SW's ward. She knew both Micah and Castaspella while she stayed there.

Also, a couple more notes about the chapter:
- Adora didn't recognize Micah when Angella told her his name is because she'd been hoping that it was a coincidence that the King of Brightmoon and SW's old student share a name.
- Shadow Weaver never found out about Adora going to Beast Island or leaving the house at all in the three days she was gone. Adora managed to get home before SW after bringing Micah back to Brightmoon.

By the way, I changed a couple of previous chapters to make sure they all make sense (the chapter with Casta in it, and the chapter with Adora's flashback in it). If you're rereading this fic and find plot holes, tell me and I'll fix them!

I'm aiming for a happy ending here, guys, so that means no lesbians die in this!!

Ok, bye-bye! I hope you liked this :)

Chapter title credit: Another Love- Tom Odell

life is just begging to include you (but sometimes you just got to stay behind)

Chapter Summary

Adora is alone.

...until she's not.

Chapter Notes

Hello!! I'm super excited for you guys to read this chapter, it's super angsty (if you couldn't already tell from the chapter title). I'll keep this short so you guys can get to reading.

I really hope you guys enjoy reading this as much as I enjoyed writing it. If you do enjoy this, I would highly recommend leaving a kudo (if you haven't already done so) and/or a comment! They are both so so appreciated and are my main motivation for writing.

Anyway, bye-bye!

TW: suicidal thoughts (a lot of them), blood, descriptions of injury

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The five-hundred-year-old girl sits on the porch, in a pool of her own blood and alone.

The lights inside Shadow Weaver’s house have turned off. There are no streetlights.

Adora is alone, sitting in pure darkness, the only light coming from the moons shining dimly above.

As Adora sits, staring at the sword she's placed in her lap, she reminisces about everyone she's lost in her life.

Her parents, Marlena and Randor Grayskull.

Adam Grayskull, her twin brother.

Her childhood best friends; Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio.

Her old mentor, Mara Hope.

… and the list goes on and on.

All of them either died before Adora could, or left her behind. It's not like Adora deserved their company, though, she's a monster. It's only a matter of time before Adora hurts them; hurting people is all she does.

It's not just people she's lost, either. Adora used to have so much hope and so many dreams for her future. Even after Shadow Weaver killed her, Adora still held onto her hope, praying to whatever deity was out there that she'd be free again one day.

Months turned into years, then years into centuries; Adora's hope faded until it was nonexistent as the years went by. She'd given up on the idea that she could ever be free from Shadow Weaver's grasp until she'd met the princesses.

What a fool she'd been to have hoped again. She should have learned her lesson the first time. Hope only leads to disappointment and pain, and Adora knows that better than anyone on Etheria.

The pain in her abdomen spikes as Adora twitches from the aftereffects of the hours of being tortured with electricity. Hesitantly, Adora lifts the hem of her shirt to reveal the stab wound. Her blood is drying, but there are still black tendrils covering her exposed skin. Adora recognizes the marks as the first sign of the sword's old magic taking effect.

If dark magic hadn't corrupted the sword, Adora would've died in an instant, the black tendrils spreading rapidly to cover her entire body until she was an unrecognizable husk. It was a gruesome death, but Adora's fate is worse. She gets to watch the effects of her sword in slow-motion, despite her wishes to die as quickly as possible.

As the pain spreads, Adora thinks of everyone she'll miss when she's gone.

The Best Friend Squad: Bow, Glimmer, and Catra

Her best friend, Hordak.

The princesses.

Catra.

She closes her eyes, not wanting to think of Catra's reaction to her death. Catra might mourn her for a while, but she'd move on. Catra will be happier without Adora there. The vampire would only cause pain for the Magicat, it's better if Adora leaves now and saves her the suffering. Besides, Catra already has all the princesses as her friends, she won't miss Adora much.

Adora's about to accept her death when she remembers why she got herself into this mess. She's trying to be a good person, to be a kind person where Shadow Weaver is a cruel monster.

She and Hordak had a plan to succeed, and Adora ruined everything. Will Hordak even be able to defeat Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver by himself, then lead the Horde? Adora feels guilty for placing all the pressure on him, but he'll probably be happier without having to deal with Adora. The only thing she's done for Hordak is annoy him and get him into trouble, Adora doubts he'll miss her very much.

Despite that, Adora still worries about the blue-haired man. What if Shadow Weaver goes after him, now that she knows Adora

wants to be a good person? What if Horde Prime executes him, or sends him to Beast Island?

The blonde remembers the last thing she said to Hordak. Adora had visited Horde Prime's manor to look at her other weapons, the ones she keeps in Hordak's sanctum for safekeeping. She was playing with Imp when Hordak told her to leave, since Horde Prime would get suspicious soon. Adora snuck out through the basement window, making some stupid joke about how Hordak should leave his lab sometimes. Hordak just chuckled and rolled his eyes as he walked away.

That's not what she wants her last words to her long-time friend to be. She wants to apologize to him for ruining the entire plan and possibly his life. It's the least he deserves, for all the trouble Adora's given him.

With that, Adora shifts to grab the small tablet she always keeps with her. Adora silently thanks Entrapta for making her a mini tablet that is discreet enough for the dark sorceress to not notice it.

The bright screen of the tablet stings in her eyes, which had adjusted to the darkness of the night. She taps the small screen until she finds Hordak's contact. With a shaky hand, she clicks on his contact, blood smearing onto the glowing screen. Adora's thankful that Shadow Weaver's asleep right now, even though it would be impossible for her to see the glow of the screen.

Adora notices her reflection in the shiny screen. Her hair is a mess, mixed with tinges of blood. There's blood all over her face, obvious tear tracks lining her cheeks, and her eyes are puffy and red.

After a few seconds of Hordak not reaching, tears blur Adora's vision again. Why did she expect Hordak to care about her? It's not like she's ever helped him or been anything but a nuisance to him. The blonde is about to close the call and resign herself to her fate when Hordak picks up.

“Adora? What is it?”

At the sound of his voice, Adora bursts into tears. Hordak actually answered. Adora can say goodbye to him one last time. Through her blurred vision, Adora can see Hordak’s face wash over with concern as he takes notice of the state of Adora, definitely noticing the blood and tears.

“What’s wrong?” he asks. Adora’s never heard his voice sound so gentle before. It’s a pleasant change from the loud yelling of Shadow Weaver’s voice from earlier.

“I’m sorry. I’m so, so sorry, I ruined everything. Goodbye, Hordak,” Adora says through sobs.

Before an extremely concerned Hordak can respond, Adora ends the call and slumps against the floor. She tries to convince herself that everyone is better off this way, that Hordak will be better off without his useless friend to bother him anymore.

Another surge of pain courses through Adora, and she groans as she curls into herself. She doesn’t need to pull up her shirt to know that the black tendrils are spreading quicker, engulfing her body in pain.

She curls into a ball, grateful that she got to say goodbye to the one person who stuck by her through everything.

Hordak

“Goodbye, Hordak.”

With that, the screen goes blank as Adora’s tearful and bloody face vanishes.

For a moment, Hordak stares at his reflection through the black screen in shock. Did Adora just… say goodbye to him? No, this has to be some kind of sick joke. It has to be.

As soon as the shock passes, panic sets in. Why was Adora covered in blood? Why was she crying so much? What happened?

He opens up the tracker on his tablet and tracks Adora's mini tablet. The map shows Adora is still at Shadow Weaver's house.

Hordak slowly connects the dots in his head. If Adora's with Shadow Weaver right now, and she's crying and covered in blood, that could only mean that…

The vampire runs upstairs and, after grabbing some cow blood bags on the way, throws the front door open, running to his skiff.

Thankfully, Horde Prime is busy at his factory, where he manufactures his clones. There was a problem with the inventory, so he went to deal with it himself, telling Hordak that it'd take a while to fix. Horde Prime doesn't leave his home without Hordak often, but when he does, it's a rare treat for Hordak.

The skiff roars to life and Hordak sets course for Shadow Weaver's house. The ride isn't long, since the two homes aren't far from one another, but the journey feels like an eternity for Hordak as he worries for Adora.

He knows of the abuse Adora receives with Shadow Weaver, but there's nothing he could do without getting caught, himself. If that were to happen, Horde Prime would likely take all his memories, like he does with the other clones when they make mistakes. Then he wouldn't be able to help Adora or himself.

Hordak has seen glimpses of the bruises, the cuts, the scars, and the black veins that mar Adora's body. He sees how little Adora cares for herself, and how much she hates herself, in the way she acts. He hears all the ways Adora's degrading thoughts of herself mimic what Shadow Weaver tells her. The cries for help were there, bright and obvious for Hordak to hear. Despite knowing all that, Hordak did nothing to stop the masked woman.

He's done everything he could to show Adora that she's not what Shadow Weaver tells her she is, that she's an amazing and strong

person, but Shadow Weaver's manipulated Adora enough for the blonde to not even consider herself worthy of love or kindness.

Adora's always struggled with asking for help and Hordak knows that, even if she didn't say it, that goodbye was Adora's cry for help. It was her way of saying she needs someone to help her, even if she didn't explicitly say that. Well, Hordak heard this cry for help, and he'll finally listen.

Even if Hordak couldn't help Adora then, he can help her now. He can make sure Adora knows just how much Hordak, and all of Adora's friends, cares for her. Adora's the closest thing Hordak has to a family, and he'll do anything to ensure Adora's happy and healthy because he's certain she'd do the same for him.

Finally, the skiff reaches the outskirts of the large, dark house on the edge of the woods. He knows to not park close enough to the house that Shadow Weaver won't see him, but that means he has to walk all the way over there.

He parks the skiff, grabs the blood bags, and begins the short walk to the dark house.

As he approaches the house, he sees a shaking figure sitting on the porch alone. Upon closer inspection, Hordak recognizes the figure as Adora curled up into a ball, surrounded by her own blood.

The vampire's heart breaks for his friend, as he slowly makes his way up the few steps of the porch.

She's not sure when she closed her eyes in the first place, but Adora's awoken to the sound of someone walking up onto the porch slowly.

Afraid of the person being Shadow Weaver, Adora instinctually cowers away from the person. She doesn't get far because of her wound, but her feet try to push her away. Adora shuts her eyes

tightly, not wanting to see the face of the woman who's only hurt her. Tears well in her eyes as she realizes just how far the pain in her abdomen has progressed.

"Adora, relax. It's me, Hordak."

What? Adora said goodbye to Hordak, though. Why would he come back for her? It must be a hallucination, one caused by blood loss or maybe insanity.

Adora peeks an eye open to look at the person incredulously, only to see Hordak crouching down beside her. She unfolds herself from the curled-up position she was in.

"Wh-What are you doing here?" she asks.

Hordak smiles sadly. "I'm here to help you."

She uncurls further, opening both her eyes in genuine confusion as she asks, "Why? I-I don't deserve it."

A pained expression falls on Hordak's face as his eyes gloss over. "You do, Adora. You deserve so much better than this." Hordak clasps Adora's bloodied hand in his own as the blonde looks down at their joined hands.

The tears previously welling up in Adora's eyes slide out as a sob rips through her. She's become so accustomed to hearing Shadow Weaver tell her she deserves nothing good because of how useless she is. Adora never realized how much she'd missed positive affirmations.

Adora told herself she'd never ask for help. It's a sign of weakness, and Adora doesn't want anyone to know how weak she truly is. But it's been so long, and she's so tired…

The blonde uses her last shred of strength to push herself forward and wrap her arms tightly around Hordak's neck as she sobs more. Hordak reciprocates the hug as he rubs his hands up and

down her back to ground her to the present. Adora leans her head on Hordak's shoulder, a much needed support right now.

Adora's cries and sobs echo out into the vast darkness of the night. All the emotions she was hiding in front of Shadow Weaver spill out of her as she tightens her grip on Hordak. Blood and tears soak into the front of Hordak's black shirt as Adora shakes with emotion in his arms.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry," she says repeatedly in hushed whispers through her sobs, like a broken record. Hordak hugs her tighter, the only comfort he can offer right now. "You did nothing wrong, Adora. You did nothing to deserve this."

"Let me help you," Hordak says once Adora's loud sobs have died down to silent crying, a single tear rolling down his pale face and onto the top of Adora's head. It truly breaks his heart to see Adora in this state. He's seen many low points in Adora's life before, but nothing compares to this.

One painstakingly long moment later, Adora nods. "Okay."

With that, Hordak moves to lift Adora up onto her feet. As soon as he moves her, Adora groans in pain and shuts her eyes tightly. Hordak's eyes drop to the large bloodstain on Adora's shirt. He then glances at Adora's sword covered in dried blood resting on the floor beside them and connects the dots.

"Adora, did Shadow Weaver stab you with your sword?" Hordak asks.

The vampire nods, humiliated. Hordak's heart drops; he knows the capabilities of the ancient Eternian sword. Adora doesn't look Hordak in the eyes as she says, "The magic is spreading, I don't have much longer."

Slowly, Hordak lifts Adora's shirt just enough to see the huge black tendrils pouring out of the stab wound on her abdomen and gasps. Hordak was planning on taking Adora back to Horde Prime's manor and letting her heal in his sanctum. But that isn't

an option anymore. Adora won't get better, not without help. Not without magic.

Hordak instead opts to carry Adora back to the skiff parked outside the house's property. Adora taps his shoulder to get his attention as she says, "Just leave me behind, Hordak. It's not worth it."

"I'm not leaving you behind, Adora! It- *You're* worth it, alright?"

"Etheria will be better off without me. You'll be better off without me."

At that, Hordak grows enraged. Not at Adora, but at the woman who made Adora believe that she's worthless. "Nobody will be better off without you! Please, don't give up, Adora." His voice drops to a whisper at the end.

"It's better this way." Her voice cracks at the end of her sentence.

"You can't give up that easily. I won't let you."

Adora sighs and doesn't respond, dropping her tired head backwards. This time, though, she doesn't accept her death. Maybe she'll keep going, just a little longer, to see what happens.

The two friends eventually reach the skiff, and Hordak gently places Adora down onto the metal before moving to the controls. He sets the skiff to auto-pilot, a feature Entrapta only recently installed into the machine, and moves to sit beside Adora. The skiff leads them to Brightmoon.

He grabs one of the blood bags and pops open the spout, handing it to Adora. The blonde immediately begins gulping down the deep red liquid quickly in the hopes it will heal her other injuries. It doesn't work, and it usually does.

Once Adora has finished the entire bag, she places it down in her lap. She turns to weakly smile at Hordak sheepishly. "Thank you."

Hordak smiles, but there's still a sad glint in it. "Of course, Adora. Now, would you mind telling me what happened?" he asks.

Just like that, any semblance of a smile disappears from Adora's features as she looks down at her lap again. Despite being the last thing she wants to do right now, Adora explains what happened.

"Uh, I got back from the welcoming celebration for King Micah and Shadow Weaver was there waiting for me. The whole 'getting ingredients' thing was a trick, so she could see if I left when she told me not to. She said I could make it up to her by killing a human she had kidnapped in the basement."

Hordak notices her pale face and passes her another bag of blood wordlessly, which Adora opens and sips while continuing to retell the story.

"Did you do it?" he asks. His tone doesn't sound accusatory, just calm as he sits patiently and listens.

Adora shakes her head slowly. "No, I couldn't. Shadow Weaver killed the woman in front of me. There wa-was blood e-everywhere." Adora's shoulders shake as she remembers the woman's face of horror as she drained the blood out of her.

Adora finds it hard to believe that, just a few months ago, she used to do the same thing; kill senselessly, without a care in the world. Now, all she can think of is who is going to miss that woman now that she's dead, or who that woman left behind with her death. Every lost life, every funeral planned because of her, every mourning family, every single one all caused by Adora. It makes her sick to think about.

Hordak wraps an arm around her shoulders to still the shaking and calm the blonde. Adora takes a couple shaky sips of the cow's blood before continuing the retelling. She feels so weak, but she can't find the strength to do anything but keep talking.

“Shadow Weaver kept talking about how weak I was, and she was laughing at me, so I told her to leave me alone. She got angry and threw me into her spell room. Then, she tried using dark magic on me, but it didn’t work. She cuffed me onto this metal machine I’d never seen before.”

Hordak’s arm tightens around the blonde. Adora quickly glances over at him to see a mortified, but knowing look on his face. He doesn’t speak, though, so Adora continues.

“She, um, she electrocuted me for hours, only stopping to yell at me to tell her who’s been influencing me, then turning the machine on again. It was- It was so awful, Hordak.” Her voice shakes as she finishes speaking, remembering the seemingly endless pain of the electricity. Shadow Weaver had never used electricity on her before, in the decades that Adora’s known her.

Hordak nods. “I know,” he says, with no further explanation.

Adora doesn’t turn to him this time as Hordak says, “Horde Prime used to use that machine on me, when I used to show emotions in front of him.”

“Oh. I’m so sorry, Hordak.” She leans her head on his shoulder in an act of support, the only thing she can do given her circumstances. Hordak rubs her shoulder for a second, before going back to being perfectly still.

Hordak sighs. “It’s alright, it’s in the past. Go on with your story, if you’re able to.”

“Okay. After she got bored with that, she took me off and kicked me on the floor until there were blood and bruises everywhere,” she says. With that, Hordak’s hand on Adora’s shoulder loosens. Adora smiles, appreciating the slight gesture.

To finish her story, Adora says, “That’s when she stabbed me with the sword and threw me outside with it.” She glances at the sword they brought with them onto the skiff. Adora’s not exactly sure why Hordak brought it, but she won’t question it right now.

"Thank you for telling me. You're safe now, I promise."

The two ancient friends fall into a calm silence, the only sound being the consistent hum of the skiff engine. They stay like that, leaning on each other for support and listening to the rustling of leaves around them, until Hordak's voice breaks the silence.

"When we arrive at Brightmoon, promise me you'll fight. Promise me you won't give up."

Adora sighs, tired, "What's the point?"

"The *point* is that you can't give up this easily. I've known you for over five centuries, and I've never seen you give up. Don't start now, okay? Please, Adora."

The words remind Adora of what Shadow Weaver said about Marlena being disappointed in what Adora's become. Deep down, Adora knows Shadow Weaver is right. Her mother would hate her for the monster she let herself turn into. If Adora's own mother would've hated her, then the princesses definitely do, too. Catra probably just pities Adora, and that's why she's been so kind to the vampire. There's no other explanation for her kindness towards Adora.

Unless… Does she feel the same way?

No. *No.*

Adora shuts that thought out as quickly as it came. She learned a long time ago to not hold on to hope, anymore. Hope just leads to disappointment, and Adora knows better. Hope makes Adora believe that there's a possibility of a peaceful future for her somewhere, when she knows that that could never be true.

The blonde shakes her head, "Nobody would miss me, Hordak. They'd move on, and so would you." In the distance, the tips of Brightmoon Palace come into view. Dread fills Adora's body, along with pain radiating from her wound.

Hordak moves to sit in front of Adora, gripping her shoulders. His grip is the only thing keeping Adora upright; she can almost feel the black tendrils covering more and more of her body, swallowing her body in pain.

The blue-haired vampire looks at Adora with such a determined and heartbroken look in his eyes that Adora can't help but listen.

"That's not true, Adora. The Princesses would miss you. Etheria would miss you. I would miss you. I-I can't do this without you."

Adora shuts her eyes, not wanting to think about them, or Hordak, dealing with her death. It'll only make this so much harder.

"And what about Catra? You don't think she would miss you if you died?" Hordak asks.

With that, Adora peeks her eyes open again. It's getting more and more difficult to keep them open, but she does at the mention of the Magicat.

"She would move on. She has other friends, ones that are better for her."

Hordak scoffs, "You haven't realized yet? Adora, Catra loves you."

Adora's eyes widened. "W-What? How do you know?"

His eyes soften when he says, "Whenever she looks at you, she gets this certain look on her face that makes it clear she's in love with you."

"How would you know what that look looks like?"

"Because I see it on your face when you look at her. I know you, Adora, and I've *never* seen you look at anyone the way you look at Catra."

Adora looks down, not wanting to feel the hope brewing in her chest, as a pale blush coats her cheeks. She picks at her nails as she tries to shove down the feeling deep down, somewhere she can't find it.

Hordak grabs both her hands to stop the fidgeting. Adora looks up at him when he says, "You'd be breaking Catra's heart by leaving. Please, stay and fight."

Just then, another wave of pain hits Adora and her eyes droop closed. She sees Brightmoon Castle behind her as the skiff stops in its tracks. Hordak moves to pick Adora up again as he leads them off the skiff and down the narrow bridge leading to the palace.

Adora can only see small glimpses of her surroundings as she's carried, her eyes barely holding on to their strength. In those tiny moments of light, Adora sees many things.

Hordak yelling for help with a scared look on his face, more scared than Adora's ever seen him.

Terrified guards moving to let them in. Hordak walking down the halls, looking for anyone who can help them.

Angella and Micah's worried glances as they look down at Adora's bloody and bruised form. Distantly, Adora thinks of how much Micah's grown since she met him in Mystacor.

Glimmer's face crumpling in sadness and worry over the blonde's weak state as she places a hand on Adora's shoulder to rouse her. Adora not moving, too weak to do anything but teeter on the edge of consciousness and unconsciousness.

Hordak practically running into the infirmary, followed closely by Angella, Micah, and Glimmer. Being led into one of the hospital rooms.

Being placed gently down onto the soft hospital bed as nurses and doctors filter into the room. Hordak, Glimmer, Micah, and Angella

discussing what to do beside her. Adora doesn't filter into the conversation, not caring to know what they'll do to her. She trusts them.

Eventually, the initial panic of the room dies down as Adora rests. She doesn't know how long she sleeps for, just that it wasn't very long.

When she awakens, Adora doesn't hear anyone's voices. They probably left to go deal with more important matters. Although, Adora can feel a hand holding her own.

Curious, Adora peeks her eyes open to see who's sitting by her side. Bow's worried, but relieved expression appears in front of her. "Hi, Adora. How do you feel?"

Adora smiles, but it's shaky. "Hey, Bow Not too good, actually." Bow smiles at the sarcasm, glad Adora's still well enough to use any.

"Hordak went to get an update on how we're going to heal you, since normal medicine doesn't work on you." Ah, the curses of being from a dead kingdom *and* being an ancient vampire.

The blonde practically ignores everything Bow just said. She doesn't want them to waste any more time on her. The pain in her abdomen is even worse now, some even spreading to her chest. She wants to say goodbye, though.

"Bow, have I ever told you I love you?" She tightens her grip on his hand.

He smiles, surprised by the subject change, and shakes his head.

Adora smiles warmly at him, "Well, I do. You were the first human to be kind to me since *I* was human, too, and that was a very long time ago. I don't know where I'd be if you hadn't talked to me that day when I first visited Brightmoon. Thank you, Bow."

Bow's smile fades as Adora keeps talking, realizing what Adora's trying to tell him.

"Wha- Is this you saying goodbye?" He asks, tears welling in his dark brown eyes, and Adora's as she nods.

He shakes his head, "No. No, we'll fix this, Adora. You'll survive this, okay? You will." The tears slide down his face, fear clear on his face.

Adora's heart breaks at his terror. "It's okay, Bow," she says to comfort him. It has the opposite effect.

"Stop saying goodbye, Adora! Please, don't lose hope, yet," He says, his voice dropping to a whisper. As he looks up at Adora's face, he knows that it's already too late for that. Shadow Weaver destroyed any hope left in Adora a long, long time ago.

Adora's about to continue her goodbye when the door to the hospital room slams open to reveal Glimmer, Micah, Angella, Hordak, and…

… Castaspella?

The black-haired sorceress rushes to Adora's side. She wipes the tears on Adora's bloodied cheeks away with her hands. Her hands are so gentle on the bruises painted on the blonde's face. Nothing like Shadow Weaver's touch.

Adora leans into the touch on instinct as she looks up at the sorceress to ask, "Casta? What are you doing here?"

Castaspella smiles at the nickname Adora gave her as a kid, though there's a gleam of sadness in her eyes. "Hello, Adora. You helped me, so I'm here to help you."

Adora glances over from her now seated position on the bed to Glimmer, who asks, "Wait, you two know each other?!"

Castaspella gives Adora one more comforting smile, which Adora tries to reciprocate, before standing up to face her niece. Adora immediately misses the comfort of the hand on her cheek. Instead, Micah comes over to stand beside Adora as he reads something out of a spell book, holding a bottle of something undeniably magical in his other hand.

"Adora saved my life not too long ago, and I want to repay her for her kindness. I used to know her when I was a kid, too, when Adora lived in Mystacor."

Angella grins at Adora, but the blonde can see the underlying worry underneath it. Instead of discussing the fear everyone is feeling, Angella asks, "Does Adora know every sorcerer in Etheria?" Her tone is meant to be light, but everyone is still worried as they look between Adora and Micah as he works with the book.

Adora laughs—it sounds more like a hoarse wheeze—as she says, "When you get to be as old as me, you meet a lot of different people in every kingdom." Hordak, who's standing by her side, smiles down at her with understanding in his eyes. They've met a lot of people along the way, and Adora's glad she got to have so many life experiences in her time, even if most of them were quite violent.

Hordak, as if sensing her thoughts, grabs her hand and clutches it tightly in his as he changes the subject with a stern voice. "Your life isn't over yet, Adora. You can't give up now, okay? You still have so many more people to meet."

It's then that Adora finally feels the fatigue and pain that's been weighing her down for so long. It would be so easy to give in, to allow herself to stop after living for so long. Has she really been living all this time, though? Adora didn't live the past five hundred years, she survived.

"I'm so tired, though," Adora says. Her voice cracks, no matter how much she forces it not to. Tears fall from her eyes at a slow

pace.

Tears well up in Hordak’s eyes and slide down his face, too, but he still smiles shakily at her. Adora rarely sees Hordak cry, especially not directly in front of her like this. Maybe there was some truth in what he was saying about him caring…

“I know, Adora, I know you are. But, please, just keep going for a little longer. I can’t rule the Horde without you by my side,” he says in a hushed tone.

Finally, the fatigue and pain reach a point that even Adora can’t handle. Her eyes flutter shut as her grip on Hordak’s hand loosens. The last thing Adora hears is the sound of Hordak crying as he grips her lifeless hand in his own. The last thing Adora sees is all of her closest friends either watching teary-eyed as she falls unconscious or frantically trying to find a solution before it’s too late.

If Adora had stayed awake for just a moment longer, she would’ve seen Catra frantically run into the room, looking for Adora.

If Adora had stayed awake for just a moment longer, she would’ve heard Catra cry along with everyone else above Adora’s body.

If Adora had stayed awake for just a moment longer, she would’ve felt Catra hold her hand and gently place her own forehead on Adora’s.

But she didn’t stay awake.

Chapter End Notes

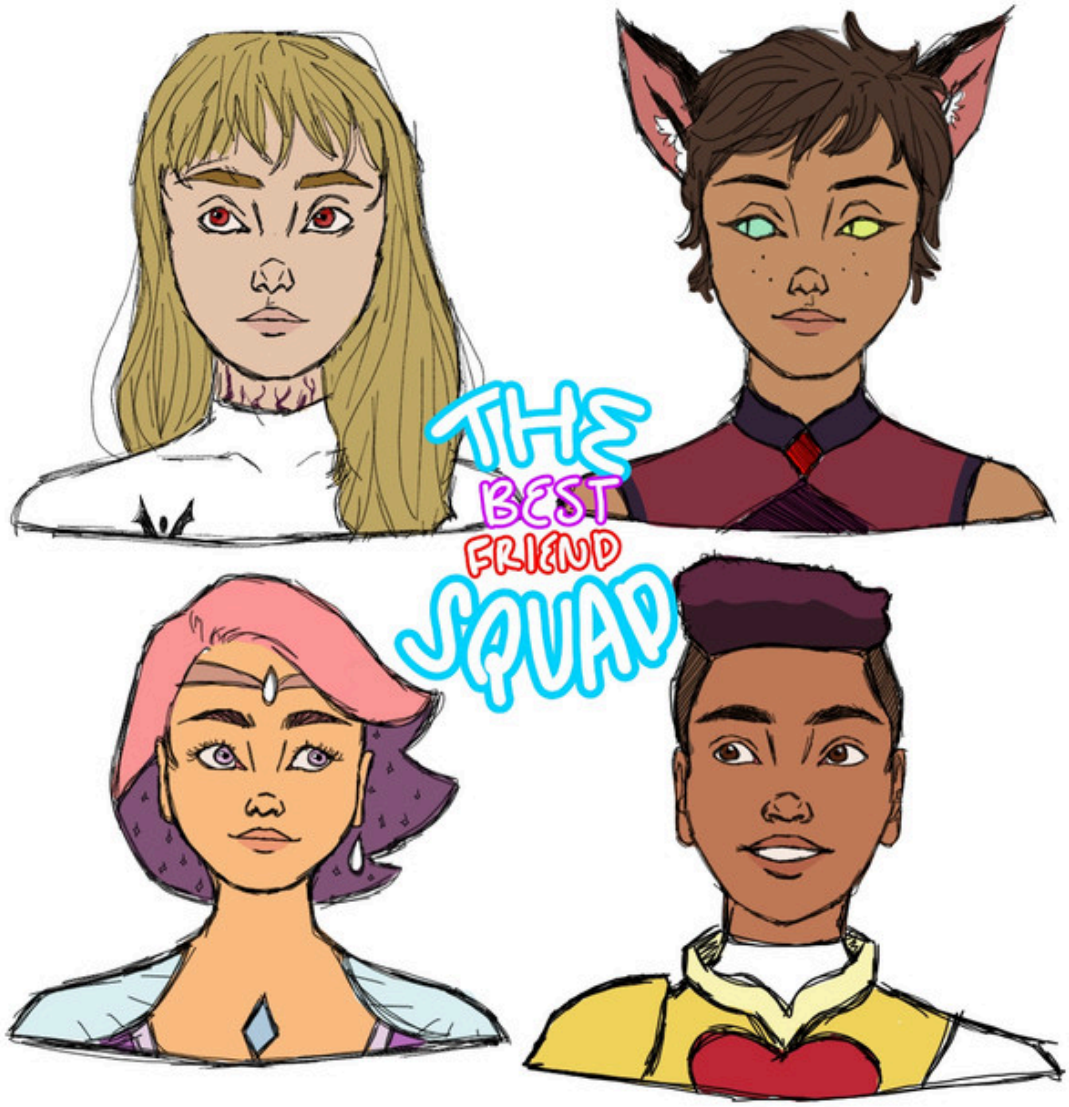
> Note: they weren't just chit-chatting while Adora was dying, if that wasn't obvious. (SPOILER WARNING) They're going to use sorcery to heal Adora, and Micah is setting the spell up to use. The rest of the group is just waiting for him to begin, and distracting Adora from the pain.

I know most of you were asking who was going to come to Adora's rescue last chapter, but I thought it would be more fitting if Adora had to ask for help herself instead of just being rescued against her will. Adora has to want to live, and she has to fight for it. I didn't want to undermine all the effort Adora went through in order to ask Hordak for help.

Ok, bye! Hope you guys liked this :)

Chapter title credit: Stay Behind- Mother Mother (Note: this is an AMAZING song that everyone who reads this should check out!)

Oh, and here's a drawing of the BFS I made!!



duplicate url finder
There's a better version on my tumblr, eloquentsapphic.

you were the sweetest apparition (such a pretty vision)

Chapter Summary

Adora sees her friends—her family—from a different perspective, with the help of a familiar face.

Chapter Notes

Hello!! I'm sorry for not posting as much, especially after how heartbreaking last chapter was :(Don't worry, though, this chapter is a lot less sad. At least, I think it's less sad. It's still pretty angsty, to be honest.

Well, I hope you guys enjoy this chapter! I really like it, and I hope you do, too. If you do, you could leave a kudo and/or a comment! Both are so so appreciated and always make me smile, no matter how short or long.

Oh! And the very amazing humANother made some super cool art for this chapter!! You guys better give them the praise they deserve because the art is amazing!

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: descriptions of blood/violence, mentions of death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

She’s organizing her bedroom when her mother, after knocking on the door, comes in with a sorrowful expression on her face.

“Catra, sweetie, can you sit down for a second?” Her voice sounds a touch too gentle to mean anything good.

Melog, as if sensing the caution in her voice, peeks their head up from their spot lounging on the windowsill. Catra, confused, goes and jumps up onto her soft mauve bed. Her mother moves quickly to sit beside her, grasping Catra's smaller hands in her own.

"Mom, what's going on?" Her voice shakes only slightly; her mom's behaviour is worrying her.

Cyra keeps eye contact with Catra, and the younger Magicat can see her teal eyes glossed over with tears. "There was… an incident, and Adora got hurt. Badly hurt." The Queen's voice is barely over a whisper, but Catra hears her perfectly. She tightens her grip on her daughter's hands.

Catra can almost feel the dam holding her emotions crack just slightly. "What? How bad is it?" she asks, gripping her mom's hands for support.

"I don't know the details, but I saw Adora in the Brightmoon infirmary. It- They told me Shadow Weaver stabbed her with her sword, the one with the vampire-killing magic. She isn't waking up, but they're going to try to-"

Her mother keeps talking, but Catra can't hear her. In fact, she can't hear anything around her, except for her heart thumping too loudly in her chest. She has to get out of here. She has to go help Adora. This can't be the end. It just can't be.

Catra's brought back to the present by Cyra wiping the tears off her face. When did she start crying? She has to go, now. It might already be too late.

"It's going to be okay, Catra. Adora will be okay, don't worry. Let's do some breathing exerci-"

With all the energy Catra has left, she forces herself to stand in front of her mom, ready to run at any second. Melog scurries to her side, ready to go with her. "I have to go see her, now! She- She'll be lonely there, I want to keep her company. It might

already be too late.” Her voice and action are sporadic and shaky as her mother watches her crumble.

“I know you’re worried, but panicking won’t help anyone. You don’t think I’m worried for Adora, too? I’ve seen how close you two have become over the months, and I swear Adora spends more time here than in the Horde. We need to stay calm, though. For Adora.”

Catra doesn’t take the older Magicat’s advice as she paces in a tight loop in front of her. “How am I supposed to stay calm right now?! Adora’s dying, and I can’t do anything to save her! I can’t lose her, mom. I-I lo-” Catra says, her voice shifting from a yell to a meek whisper, but she can’t bring herself to finish the sentence. She stops pacing to stand in front of the Queen, shaking from the effort of holding in her emotions.

Cyra seems to know how the sentence ends, anyway, and smiles sweetly at her daughter. “I know, kitten, I know. I’ll take you to see her now, okay?” Catra moves to pull her mom into a tight hug, which Cyra reciprocates expectantly, then the two Magicats move to get ready.

They don’t take long to prepare, leaving on the clothes they’re already in. Cyra shares a quick kiss with her husband, King Milo. He pulls Catra into a tight hug, Catra leaning her head on his shoulder. “You’re both going to be alright. I love you, kitten.”

Catra smiles weakly as she lets go and boards the skiff with her mom. “I love you, too, Dad.”

The ride to Brightmoon is silent, but the silence isn’t uncomfortable. Catra sits and looks at the horizon as they cross the Fright Zone to reach the Whispering Woods, while Cyra drives the skiff. Smoke rises from factories that are scattered across the region, and there are houses varying from tiny to huge in between the factories. Catra wonders how Adora can spend so many years in a smog-filled, miserable kingdom. ‘She never had a choice,’ Catra reminds herself in her head.

Eventually, they reach the Whispering Woods, and all they can see is trees as far as the eye can see. Catra spends the time thinking of how Adora is doing.

How bad is Adora's injury? What happened for Adora to get stabbed with her own sword? Was it on purpose? Was it an innocent mistake?

Well, she doesn't have to be a genius to figure out what the answer to that last question is. It simultaneously breaks her heart and angers Catra so much to think of how much Shadow Weaver has hurt her. Adora hasn't told Catra much about her past, but she doesn't have to tell Catra for her to know that Shadow Weaver has been hurting Adora for far too long.

Sometimes when she and Adora are together, Catra can see bruises, cuts, or even red veins on Adora's body, but the blonde always dismisses them and changes the subject. Catra can see how much pain Shadow Weaver brings her and, if she'd just let her walls down a little, the Magicat could help her.

That trust takes time to build, though, and Catra's willing to wait.

Catra's so busy thinking of Adora, she doesn't notice that they're at Brightmoon now. Cyra parks the skiff and Catra jumps out immediately, followed by Melog. She turns to glance at her mother. "You're not coming?" she asks.

Cyra shakes her head, "I've already seen Adora today, I wouldn't want to bother her. If she's awake, tell her I said hello."

Catra nods as the skiff leaves, but all her mind can focus on is "if she's awake." The reality of the situation rushes back to Catra as she runs into Brightmoon. The guards don't even speak to her as she and Melog rush past them, already knowing why she's here.

As Catra's running down the halls of the castle, she can't help but notice the looks of pity from everyone she passes. Their mournful expressions only make Catra more and more scared. Her eyes blur

with tears as she keeps going, despite struggling to see. She can't stop now. She can't leave Adora now.

Finally, she reaches the infirmary, but there are too many rooms that Adora could be in. Frantic, Catra turns to the secretary looking over a form. The secretary looks up to see Catra's frazzled form and wordlessly points to the third door from the front.

Catra rushes into the room only to see Adora's friends crying over a body in the gloomy hospital bed. She moves to see Adora in the bed, and bursts into tears at her appearance.

Her mom didn't mention all the other injuries covering Adora's body. There are dark bruises all over her face and exposed skin, and there's blood all over her abdomen. The nurses pulled her shirt up to expose her abdomen, a large gash covering it. There are black tendrils pouring out of the wound and all over Adora's body, creeping up her arms and neck. Shadow Weaver did all of this to someone as kind as Adora?

Distantly, Catra thinks Adora looks almost like an angel right now. Her hair is splayed out on the pillow, and she has a blank expression on her face while her eyes are closed. With all the blood and bruises covering Adora's body, though, she looks more like an angel who's just come back from war. A bruised and bloody angel, a warrior with kindness in her heart.

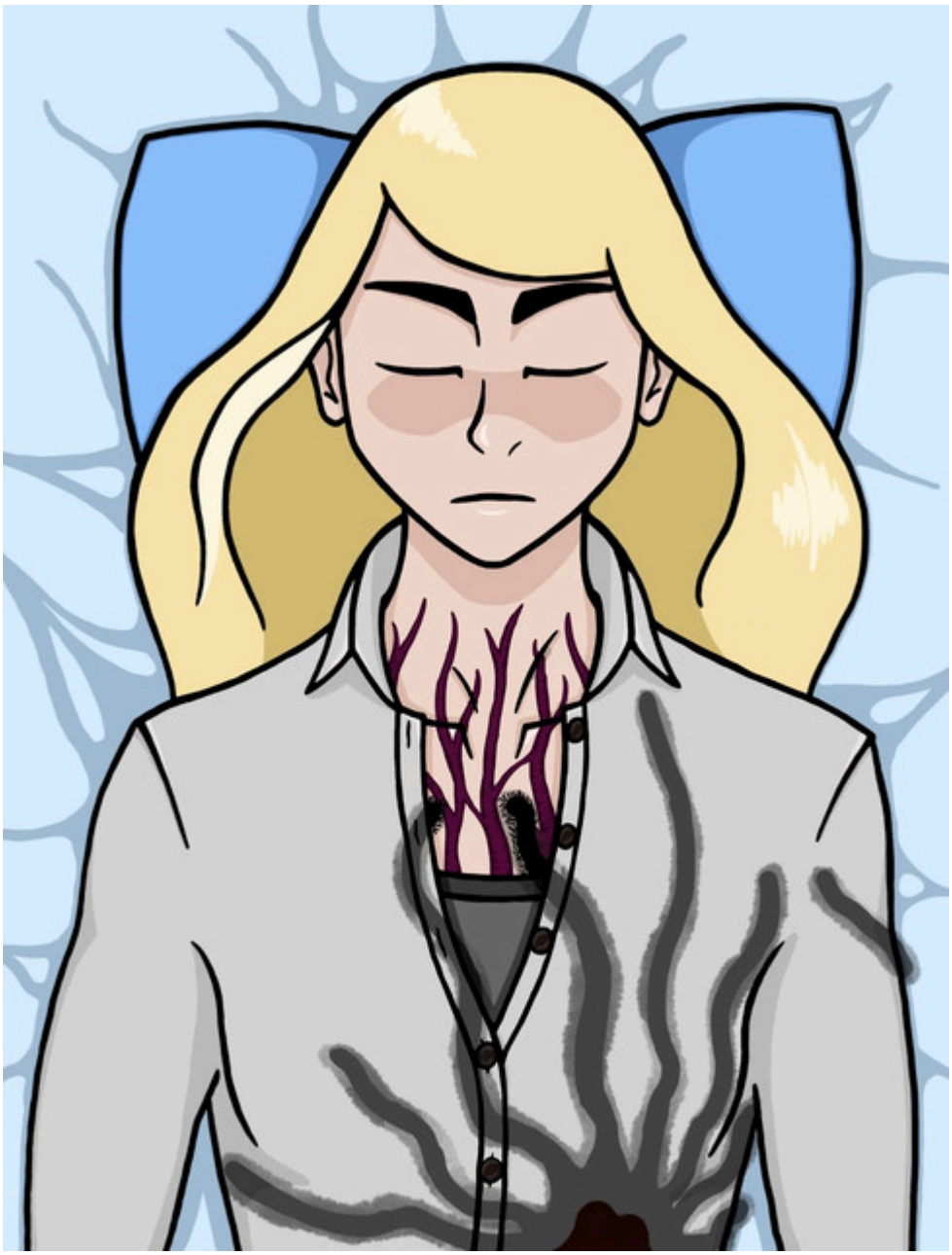
Catra can feel Glimmer pull her into a gentle hug. What's surprising, though, is that Catra hugs her back just as gently. While the two friends haven't always seen eye-to-eye, they need each other's support right now.

Catra peeks over at Adora's body again. She's so still, so lifeless. With the paleness of her face and the blood everywhere, she already looks like she's died.

Catra doesn't want to see Adora for the last time while she looks like that, it breaks her heart too much. She turns away from the

bruised and blood-covered blonde and leans her head down on Glimmer's shoulder.

Adora deserves so much better than this. Why can't she get her happy ending? Why doesn't she get to be happy?



Adora

It takes an immense amount of energy to open her eyes, but she does. All she sees is herself, and white all around her. She doesn't

lift her head up from where she's standing in pure white, though.

Hesitantly, she peeks at her hands. There's blood on them, and it's then that she notices the blood staining her white t-shirt and pants. One glance at her arms tells her that all the bruises are still there, fresh as if they just happened.

Adora still doesn't look up, scared at what she'll find. She knows she died, but she doesn't want to yet. There was so much she hadn't done yet, despite her old age.

She never told Glimmer how much she appreciates her.

She never thanked Castaspella and Micah for making her time in Mystacor fun.

She never thanked all the princesses for being her friends and helping her.

Most importantly, though, she never told Catra she loves her.

Finally, Adora looks up. If she's going to die, she might as well get it over with. It's not like she deserves to live anymore, anyway. She lost that privilege when she started killing innocent humans.If she's being honest with herself, Adora wishes she'd never been born. She caused so much pain to so many people, humans and vampires alike. Adora killed so many people with her sword, she deserves to suffer the same fate as them.

Hesitantly, she lifts her head to find the last thing she expected from her death.

There, standing with a calm smile on her face, stands Queen Marlena of Eternia. Her mother.

Adora feels tears well in her eyes. She stays silent, though, worried she'll break the dream if she speaks. She'd heard the rumours that, once a vampire dies, they see the person they miss most one last time, but she assumed it was just a myth. Turns out, it wasn't.

The blonde walks to stand in front of Adora with a frown on her face, her angelic white dress flowing behind her. Marlena is still as beautiful as Adora remembers, the golden crown on her head only adding to her beauty. Adora remembers staring in awe at her mom's royal painting, wishing she could be like her one day.

Adora flinches from her touch, expecting pain. It wouldn't be surprising, she's such a disappointment to her mother. She ruined everything, ruins everything.

Instead, Marlena places her hands on Adora's shoulders and slides them down the scars and bruises and dark magic covering her arms gently—oh, so gently—until she's holding Adora's hands. "What did she do to my poor baby?" she asks, rhetoric, but there isn't any pity in her voice. Only love and compassion.

Tears glide down Adora's face as dread, instead of joy at seeing her mom, overwhelms her. "Mom? Is that you?" she asks in fear.

Marlena will finally see how much of a disappointment her daughter is, she'll be disgusted by what Adora's become. She'll hate Adora as much as Shadow Weaver does, and she'll prove Shadow Weaver right.

With a quiet sob, Adora pulls her hands free from her mother's grasp, pulling them to her chest. Her soft hands felt so familiar, and so warm. But they'll only leave her again. 'It's for the best,' Adora reminds herself internally. 'I don't deserve her kindness.'

Instead of leaving, like Adora expects her to, Marlena takes a step forward. Adora closes her eyes this time, hoping Marlena will still be there when she opens them again. She feels Marlena's gentle hands on her face, wiping her tears away just like she used to when Adora was a kid. Adora sobs louder this time, leaning into the touch on instinct and keeping her eyes closed.

"What's wrong, Adora?"

Adora peeks her eyes open. Marlena's now standing directly in front of her, smiling that same serene smile she always does when

Adora used to have panic attacks as a kid. It's so familiar, even after all this time, that Adora can't help but cry more. She didn't realize how much she'd missed her mom, and how different she and Shadow Weaver are.

"You-you'll hate me. I'm a mo-monster. I disappointed you, and-and I ruined everything," Adora says through sobs and cries.

Marlena continues smiling—her lip quivering as she does so—rubbing her thumbs on Adora's cheeks to catch the tears. They slip from her grasp, sliding down Adora's face, instead. The Queen's eyes glisten with tears, and a couple slip out as she looks at her daughter.

"I could never hate you, Adora. And you could never disappoint me." With that, she pulls Adora into a tight hug.

At first, Adora keeps her hands where they are, in tight fists at her chest. Eventually, the warmth and kindness radiating from Marlena is too enticing, and she wraps her arms around her mom again for the first time in over five hundred years. Adora feels Marlena sigh in relief at Adora finally accepting her love.

Adora buries her face in the crook of Marlena's neck—though it's difficult because of Adora's height, making her and her mother the same height—ingraining every second of the hug into her memory. "I miss you so much, mom," Adora says, whispering as she cries.

Marlena runs a hand through her daughter's dirty blonde hair; Adora can feel how shaky her hand is. "I miss you, too. I always will." Adora feels tears land on the top of her head. The Eternian Queen places a gentle kiss on the top of Adora's forehead as the two women cry in each other's arms. Black blood leaks from Adora's wound, staining Marlena's ethereal white dress, but Marlena doesn't seem to care.

As the two stand there in pure white, Adora hears Marlena's voice above her. "I'm sorry, Adora."

Adora lifts her head up from the comfort of her mom's shoulder. "What are you talking about? I'm the one who got you… killed." She hesitates at the end of her sentence.

Marlena sighs, regret heavy in her voice. "No, you didn't," she says. "I failed you, and for that I apologize. You deserved to have a nice, normal childhood. Instead, I taught you to fight and kill vampires, people who had done no harm to us. It was cruel to rob you of your youth, and I wish I hadn't done it. Maybe then you would have had the opportunity for a happy life." She runs a hand through Adora's blood-stained hair.

Adora gives a weak shake of her head as surprise paints Marlena's face.

"You did what you thought was best for me. Besides, you made me strong. I wouldn't have survived these past years without the strength you taught me." Despite believing every word coming out of her mouth, Adora can't help the shake in her voice. She's been strong for far too long; she wants a break.

Tears build in Marlena's eyes again and run down her pale face. She puts one hand on Adora's cheek. "You shouldn't have had to be strong, you should've been happy."

The blonde leans into her mother's touch as tears of her own slide down her bloodied cheeks, a look of pain and exhaustion on her face. "It's too late for that, mom. I've failed." Adora's voice is a shaky, defeated, whisper as she looks down.

Determined, Marlena puts her other hand on Adora's opposite cheek. "Look at me, Adora," she says, simultaneously stern and gentle. She doesn't continue until Adora finally lifts her weak gaze from the white floor under them. It breaks Marlena's heart tenfold to see such exhaustion and defeat in eyes that once held so much hope and happiness in them.

"It's not too late. Keep going, Adora, you're not done yet. You still have so much to live for, okay? I know you can do this, I know

you can make Etheria a better place.”

Adora places her hands on top of her mother’s and closes her eyes. “Wh-What if Shadow Weaver was right? What if I’m a bad person and-and I’ll never be good? I don’t want to hurt anyone anymore, mom,” Adora says, pleading for her mother to not despise her.

Marlena smiles. “You’re not a bad person, not anymore. I’ve seen how you’ve changed these past few months, how kind you are. You’ve always had that love and kindness in you, you just had to find it again. I knew you could do it. I’ve always believed in you.”

The tears continue their slow slide down Adora’s face. “But I-I don’t want to leave you again, mom. I don’t deserve to live, not after everything I’ve done.”

“Never say that, Adora. You deserve so much better than what you’ve received. You deserve to live, and you deserve to be loved.” Marlena's voice takes on a stern tone as she tightens her grip on Adora’s face. “There aren’t enough words to describe how much I’ll miss you, but we cannot stay together. Not yet, at least. You’re needed on Etheria. You need to teach the Horde how to be human again.”

“Do you really think anyone on Etheria will miss me, mom?” Adora asks, genuine.

Marlena smiles a sad smile as she turns to look behind Adora. The Eternian princess turns around, too, gasping at what she sees.

In front of her and Marlena, is the infirmary room which Hordak brought Adora to when she first arrived in Brightmoon. The key difference from that time is how full the room is now. All the Princess Alliance—the name for the princesses, Bow, Sea Hawk, Adora, and Hordak—members are standing around the hospital bed Adora is lying in. They have tears in their eyes as they look down at her. On one of Adora’s sides is Catra, clutching onto Adora’s pale and bloody left hand with one of her own tightly. On

the other, Hordak is also holding her hand, but he's much more gentle with her. Both of them are crying the most as Adora lays, lifeless, on the bed. Micah is casting a rune over Adora's head, and Adora can see the sheen of sweat on his forehead; he's obviously been trying to get the spell right for some time now.

"These are all the people who would miss you, Adora, and so many others. Etheria is such a better place with you in it so, please, stay there," says Marlena, startling Adora, who didn't notice her mother was beside her.

Adora also didn't notice the tears running down her face. These tears aren't of sadness, though. They're of joy. There are people who… care about Adora. They want the best for her, and they support her. Adora's never had many friends as a vampire, but now she does. She can't waste her opportunity, right?

Marlena places a soft hand on Adora's shoulder, saying, "Go back to them, Adora. I'll be here, waiting for you, when it's your time to leave again."

Before Marlena can react, Adora pulls her into another tight hug. Adora forces herself to memorize every single detail of the hug, knowing it will be a long time before she sees her mom again.

"I'll miss you so much, mom. I'll be good this time, I promise you," Adora says, resting her head on Marlena's shoulder. This time, Adora knows she'll keep her promise. She won't succumb to darkness like she had when she died for the first time.

"I know you will, my little princess. I know you will, and I am so proud of you." Adora smiles at the childhood nickname.

Adora is the first to let go, turning to look at the scene in front of her again. The room looks different from last time she looked, though. Everyone except Catra and Hordak slowly filter out of the room, whispering supportive words to the two as they exit. Adora looks back at herself to see the reason they're all leaving.

The spell Micah was working on earlier is now permanently hovering over Adora's body. She can see the bright blues and purples of the rune glow, basking her body in pale light. Faintly, Adora can see some magic moving away from the rune and into Adora's wound. The magic is working.

After everyone leaves, Hordak looks up from Adora's body to face Catra. They talk about something Adora can't hear, but she can see tears building in Catra's face as Hordak tells her something. They go back and forth, both teary-eyed now, as Adora lies between them.

Eventually, Hordak slowly gets up from his chair beside the blonde—he's reluctant to let go of Adora's hand, but does eventually—and leaves the room with hunched shoulders. They both look so defeated, so lonely. Adora wishes above all that she could hug them and tell them she's okay.

She walks over, so she's standing in front of Catra, beside the hospital bed. Marlena moves to stand beside her, looking down at Adora's unconscious body with an almost angry expression. Marlena looks back up at Adora, and her expression morphs back into its familiar softness whenever she's looking at her only daughter.

Despite seeing her dying body in front of her, all Adora can focus on is Catra. The princess looks so heartbroken as she holds Adora's lifeless hand in hers. The tears on her face have dried now, but she still looks so distraught.

Catra whispers to Adora's body, but Adora can't hear what she's saying. She can tell that it's something difficult for Catra to say, given the tears pooling in her mismatched eyes again. The Magicat lifts a shaky hand, the one not holding Adora's hand, and tucks her dirty blonde hair behind her head. Instead of putting her hand back down, Catra rests it on Adora's cheek, the pad of her thumb wiping the dried blood and tears off her face as tenderly as possible. Adora only wishes she could feel the soft touch.

The vampire can’t handle seeing the pain on the princess’s face, Adora can’t handle seeing Catra alone like this. She has to do something about it. She promised herself she would never hurt Catra again, not after last time. Catra deserves to be happy, she deserves to have a good life.

Does that life include Adora, though?

Marlena, as if sensing Adora’s thoughts, holds her hand. “Go to her,” she says. “She loves you so much. Don’t break her heart by leaving.” Her voice is barely over a broken whisper as she smiles lovingly at Adora one last time.

Adora leans on her mom’s shoulder, still gripping her hand tightly, as she asks, “Do you think I’ll be a better person this time?”

Marlena leans her head on Adora’s. She was taller than Adora when she was human, but now they’re the same height. Her presence comforts Adora all the same.

“You lost your way all those years ago because you were alone, and it was the only thing you could do. But you’re not alone anymore, you never will be again. Catra taught you to be kind, and now you can teach the Horde, too. You have so much waiting for you on Etheria, Adora. Go look for it.” She finishes her speech with a kiss to Adora’s temple.

Adora nods and, begrudgingly, lets go of Marlena’s hand. She moves to stand beside Catra again.

Turning to her mother one last time, Adora says, “I’m so sorry, mom.”

Marlena smiles again, but it’s shakier than before. “You have nothing to apologize for. I love you more than you’ll ever know, my little princess.”

With that, Adora places a pale hand on Catra’s shoulder.

A bright light glows from Adora's body, blinding her. Then darkness surrounds her.

Just as Adora's about to accept that this was all a dream and that she's truly died, she hears a familiar voice.

A voice saying the words she's been waiting to hear for months.

Catra

She grips Adora's hand tight in her own, despite Adora not holding hers.

The others in the cramped infirmary room murmur to each other through their grief, but Catra doesn't focus on them. All she can focus on is Adora.

Adora, who's just trying to be a good person when everything is stacked against her.

Adora, who's trying to make Etheria a better place for everyone; vampires and humans alike.

Adora, who understands Catra better than anyone she's ever met.

Adora, who's dying in a hospital bed right now, something Catra can't do anything to fix.

As Catra memorizes every feature of Adora—her soft golden hair, her bright smile, the way her beautiful red eyes scrunch up when she's smiling, her dorky laugh, how clumsy she is, and every little thing that makes Adora anything but a monster—a soft blue-purple light glows down on Adora's body.

Catra looks up to see Micah casting a spell over Adora's body. She sniffles, asking, "What is that spell going to do?"

Micah glances down at her, as if noticing her for the first time, and an expression of sympathy washes over his face upon seeing how

scared Catra looks.

"It's the strongest healing spell on Etheria. It should be enough to stop the effects of the sword, especially since the dark magic weakened the sword so much." If this were a different situation, Catra would laugh at the irony of dark magic being the very thing that might save Adora's life. The one thing that caused Adora's death could also cause her survival.

Catra doesn't laugh, though; Nobody does. They all stay deathly silent—save for a few sniffles here and there—as the spell casts brilliant soft light onto the dying vampire.

Eventually, Micah's arms drop back down to his sides and the spell stays in its place above Adora's body. He turns to grab his spell book from a small table beside him, then turns to everyone else in the group.

"The spell may take some time to work. We can sit in the waiting room in the meantime. It may overwhelm Adora to wake up to so many people surrounding her."

The Alliance members think over it for a moment then, begrudgingly, they all slowly make their way out of the room.

Well, almost all of them. Catra and Hordak stay rooted in their places on each of Adora's sides; Catra at Adora's left side and Hordak at her right.

Glimmer and Bow lean towards Catra. "She'll be okay," Glimmer says, whispering softly. Beside her, Bow asks, "Have hope for Adora, okay?" Catra gives them a weak nod, trying to smile but failing miserably.

Now, the only people in the infirmary room are Catra, Hordak, and Adora. Neither of the two conscious people in the room speak, only clinging to Adora's hands in one of their own. The only sounds in the room are the beeping of the machines monitoring Adora's brain activity and breathing, since she doesn't have a

heartbeat. Her breathing has been gradually slowing since she got to Brightmoon.

Some time passes, Catra and Hordak not moving a muscle as they watch the magic flow into Adora's wound, when Catra hears Hordak's voice.

"She loves you, you know," he says matter-of-factly, voice hoarse from crying.

Catra's head shoots up, eyes wide. "What?"

"Adora. She loves you, but she never told you."

"How do you know?" she asks.

Hordak smiles, but his lip quivers just slightly, as he says, "You know, she asked me the same thing. It's obvious from the way she looks at you. I've never seen her look at someone with as much adoration as she does with you."

Catra can feel her world close around her. Adora loves her, and now she might never know Catra felt the same way.

"Why-Why didn't she tell me?" she asks, but she already knows the answer.

Hordak's smile fades as he looks down at Adora, grief-stricken. "She never thought you loved her back. She thought… she thought you, and Etheria, would be better off without her." He has tears shining in his eyes, too. A single tear slides down his cheek, wiping off the dried tears there from earlier. Hordak's quick to wipe the tear off before it can drip onto Adora's blood-stained shirt.

"I'm going to the… washroom. I'll be back soon," he says, looking antsy to leave, but waiting for a response from the Magicat. Once he notices the heartbroken expression on Catra's face, his face softens. "Adora will be okay, don't worry. In all my time alive, she's the strongest person I've ever met. Besides, I've seen her in

much worse situations. If she can survive those, she can survive this." Catra tries her best to believe him.

Catra gives him a faint smile, but she can't help but wonder what could possibly be worse than this? She nods, despite knowing he's not really going to the washroom. She's been friends with Adora long enough to know vampires don't need to go to the washroom, but it' clear that Hordak doesn't want to cry in front of the Magicat.

Before Catra can react, Hordak stands up quickly, still holding Adora's limp hand. He lets go of her hand and places it down by her side as gently as possible. He leaves the room in one quick motion, leaving Catra alone with the blonde.

The princess turns her gaze back to the vampire. The ever-present glow of the rune above her is brighter now. Catra watches the blue and purple hues of the light flow into Adora; vibrant against the dark magic, black blood, and bruises marring Adora's torso. Catra, not being able to look at the painful reminder of everything Adora's gone through in her life, looks back up at Adora's face.

The cool tones of the light make her look paler than she likely is, her hair looking more platinum than wheat-coloured. A few strands of hair have made their way to Adora's face, right over her closed eyes.

Even as she's dying, Adora still looks as beautiful as she always does. Well, as beautiful as Catra always sees her.

Catra lifts a shaky hand to tuck the dirty blonde hair behind Adora's ear, but she can't find the strength to take her hand off Adora again. Instead, she places her gentle hand on Adora's cheek, minding the bruises covering her face.

She rubs her clawed thumb over the dried blood and tear stains under Adora's eyes. With every second that Catra sees Adora in this state, her heart cracks just a little more. Catra decides that, if

this really is the last time she'll see Adora alive, she wants Adora to know she feels the same way. She doesn't want Adora to die not knowing, even if she might not hear Catra.

"You can't leave, okay?" she says, voice so shaky she can hardly understand herself. "You can't leave because I need you, Adora. I need you to stay here, with me. Etheria won't be the same without you." she wills herself to say the next part. "You can't leave because… I love you, and I want you to stay with me."

Nothing happens. No gigantic explosion, no magic lights, nothing. Adora lies still on the bed, unmoving. A tear slides down Catra's face.

"Please don't leave me. I love you, Adora," she says again, voice barely over a whisper. Catra leans down so her forehead connects with Adora's. Her forehead feels so pale compared to Catra's, so lifeless.

As she's leaning her head on Adora's forehead, something strange happens.

It's almost as if… she can feel someone's hand on her shoulder. The hand feels so familiar, though…

She whips her head around only to find nobody behind her. She could've sworn—

Before Catra can think about it further, she feels the limp hand in hers shift. The hand squeezes Catra's.

Catra turns back as quickly as possible to see Adora's fingers wrapping around Catra's hand tightly. The magicat, still keeping her other hand on Adora's cheek, looks up at Adora's face.

Adora's eyebrows are scrunched up—in pain or in discomfort, Catra's not sure—and she's squeezed her eyes shut. Catra feels tears of relief well up in her eyes, but she wills them not to fall. She doesn't want to worry Adora.

Slowly, but surely, Adora peeks her eyes open. They're the most beautiful sight Catra's ever seen in her life, no matter how many times she's seen them. The way the red hues of her eyes almost glow as she adjusts to the bright fluorescent lights above them. Her eyes eventually open fully until she's looking at Catra with an awe-struck expression.

"You… You love me?" she asks, half parts curious and surprised.

Catra laughs, genuinely laughs. "You're such an idiot." She flashes Adora a soft smile.

Adora responds with a soft smile of her own, albeit much weaker than Catra's.

"I love you, too."

Wordlessly, Catra pulls Adora's head forward until their lips meet. It's Catra's first kiss, but it's already her favourite. It's the perfect combination of tenderness, love, and affection that Catra can't help but melt into the kiss a little. Adora does the same, smiling a little into the kiss.

As Catra pulls away from Adora, she beams down at her. Adora smiles just as brightly—if not brighter—as she lifts her other hand slowly to rest it on Catra's cheek. Catra takes her hand off Adora's cheek to place it on top of the blonde's hand.

"I- You didn't leave," Catra says, breathless.

Adora's smile softens. "I could never leave you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other," she says, as if it's the simplest fact on Etheria. As if nothing could change that.

In a sense, though, maybe that's true.

"Promise?"

Because Adora gave Catra her heart.

“I promise.”

And Catra made it human again.

That’s a feat that nobody ever thought possible for a vampire.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter title credit: i saw you in a dream- The Japanese House

Note: I feel like i should mention that Adora isn’t ACTUALLY a human at all now. She’s still a vampire, and that will never change! I think Adora has the vulnerability and love of a human heart while still being a vampire; hence the last few sentences of this chapter saying Catra made Adora’s heart human, not Adora herself.

Hope that clears things up! Until next time, bye!

mom, am i still young? can i dream for a few months more?

Chapter Summary

Adora gets some visitors.

Alternative chapter title: the mommy issues chapter.

Chapter Notes

Hellooo!! Here's a new chapter, fresh of the press! I have a feeling you guys are going to be mad at me for this chapter, but it's the best I could do. Nevertheless, I hope you guys enjoy this chapter :)

If you guys do enjoy this chapter, I would appreciate it so so much if you left a kudo and/or a comment! Either one makes me so happy, and I love to see what you think of my work!

I promise I won't take too long to get the next chapter out, and the next one's going to be a big one!

Oh, and I remember someone commented about the characters' heights, so here's a useful little diagram! Yes, Adora IS taller in this AU! That's not your eyes deceiving you!



picture upload
I added another drawing at the end of this chapter :)

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: mentions of blood, violence, bruises, and abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The door creaks open again as Hordak shuffles back in.

With red-tinted cheeks, Catra moves away from Adora, still keeping her grasp on her pale hand. Catra still keeps her eyes on Hordak, who hasn't looked up from the linoleum flooring of the infirmary room. Adora turns to look at Hordak, too, now that she's in an upright position.

His eyes are bloodshot. Dried tears tracks he hasn't bothered to wipe off trail down his face pale face. His hair, normally swept back and out of his face, now hangs low in front of his downcast eyes. Adora's never seen him look so… heartbroken before.

Looking at the miserable man in front of her, the blonde can't believe there was a time she didn't think Hordak cared for her.

Hordak opens his mouth to speak, still not raising his head. "The others are waiting outside. If you would like, I can stay with Adora while you go wait with them," he says, voice barely over a shaky whisper. Adora smiles sadly at him, wanting nothing more than to stand up to give Hordak a hug. He waits for a response with his head still hung low.

The blonde turns to Catra, noticing the sad smile she also has on her face. Catra nods, so Adora turns back to the blue-haired man. "Hi, Hordak," Adora says, barely being able to contain her growing smile.

It takes a second for Hordak to process whose voice that was but, once it does, his head shoots up to look at the hospital bed with wide eyes. Adora grins back at him, waiting for his reaction.

She was expecting Hordak to ask how she's feeling. Maybe call in the others to check up on her. What she wasn't expecting was-

"ADORA!" Hordak rushes forward and wraps his arms around Adora in a tight hug. After the initial surprise of the embrace, she hugs him back just as tight.

The younger vampire chuckles. "Careful, Hordak," she says. "Otherwise, people are going to think you care about me." Hordak pulls away from the hug with a stern frown, still keeping his hands on Adora's shoulders.

"Of course I care about you, Adora. You're my best friend, and- and you could've died!"

Adora feels her eyes water a little. "Aww… You're finally admitting we're best friends?"

Hordak sighs, but she can see the hint of a smile on his lips. "*Yes*, we are best friends. But it's not like I was worried, or anything. I knew you'd be okay."

The blonde tries to ignore how sweet that is, especially coming from a clone who Prime created to not feel any emotions. “Are you secretly a big softie, Hordak?” she asks. She keeps her tone teasing as she smiles at him.

Hordak moves to stand up fully, crossing his arms and pouting only a little. “No! I’m… I’m extremely tough,” he says while trying to stand taller.

Adora laughs, louder this time but with a small wheeze. She notices Catra’s grip on her hand tighten. “Sure you are, Hordak. Sure you are. Big ol’ clone with a heart of gold.” Hordak is about to respond when Catra cuts him off.

“It is terrifying how nonchalant you two are being about a near-death experience. And as cute as this little reunion is, we should probably let the others know Adora’s okay.”

Hordak nods, sobering up as he moves to the door of the room. He doesn’t leave the room, only peeking his head out, as he tells the others of the update in Adora’s consciousness. Soon enough, Adora hears quick footsteps quickly make their way to the room as Hordak moves back to his chair by Adora’s side.

Glimmer and Bow are the first in the room, immediately storming in to hug Adora as tightly as humanly possible. Adora laughs as two of her best friends ramble about how happy they are that she’s okay, patting both of them on the back.

Adora goes around giving hugs and talking to the people she loves, assuring them she’s okay. Her body is still in immense pain, but maybe she can just ignore it until it goes away. She laughs at something Catra said, but her laughter quickly morphs into a coughing fit. Guess not.

The room goes into an anxious silence as Adora continues coughing, wheezing in between hoarse coughs. Glimmer turns to Micah, asking, “What’s wrong with her? I thought the spell healed her.”

Micah sighs as he glances at something in his spell book before looking back up at Glimmer and Adora, who's stopped coughing.

"The spell stopped the effects of the sword's magic from spreading. The magic is gone now, but Adora still has to heal from the effects it had on her body and all the… other injuries she has." Adora notices the pause as everyone looks at all the bruises and cuts littered on her body.

Adora scoffs, wondering why everyone's making this such a big deal. "Okay, so how long will it take to heal? A few hours, a day…"

"At least a few weeks until you're back to full health," Micah says, finishing Adora's sentence.

"Weeks?! Bu-But I *never* take that long to heal! And, trust me, I've had much worse injuries than these before." Again, Adora feels Catra's grip on her hand tighten. Maybe she shouldn't broadcast all the abuse she's endured in the past few centuries to these humans….

"Maybe, if you hadn't been stabbed with your sword specifically, that would be the case. However, the magic in your sword has weakened your body and, as a result, your body will heal at a human rate. There's no medicine for vampires, so you'll have to heal naturally," Micah says.

Entrapta lifts her head from where she was tapping on her tablet. "That's not true! Hordak and I have been experimenting with animal blood. According to our research, Magicat blood is the most efficient at healing vampires. Though, the only downside of using their blood is that it causes a small amount of intoxication in any vampire who drinks it."

Everyone turns to Catra.

Catra shrugs. "Yeah, sure, she can drink some of my blood."

Adora tightens her grip on Catra's hand until she looks down. The last thing she wants is to use Catra, especially for something like her blood.

"You don't have to if you don't want to. I can heal on my own, it's fine." She keeps her tone hushed, but everyone can obviously hear them in the cramped hospital room. Adora can almost feel everyone watching them, especially since they're still holding hands. Despite knowing that, Adora doesn't let go.

"It's okay, Adora. I want to. Besides, I get to watch you embarrass yourself while high, so we both benefit from you using my blood," Catra says with a smirk.

Adora sighs. "Okay, but only because Catra's okay with it."

Entrapta pulls out a blood collection kit from the back of the robot she snuck into the room, Emily. "Great!"

Mermista glances between the robot and Entrapta. "So… we're all okay with her just carrying that with her at all times?"

Five Hours Later…

Adora peeks her eyes open to look around the room. Everyone has already left, deciding to give her privacy after the effects of Catra's blood set in.

Just as she accepts that the room is empty, her eyes land on Catra, who's still sitting in the same spot as before and reading a book that she likely got from the palace library.

Now fully awake from her nap, Adora weakly lifts an arm to get Catra's attention. Entrapta really wasn't lying when she mentioned the intoxication of the Magicat blood. She felt so sluggish after drinking it, she almost immediately fell asleep. Is that a side effect of intoxication? She's not sure.

Eventually, after flapping her arm around for a couple seconds, Catra finally notices Adora. She places a bookmark on the page she's reading and sets it down on the small table beside the bed, redirecting her focus onto Adora.

"Hey, Adora. How was your nap, sleepyhead?" Her voice sounds so gentle and sweet that Adora worries it'll lull her to sleep before she can ask what she planned to.

Adora grins, feeling the lingering effects of the blood in her body. She loves it when Catra says her name like that. So sweet, but still teasing. "It was great, thank you."

She lifts her arm again and places her hand on the side of Catra's arm, trying to steady her voice. "I had something reeaally important I needed to ask you, though."

Catra leans forward, an eager smile on her face. "What is this *reeaally* important question, then?"

Adora feels her face redden as she shifts slowly into a half-sitting position. "Uh… Would you like to be my girlfriend?"

"What?" Catra has a light blush covering her face, too, as she laughs.

"Well, I mean, we both said we love each other, and then we kissed. But I don't want to assume anything, so… Would you do me the honour of being my girlfriend?"

Again, Catra laughs. Adora can't help but smile, too, as she looks up at her. In all her years of living, her laugh is the most beautiful thing she's ever heard. She wants to hear it for the rest of her life.

"Yes, Adora, I would love to be your girlfriend. Do you want to be my girlfriend?" Catra asks.

Smiling brightly, Adora says, "Yes, I would."

Catra giggles at their ridiculousness as Adora flops back down onto the bed, a blissful smile still gracing her features. As Adora's eyes flutter closed again, a firm knock on the door stops her from falling asleep again. She keeps her eyes half-lidded, though, not having the strength to do much more.

From her spot on the bed, Adora hears heels clack on the linoleum flooring as Castaspella walks into the room. She doesn't move from her comfortable position as the black-haired woman walks to stand in front of Adora.

"Hello, my dear, how are you feeling? I'm sorry I couldn't be here when you awoke, I had some matters to attend to," Casta says, sitting in the empty chair beside Adora's bed.

Adora grins sleepily, eyes still millimeters from closing. "I'm feeling okay. I'm glad you're here, though." She has the fleeting thought that Shadow Weaver wouldn't see her before she remembers that Shadow Weaver is the whole reason she's here. That's fine, though; she doesn't need Shadow Weaver, anyway.

"That's good to hear. Oh, I knit you a sweater! I had to guess on the sizing, but I think it's about right," says Castaspella, gently placing something soft and fluffy in Adora's lap. Adora brings the soft fabric up to her face, hugging it close. Her mother used to knit her sweaters, too, when Adora wasn't training or on missions.

"Wow, it's so soft. Thank you so much, mom," Adora says, still hugging the sweater as if it were a stuffed animal. If Adora had been looking, she would've noticed the pure surprise written all over Castaspella's face and Catra trying to stifle her laughter. It's only a few seconds after speaking that Adora realizes her mistake, eyes widening.

"Oh no. I'm so sorry, Casta. It was an accident, it won't happen again. It's just, my mom used to knit me sweaters, too, so I got mixed up. I didn't mean to-"

Castaspella cuts off her ramble with a light laugh. “It’s quite alright, Adora. I know you didn’t mean to call me that. Besides, you’re probably the closest thing I have to a child, anyway. We’ll just forget you ever said that.”

It’s true that Adora sees Casta as a sort of mother figure since she saved her life when Shadow Weaver ordered her to kill the sorceress. Sometimes, Adora visits Mystacor just to watch the eclipses with Casta and see the changes to Mystacor since she’d lived there. It’s nice… to just sit under the moons and talk about her day, or her friends, or how much she hates Shadow Weaver, with Casta. The sorceress was definitely the first to know about Adora’s feelings for Catra and even helped her make her apology speech months ago.

It’s the kindness and support Adora always got from her mother, and never from Shadow Weaver.

“Okay… Thank you for the sweater, though. It’s really nice,” Adora says meekly, pulling the knitted sweater up to cover her reddened face.

The sorceress smiles down at Adora, ruffling her hair. “It’s not a problem, dear. I hope it keeps you warm in this… dreary infirmary room,” she says, looking around the small room with an upturned nose before turning to look back at Adora with a smile. “I’ll see you soon, alright?”

Adora, still keeping her face in the warm sweater, says, “Of course. Bye, Casta!”

Once the sorceress has left the room, Adora hears a snicker from behind her. Blushing, she turns around to look for the culprit only to see Catra trying to hold in her laughter.

“And what do you think is so funny?” Adora says, embarrassed. She knows what Catra thinks is so funny. In fact, she *is* what Catra thinks is so funny.

Catra smirks, rubbing her thumb across Adora's hand. "You just called your best friend's aunt mom." She almost sounds shocked that Adora actually just did that.

The blonde groans loudly, letting go of Catra's hand to cover her face with her pillow. Catra laughs loudly this time, likely annoying the other infirmary employees and patients, as Adora mumbles indignantly into the pillow.

Adora drops her pillow, feigning annoyance, but not being able to feel anything other than grateful to hear that laugh again.

Once Catra's laughter has subsided, it's quickly replaced by a soft smile as she looks down at Adora.

"So…" Catra says, fiddling with the hem of her maroon t-shirt. "Where are you going to be staying now that Shadow Weaver thinks you're, you know, dead?"

Oh.

It hadn't dawned on Adora yet that Shadow Weaver doesn't know she survived. She can live her life now, without Shadow Weaver's control. She can be free. Adora hasn't been free in over five hundred years. What will she do with her newfound freedom, though?

Adora has a place in mind she wants to stay, but she's not sure if she can ask. She could always just sleep on the couch in Hordak's sanctum, but that thing isn't very comfortable; Adora's had to sleep on the couch after Shadow Weaver kicked her out for the night enough times to know.

Before Adora can come up with an excuse, Catra says, "You could, uh, stay in Halfmoon. With-with me." There's a deep blush dusted over the thin fur on her face, highlighting her freckles.

"Really? You'd allow me to stay with you?" Adora asks, hopeful, but too afraid to get excited.

Catra snorts, moving to hold Adora's hand again. "You're my *girlfriend*, dummy. Of course you're welcome to stay with me. Besides, now you get to meet my parents as my girlfriend. That'll be fun, right?" She has a smug grin on her face that lets Adora know that definitely will not be fun. "But only if you want to, obviously," she adds, her grin softening.

"I'd love to, Catra. I love you." Adora doubts she'll ever be able to say those last three words to Catra without smiling.

"I love you, too, Adora."

One week later…

Adora sits in her hospital bed, barely able to contain her excitement, as she waits for Hordak.

After an entire week of staying in the infirmary, Micah finally agreed to let Adora go stay in Halfmoon. It took a while to convince him and Hordak that she would have healed enough after a week of rest to go stay with Catra, but she and Catra did. Adora knows they're just worried for her health, though, especially after seeing her struggle to do so much as walk on her own after the attack.

She's spent the entire week either resting, taking her "healing medicine," or slowly building her strength back after having lost nearly all of it. She had to lean on Hordak to walk—Adora refused to use a wheelchair because of how humiliating that would be—her wound flaming up in pain if she tried to walk on her own.

Her time spent bedridden wasn't spent alone, though. At least two Princess Alliance members visited her each day, keeping her spirits up as her body healed. Hordak spent as much time as he could with her, as to not make Prime suspicious, keeping her up to date on the latest Fright Zone news and telling her funny stories. Bow and Glimmer brought board games for them to all play, which always ended in them all crying tears of laughter. Mermista

brought her collection of Mer-Mysteries books, which Adora actually enjoyed reading. Perfuma gave her an assortment of fresh flowers to liven up the infirmary room. Castaspella knitted her more comfy clothes, which Adora appreciated in her cold room, and gave her advice. Catra… Catra kept Adora company the entire time, making her laugh and stay hopeful. Yesterday, she even walked on her own, while being cheered on by Catra.

Speaking of Catra, the Magicat is currently in Halfmoon, getting her room ready for Adora's arrival. Cyra and Milo were thrilled to have Adora stay with them for a few weeks, but maybe that's just because she hasn't told them she's dating their daughter yet.

As Adora's thinking of a plan to tell the Magicat Queen and King that she's dating their daughter, Hordak opens the door and walks in with a smile and a change of clothes. Given that she's currently wearing a hospital gown with a knitted sweater on top, Adora's grateful for the clothes.

"So?" Adora asks.

Hordak grins as he places the clothes—a black t-shirt with the Horde emblem on it, and a pair of grey leggings, both seemingly too big for Adora—onto the bed. Since all of Adora's clothes are currently at Shadow Weaver's house, the clothes Hordak gave her are most likely his. "You're good to go. I'll be waiting outside on the skiff, okay?"

Adora nods, reaching over to grab the clothes. "Yup, see you there!" Hordak walks out of the room with a nod as Adora moves to stand up. As she's changing out of her clothes, she can feel the tightness of the stitches on her abdomen, and the soreness of the bruises covering her body.

Walking to stand in front of the floor-length mirror, Adora tries to count the bruises and cuts covering her and ends up losing count. Her face and torso have the most bruises on them, one eye purple and still slightly swollen. The two wounds on her abdomen and back aren't covered with bandages anymore, and are now stitched

up. Adora knows they're going to scar, even if vampires aren't meant to scar.

As she's looking at herself in the mirror, Adora can't help but wonder how she's lived like this for so, so long. How she tolerated everything Shadow Weaver's done to her.

All the arguments and fights.

The bruises and blood.

The *manipulation*.

Though, Adora already knows why she tolerated it. What other choice did she have? She could either follow Shadow Weaver or have her kill Adora and her mother. Even if Marlena had already lost her memory when Adora agreed to go, she still deserved to live. Adora, on the other hand, not so much.

Adora lifts a slow, shaky hand to the large stitched-up wound right below her sports bra, trying to ignore the thoughts in her head. If her mom said she deserves to live, then maybe she's right. For the sake of survival, Adora tries to believe her.

The wound stings when Adora's fingertips touch it. The blonde winces, but doesn't remove her hand. Shadow Weaver has never gone this far in hurting Adora, only ever bringing her near to the brink of death but making sure she survives. As Adora tries to remember a time when Shadow Weaver hurt her to this extent, she remembers what day it is today.

How could she have forgotten? Today is…

It's her birthday today. Her five hundred sixty-second birthday.

A dark, humourless chuckle comes out of Adora as her eyes roam over her bruised, damaged body. Spending her birthday in pain isn't unusual for Adora, but the irony of the moment hits her all at once.

“Happy birthday to me,” Adora says, whispering to nobody.

Chapter End Notes

Surprise! Happy Birthday, Adora! If you haven't realized yet, the timeline in this AU doesn't follow real life and is a bit of a mess haha. Also, I've always imagined Etheria to not have very extreme seasons, so don't expect it to be super cold and always snowing in this fic now because Adora's birthday is January 19th.

Ok... I KNOWWW you were probably expecting more from this chapter, and I'm sorry if this was disappointing for you, but I wanted to further show Adora's connections with the other characters, and how they support her. Adora's connections and friendships with the characters is one of the most crucial components of this fic, and I feel like I haven't gone into enough detail about some of them. Also, these past few chapters have been SO angsty, so I decided to give you guys a little breather.

I PROMISE, in the next chapter, I'll move the plot forward a lot. But for now... Catradora canon girlfriends!! Yay!!

Here's the drawing I promised. Hope you guys like it:



picture upload
Ok, bye! Leave a comment if you enjoyed this chapter, they mean a lot to me :)

Chapter title credit: class of 2013- mitski

setting the world on fire, and watching from the center of the flames

Chapter Summary

Catra has a small birthday surprise for Adora.

Adora and Hordak have doubts.

They pay Shadow Weaver a visit.

Chapter Notes

Hey!! As an apology for not updating this fic, here's the chapter you've all been waiting for! The beginning is mostly fluffy, and then shit starts hitting the fan. I really enjoyed writing this chapter, though!

I hope you enjoy reading this chapter! If you do, you could leave a kudo and/or a comment. I appreciate both so so much, and I love hearing what you guys have to say :)

Anyways, bye-bye!

TW: mentions of abuse, death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The walk to the skiff parked outside is quiet. Well, quiet on the outside, at least. As Adora walks outside of the Brightmoon infirmary, she can't help but let her thoughts spiral.

What if Catra's parents don't like her?

What if Adora is too weak to kill Shadow Weaver?

What if Shadow Weaver was righ-

"Hey!" a voice says in front of her. Adora forces her eyes up to look forward at Hordak, standing in the skiff and waiting for her. She boards the skiff wordlessly, as Hordak starts the motor and the two glide into the forest.

Once he's set the skiff to autopilot mode—they should really thank Entrapta for adding that feature—he moves to kneel in front of Adora, who's sitting curled up on the back of the skiff. "What's wrong?" he asks, patience and a hint of concern leaking into his voice.

Adora doesn't look up at him as she asks, "Do you think Shadow Weaver was right about me? That I'm weak, and a monster?" She must surprise Hordak with her questions, because silence falls over the two friends. To be fair, Adora's barely mentioned Shadow Weaver at all since the incident.

Eventually, Hordak regains his voice. Adora hears him shift in front of her, probably into a sitting position. "Shadow Weaver was wrong, Adora. She was wrong about everything. Anything she told you about yourself was a lie to make sure you didn't go against her. You're not weak, or a monster. Shadow Weaver doesn't know you."

Adora looks up at him after a moment to think over his words. "Do you really think that?"

Hordak smiles. "I wouldn't lie to you, Adora. You know that." Adora cracks a small grin of her own at the light-hearted joke. If even Hordak can make jokes at a time like this, maybe there's hope for her, after all.

That reminds her, though. "We should start making a plan, though, right? For how to deal with Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver?" she asks. Hordak sobers up almost immediately at the mention of the Horde Lord and Second in Command.

"We should. Do you want to start now, or later?"

“It’s best if we start as soon as possible. We don’t know what Shadow Weaver is planning to do now that she thinks I’m dead.” Hordak nods his head in agreement.

“Alright, well. Let’s plan, then,” he says, determined.

Adora can only hope this won’t blow up in their faces.

By the time the two arrive at the gates of Halfmoon Palace, they’ve come up with a stable-enough plan to kill Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime. It’s not a very complex plan, but they want to keep it as simple as possible to prevent anything going wrong. At least they have the upper hand, since Shadow Weaver thinks Adora is dead and Horde Prime doesn’t suspect Hordak is a traitor.

When the skiff stops, Hordak turns to Adora with a grin. “Happy five hundred sixty-second birthday, by the way.”

“You remembered?” Adora asks, a warm smile growing on her face as she jumps off the skiff. Hordak doesn’t get off, planning to drive back to Prime’s manor to not raise suspicion.

Hordak’s grin softens. “Of course I did. Now, I know you hate celebrating it, but I told Catra it’s your birthday today. I don’t think she’s planned anything for it, but I’m sorry in advance if she does.”

Adora knows Catra, though, and the Magicat doesn’t seem like the kind of person to go big on birthdays. “It’s fine, Hordak. I’m glad you told her, because I definitely wouldn’t have.” It’s nothing against Catra, Adora just hates people knowing her birthday.

Hordak nods. “Okay, well, I’ve got to get going. I’ll see you soon, okay? Don’t do anything stupid,” he says jokingly, but Adora can see the worry hidden underneath his nonchalance. He knows Adora hasn’t fully healed yet, which is clear by her slight limp when she walks and the bruises scattered all over her face and

the rest of her body. Though, the bruises have mostly faded from their original dark purple into a pale purple-ish blue.

"Yeah, I'll see you soon. And don't worry so much, I'll be fine." With that, Adora turns and walks down the path towards the large maroon doors leading into the palace. She glances over her shoulder to see the skiff roar to life again, Hordak leading it back to the Fright Zone.

As soon as Adora steps through the palace doors, she's greeted by the Magicat Queen and King wrapping her in a tight hug. Once Adora protests in pain from the pressure on her bruises, the two move back to smile at her.

"Welcome, Adora! We're so happy to have you here," King Milo says, smiling brightly. His yellow eyes crinkle at the edges as he does so.

"You're welcome to stay here as long as you need, dear. We'd love for you to stay and keep Catra company," Cyra says, smile growing at the mention of her daughter.

Speaking of said daughter, though… "Thank you for letting me stay here. I appreciate it so much. Where's Catra, though?" She looks behind the couple, down the hallway, but sees nobody there aside from a couple guards.

Milo and Cyra smile at each other, as if expecting this question. "She's in her bedroom waiting for you." Adora nods as they move aside to let her pass, walking down the hall to where Catra told Adora her room is.

Catra

Pacing back and forth in her room, Catra worries if Adora will like the gift she's going to give her. Melog mews in protest of her pacing while splayed out on her bed, the sun shining down on their soft purple fur.

If Hordak had told her sooner, she could have come up with a better gift for the blonde. Though, given the small time she's been given, Catra's still proud of her gift. It's nothing fancy, small enough to fit in a little box in her palm.

The door creaks open and Catra stills, hiding the box behind her back. Adora walks into the room, looking nervous. Once her eyes land on Catra, though, most of her hesitance melts away. "Hey, Catra," she says in an almost-whisper, as if she isn't allowed to speak any louder. Catra notices her slight limp and pale bruises, but decides not to let her eyes wander to them. She won't let what Shadow Weaver did ruin this day.

Catra smiles, heart warming at Adora's gentleness. "Hey, dummy." The blonde moves across the room to stand in front of her, fiddling with her fingers. Adora looks down at Catra's arms, where they're hidden behind her back, with an inquisitive look.

"Happy Birthday, Adora," Catra says, pulling the small box from behind her back. She hands the box to a very surprised-looking Adora, who opens the box to reveal a simple ring in the shape of Catra's old mask. There's a small, dark ruby in the middle of the ring—the middle of the helmet.

As gently as she can, Adora slips the ring onto the index finger of her left hand. The red of the ring matches well with the black and maroon Horde ring on her right ring finger. The Horde-issued ring protects her from the sunlight, and has the Horde insignia engraved into it, ensuring that anyone who sees it knows which kingdom she's in. Oddly enough, the obviousness of the ring is both a blessing and a curse. Though, Catra's ring softens the cruelty associated with the Horde ring.

"It's… It's beautiful, Catra. I love it so much, thank you," Adora says, staring down at the ring in awe. Before Catra can react, Adora pulls her into a tight hug. The Magicat wraps her arms around Adora with a laugh, resting her head on her taller shoulder. Catra's too embarrassed to admit that she has to tiptoe to reach the blonde's shoulder, though.

Once the two pull away from the hug, Catra lifts a hand to rest it on Adora's cheek. Adora leans into the touch, smiling. "I'm glad you like it. If I had more time to plan, I would've come up with something better." Adora shakes her head as Catra says the last sentence.

"No, I love this way more than I would've loved a big party and gifts. I'll love anything you do for me, though," says Adora, face, blushing. Catra can't help but smile brighter at Adora's words, not understanding how anyone could possibly see Adora as an evil person.

"Well, that's good to know. Wanna go show my parents, now?" Catra asks, her smile turning mischievous. Adora pales at the thought of telling Catra's parents they're dating. Before Adora can protest at the idea, Catra grabs Adora's hand and pulls her towards the door.

"Is this a good idea, Catra? What if your parents don't want me to date you? What if-" Catra's voice cuts her off before her thoughts can spiral again.

"You trust me, right?" Catra asks.

The random question works to surprise Adora into almost-silence. "Of course I do," she responds.

"Well, trust me when I say that my parents will love you, no matter who you are to me. You're basically family to them at this point."

Adora's panic morphs into happiness.

Family? They see her as family?

Adora, One Week Later...

"Are you sure you'll be okay?" Catra asks, standing in front of Hordak's skiff as Adora throws a backpack onto the metal

transport.

Adora turns back to her, smiling despite where she's about to go. She moves forward to give the Magicat a quick kiss, ignoring her parents' cooing from behind Catra. "I'll be fine, you don't need to worry." She leaves her hands resting on Catra's face, not having enough strength to pull away.

"I just don't like the idea of you going to fight Shadow Weaver alone," Catra says, leaning into Adora's touch. Hordak responds from his spot on the skiff behind Adora.

"She won't be alone, I'll be there with her." They both turn around to face him, Adora's hands subsequently dropping from their spot resting on Catra's face. Adora takes his words as her cue to say her goodbyes and get on the skiff. She turns back to Catra. Fortunately, Catra is thinking the same thing.

"I love you, Adora. Come back to me, okay?" she asks in a hushed tone, not wanting the other to hear her. Adora's warm smile returns as she places a gentle kiss on Catra's forehead.

"I love you, too, Catra. I promise I will." It probably isn't a good idea to promise anything right now, but Adora can't help it. Catra is so worried, she can't leave knowing how anxious the Magicat is for her. The promise does its job in alleviating some of Catra's stress, though. A small smile grows on her face as she nods, and Adora is grateful to see that smile one last time before she leaves.

'*I'll come back to her*,' Adora reassures herself internally. 'Shadow Weaver won't kill me again. She can't.'

Before Adora can regret her decision, she hops onto the skiff. Hordak turns the skiff to face in the direction of the Fright Zone, and Adora waves to the King, Queen, and Princess. They all wave back, misty-eyed but still smiling up at her.

The skiff—equipped with its auto-pilot feature—speeds further and further away from the palace, the place Adora has stayed for the

past week. Milo and Cyra were so welcoming to her, even after finding out about her relationship with their daughter. They might as well have welcomed her into the family.

Adora glances down at the ring on her left index finger. The gold and small ruby glisten in the sunlight, rainbow colours dancing across the deep reds of the gemstone.

“Looks like someone had a good time in Halfmoon,” says a voice in front of her teasingly. Adora looks up at Hordak, blushing and hiding her ring behind her. Before Adora can respond, Hordak beats her to the punch.

“Oh, don’t look so embarrassed. I’m just kidding, I’m glad you enjoyed your time with Catra.” Adora drops her hands from behind her back, relieved.

“Yeah, Catra’s great, and her parents were so nice to me,” Adora says, grinning. Hordak smiles with her, glad to see how happy Catra makes Adora.

Hordak turns his head in the direction the skiff is going, noticing that they’re closer to the Fright Zone than they thought. His smile morphs into a frown, turning to face Adora again.

“That's good. We’re still okay with the plan, though?”

Adora’s grin fades, too, as she realizes what she’s about to do. Though she’s confident with the plan she and Hordak came up with. “Yup. You brought the magic-blocking restraints, right?”

Hordak crouches down to grab the metal handcuffs, which have a thin ring of green on them. “Yes, Entrapta finished them earlier today.” Adora nods, relieved they have reached no hitches in their plan. Yet.

“Okay… Okay, that’s good.”

Noticing the growing anxiety of the blonde as they reach their dreaded destination, Hordak places a gentle hand on her shoulder.

“We can do this, okay? We know the plan, and we have the upper hand in this situation. You don’t have to go through with killing Shadow Weaver alone,” he says, his voice an equal mix of determination and care.

Adora nods again, albeit less hesitantly this time. She even cracks a small smile, despite knowing what’s going to happen today. “Yeah, you’re right. We can do this. Together. And you won’t have to kill Horde Prime alone, either. I’ll go with you, I’ll stay by your side.” Hordak’s eyes widen just slightly, as if he’s surprised Adora’s going to go with him.

Hordak pulls Adora into a tight hug before the blonde can react, though Adora reciprocates it with just as much love.

“If Horde Prime kills me or-or wipes my memories,” Hordak says, voice shaking. “I want to thank you. So… Thank you, Adora. You showed me how to be myself, and it scares me to think of who I’d be without you. You’re my best friend, and I… I love you.” Hordak doesn’t move while he speaks, tightening his arms around Adora and leaning his head down to place it on Adora’s shoulder.

Adora doesn’t pull away, knowing how much Hordak has struggled to show his emotions in the past. Maybe not seeing her face will help him speak openly, and Adora’s more than okay with helping Hordak. He’s been such a kind friend to her, the least she can do is reciprocate it. She leans her head on Hordak’s shoulder, allowing him to be comforted by her.

“Of course, Hordak. You deserve to be yourself, without fearing what Horde Prime will do to you. I love you, too. You’re my best friend and always will be. Once Prime is gone, you won’t have to hide anymore.” A sob shudders through Hordak at Adora’s last sentence. Adora slides her hands up and down Hordak’s back, a grounding technique she’s felt other use on her when she’s panicking.

As the smoke plumes rising from Prime’s factories appear closer and closer, Adora and Hordak prepare to begin their plan.

Hordak pulls away from the hug, wiping his eyes and smiling sheepishly. “I’m sorry,” she says in a mutter.

Adora smiles a soft smile. “You have nothing to apologize for.” The skiff slows down as they approach the hill that leads up to Shadow Weaver’s house. The house is too far away from the skiff for Shadow Weaver to see them, the area surrounded with dense forestry.

“Are you sure you want to come with me? I can go in myself, if you’re not ready.”

Hordak’s eyes shoot towards her, wide and surprised. “What? No, you will not confront the woman who’s been tormenting you for half a millennium alone. I won’t let you. Besides, our plan won’t work if I’m not there to distract Shadow Weaver.”

Adora glances at the hill—squinting to see the house, but not seeing anything but old trees and bushes—then back at Hordak. “Okay. Thank you, for making sure I don’t do this alone.” She wouldn’t admit it, not even to Hordak, but she's scared. Terrified, even. She’s been nothing more than Shadow Weaver’s ward for five hundred years. What if she won’t be anyone else after Shadow Weaver is gone? What if… What if she’s nothing without Shadow Weaver, just like the masked woman has told her for years?

“It’s not a problem, Adora. We stick together, right?”

Adora smiles and nods. “Yeah, we stick together.”

With that, the two friends exit the skiff, remembering to bring all the equipment they’ll need. It takes some time to get the heavy materials off the skiff, but they manage.

This is going to be a very interesting day for Shadow Weaver.

Hordak

With a deep breath and a wipe of his eyes, he knocks on the front door. Hordak hears heels clacking on the floor behind the door before it swings open to reveal a very cheerful-looking Shadow Weaver.

The dark sorceress' eyes widen at the sight of Hordak behind her mask. Hordak offers a tight smile in response.

"Hordak! It's so good to see you, it's been too long," says Shadow Weaver. It takes all of Hordak's strength not to snarl at the cruel woman in front of him. Instead, he nods at her.

"Yes, it has. Would you have any time to spare? I would love to catch up with you about how you've been handling Adora's death." He keeps his voice neutral, a skill he learned from living with Horde Prime for his entire life. He can only hope Shadow Weaver won't find it suspicious that Hordak came here without Horde Prime. Maybe he can blame it on his grief over Adora, though…

Shadow Weaver steps aside to allow Hordak in. "I have time, so come in. Go on, take a seat," she says, stretching an arm towards the living room. Hordak obliges, moving past Shadow Weaver and into the living room.

Once he sits down in one of two armchairs, the masked woman sits in the other. From what Hordak's seen of her since Adora was presumed dead, Shadow Weaver has been in a great mood for weeks. At least, that's what Prime told him. He hasn't spoken to her since… When was the last time he spoke to her?

"So, how have you been since Adora died? I know you and her were friends," Shadow Weaver asks, looking positively overjoyed at the mention of her presumably dead ward. Hordak wonders internally how Adora had tolerated someone as irritating as Shadow Weaver for half a millennia.

Hordak sighs, looking down. "While clones cannot feel emotions as regular Etherians can, I will admit that I miss Adora dearly. The Horde will not be the same without her." Oh, how he wished he

couldn’t feel emotions after he had seen Adora bleeding out on her porch the night Shadow Weaver stabbed her.

Shadow Weaver tsked, as if Adora’s death was merely an inconvenience for her. It likely was, if Hordak were to be realistic with himself. Now, Shadow Weaver doesn’t have anyone to manipulate and use.

“Yes, it is truly such a shame that Adora’s life was cut short. I was heartbroken when I heard the news of her death, as I’ve known her so long. The Horde will miss her greatly, especially me.” Hordak is surprised he hasn’t jumped over the small table separating himself and Shadow Weaver to strangle the woman to death. Who does she think she is? She’s the one who almost got Adora killed.

Instead of ruining the plan, Hordak sighs and nods. He moves on to getting any information out of Shadow Weaver before they go through with the next part of their plan. “I’m sure you were. How have you changed your life now that Adora isn’t here, though?”

Shadow Weaver practically jumps up at the opportunity to discuss her Adora-free life. “It’s funny you mention that, because I have some paperwork that I must sign right here.” She stands up to grab a small stack of papers, dropping them onto the dark-oak wooden coffee table in front of Hordak.

The blue-haired man grabs the stack, his eyes skimming over the words. Horde Prime’s will? “What are these for?” he asks, straining to keep the curiosity and anger out of his voice. Hordak doesn’t have to see Shadow Weaver’s face under her mask to know she’s smiling.

“After Adora’s death, Horde Prime was concerned about the safety of those in the Horde, especially himself. If Adora was killed by a vampire hunter, who’s to say they won’t go after Prime, too? He wants to ensure that the Horde is in safe hands, so he’s changed his will to ensure that I would inherit the kingdom’s power if he were to die.”

Hordak raises an eyebrow. If he remembers correctly, he was meant to become Horde Lord if Prime were to die. Shadow Weaver, somehow knowing what Hordak was thinking, laughs darkly.

"There is no need to worry, Hordak. I am not replacing you in any way. Horde Prime is just ensuring his kingdom would go to someone who could actually protect it."

"And what is *that* supposed to mean?" Hordak asks, unable to hide his scowl anymore.

Shadow Weaver laughs again, this time more snarky than cruel. "I hate to be blunt, but you're a defect, Hordak. You were a mistake Horde Prime made while creating his flawless clones, something you will never be. Between the three of us—you, Adora, and myself—I am the only one suitable as ruler of the Horde. Adora was always too weak to lead, and you're too broken to lead."

It's a miracle Adora's killing Shadow Weaver today because Hordak doesn't think he can handle listening to her for one more second. "Oh, be honest, Shadow Weaver. You've been planning to kill Adora and Horde Prime for decades now. I'm surprised you could even pull off Adora's death, though. Everyone knows Adora's always been stronger than you." Hordak pauses to laugh; however, his laugh is laced with pure rage more than anything else. "Adora doesn't even have any magic, and yet she's stronger than you'll ever be."

Shadow Weaver had been watching Hordak with wide, enraged eyes. But Hordak's last sentence is seemingly the last straw for any semblance of calmness the woman had. She stands up, moving in front of Hordak and yelling loudly.

"Who do you think you are, walking into MY home and saying Adora was stronger than me! ADORA WAS THE WEAKEST, MOST PATHETIC NUISANCE I'VE EVER BEEN CURSED TO KNOW! THE HORDE IS BETTER OFF WITHOUT HER, THAT'S WHY I KILLED HER!" She gasps when she realizes what she just revealed.

Hordak crosses his arms with a grin while still sitting down in the comfortable armchair. Shadow Weaver takes a step back, eyes still wide, before moving forward to point a finger into Hordak's chest.

"You- Horde Prime can't know I killed Adora. You will not tell him, otherwise he'll never trust me to rule the Horde. I'll… I'll lose all my power, all my authority."

Hordak stands slowly, standing taller than Shadow Weaver and looking down at the terrified sorceress. "I wouldn't worry about your future if I were you," he says, before grabbing a small stun baton, which he had concealed in his pocket. Shadow Weaver is so preoccupied while worrying about her potential power that she doesn't notice the weapon in Hordak's hand. Hordak electrocutes her until she falls limp onto the floor, and the house falls silent.

Well, almost silent. Now that nobody is speaking in the home, it's much easier to hear the sound of footsteps and powder falling onto the floor upstairs. Slowly, the footsteps make their way down the stairs.

Adora stands in the middle of the house, holding a large crate of gunpowder. Hordak crouches down to place Shadow Weaver's wrists into the magic-blocking handcuffs, making sure the green ring glows on the metal to show that they're preventing Shadow Weaver from using any magic. Once he's sure they're working, he walks over her body to stand in front of Adora.

"So, I'm assuming you heard everything Shadow Weaver said?" he asks, his tone equal parts concerned and joking. Shadow Weaver did say some pretty cruel things when she thought Adora wasn't listening.

Adora chuckles. "Yeah, but it's nothing I haven't heard before. That stuff about Horde Prime replacing you was weird, though, right? I was sure he wasn't suspicious of you at all."

"Yes, it was, but it isn't of much concern to us. We'll be ruling the Horde soon enough, without either of their help. Though, are you

sure it's necessary to destroy this place?" Adora nods without hesitation at the question.

"This house is full of dark magic. It wouldn't be right to leave it all here for anyone to take. Besides, I want to destroy every trace of Shadow Weaver on Etheria. I might as well start by destroying all her work," Adora says, shrugging nonchalantly while explaining her plan with an almost-sadistic grin. Hordak practically shivers from the pure cruelty in the look, the blonde being just a bit too excited at the prospect of destruction.

Instead, he just shrugs. "Alright, if you say so." Adora, however dangerous she is when angry, only wants the best for Etheria. If she thinks that blowing up Shadow Weaver's home is a good idea, Hordak will help her since Adora would do the same for him.

While Adora goes room-to-room, covering as much space as she can in the explosive material, Hordak carries Shadow Weaver's body outside. He places her down on the dead grass, leaning her on a streetlight pole. He takes off the handcuffs for a moment so he can loop them around the pole and bound her again. Now, she won't be able to look anywhere else but at the large house in front of her.

After Hordak has secured Shadow Weaver to the streetlight pole, the woman groans and shifts in her spot. Hordak stays crouched down as he waits for her eyes to open from behind the mask.

Shadow Weaver groans, then peeks her eyes open to look around. She glares at Hordak once her eyes have adjusted to the sunlight, and Hordak is sure she's sneering underneath her mask. "What's your plan, Hordak? Kill me and take my place as future Horde Lord? It won't be hard for Prime to find out it was you." Shadow Weaver is too busy trying to scare Hordak into letting her go that she doesn't notice the front door open and a certain blonde walks out with an empty box.

Hordak chuckles. "You're right, Horde Prime *would* likely figure out it was me if I were to kill you. The only problem is… I'm not the

one who's going to." Shadow Weaver continues yelling and berating Hordak more at his words.

Adora

She sets the box down on the porch quietly and makes her way to the two. She's close enough that Shadow Weaver could definitely notice her if she weren't so focused on yelling at Hordak. It's only after hearing Shadow Weaver call Hordak a "defect" that Adora decides she's had enough of this.

She moves to crouch down in front of the masked woman as Hordak stands beside her. "Hey, happy to see me?" she asks with a smirk. Shadow Weaver gasps, eyes wide, at the sight of a not-dead Adora in front of her. She stammers to no avail in an effort to say something, anything.

"I- You're supposed to be dead," is what she comes up with.

Adora laughs, dark and cruel, throwing her head back. She lowers her head again to level Shadow Weaver with a sharp glare. "And you're supposed to be stronger than me, but it looks like we're *both* disappointments, right?"

If Adora had said that at any other point in her life to Shadow Weaver, she probably would've ripped Adora's head off. Now, though, the dark sorceress still seems to be too shocked to see Adora again to even yell.

"I-I saw you bleed out. I stabbed you… with your sword. That should have killed you!" Shadow Weaver says, regaining the anger that was temporarily extinguished by surprise.

Adora tilts her head, smiling. "Aw, did you really think that would be enough to get rid of me?" She stands up, glancing at Hordak to see if he's alright. He gives her a nod back, showing that he's okay. Shadow Weaver always finds a way to cut deep with her words, and Adora won't go through with her plan in front of Hordak if he's uncomfortable.

The blonde's words seem to be the spark that really angers Shadow Weaver as she struggles in her restraints. She moves so that kneeling forward, straining in her handcuffs.

"Have you lost your mind, Adora? What do you think you're doing?"

Adora pulls out her sword, resting it underneath Shadow Weaver's masked chin. "I'm feeling better than I have in over five hundred years, actually. And I thought what I'm doing was pretty obvious, but maybe you need a little more help," she says, moving her sword just slightly forward, pushing the skin on Shadow Weaver's neck but not cutting it. Shadow Weaver makes a faint wheezing sound as the sword pushes on her throat.

"I'm doing what's best for the Horde, of course. But before I do that," Adora says, pulling her sword away fully. "I want you to watch what's about to happen." Shadow Weaver looks momentarily confused as Adora looks up at Hordak expectantly.

Hordak steps forward, lifting his right arm to power up the laser cannon attached to it. A deep orange light blooms from the tip of the machine, then a large ray of light shoots out of the cannon and straight into the heart of the home in front of the three. Shadow Weaver's eyes widen as the fire from her home burning down reflects on her mask.

The fire grows so quickly that, if you were to blink, you'd miss the flames engulfing half the building.

The smoke from the fire billows up into the blue sky, but Adora isn't worried about anyone suspecting anything. There are so many of Horde Prime's clone factories that throw polluting dark smoke into the air, that the burning of the masked woman's home will blend right in with them.

Adora could almost laugh at the irony of Horde Prime's buildings being the reason he doesn't find out about his Second-in-Command being murdered.

Suddenly, the orange-hued flames of the fire turn into a colourful rainbow of explosions. Adora and Hordak laugh as Shadow Weaver's eyes widen further. "Looks like the fire reached your spell room," Adora says, staring in awe at the colourful flames growing higher and higher into the pale blue sky. It really is a beautiful sight.

Once Adora decides she's tired of watching the raging fire, she turns her head to look down at Shadow Weaver. Seeing the completely heartbroken look on Shadow Weaver's face as all her work goes up in flames almost makes her feel bad for the dark sorceress. Almost.

"Centuries of work, all gone…" Shadow Weaver whispers in shock.

Adora sighs. "I'm sorry, Shadow Weaver," she says, not meaning a single word of what she's saying.

Shadow Weaver whips her head up to glare at Adora. "No, you're not. You're *cruel*… and a traitor."

Adora laughs a dark laugh again, pulling her sword out of its sheath at her side. The fire reflects onto the metal of the sword, casting brilliant colours onto it.

Moving forward, Adora pulls Shadow Weaver's mask off.

Hordak winces at the sight of Shadow Weaver's scarred and mutilated face. It's the first time he's ever seen the woman without her mask.

Adora doesn't flinch. She's seen Shadow Weaver's face too many times to react anymore.

"Who do you think I learned it from?" Adora asks with a frown, raising her sword up.

Shadow Weaver's eyes widen, the movement stretching the scars lining her face, as she looks up at the monster she's created. The fate she's brought on herself.

“Goodbye, Shadow Weaver.”

Adora brings the sword down with a slice.

Chapter End Notes

Just wanted to clarify that Adora didn't enjoy killing Shadow Weaver. She definitely enjoyed blowing up the house, but she doesn't take any joy in killing anymore, even if it is Shadow Weaver.

Ok, bye! Hope you liked this chapter. In the next chapter, the vampire duo will be visiting Horde Prime's manor ;)

Chapter title credit: THIS tumblr post on an Instagram page bc that Tumblr page is gone.

then i shall face god and walk backwards into hell

Chapter Summary

Adora and Hordak continue on with their plan.

Some people disagree with them.

Chapter Notes

Hey!! Wow, it's been a little while since I've updated this fic haha but anyway, I'm really excited for you guys to read this chapter! And I know I take a while to update my fics sometimes, but I'm 110% certain that I won't leave these as WIPs! Don't worry, I won't just leave this story.

With that aside, I really hope you enjoy this chapter! If you do enjoy it, I would really appreciate a kudo and/or a comment. Your words inspire me to write more, so if you want to see more of my work, leave a comment! Or don't, I won't tell you what to do.

Ok, bye-bye!

TW: electrocution, a LOT of mentions of blood, murder, mentions of abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Silence.

That’s the first thing Adora notices as her eyes trail down to the black blood dripping from her sword, and the pile of dust sitting in front of her. A skull sits atop the dust, staring forward at Adora.

Staring at Adora in a way that makes goosebumps appear all over her arms.

"Adora?" a voice she vaguely recognizes says behind her.

The blood-covered sword and Shadow Weaver's mask drop to the floor with a dull clatter, and Adora takes a step back.

"I… I killed her. I'm-I'm free," Adora says, eyes wide and voice breaking as tears build in her eyes, subsequently sliding down her face. The tears mix with the blood splattered across her face, leaving obvious tear trails down her cheeks. Why is she crying, though? Is it guilt? Regret? No, that's not it…

Adora hears rustling behind her, then a hand on her shoulder. She turns her head to look at Hordak, who's looking at her with pain in his eyes. "After over five hundred years, Adora, you're free from her grasp." Adora can see the shine of tears in his eyes.

"I'm free, I'm free," Adora repeats, over and over again, until the words finally settle in her head.

No more manipulation. No more lying about where she is and with who. No more pain at the hands of dark magic and berating words and shouting arguments and starvation. No more being kept in a cell for days or weeks on end for crimes as simple as having emotions.

The relief at her freedom hits Adora all at once, but so does the guilt of killing another being, no matter how cruel she was. No matter what Adora tries to convince herself of, Shadow Weaver was still a person. A heartless, manipulative person who Adora killed.

Adora's vision clouds with tears as she looks up at Hordak. The blue-haired man pulls Adora into a tight hug, one which Adora reciprocates instantly. Sobs wrack Adora, and she buries her head in Hordak's shoulder.

“It’s going to be okay. We’re going to be okay,” Hordak says above her, and Adora’s not sure whether he’s trying to convince her or himself. No matter who the words are meant for, she nods from her spot, hoping Hordak’s right.

The two friends stay like that, clinging to each other and shaking —from a combination of the chill in the night air and the murder that just happened in front of them—for what feels like an eternity. Eventually, Adora gains enough strength to wipe the tears from her eyes and lift her head. It’s only then that she notices how much of the blood and tears on her face wiped off onto Hordak’s black shirt. She looks up at him, giving him a smile so weak she can barely feel it.

“We’re going to be okay,” she repeats to Hordak, sounding more confident than he did.

Hordak nods, and a shaky smile grows on his face, too. “Are you ready to go, now?” Adora nods and crouches down to pick up her sword, but her hand hesitates on the maroon mask lying on the ground. The last piece of Shadow Weaver left on Etheria, aside from the scars marring Adora’s body.

“Should I take it?” Adora asks, without moving.

“I can’t be the one to decide what you do with anything involving Shadow Weaver. You make that decision on your own.” Adora sighs, but she knows he’s right. She should decide what she wants to do with the last remaining part of her “mentor” on her own.

She stares at the mask, hoping it’ll make this decision for her.

It doesn’t.

Adora picks up the mask herself. She might as well keep this one part of Shadow Weaver as a small reminder of everything she’s gone through to get to where she is today.

And where is she today? In front of the ashen remains of the place she's called home for centuries.

With a frown, Adora moves to stand up and turns to Hordak.

"Ready to go?" Hordak asks, smiling just a little brighter.

"Yeah, let's get out of here," Adora responds, turning to walk side-by-side with Hordak back through the dense forest to their skiff.

Adora doesn't turn to look back at the smouldering house one last time. Or the woman there who treated Adora like the daughter she always despised. There's nothing left there other than pain, anyway.

The skiff's engine stops its incessant rumbling as the machine comes to a stop a few blocks from the large white manor in front of them. Horde Prime's large white manor in front of them. It seems that both Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver valued their privacy because both of their homes are in the middle of nowhere, with nobody within a ten-kilometre radius.

That's perfect for Adora and Hordak's plan, though.

Adora looks towards the elegant house, then back to Hordak. His hands are shaking so much Adora can see them from where she's standing beside him, and his eyes are wide as they stare forward.

She taps his arm gently to get his attention, not wanting to startle him. The blue-haired man jumps at the touch all the same, though. Hordak looks down at Adora inquisitively.

"If you don't feel ready to go through with this, I can… I can do it for you," she says, keeping her voice in a hushed whisper.

Hordak's curiosity shifts to anger, but none of it is directed at Adora. "No, I'll do it. Prime has a way of-of hurting people without even touching them, and I'm more experienced in dealing with his

manipulation. I don't want you to get hurt while doing something you don't need to."

Adora nods, nudging his arm with her elbow half-heartedly. "Alright, but you already know I'm not letting you do this alone. We've looked out for each other for far too long for me to leave now. We stick together, right?"

"Me and you taking over the Horde? I wouldn't have it any other way," Hordak says, smiling down at his closest friend for millennia with a warm smile.

With that, Adora crouches down to grab her sword—just in case—and her eyes trail over the mask lying on the metal. Oh, how hilarious it would be to see the look on Prime's face when she shows him the mask. With a smirk, she grabs the mask and jumps off the skiff with Hordak.

Once Hordak notices the mask, he chuckles loudly. "I can't wait to see how Horde Prime reacts to seeing that thing." Great minds think alike, huh?

Adora laughs with him as the two walk down the broken dirt path that leads to Horde Prime's manor. Prime really hated anyone knowing where he lived, so he keeps his house in the most inconspicuous place in the Fright Zone. Who would have thought that Prime and Shadow Weaver's aversion to people would make plans to murder them so easy!

Once the two get close enough to the house, they split up. Hordak keeps walking towards the front of the house, while Adora walks around the house to the back of the house. During the daytime, when a vampire is most vulnerable, Prime's manor is guarded by a handful of his clones. Adora doesn't doubt that the number of guards surrounding the home has gone up with the gossip about her own death all over the Fright Zone.

Adora ducks under a bush, peeking up to check how many clones are waiting by the back door for any intruders. Four guards. Okay,

Adora can work with that.

With that knowledge, Adora places one hand on her sword and moves to the clones as quickly as she can. Prime's clones aren't exactly the strongest beings on the planet, so Adora isn't too worried about losing this fight.

One clone' heads is chopped off before the other three can even notice her and, when they do turn to see Adora standing beside them, it's already far too late. With a few swings of her sword, the only person standing in front of the back door is Adora. She looks down at green blood sliding down her sword in disgust, but moves ahead anyway.

Adora peeks into the house. She sees Horde Prime standing at the front door, and Hordak on the other side. Hordak walks in, grinning like he knows a secret Prime doesn't, and Prime follows. It's faint, but Adora can see the slightest bit of confusion in Prime's four eyes. Adora sees Hordak glance towards the back door, where Adora is waiting, and she takes that as her signal to enter.

Stealth isn't an important part of this plan, and Adora knows this, which is why she chooses to stab the sliding glass door with her sword and kick any remaining shattered glass away with her foot. Horde Prime whips around at the sight of shattering glass, eyes wide with rage and shock.

The rage quickly turns into a smug grin, though. "You cannot enter unless I welcome you."

Adora returns the grin with one of her own. "You already did, remember?" She steps into the home and onto the bits of glass scattered all over the tiled floor. The smugness on Prime's face vanishes as quickly as it came, morphing into fear. He hides the emotion well, though. Adora walks to stand beside Hordak—in front of Horde Prime—holding her sword in one hand and the mask in another hidden behind her back.

“What are you two doing? Have you lost your minds?” Horde Prime asks indignantly.

Adora shrugs, smiling wickedly. “We’re feeling great, actually. You, on the other hand, don’t look like you’re doing too well.”

Horde Prime scoffs. “I’m feeling fine. I know Hordak, my loyal servant, would do nothing to hurt me. Isn’t that right, little brother? Is rebelling like this really worth the consequences that will come from this?” Horde Prime asks, and he doesn’t have to specify what consequences he’s talking about. Prime made Hordak and Adora watch the purifying process enough for it to be permanently ingrained into their brains.

Adora risks a glance towards Hordak, and notices how his whole body quivers with fear in front of Prime. She turns back to the ancient vampire in front of them, anger burning bright in her chest. “This has nothing to do with rebelling. This is about justice, and giving you what you deserve,” says Adora, standing tall but still being looked down on by Prime.

Prime turns his focus from Hordak to Adora. “And you, *little sister.*” Adora feels the hair on the nape of her neck stand at the nickname. “What would Shadow Weaver think if she saw you betraying your leader like this? I’m sure Shadow Weaver would love to put you in your place in that dingy little cell she has waiting for you.”

Adora smirks, pulling the mask from behind her back and letting it clatter to the floor in front of the three. “I don’t think Shadow Weaver is going to be a problem for us. Well, not anymore, that is.”

Horde Prime’s eyes widen further as he stares down at the empty mask. Adora could almost laugh at the look of pure shock on his face, but she composes herself. She can laugh about this with Hordak later, but for now…

Hordak must notice that Prime is about to tap into his hive mind of clones, because he moves quickly to place the metal collar around Prime's neck and buckle it into place. Immediately, the metal machinery whirrs to life and tightens around Prime's neck. The collar does its job of cutting Prime off from his hive mind, making it impossible for him to call on his clones to come attack Adora and Hordak.

Adora sees sparks come off the collar, but Prime doesn't react to the pain he's obviously feeling. Prime moves to attack Hordak, but the sparks on the collar grow and he groans in pain.

"I wouldn't try that if I were you," Adora says, crossing her arms. Prime looks back at Adora.

"Did it feel good to betray your kingdom like this? To kill the mentor who's taught you everything you know about the Fright Zone?" Horde Prime asks, baring his teeth.

"Yes, it did," Adora half-lies. Horde Prime is too preoccupied with the pain in his neck and his inability to communicate with his clones to notice the lie. Adora turns to Hordak, and gives him a gentle questioning look, asking if he's ready to go through with the next part of the plan. Hordak, as if reading Adora's mind, nods.

With the controller in Hordak's hand, he boosts the voltage of the collar until Horde Prime collapses onto his knees with a loud thud. Once Hordak lowers the voltage, Prime lifts his head weakly.

"Wha-What's your plan here? Kill me… and then what? You're useless without me, and Adora's useless without Shadow Weaver."

Hordak grabs the well-hidden wooden stake from his side, but Adora moves to hand her sword to him. Hordak looks at the sword, then back at Adora in surprise.

"Really?" he asks, whispering even though Prime can definitely hear them.

It’s no secret that Adora’s protective of her sword. It’s the last piece of her family she has left, even if it is corrupted with dark magic. But Adora allows Hordak to use her sword as a gift, of sorts, for deciding to stick with her to kill Shadow Weaver. It’s the least she can give him, even if it was his choice to stick by her side.

Adora nods. “Go for it.” Hordak grabs the sword, moving it around in his hand to adjust to the weight of it. He smiles down at the perfectly crafted sword, then brings his head back up to grin down at Prime. He moves the sword to rest it in front of Horde Prime’s chest, where his heart rests.

Now, they can both see the pure fear in Prime’s eyes. The way his wide eyes look down to see a mixture of green and black blood trailing down the hand-crafted metal of the last remaining Grayskull sword.

The irony is not lost on Adora that the last remaining part of Eternia will kill the last remaining part of Horde Legion. The last remaining Eternian is helping to kill the last remaining Horde Legion soldier, putting an end to the millennia-old war between the two ancient kingdoms.

“We’re going to take over the Horde,” Hordak says with a grin. “And turn it into your worst nightmare.”

He pushes the sword just an inch further.

“We’re going to make the Horde *good.*”

The fear in Prime’s eyes mixes with pure rage, more than Adora’s ever seen. “NO!” he yells so loud that Adora’s eardrums ring.

The sword dives into Prime’s chest, led by the hand of Prime’s failed experiment. Dark green blood pours from the wound, and Prime turns into a pile of ash in front of them, just as Shadow Weaver did.

Once the adrenaline of the moment wears off, Adora turns to Hordak. He doesn't look as terrified as Adora did when she killed Shadow Weaver.

"You did it," she says in awe.

"*We* did it," Hordak corrects.

With a laugh, Adora pulls Hordak in for a tight hug. Hordak reciprocates the hug with a surprised laugh of his own, wrapping his arms around and lifting her up to spin them around in their spot.

The reality of their situation quickly sets in, though, and their hug ends. Hordak sets Adora down and hands her the sword back, and Adora moves to pick up the mask again.

"Are you ready to take over the Horde?"

Adora nods, determined. "Absolutely." She pauses. "But can we change into some new clothes before we go? We reek of blood right now."

The two look down at their clothes and all the blood that covers them. A moment of silence passes, then the two burst into laughter at the pure ridiculousness of their situation. The laughter is well-needed, especially after all the tears they've shed today.

"Yes, that's probably a good idea."

Two outfit changes later, Adora and Hordak have finally gotten rid of the blood covering their clothes. Changing out of the clothes doesn't seem to have rid Adora of the guilt bubbling in her gut, though.

Adora turned to Hordak as he wiped the green blood on his face off with a damp towel. "Hey, do you feel any, you know, guilt? For

killing Horde Prime?" She fidgets with her fingers as she awaits his answer.

Hordak stops wiping his face in front of the aluminium mirror and turns to Adora with a pang of sympathy in his eyes. He shakes his head, looking calm and collected. Unlike Adora. "No, I don't. If it had been any other being, I would have, but not Prime. That man has no place on Etheria, but I don't even think he can be called a man. He was a pure monster. There was no redeeming him, all he cared about was control and power."

Adora stays silent. Maybe Shadow Weaver could've become a better person. Maybe she could have… could have learned how to be a good person, like Adora is trying to now. She turns to stand in front of a large metal machine.

"What if Shadow Weaver still had some good left in her, and I-I killed it?"

In her reflection, Adora sees Hordak turn to look at her but not move from his spot. The sympathy in his eyes grows, and Adora looks away from his reflection.

"You gave Shadow Weaver so many chances to turn over a new leaf. She could have treated you better at any moment, but she chose to keep hurting you. She could have tried being a good person when she discovered we can drink animal blood, but she tried to kill you instead. I don't think Shadow Weaver could've been good, even if she tried to."

Adora lifts a hand to rest it on her stomach, feeling the raised skin of her wound scar through her black shirt. In turn, she sees the purple dark magic veins creeping up her hands. Shadow Weaver never bothered to be kind to her. She couldn't even be bothered to stop hurting Adora.

She could've stopped at any time, but she never did. Adora wraps her arms around her waist, as if to protect herself from a woman who's already gone.

Hordak continues. “Keeping Shadow Weaver alive wouldn’t have helped anyone. She would have just rotted in a prison cell for the rest of her life. We’re sparing her from spending a lifetime imprisoned, just like she’s done to you for the past five hundred years. Don’t feel guilty for getting the justice you deserved, after all this time.”

“Justice… for me?” she asks, voice barely over a whisper. She turns to look back at Hordak.

Adora knew this plan was about getting justice, but she always thought they were getting justice for the Horde. For the vampires of Etheria. For Hordak, after everything Prime has forced him to do. It hadn’t even occurred to her that killing Shadow Weaver could be a way for her to get justice for herself, and everything she’s endured from the masked woman.

“Yes, justice for you. You and I both deserve justice, and so does the Horde. They deserve a leader that will really care about them and their well-being. Someone who will lead the Horde to not only kindness but also greatness. That leader is you, Adora.”

The blonde smiles, the brightest one she’s smiled all day. “You really think I’ll be a good ruler for the Horde?”

Hordak matches her smile with the same softness and joy. “I’m sure of it. Now, let’s get out of here before the clones realize Prime isn’t responding in the hive mind.”

The two move quickly to grab everything they need and get out of the house, and Adora slings a small backpack over her shoulder. They aren’t going to burn down this one because of how much valuable information Prime’s hidden in it, but they’ll get back to organizing it later.

Now, though, they’re on a mission.

A mission to reclaim the Horde.

They jump onto the skiff, moving swiftly and quietly. Hordak sets the coordinates for the Horde's headquarters, since Prime's too "sophisticated" for a palace like every other kingdom.

"Hey, Hordak?" says Adora.

Hordak turns around to look at Adora with an inquisitive look. "Yes?"

She grins. "You *do* know that I'm not going to be the only ruler of the Horde, right? I wasn't just going to drop you the second we get to the palace, we'll lead the Horde together."

"Don't worry, I know you wouldn't do something like that." Hordak returns her grin with one of his own, and Adora's grateful to have a best friend as loyal and kind as him.

With that, Adora nods and sets her supplies down onto the metal floor of the skiff while she thinks over their plan.

There's a back exit in the headquarters that none of the clones know about; one that Prime only told Hordak about in case of emergencies. They'll go in through there if the main entrance is too guarded for them to pass without attracting attention. The headquarters are surrounded by the homes of other vampires, primarily the ones that are either the loyalest to Prime or have been in the Horde the longest. Once they're in, they'll move to Prime's throne room. By this point, people will have noticed them but that's okay becau-

"Adora, we're here," Hordak says, though he sounds… distracted? Adora turns to Hordak, only to see him looking at the front entrance of the headquarters with a look of pure confusion.

"What's wrong?" she asks.

Hordak points to the huge white and green building, where there are usually clones posted to surround the building and guard it. Today, though, there isn't a clone in sight. That'll definitely change their course of plans…

“Huh. That’s weird,” Adora says, crouching down to grab her sword and moving to stand back up. Hordak still seems puzzled as he looks at the building in confusion.

“In all my years under Prime’s control, I’ve never seen the headquarters unguarded. Something’s wrong,” he says, turning back to Adora.

The blonde scoffs. “Yeah, what’s wrong is that their leader is dead,” she deadpans. Adora jumps off the skiff, turning back to Hordak expectantly. Hordak lands on the concrete with a light thud, and the two begin the short trek to the large double doors of the building.

“No, I know that, but I hadn’t considered how much the clones would be affected by Prime leaving the hive mind. Why wasn’t I affected by it, though?” he asks himself out loud.

Adora sighs as they reach the doors of the building. Still nobody. “Maybe it’s because you don’t depend on Prime for commands. Not anymore, at least.” She pushes the door open, and the two step into the building.

There are clones scattered all over the hallway, most of them curled up in balls on the floor. The ones who aren’t crying on the floor are running around in a desperate attempt to find their dead leader. Adora can’t help but feel sympathy for the lost clones. They’ve never been given the option to be anything other than Prime’s servants.

“This is… This is what would have become of me if you hadn’t shown me how to get out of Prime’s grasp,” Hordak says, watching the clones’ collective despair in horror.

Adora nudges his arm to get his attention. “We have to keep moving. There’s nothing we can do for them now.” Hordak turns to Adora and nods, wishing there was more he could do for them. Maybe they can try to help the clones that are left after they’re done here.

Hordak and Adora keep moving, navigating the tall hallways of the building with ease. They don't see anyone other than clones writhing on the floor, as Prime didn't trust anyone other than his own clones to work alongside him in his headquarters.

That decision really ended up working against him, huh…

Eventually, they reach the empty throne room, the largest room in the building. Adora climbs up the stairs to the throne, where she knows there's an emergency protocol button which will sound a loud alarm throughout the entire kingdom of the Fright Zone. The alarm will alert all Horde citizens to get to the headquarters as soon as possible and, because the population of the Horde is so small, they should all be able to fit in the headquarters.

With a press of the hidden button, a loud alarm sounds. The warning is so loud that Adora's sure the nearby kingdoms can hear the faint sound. It's a good thing Adora warned the princesses about the alarm.

While the alarm sounds, Adora sits down on the throne, throwing her legs over one arm of the throne and leaning her back on the other. She sets the backpack down beside the throne; she'll be needing it soon, anyway. Hordak leans on the side of the throne as vampires trickle in through the enormous doors leading to the throne.

When it comes to population, The Horde is the smallest out of all the other kingdoms. You have to be the best of the best to be accepted into the Horde by Prime himself, and few vampires make the cut. Anyone who doesn't make it has to fend for themself and try not to get killed by a vampire hunter. Adora wants to change that. Adora wants the Horde to be a safe haven for vampires to be able to flourish, without the need to kill.

Eventually, the throne room is practically filled to the brim with Horde citizens. Adora wouldn't be surprised if every vampire in the Fright Zone was in this room right now.

“Where’s Prime?” a man yells from the crowd. As Adora and Hordak scan the room, most people in the room either look confused or angry.

Adora stands up, standing confidently as she looks down at the crowd. As if on cue, a clone bursts through the side doors in a panic. “Gone!” the clone yells, tears streaming down his face. “Prime has gone from the hive mind!” The clone collapses on the floor, his eyes going from their regular pale green to an eerie white.

“Prime’s dead,” Adora corrects, and there are gasps and hushed murmurs from the crowd. Though, they look no more angry at Adora or Hordak for killing their leader, which isn’t surprising for Adora.

The only people in the Horde who didn’t hate Prime were his clones. Prime never cared about a single person in his kingdom, and this is a known fact across Etheria. Everyone knows Prime only cares about power, even people who hate the Horde.

“Then, where’s Shadow Weaver?” the same man yells, now sounding angry and confused.

Adora pulls the mask from out of her backpack. She tosses it with little care down the stairs and in front of the crowd. “Also dead.”

This time, the man stays quiet, and so does the rest of the crowd. So, Adora takes over the talking portion of the plan.

“You’re probably wondering who will lead the Horde, now that Prime and Shadow Weaver are gone." Silence from the angry crowd. "Well, you’re now looking at your new Horde Lord and Second-in-Command,” says Adora, grinning proudly.

The crowd’s reaction is immediate, and exactly what Adora expected it to be.

Chaos ensues. The crowd yells out their disagreement loud and clear to Adora and Hordak. They yell how Adora and Hordak aren’t

fit to rule, to lead. They yell how they don't want Adora or Hordak as rulers, how they'll be just like Prime and Shadow Weaver.

Prepared for this situation, Adora and Hordak both grab a pair of earplugs from the bag they brought with them. After they've put them on, Adora goes back into the bag to pull out an air horn and turns it on.

The crowd's yelling turns into quiet groans of pain as they cover their ears from the loud horn noise. Once Adora has deemed they're quiet enough, she turns off the horn and she and Hordak take their ear plugs out.

"Are you ready to listen, now?" Hordak asks. The crowd stays silent, but that's more than enough of an answer for them.

"All we're asking is that you listen to what we have to say. If you can't do that, well, you know what'll happen."

Adora clasps her hands together, grinning. "Alright, first order of business is that there will not be any more murder in the Horde!"

Again, chaos ensues. The angry crowd becomes angrier at even the mention of this idea, yelling indecipherable curses at the two standing above them. Adora and Hordak could almost laugh at how angry the vampires below them are at the thought of changing their ways.

So, again, Adora blows the air horn after she and Hordak have put their ear plugs in. Once the vampires have settled into angry grumbles, Adora and Hordak take their ear plugs out.

"I told you what would happen if you didn't listen, didn't I?"

The crowd grumbles more.

Adora sighs. "I know killing can be fun, but don't you want to be better than what the rest of Etheria thinks of us? Don't you have anything else that you want to be other than senseless murderers? They think we're cruel monsters who can't feel

emotions, but I know we can be better than that. I know there's potential in the Horde, so come on. I want to hear your voices. What do you want to be other than monsters? What do you want to do other than kill?"

Silence.

Most of the Horde citizens look surprised that Adora's even asking them anything. It's not like Horde Prime ever asked; he did whatever he wanted without even thinking about the vampires of the Horde. It's not like he ever cared about the people of the Horde, only gaining more power and control over Etheria. Prime never would have concerned himself with trifles as insignificant as how the people of his kingdom feel.

Adora feels fear build in her gut as the minutes go by, and nobody speaks up. What if the people of the Horde don't want her to lead? What if she's really not meant to lead, just like Shadow Weaver sai-

"I-I wanted to be a farmer," an older vampire says, raising his hand.

"I wanted to be a bartender," a purple-skinned woman with large muscles says, raising her hand, too.

"I wanted to be a teacher," another vampire in the far back of the group says, as he raises his hand.

Before Adora knows it, almost everyone in the crowd is raising their hands and announcing what they've always wanted to be. The sight makes Adora feel proud of herself for inspiring the crowd, but also heartbroken at all the chances they've lost at happiness because of the ostracism and exclusion vampires face on Etheria.

Adora raises a hand to silence the crowd, and it works surprisingly well. She smiles, turning to glance at Hordak to see that he has an identical grin on his face. She turns back to the crowd below her, asking, "Well, what if I told you there's a way for you to live,

without having to kill? You could be all the things you've always wanted to be with me ruling the Horde."

Murmurs begin in the crowd again, but they mostly seem incredulous at the idea of ever being free of their eternity-long curse of killing. Adora's glad to hear that they're not as doubtful of her leading abilities as they are of not being forced to kill. So far, the people of the Horde seem to be accepting Adora and Hordak as their leaders relatively well.

Hordak reaches into the bag to pull out a bag of cow's blood, not that the crowd knows that it's cow's blood. "You can drink animal blood, instead," he says, holding the bag up for all to see. He even walks down the stairs so he can stand in front of the hesitant vampires.

"Who wants to try it first?" Adora asks.

The crowd goes so silent, you could hear a pin drop onto the metal floor. If anything, they might even take a collective step away from the menacing blood bag.

Just when Hordak's about to put the bag down, the muscular woman who wanted to be a bartender steps forward. "I'll drink it."

Adora sighs internally, relieved that someone stepped up. "Great!" she says. "What's your name?"

"Huntara," the gruff woman says as she grabs the bag from Hordak and pulls the spout open. Saying nothing else, Huntara tips the bag backwards and takes a huge sip of the blood. She brings the bag back down, and the crowd (plus Adora and Hordak) watch with anticipation.

"Hm. Taste just like human blood. Nice job, Blondie, you've done some good work here." Adora tries to hide the faint blush of embarrassment that blooms on her face at the nickname. With Huntara's words, a few other vampires slowly creep their way up to try the fresh blood. Adora and Hordak almost laugh at the

other vampires' awestruck faces as they taste the blood which is almost-identical to that of a human's.

While Hordak throws more blood bags towards the part of the crowd that wants them, the other part of the crowd grumbles their resentment. They even look angry at how easily the rest of the Horde accepted Adora as their leader. It was only a matter of time before people began rebelling against Adora, but that's fine. Neither Adora nor Hordak expected to be fully accepted as the Horde's rulers immediately.

"What if some of us don't want to stop killing, huh? What if some of us don't want to be good little vampires under your control?"

Adora smirks, moving forward to stand in front of the side of the crowd who've chosen to disagree with Adora. "That one's simple. You can leave," she says, shrugging as if her words are the simplest in the world.

The rest of the crowd pauses in their drinking to look over at Adora in surprise. Even the ones who disagree with Adora look shocked at her words. Leave the Horde? Nobody ever leaves the Horde once they're in! Just getting in is hard enough, anyone who tries to leave would've been killed by Prime.

Adora moves to address the crowd as a whole. "If any of you disagree with how I lead the Horde, you are welcome to leave at any time!" As she says this, the resentful part of the crowd moves to leave while the rest stay. The noise in the room picks up as the group walks away, talking and shuffling together. Adora smirks as they slowly make their way to the door.

Right before they can reach it, though, she says, "Oh, I forgot to mention something!" The crowd turns their heads out of curiosity, but doesn't move from their spots.

The smirk on Adora's face grows more sinister.

"Anyone who leaves the Horde won't be protected from the vampire hunters scattered all over Etheria. I doubt you'll last a

week out there by yourselves.”

Silence falls over the group.

“What?” one of them asks.

“What, I didn’t mention that? I’ll be welcoming any vampire to join the Horde at any time, and they’ll be offered free protection from vampire hunters and anyone else who wants to hurt us. As long as they follow our rules, though, which also includes no more killing humans. Anyone who cannot follow these rules or simply doesn’t want to stop killing can leave the Horde whenever they want, but vampire hunters are going to be even more vigilant now as they look for non-Horde-affiliated vampires.”

“So, what, my options are to stop killing or leave the Horde and get killed?” another one of them asks. The group looks just about ready to run up the stairs and fight Adora themselves.

Hordak has a smirk on his face, too; one that’s identical to Adora’s. “It’s your choice. Are you sure you still want to leave, though? Are you really willing to sacrifice the possibility of peace just so you can keep killing innocent humans?” he says, crossing his arms beside Adora.

It's at this moment that Adora's extremely grateful for her reputation across the Horde as a ruthless killer of both humans and vampires taught by the Horde's very own Second-in-Command. Huh, maybe Shadow Weaver really was useful for something after all...

Reluctantly, some of the group make their way back to stand with the rest of the crowd. Some leave, and Adora’s sure she won’t be seeing their faces ever again. They made their choice, though, and she can respect that.

Adora moves to stand on the edge of the stairs, overlooking the crowd below her. The people who are now under her and Hordak’s rule as Horde Lord and Second-in-Command, respectively.

“So, you are all in agreement that you must follow our rules, which include never killing again, in order to continue staying in the Horde, correct?”

The crowd nods their heads.

“And you are all in understanding that I am the new Horde Lord, with Hordak as my Second-in-Command?”

Again, the crowd nods.

Adora moves to sit down on the throne, crossing her legs and leaning back comfortably in her new throne. She overlooks the citizens of her new kingdom with a smirk full of pride.

“Great. Welcome to the Horde, everyone. Questions?”

Chapter End Notes

> Okay, I know you guys were probably expecting big explosions and fighting when Adora and Hordak overtook the Horde, but I don't really think that's their style. Remember, they aren't taking over for power, they're taking over so that the Horde can have more opportunities for success. If the vampires in the Horde didn't accept Adora and Hordak as their rulers, they would have stepped down because they want what's best for the people of the Horde.
>
> Trust me, this is just the beginning of Adora's rule over the Horde, and there will be many more problems later on. Would this really be a vampire AU if there wasn't intense angst and pain?
>
> Anyway, I hope you enjoyed this!
>
> Until next time, bye-bye!

no one will know the violence it took to be this gentle

Chapter Summary

Adora and Hordak realize ruling the Horde alone is harder than they thought.

They get help, from Adora's... old friends.

Chapter Notes

Hey! I'll keep this short so you can get to reading, don't worry. This chapter has not one, but TWO artworks in it!! One is mine (that one is in the end notes), and the other is by the AMAZING suga.rcloud on instagram who I comissioned!! Her work is so good, and you guys should really check them out!

Anyway, onto the chapter! Hope you guys enjoy :)



See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

From there, it was mostly smooth sailing.

Mostly being the key word here.

While the Horde citizens had left the headquarters, at Adora's orders, there were still two problems they needed help with.

The first being that, since Prime's clones are mostly either sobbing somewhere in the headquarters or have died, there isn't anyone

to help Adora and Hordak lead the Horde in an organized manner.

The second being that there is still an army of clones roaming around the headquarters aimlessly, with no direction or cause.

“So… What are we going to do about the clones?” Hordak asks, while Adora sighs from her spot on her throne.

Adora knows what she needs to do, but she’s not sure if it’ll even work. But their options are… slim, to say the least. Who else is left to help them?

“I… I have an idea,” Adora starts, hesitant in her words. Hordak turns to face her, curiosity painting his features.

“But we’ll have to go through Horde Prime’s files for it.”

Hordak groans, throwing a pile of papers onto the dark floors. “It’s not here, Adora!” he says from his pile of Prime’s documents. They spent the past hour combing through Prime’s files, looking for them, and still nothing.

Adora drops her head into her hands in defeat. With a quick comb through her hair, she sighs and lifts her head again. “They have to be documented here somewhere. There’s no way Prime would have just ignored three undocumented vampires with close ties to Eternia.”

“Well, maybe Prime just… didn’t notice them.”

“Does Horde Prime really seem like the kind of person to make mistakes?”

Hordak’s silence is answer enough. They continue their search through the never-ending piles of documents Prime has built up over the years on any vampires on Etheria.

It’s become somewhat of a rumour in the Horde that Prime has a file for every living vampire on Etheria. That whenever a vampire on Etheria dies, so does their file in a fire set by one of Prime’s clones. Most don’t believe it’s true, while others claim Prime is just that powerful and all-seeing. While Adora knows Prime was neither powerful nor all-seeing, the man was a severe control freak and dedicated enough to go to extreme lengths just to keep a close eye on his kingdom.

Just when Adora’s about to give up on her search for her long-lost friends, she notices the corner of a paper peeking out of the side of one of the file drawers. It’s a miracle she even noticed it, given just how many filing cabinets are in this one room. The number would definitely be in the hundreds.

She pulls the paper out of its hiding spot, wiping the dust off of it. Hordak peeks over from across the room, throwing the paper he was holding to the side. “Where did you find that?” he asks, moving to sit beside her.

“It was hidden in this drawer. It looks like it’s been sitting there for years. There’s no way Prime knew about this.” The dust on the paper has been there for so long, it’s permanently attached to it.

“Well, what does it say?”

Adora’s eyes skim over the pale, printed words on the page. Her eyes widen more and more as she reads, excitement growing with every second. Hordak must notice the smile growing on Adora’s face when he asks, “Is this it?”

“Yeah,” Adora says. “We found them.”

With that, the two quickly stand and leave the room in its chaos. They’ll make sure to organize the entire room later, but not right now.

Because of course, they have better things to do right now. Things of the utmost importance right now.

They have to go search for Adora's oldest friends.

As Adora and Hordak storm through the halls of the headquarters, they can't help but notice how bleak the usually bustling building is. While non-clones are rarely allowed into the headquarters unless they're first joining the Horde, the vast building used to be filled with clones dutifully fulfilling Prime's every order. The sight of empty halls compared to Horde Prime and his brainwashed army is a welcome one, but Adora can't shake the eeriness looming in the air.

It doesn't take long for them to reach the large double doors leading outside, which they slam open in their rush. Adora can't help the smirk that rises on her face at the sight of some lingering vampires standing far from the building, but gossiping with wide eyes toward her and Hordak.

All she picks up on the way towards Hordak's skiff is "killed Prime," and "stronger." Adora chooses to ignore the puzzle pieces of the hushed conversation and keep walking.

The two jump onto the skiff, and Hordak inputs the coordinates for the three vampires' last location. Once the attached GPS gives them directions, Hordak grabs the control handle as the skiff roars to life.

Adora's grateful that the coordinates aren't too far from the Horde, just on the edge of the Crimson Waste. The blonde forces herself not to shiver at the reminder of the wasteland which used to be her home kingdom. Besides, it's not like anything from Eternia has survived in the Crimson Waste.

All that's left now is the remains of a once-powerful kingdom, the kingdom that Adora grew up in, now covered in a thick layer of sand and criminals.

Adora shakes off the nostalgic feeling that took hold of her. Eternia is long gone, and is never coming back. She's accepted that she's the last of her kind decades ago.

As the skiff slowly glides down the hill leading to the headquarters, Adora waves with an amused grin to the few wide-eyed vampires who are still standing stick-straight at the bottom of the hill. They all salute to her, and Adora's smile morphs into a frown as soon as they do.

That's not how she wants to lead the Horde. She doesn't want her citizens to be so afraid of her they feel the need to salute to her in fear of execution. That was how Prime treated the people of the Fright Zone, but Adora refuses to follow in his footsteps.

She'll work to gain the Horde's trust, and to make sure they're not as scared of her as they were of Prime.

Adora turns back to Hordak, who has an expectant look on his face. She raises a brow at him.

"What is it?"

"You know, you haven't even told me who the people we're looking for are." He raises a brow back at her challengingly. Adora sighs and moves to sit down on the skiff floor, pulling her knees up and outstretching her arms on them. She barely even notices as the factories and grey skies of the Horde morph into the orange sand and bright blue skies of the Crimson Waste as the skiff speeds up. The only indicator of the change is the heat and brightness of the sun strengthening as the polluted skies of the Fright Zone move into the distance behind them.

"They're- they were… my best friends, back in Eternia." Adora takes a moment to laugh weakly. "I mean, we were so close, I think they spent more time at my family's house than each of their own. We- we did everything together, but once Shadow Weaver killed me-"

She sighs in exasperation. Hordak has a look of sympathy on his face.

"You had to leave?" he asks, helping Adora keep going with her explanation.

Adora nods. “Shadow Weaver made me go with her to Mystacor, all the way across Etheria. I had no way of contacting them, and I didn’t even get to say goodbye when I left. It wasn’t until I got into the Horde and heard Prime mention a group of three rogue vampires living in the remains of Eternia that I found out they hadn’t actually died. I just knew it was them, even if Prime never mentioned it. Their names were L-”

Adora doesn’t get the chance to finish her sentence when Hordak makes a sharp turn and parks the skiff in front of an empty patch of the desert.

“Sorry, but we’re here.”

Adora’s not sure if it’s the blistering heat of the sun on her head, or the fear that her last connection to her human life really is dead, but she can’t help the hysterical laughter that bubbles out of her. The laugh has an edge to it that even Adora’s ears can pick up, something dark and worrying.

Hordak has a look of concern on his face at Adora’s bad-timed and, frankly, unsettling laughter. Adora wipes a tear of mirth from her eyes, saying, “Come on, Hordak. There’s nothing here.”

Technically, Adora’s not wrong. There really is nothing in front of them. Just endless stretches of sand, dried-up trees, and the corpses of long-dead animals. Maybe they got the address wrong, or maybe they’re just go-

“No, Adora, look down. On the floor, right there. Do you see that crack?” Hordak asks, jumping out of the idle skiff to inspect the crack.

Adora, letting her curiosity get the best of her, jumps out and follows Hordak. It’s only when she stands beside Hordak that she can finally see what he was trying to show her.

A huge crack exposes the inner parts of the land, and is filled to the brim with makeshift houses and tents, along with criminals taking refuge in the almost-unlivable desert.

But it wasn’t always a desert, was it?

Because Adora remembers what used to stand here, before the Horde Legion destroyed Eternia in their decades-long war that raged hundreds of years ago. Adora is living proof of the life that used to live in the Crimson Waste; she’s all that’s left of the Eternians—or as the Etherians call them now, the First Ones.

A familiar wave of nostalgia hits Adora as she remembers visiting the crack in the land they called the “Ancient Canyon” with her family. All those years ago, the Ancient Canyon was protected land, and a national landmark in the kingdom. People would come from across Etheria just to look down at the lush wildlife and shining river at the bottom of the crack.

The wildlife has turned into dust and cacti, and the once-bountiful river is now nothing more than a few dirt-filled puddles.

She remembers her and her twin brother, Adam, racing along the length of the canyon, seeing who could get to the other side first. Her parents, Marlena and Randor, telling them to slow down and not bump into anyone while Adora rolled her eyes back at them. She remembers listening to her father tell of the ancient history behind the canyon, and the myth that the great She-Ra was the one to create the canyon thousands of years ago to realign the runestones.

Most of all, though, Adora remembers thinking that the joy she felt then with her family would last forever.

It didn’t, and the near-lifeless desert wasteland in front of her is a blatant reminder of that.

“Come on,” Hordak says, nudging her shoulder to bring her back to reality. He’s always been good at noticing when Adora’s getting lost in the swirl of memories, and bringing her out of it. “We should get going, before the sun goes down.”

Adora shakes her head in an effort to focus. “Yeah, you’re right. Let’s go.”

With that, the two make their way down a rickety wooden staircase to the bottom of the canyon. Adora didn't notice how busy and packed the place was until she looked around.

Every inch of the narrow canyon is filled with tents and people, and Adora's sure the filled canyon is crawling with crime everywhere.

As Adora and Hordak make their way through the desert looking for the address given to them by Prime's documents, they can't help but notice the stares they're getting from everyone around them. It's only because of their heightened sense of hearing that they can hear the hushed whispers of gossip between the criminals. They send snarls back at the gossiping criminals, who quickly turn away from them and keep their mouths closed.

While Adora doesn't love the fact that the vast majority of Etherians are afraid of her, she can't deny the perks that come with it.

They're walking down the narrow walkway as the Crimson Waste inhabitants move out of the way for them when they're both grabbed by their arms and dragged into a secluded alley. The criminals who were previously watching them go back to what they were doing before Adora and Hordak showed up, but continue gossiping.

Adora turns to see who grabbed them and finds she has to raise her head to look them in the eyes.

"Have you two lost your minds? You can't just walk into the Valley of the Lost like you own the place," says the gruff purple-skinned woman in front of them who Adora's sure she recognizes from somewhere.

Suddenly, it hits her. "Huntara?" she asks, remembering the buff woman as the first to drink animal blood at Prime's headquarters —or, should she say, Adora's headquarters. One glance at Hordak says that he also recognizes Huntara from the headquarters.

Huntara laughs, patting Adora on the back. Adora practically falls forward from the force of the pat, but manages to stay standing only for her remaining dignity. “I’m glad to see you remember me from earlier, Blondie.”

Adora huffs at the nickname, but hides the embarrassed blush on her face well. “What do you want?”

The purple-skinned woman sobers up at the question, crossing her arms. It takes all of Adora’s strength not to ogle at Huntara’s biceps, which look to be the size of Adora’s head. “I’ll keep this quick since you’re obviously trying to get somewhere, but you’re going to get yourselves killed if you walk through here as openly as you were. Do you know how many vampire hunters are in the Crimson Waste, waiting for unsuspecting vampires like you two to come through?”

Hordak crosses his arms, mimicking Huntara’s confident stance but falling short. “We’ll be fine, thank you. Believe it or not, we know how to take care of ourselves, without your help.”

Adora nods, saying, “We appreciate your offer, but we’ll be fine.” She turns to leave the alley, and Hordak follows her lead.

Just as Adora’s foot moves past the edge of the alley, a dart flies past her nose. The dart is followed by two more, closer to hitting Adora and Hordak than the first. Adora whips her head around to stare at the three darts where they’ve hit the wall with wide eyes. A liquid seeps out of the tip of the darts, and Adora’s sure that the substance is a paralyzing drug.

Looks like Huntara wasn’t lying about those hunters.

Speaking of Huntara, the muscular woman grabs Adora and Hordak by their arms and pulls them away from where the darts came from. The two get the idea, and run as fast as they can away further into the alley. Adora hears running footsteps behind them, and it’s clear that there are multiple vampire hunters following them. It’s only once they reach the end of the alley that

Adora reaches a hand down for her sword, ready to defend herself against the hunters. She hears the laser cannon attached to Hordak's arm whirr to life beside her.

"Wait!" Huntara yells. They both turn to her and notice the hidden door on the side of the alley wall, concealed by a layer of dried moss. Huntara lifts the moss to reveal the door, and the three of them run in before the hunters notice where they went.

Huntara lets go of the moss, and it drapes back down to cover the concealed door. The three continue running down the hallway from the door until they reach the inside of a tent. Huntara moves quickly to grab two large, beige robes from a drawer. She throws each of them to Adora and Hordak.

"You should have listened to me earlier. The Crimson Waste is nothing like the Fright Zone, you can't rule it like you do there," Huntara says with a smirk.

Adora rolls her eyes as she drapes the robe over herself, pulling the hood over her head. The sound of ruffling fabric beside her is enough for her to know Hordak's done the same.

"Yeah, yeah," the blonde says with a wave of her hand. "Whatever, you were right. Now, can you please help us find an address here?"

Huntara crosses her arms again, raising a brow at Adora. "Who could *Horde Lord Adora* and her Second-in-Command possibly be looking for in the Crimson Waste?" she asks, sarcasm practically dripping off her words.

Adora resists the urge to roll her eyes again. Instead, she reaches into her pocket to grab the folded-up paper with the information they have on Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. Unfolding it, Adora hands it to Huntara. "Have you heard anything about them recently?" asks Adora, forcing her voice to not convey how nervous she is.

As Huntara's eyes skim the words on the paper, she sighs. "I have." Adora hates how hopeful she immediately gets at the

words. "... But they're not here."

"What? Where are they?" Hordak asks, frustration growing at this game of cat and mouse they've been playing all day.

Huntara moves to grab a pen from a nearby desk, and messily scrawls another address below the one already on the paper. "They were here for a long while, but they were hunted down by vampire hunters and forced to move. Last I heard, they left for this address."

Adora nods, grabbing the paper and folding it back into her pocket. "Okay, thank you for your help." Huntara gives them a wordless nod as they move to leave the tent and out onto the bustling street.

"Hey, Adora?"

The blonde turns to glance back at Huntara from the edge of the tent.

"If you ever need any help with the Horde, you know where to find me."

Adora nods with a grin, and the two set off.

It doesn't take long to find the new address Huntara gave them.

A small cabin in the middle of nowhere on the edge of Halfmoon.

If this were any other situation, Adora would take the time to appreciate just how adorable the little cabin is. There are colourful flowers and bright green grass surrounding the cabin, but they're still well-kept. The wood of the cabin is a deep red-ish colour and looks only slightly worn. A narrow cobblestone path leads to the front door of the house; a large wooden door that is a deeper brown than the rest of the cabin walls.

The two walk up the cobblestone path and up the few steps of the porch. Adora lifts a hand to knock on the door, but finds herself getting cold feet when presented with the opportunity to find out if her old best friends have survived all this time.

What if they're dead by now?

What if they hate her for leaving?

What if-

Her thoughts are cut off by the front door opening to reveal a scrawny man with blonde, scruffy hair who Adora recognizes immediately. She can't help the warm smile that grows on her face at the sight of him, just like how she remembers him when they were kids.

The blond gasps once he sees Adora, eyes wide in shock. "Adora?!" he asks, as if he can't believe the sight in front of him, either. He has a bright smile on his face, one that hasn't changed at all since Adora saw him last.

"Hi, Kyle," says Adora softly, her smile somehow growing.

She can't say anything else, as Kyle rushes forward to wrap his arms around Adora in a tight hug. Adora laughs, reciprocating the hug with just as much joy.

From over Kyle's shoulder, Adora sees Lonnie and Rogelio come down the stairs of the cabin to see what's happening.

Once their eyes land on the Adora, they widen as they both run to the front door. Adora pulls one of her arms off of Kyle to open it for Lonnie, who slides in beside Kyle and wraps her arms around both of them. Rogelio wraps both his arms around all three of them and lifts them all up in a searing hug.

The four laugh together, and Adora feels the wave of nostalgia hit her again. Though, this time, it's a good feeling instead of one that reminds of the painful parts of her past.

Eventually, Rogelio puts them back down onto the wooden porch under them. Lonnie and Kyle step out of the hug to get a better look at Adora, who's still smiling at them like they're her heroes.

"Come in," Lonnie says. "We can talk inside."

Adora's smile morphs into a smirk as she walks in, closely followed by the others. "What, that's all you have to say to me after five hundred years?" Lonnie pushes inside Adora with a loud laugh.

Adora and Hordak settle on one couch, while the trio sits on the one opposite of it.

"So what happened, Adora? We thought you died all those years ago," Kyle says, curiosity obvious on his face.

"Well, uh, it's a long story. To cut it short, I did die, like you guys. I just came back to life! And then I was taken to live in Mystacor for a few hundred years, and now I'm in the Horde. Well, actually, Hordak and I are ruling the Horde now. Oh, you guys know Hordak, right? He's-"

Adora trails off when she sees the wide-eyed expressions of the three vampires in front of her. Hordaks nudges her arm, whispering, "I think you're going over this too fast, Adora."

Lonnie shakes her head, as if to rid herself of her surprise. "No, no, we got all that. It's just… a lot. So, if you're ruling the Horde with Hordak, why did you come all the way here to talk to us? I'm sure you have much more *important* things to be doing right now." She crosses her arms, and Adora can recognize the defensiveness of the position.

"I never wanted to leave you guys, I didn't have a choice-"

"You could have written to us-"

"I tried that, too, but Shadow Weaver wouldn't allow me to. I just- I'm sorry, okay? I never wanted to hurt you guys, but I couldn't come looking for you until now."

The three shiver at the mention of the masked woman. While they never met her, everyone in Eternia heard of the dark sorceress who killed the once-great Greyskull family. They assumed Adora had died with the rest of her family, even though her body was never found at the scene.

"And what about Shadow Weaver? Does she know you're here?" Kyle asks, looking around nervously, as if she'll appear out of nowhere in front of them.

"Oh, um- Yeah, Shadow Weaver's dead."

"What? How?"

Adora smirks, and that's enough of an answer for Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio.

Kyle gasps, and Lonnie laughs loudly. "No way! You actually did it?" she asks, surprise and joy mixing in her expression.

Adora nods, still feeling the relief of never having to see Shadow Weaver again.

Kyle is about to say something when Hordak interrupts them. "As much as I'm loving this little reunion, we should get going. We've already spent way too long looking for you three. We must get back to the Fright Zone now."

Lonnie frowns at Hordak, about to argue with him, so Adora cuts her off before she can start.

"Hordak's right. I'll tell you everything else that's happened on the ride back to the Fright Zone, okay?"

"Fine."

With that, the five make their way out of the house and onto Hordak's skiff.

While driving back to the Fright Zone, Adora tells the trio everything as quickly as she can. About Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime. About her and Hordak's plan to overthrow the Horde. About the clones, and Huntara, and the Crimson Waste, and everything in between. They even come up with a semblance of a plan for what to do with the clones when they get to the headquarters.

Speaking of the headquarters, it's only then that Adora notices the slowing of the skiff as they reach the monumental building. The blonde turns to Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio.

"You guys ready?"

"Yeah!" Kyle says.

"Absolutely," Lonnie says.

Rogelio roars in approval, and they all make their way off of the skiff and up the hill to the headquarters.

Walking into the building is… different from the first time, to say the least. Despite Adora and Hordak having only severed the clones' connection to the Hive Mind this morning, the clones have changed in that time.

Well, the clones which are still alive have. Many either died upon the disconnection, or killed themselves in fear of a life without their leader.

Lonnie looks around at the clones who are walking—not running and screaming anymore, Adora notes—aimlessly through the halls of the headquarters. "You know, we always heard rumours that Prime's clones were these… indestructible and powerful things that nobody fucked with. But look at them now."

Adora turns to glance at one clone who's taken to sitting on the floor and muttering "into the light of Prime," over and over again.

She notices the shine of tears in his eyes, and can't help the sympathy that plagues her at the sight.

It seems that the clones have gone from anger at Adora for killing their leader and determination to bring him back, to acceptance that Prime is never coming back to save them.

That fact has numbed them from angry yells about power into weak mumbles of hopelessness.

Nevertheless, the small group of vampires continues making their way to the throne room. They can't get the clones to listen to them if they're scattered all over the building. That just won't do.

Once they reach the intersecting hallways which lead to the server room and throne room respectively, Hordak gives Adora a nod and walks down the hall to the server room, while the four walk towards the throne room.

Kyle's eyebrows scrunch up as he asks, "Wait, why is Hordak not coming with us?"

"You'll see," Adora replies with a grin, deciding to keep the intricate parts of her and Hordak's plan a surprise. Adora's glad she and Hordak made a small plan for how to round up the clones.

Sure, the plan about what to do once they've rounded them up was made with the help of Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio; but the rest was all Adora and Hordak.

The four make it into the throne room, and Adora moves to sit in her throne while Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio look around the room. There isn't much in the room itself, Prime was something of a minimalist, but the design of the room is still interesting to look at.

Lonnie opens her mouth to say something Adora's sure will be sarcasm-filled, but is interrupted by countless clones filtering into

the throne room like lost sheep. Hordak, acting as a shepherd of sorts, follows behind the herd of clones.

Once the clones are all standing in the large room—looking blankly around at each other as if they're still searching for Prime—Adora stands up from the throne to overlook the crowd. Hordak walks up the stairs to stand beside her, while Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio stand near the doors on the outskirts of the room.

"Hey, everyone," Adora says loudly. The clones all turn to look up at the source of the sound, and an appalled expression falls on their faces at the sight of Adora in Prime's throne. Some scrunch their eyebrows in anger at Adora, looking seconds away from running up the stairs to kill her themselves.

Hordak gives them all a warning glare, turning on his laser cannon just enough so that they can see the burning light, then turning it back off again. The clones still look various levels of distraught and angry, but they don't move from their spots.

"I know you're angry at us because, you know, Prime is dead, and he was your '*all-powerful ruler*' or whatever you called him," Adora starts, using air quotes around the title. "But you all need to know the truth about Prime. About what he was doing, and what he thought of you."

This only makes the clones more upset. "Prime loved us!" one yells. "We were his brothers, and he only wanted the best for you." The others nod eagerly at the clone's words, clutching onto their hope like it's the only thing keeping them alive. Adora rolls her eyes at the words and wonders how Hordak could have ever thought the same way the clones in front of her do.

"Prime was lying to you. He didn't care about any of you, and he only ever saw you as expendable objects. Haven't you ever wondered why there are so many clone factories in the Fright Zone if Prime already had more than enough clones to help in the headquarters?"

The clones don’t have an answer for her. Some even look curious for the answer.

“It’s because Prime wanted to rule over Etheria, and he was planning to use you to do that for him. He had been slowly expanding the perimeters of the Fright Zone, and was making more and more clones so that, when the time came, he would easily defeat the other kingdoms and rule Etheria, just like he’d always wanted to do for centuries. None of you meant anything to him. You were just replaceable soldiers in his endless quest for power.”

Adora knows she’s being harsh to the clones, but they need to know the truth if they’re ever going to have their freedom.

Some clones have a puzzled expression on their face as they try to understand how the man they’ve idolized and praised was a fraud, and others have begun to cry at Adora’s words. They all look so devastated over the words, and Adora can’t help but be reminded of all those years ago when she first helped Hordak find his identity after being one of Prime’s mindless clones for so long. It breaks her heart to see them in so much pain, but she can only hope learning the truth will be better for the clones in the long run.

One clone looks up at Hordak, tears shining in his pale green eyes. “Brother, is this true? Had Horde Prime never loved us? Has Horde Prime only been using us for more power?”

Hordak looks just as distraught at the clones’ pain, if not more. He sighs, then says, “Yes, it’s true. I’m sorry you had to find out this way, but we did not want to lie to you like Prime had.”

The heartbroken clones only cry more at Hordak’s words, and many have begun to look to each other for comfort. Adora turns to glance at Hordak worryingly, and he looks back at her with an almost identical expression. Adora remembers how distraught and upset Hordak was when he finally realized just how little Prime cared for him, remembers comforting him as he cried into her

shoulder and clung onto her like a young child would with a stuffed animal.

Eventually, though, Hordak moved past his distress, and only then was he able to do what he wanted and feel how he wanted to feel.

Only then was he able to *want* anything besides following Prime.

Adora glances at Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio, who are still standing at the very back of the room. They all have confused looks on their faces as they watch the clones sob with one another. She can explain all of this to them later.

One clone looks up at Adora curiously and sniffles. Adora gives him a gentle smile; the clone, likely having never had the privilege of seeing a smile, scrunches his brows at the blonde in confusion. "What-What do we-we do now? I- We're nothing without Horde Prime."

It's Hordak that replies to him this time.

"You're not nothing without Prime. All of you have the potential to have happy and fulfilling lives without Horde Prime, you just have to figure out what you want. Now that Prime's dead, you can do whatever you want, within reason. You can live your lives however you please." His voice is stern, but Adora can hear the softness hidden underneath the words.

The clones wipe their eyes and look up at Hordak with confused faces.

"Want?" one asks.

"How do we *want*?" asks another.

"We can help you with that. Is there anything you'd all like to try first?" asks Adora.

There’s a moment of silence. Then, one clone points to Hordak’s hair. “How can we change our hair like brother Hordak has?” Other clones nod eagerly, looking up at Hordak’s navy blue hair, which is a stark difference to the white of all the other clones’ hair.

Adora can’t help the light-hearted laughter that bubbles out of her at the question.

One Week Later…

“Sister, do you like our new hair?” a clone with pale purple hair asks. The clone beside him has red hair, which he is wearing proudly.

Adora grimaces at the nickname, remembering her last conversation with Prime. “Yes, but don’t call me that.”

The clones, who have chosen to go by Harold and Kilgan respectively, both nod with considerate expressions on their faces. They have been teaching the clones about compassion and understanding others—especially humans—and it’s no surprise to anyone that they’ve been exceptionally quick learners. “Oh, alright. Well, thank you, Lord Adora,” says Harold, saluting.

Kilgan turns to Harold. "You can't just call her by her first name!" he says with a frown. He turns to Adora. "Apologies, my Lord." He salutes, and Adora frowns at the clones again.

“It's okay, you don't need to salute. And just…. Just call me Adora, okay? Adora, that’s it.”

“Understood. Goodbye, Adora!” Kilgan says, waving excitedly and walking down the hallway he was just talking to Adora in with Harold by his side.

The blonde smiles despite the… odd interaction. To be fair, pretty much any interaction with the clones has been nothing other than strange. All week, clones have been coming up to her anywhere

they can find her, excited to show her what they've learned about living; whether that be their new hairstyle, or a new hobby they've taken up, or something kind they did, or a new fact they learned and just *had* to tell her, or-

The list goes on and on.

What else could she expect from hundreds of clones who have been forced into having no emotions of identity, though?

While she loves talking to them and hearing about all the things they've experienced in their Prime-free lives, it can get overwhelming sometimes. Adora imagines this is what it's like to be a kindergarten teacher… just one who takes care of hundreds upon hundreds of easily excited and hyperactive clones.

It's at moments like these that Adora is grateful for the help from Hordak, and her other friends for their help.

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio decided to join the Horde as force captains. Even Huntara, after some pleading, decided to join to be a force captain.

Thankfully, the Horde is the smallest kingdom, so they won't need quite as large of a staff as the other kingdoms do. Along with the clones, who are all willing to help the Horde in whatever way they can and want, the Fright Zone is doing exceptionally well so far.

Speaking of clones, almost all of them have found something that interests them, whether that be a hobby or a fashion style or even an occupation. Some have become extremely friendly and kindhearted, like Harold and Kilgan, while others are more grumpy and serious. Some are loud and boisterous, while others are shy and keep to themselves. Honestly, Adora would take any of their unique personalities over them having none at all.

Adora had been expecting many of the clones to leave the Horde, and she gave them the option to do that freely, but the majority of them have opted to stay in the Fright Zone to learn how to live. A group of them left, still hellbent on following Prime's teachings,

and Adora allowed them to. If there comes a time when those who have left the Horde will begin hurting humans, then Adora will begin imprisoning them. Or worse.

Adora walks into one of two weapon rooms in the headquarters—one being for the Horde's weapons, and one being for only Adora's weapons specifically—to find a large group of clones and vampires alike waiting there.

While the room is still being organized as Adora changes the headquarters from Prime's design, there are still a few weapons mounted on the walls.

The majority of the group are clones who have developed strong morals, especially concerning the well-being of humans, since Prime's death. The other non-clone vampires applied to join the group under the promise of this being a paid job, and that they would help keep Etheria safe from vampires who have kept killing humans.

Both of which are true, by the way.

Adora knows that, while things are going well now, there will be bumps in the road, and there will be people who disagree with Adora's ways of ruling. Who disagree with Adora's peace-promoting rules which promote kindness and compassion within the vampire kingdom. And she wants to be prepared for when that happens. She wants the people of the Fright Zone, who abide by her rules and are trying to be good people, to be safe from people who refuse to change their murderous ways.

While the crowd was previously talking amongst one another, they all turn their attention to Adora as soon as she walks in, giving her their undivided attention.

"I assume you all know why you're here today, right?" asks Adora, standing straight with her arms crossed behind her back.

They all nod.

“And you all know you chose to be here and have the option of leaving whenever you choose?”

Again, they all nod.

“Well, then welcome to your first training day for the Patrolling Force of the Horde.”

Chapter End Notes

This chapter might not have been what you were expecting, but I still hope you enjoyed it regardless :) It was such a blast to write, and I promise the wait for the next chapters of this fic and my other one won't be as long now that it's summer!

Speaking of long waits, sorry about taking so long to write these! I've been trying to juggle work along with writing. And I quit my job! So that's fun.

Anywho, I really hoped you guys enjoyed this chapter, and I always appreciate kudos/comments if you did!

Here's the Adora drawing I made, by the way ;)



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Epilogue

Chapter Summary

A look into the future, and what it holds for Catra and Adora.

Or should I say *who*.

Chapter Notes

Hi :)

I'm sorry for taking so long to update this!

I hope this epilogue chapter makes up for it. There's also a sketch I've added at the end of this chapter!!

Okay, enjoy!

Oh, and by the way I didn't really revise this after writing so if you see any mistakes then I apologize.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

1/2: Adora and Catra

"How do I look?" asks Catra, turning to face away from the floor length mirror she was just looking in. Adora sitd behind Catra, on their large bed, but the silver mirror doesn't pick up on the blonde's presence.

They have a Princess Prom to attend, the first one Adora is attending as Horde Lord of the Fright Zone.

"You look stunning as always, Catra," a blushing Adora says from her spot on the bed, already in her deep red suit to match Catra's maroon loose-fit slip dress.

Catra's hands move to her waist, and she grins with a raised brow. "You're not just saying that because I'm your wife, are you?"

Just the thought that she and Catra are married is enough to make a warm smile appear on Adora's face, even years after their wedding. She laughs at Catra's words, standing up. She moves to stand in front of Catra, resting her hands on top of Catra's. "Of course I'm not. You only look more and more beautiful as each day passes, and you look amazing in that dress."

Catra blushes at the attention, seemingly stunned to silence by Adora's compliments, and Adora can't help the laughter that bubbles in her chest again at Catra's surprise.

"You okay, kitten?" Adora teases.

Adora's teasing only makes Catra's blush deepen, to the point where her cheeks are the same colour as her dress.

"Oh, shut up!" Catra says, laughing loudly and pushing a cackling Adora off of her. Adora's about to respond, probably with more flirting, when a loud knock sounds on the door to their dressing room in Brightmoon.

"Come on, lovebirds! We've got a Prom to attend," a loud voice they both recognize as Glimmer yells from the other side of the door.

This year, Brightmoon is holding Princess Prom, and saying Glimmer has been stressed out is… an understatement. Angella, while still alive, retired some time last year, bestowing her title as Queen to Glimmer. The purple-haired girl has been handling the pressures of being queen well with her friends and family's support, but that doesn't mean she isn't a ball of stress right now, either.

Glimmer is so stressed about Princess Prom this year, in fact, that she made Catra and Adora get ready at Brightmoon Palace instead of their home between Halfmoon and the Horde just to make sure the Best Friend Squad would be ready on time.

“Got it, mom!” Catra yells back with a grin. Adora has to hold back a snicker at the words, but can’t resist laughing when Glimmer groans and the familiar sound of her teleporting can be heard behind the door.

“We should really get going before Glimmer scolds us, right?” asks Adora, moving back to rest her hands on Catra’s hips now that the brunette’s hands are back down to her sides.

Catra leans forward into Adora’s touch. “Hm…” she says, as if she’s deep in thought when Adora knows she isn’t. “I think Sparkles will survive if we’re a little late to her party.”

Adora smiles down at Catra. “Really?”

“Really.” Catra nods with certainty, and Adora snorts.

Standing up onto her tiptoes, Catra leans forward to catch Adora’s lips in a gentle kiss. At this point, it’s only second nature for Adora to kiss Catra back.

Realistically, Adora knows they should definitely be going down to the banquet by now. Glimmer will be mad, and Adora feels guilty missing all the work Glimmer put in to make sure Prom was perfect.

With her wife’s lip on hers, though? All Adora can focus on is her.

“Oh, look who decided to show up!”

Catra rolls her eyes as she and Adora make their way up to the two large thrones where Glimmer and Bow are sitting, Adora’s arm wrapped around her shoulders. Bow laughs lightheartedly, as to show that his wife’s anger at the two doesn’t involve him.

“We’re sorry for being late, Glimmer. Clothing emergency,” says Adora, lying through her teeth despite the fact that she’s never been good at lying if there isn’t a need for it. Glimmer narrows her

eyes at her in half-hearted annoyance, though Adora knows she's glad to see them.

Glimmer mutters something along the lines of "More of a horny emergency if you ask me," and Bow has to hide his quiet snicker at her words. Adora flushes a deep red at the words, and Catra smirks beside her.

Catra bows unceremoniously, dragging Adora down with her, and the two rise back up again. "Queen Glimmer, King Bow," Catra says, making a show of saying the words in a snobby and uptight voice to show just how little she cares for the endless rules of Princess Prom.

Glimmer nods down at the two. "Princess Catra, Lord Adora." Her voice is in the same snobby tone as Catra's, making it clear that Glimmer hates the uptight rules just as much as Catra.

"Have fun at the party, you guys! We wish we could join you, but duties call," Bow says from his throne beside Glimmer, smiling brightly and waving down at them. Catra and Adora wave goodbye to their two best friends, and make their way down the stairs back to the main floor of the banquet.

The two look around the hall. There's a table not too far with many of the Princess Alliance members, a large buffet of food (none of which Adora can eat), and a full dance floor.

"So… Where to first, princess?" asks Adora, raising a questioning brow down at Catra.

Catra leans into Adora, thinking for a minute before grinning like she just came up with a genius plan. She shifts to grab Adora's hand instead, dragging her across the hall to their destination.

Adora lets herself be pulled by Catra's hand, despite not knowing where the two are going. She wouldn't dare ruin the surprise for herself, though, so she keeps quiet as Catra leads her.

Tonight is going to be good, Adora is sure of it.

The night was amazing, as parties in Brightmoon usually are.

Adora got to talk to the friends she can't see on a daily basis, and met new people from other kingdoms. It still surprises her sometimes, when people are absolutely terrified of her because they think she's just like Horde Prime, but it doesn't take long for them to warm up to the blonde. Then, they realize just how kinder Adora is compared to Prime.

Unless, of course, you get on her bad side. Then you're screwed for eternity.

The people of the Fright Zone aren't terrified of Adora anymore, but there aren't many of them who would be dumb enough to go against her. While they're mostly not scared of her, the vampires know how powerful Adora is, even while not having the magic that the other kingdom leaders have.

There have been many vampires through the years that have broken Adora's peacekeeping rules, or even tried to kill her on some occasions, though. But Adora dealt with each and every one of them; whether that be by herself or with the help of her policing force. Not many of them are still alive, and the ones that are probably wish they weren't.

The vast majority of vampires across Etheria all respect Adora to the highest degree, and rarely go against her authority. Though, that's less out of fear over the punishment they'll receive and more out of the morals they've learned over the years.

There will always be some bad vampires, just like there are bad people in every kingdom, but Adora always tries to teach the bad ones how to be kind before she takes disciplinary actions.

Adora steps outside, breathing in the crisp night air and looking up at the Moonstone shining brightly above them. The pale pinks and purples shining off the runestone bask everything below it in glittering light.

The silence of the night is something Adora's always loved, but she appreciates it especially on a night like this.

"Hey, Adora."

Though, she'd take that voice over the silence any day of the week.

She whips around to see Catra, smiling warmly and looking stunning under the purple hues of the Moonstone."Hi," she says simply, not knowing what else to say.

Catra walks forward to stand beside Adora, and the two look down at the villages below the castle without saying anything.

Standing beside her wife in Brightmoon Palace, the runestone shining above them and casting cool hues on everything nearby, Adora feels grateful. So grateful for her second chance at life, but she can't deny the tiny speck of fear resting in her chest when she looks over at the softness of Catra's smile.

Being a vampire is a curse, and Adora has always known that, but it was easier to ignore the side effects of her curse when she had nothing to lose. Now, though, she has things she doesn't want to lose. People she doesn't want to lose. A life she doesn't want to lose. Adora didn't care about what she would lose when she was just a lonely vampire with only Shadow Weaver to keep her company, but that isn't the case anymore, is it?

Adora is going to have to watch everything she loves fade away like dust in the wind, just like she did with Eternia, and just like she will have to keep doing for the rest of eternity.

But… at least she doesn't have to be alone anymore.

Glimmer is immortal, too. And so is Angella, and Hordak, and all the other vampires in the Horde. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. Huntara, too. None of those people matter as much as the one beside Adora, though.

Adora turns to look at her wife.

Catra's looking down at the villages below, smiling to herself and enjoying the comfortable silence surrounding the two. Adora's reminded of when she and Catra first met. When she hurt Catra, and the horrible, gnawing guilt that followed. When she first apologized to Catra, and the slow friendship that began to bloom. When they professed their love for each other, and Adora felt Catra's lips on hers for the first time. When Adora proposed to Catra, smiling and feeling tears well in her eyes while staring up at the love of her life. When Catra said yes.

Adora can't lose that, and it makes her relieved that she never will.

Micah offered a solution to Adora and Glimmer's partners for their immortality issue. Catra and Bow, both married to immortals, didn't want to leave their wives behind. He gave them two potions which would stop their moral aging process, allowing them to live just as long as Adora and Glimmer.

At first, Adora was hesitant about Catra drinking it. What if she regretted her decision, or didn't want to be with Adora one day? Or what if the heartbreak of seeing all her other friends and family die would be too much for Catra? Adora didn't want to hurt Catra more than she already had in the past, but Catra was adamant, and so was Bow.

They were both willing to face the consequences of immortality if it meant their partners would never have to live a life without them.

Catra turns to Adora, who's still staring at her with stars in her red eyes. "What is it?" she asks, smiling and leaning into Adora's side.

If Adora is being honest with herself, "I love you" isn't enough to express how much Catra means to her. There's still so much Adora hasn't done for Catra, or said to her. She could spend her entire

life just trying to show Catra just how much she loves her, and it still wouldn't be enough.

"I just… I don't know how to explain to you how much I love you," says Adora, wishing she was better with her words.

Catra leans up to press a soft kiss to Adora's lips. Adora smiles during the kiss, and so does Catra. She doesn't think that feeling of pure happiness when kisses Catra will ever fade.

"Don't worry," Catra says, lifting a hand to rest it on Adora's cheek. "We have all the time in the world for you to explain it to me."

2/2: Adora and Finn

It's dawn, and it's raining.

Those are the first two things Adora notices while she walks through the Fright Zone. Sure, she could have used a skiff instead of walking, but it would be a waste of energy for just a small walk.

Going on walks has become a habit for Adora when she's feeling tired, or overwhelmed or just not in a good mood; and they're surprisingly helpful in calming her down. Even if it is raining, the rain isn't too heavy and the sun can be seen peeking its head just above the horizon. Besides, Adora loves the smell of petrichor.

Adora doesn't know why she decides to take a shortcut through an alley to get to the headquarters faster. She's never done so before, but something about the thin strip of road made her decide to walk down it on a whim.

Ignoring the odd decision, Adora makes a sharp turn and walks down the dark alley, where the sun doesn't reach. Long shadows

along the walls and floor remind Adora of her past mentor, and the thought sends a shiver down her spine.

Adora has a feeling she isn't alone in this dark, secluded alley.

Maybe it was a mistake walking through there. Maybe Adora should turn back. The shortcut isn't even worth i-

A squeak.

Adora whips her head around to the source of the sound—the corner of the alley, where a small mound of empty boxes rests. If Adora listens closely, she can just faintly hear the faint, but quick heartbeat of someone there. The person shuffles in their hiding spot.

With a hand on the hilt of her sword, Adora slowly inches her way to the pile. Once close enough, she tries to peek into the pile to see who's hiding, but it's far too dark for her to see, even with her heightened night vision. Adora uses her sword to push one of the boxes off the pile, and peeks down into the small box resting open in front of her.

A pair of large, blue Magicat eyes stare up at her.

Adora inhales sharply at the sight.

A young Magicat child—no older than three years old—sits in the box, with their tiny arms wrapped around their shaking shoulders. Their eyes are wide, and there's no mistaking the fear Adora sees in their eyes. Their dirty blonde hair sticks to their forehead, wet from the rain and far too messy to brush.

Adora crouches down to look at the young blonde, and can't help the sadness she feels seeing a child this young alone in a dark alley. She remembers when Shadow Weaver stabbed her and threw her outside to die, and how badly she wished someone would help her.

The Magicat's look of fear softens just slightly once they see that Adora isn't going to hurt them, but they still cower away from her in their tiny box. Adora is about to reach a hand up to grab their hand and help them out when the sun peeks out over the buildings surrounding the alley. Adora doesn't think much of it, knowing she has her Horde ring to protect her from the UV rays that would normally turn her to dust.

She doesn't think much of it until the sun hits the kitten and their skin starts burning, tears prickling in their scared eyes and mixing with the rain still falling from the sky. They cry out at the pain, trying to hide from the sun with no success.

Adora's eyes widened.

They're a vampire Magicat.

Running only on instinct, Adora takes off her red jacket and wraps it around the burning kitten. She makes sure to cover every inch of their skin with the blanket, including their ears and tail. Once the shaking child is in her arms, she stands back up and runs back to the headquarters, which she knows is close.

The child whimpers in her arms, curling in a tighter ball and leaning on Adora. "It's okay, kitten. You're going to be okay." She knows that's true, but Adora still can't help the fear she feels for the safety of the child.

Once they arrive at the headquarters, Adora moves quickly so nobody can even sneak a glance towards what's in her arms. The people in Adora's way quickly move to the side of the halls once they notice her storming down them, and Adora's never been more grateful for her status.

She rushes to the throne room, the one room in the building where nobody other than a small handful of people are allowed in.

Despite that, Adora warns the clone guards who are standing on either side of the door. "Do not let *anyone* into this room at all costs, do you understand? Not even Hordak." The guards share a

confused look, but nod their understanding. Adora feels bad ordering around so angrily like this, and she can tell they're a little scared of her when she does so, but this is urgent.

With that, Adora pushes the doors open and closes them with a slam.

While still holding the silently crying child, Adora shuts all the blinds in the room and makes sure no sunlight is making it in the room before turning on the overhead lights. She walks up the steps to her throne, and sets the kid down with the jacket still around them.

As slowly as she can, Adora pulls the jacket off their messy scruff of hair to get a look at their face.

Wide blue eyes stare back up at her, and Adora sends them a gentle smile. The Magicat curls in on themself and cowers away from the blonde's touch, making weak hissing sounds in an effort to scare Adora away from them. They even lift their hands up, tiny claws unsheathed and ready to attack.

The burns in their matted fur, paired with how adorably small the kitten is, don't make them as scary as they think they are.

Adora's soft smile only grows at their attempts to frighten her, but she still raises her hands up beside her head. The child flinches at the raised hands, and Adora's heart breaks all over again.

"Hey," she says in a whisper. "I'm not going to hurt you. See?" To further prove her point, Adora takes a step back and sits down cross-legged on the floor in front of the throne. Her hands sit idle in her lap, but she makes sure they're still visible for the kid to see.

Hesitant, the child peeks their head over the edge of the throne, staring down at Adora with their head tilted just slightly in confusion. The curious look on their face reminds Adora far too much of Catra.

The two sit there for a moment, looking at each other as the child searches for any signs that Adora will hurt them, before the child must decide that she won't. Slowly, they inch their way off the huge throne and walk towards where Adora is still sitting on the floor. Standing in front of the Horde Lord, they fidget with their hands, unsure of what to do.

"Hi," says Adora with a bright smile, fangs peeking out from under her upper lip.

Normally, children are frightened by Adora's sharp fangs and bright red eyes. They cower in fear behind their parents who try to assure them Adora won't hurt them, but it's no use. Even once they find the strength to stand in front of the blonde, they don't look her in the eyes and are ready to run at any given second.

But to the kitten, a vampire child with no parents to hide behind, Adora's sharp teeth and blood-red eyes are a reminder that the two are the same. That they're not alone on a planet that has hated their kind as long as they've existed.

The young blonde takes another step forward, and drops their hands back to their sides. They still look hesitant, but not scared anymore. They take another tiny step, and Adora opens her arms out for the kitten.

Seeing the kind look on Adora's face, completely devoid of malice, the child rushes forward to wrap their small arms around the ruler of the Horde. Adora, having expected the sudden movement, wraps her arms around the child as lightly as she can.

Maybe it's the unfamiliar comforting feeling of hug that makes the small kitten start crying.

Or maybe they know, somewhere in their head, that they *should* have had a family that loved them this whole time, but didn't.

No matter the reason, though, the child cries silently in Adora's arms while the blonde slides a hand up and down their back in the hopes that it will soothe them. After all, it's what Adora's mother used to do for her whenever she was upset as a child.

Once the cries have subsided into tiny sniffles, the kitten pulls out of the hug to look at Adora.

"Hi," says Adora again, curious if the small child can speak. "What's your name?" she asks, hoping to distract the child from their pain. The gentle tone her voice has taken is unfamiliar, even to her own ears.

The voice reminds Adora of her mom, and that thought makes her heart ache.

While waiting for an answer, Adora lifts a slow hand to wipe the tears off their face gently. The kitten leans into the gentle touch, and Adora tries not to think about how Shadow Weaver used to do the same to her. She won't be like Shadow Weaver. She would never hurt Finn.

The kitten nods their head shakily. "Hi. I- um…" They fidget with their hands again as they try to find their words. Adora sits and waits for them to finish patiently. "Finn. My-my name is Finn."

If Finn can speak, that must mean they've had at least enough interaction with adults—hopefully his parents—to speak and understand what others are saying. Though, Adora can't tell if that's a good thing or not.

Adora decides to continue her investigation. "Hi, Finn. My name is Adora. Do you know where your parents are?"

Although she doesn't want to admit it, Adora doesn't have much hope that Finn's parents are still alive. Vampire children are rare, and Magicat vampire children are even more scarce. Vampires need a special potion to be able to have children, so at the very least, Adora knows Finn likely had parents who cared for them at some point.

Considering that the alley Adora found them in was near the outskirts of the Fright Zone, Adora wouldn't be surprised if their parents were killed by one of the vampire hunters who stay near to the Horde to find and kill any lone vampires. Adora has been trying to find a way to stop the hunters for years, to no avail. Their actions are ruining vampires' lives, including Finn's.

Finn shakes their head no. Adora notices the deep frown on their face and the sheen of tears in their eyes. "No, they, um- left."

Adora's heart sinks. "Left? Are they coming back?" Maybe she should relax a little with the questions. The poor kitten looks like they're about to burst into tears again.

"They-they told me they were going to find shelter fo-for us. I- they said they were coming back. Do you know where they are?" they ask, hope shining in their eyes along with tears.

Adora sighs, willing the tears in her own eyes to not come out. She needs to be strong for Finn. "No… No, I don't. I'm so sorry, Finn." A few tears slide down Finn's face, and Adora lifts her hands to hold Finn's smaller ones. The Magicat stares down at their joined hands, and sniffles again.

They open their mouth to say something when a loud knock comes from the large throne room doors. Finn jumps at the loud sound, moving to grip Adora's arm like their life depends on it.

"Adora! Are you in there? What's going on?" the voice Adora recognizes as Hordak comes from the other side.

"Just give me a second, okay?" Adora yells back to him, and Hordak doesn't say anything else. Adora turns to look down at the kitten who still has their arms wrapped around Adora's.

"Stay here, okay? I'll be back in a minute, don't worry."

Finn's eyes widen at her words, and Adora realizes her mistake only a second after making it. "No! I'm coming with you," they say

with a huff. Adora sighs but nods, knowing the kitten won't let her leave without them.

With Finn attached to her arm, Adora makes her way down the stairs of the throne and to the large double doors leading to the room. She moves to unlock the door, but doesn't open it just yet. Instead, Adora ushers Finn over to stand beside the door so that, when she opens the door, the sunlight peering in from the halls won't touch them.

As Adora pulls the door open, she sees the fear shining in Finn's eyes as the shadows from outside make their hiding spot darker. She reaches over to hold their hand, and they squeeze her hand with their smaller one.

"Hey, Hordak," Adora says, hoping to sound casual. By the look on Hordak's face, he doesn't believe it for a second.

"That's all you have to say? 'Hey, Hordak'?" he asks, mocking her faux-relaxed voice. Adora is ashamed to admit that his impression is pretty good.

"What else would I say?"

"Maybe you could, for starters, tell me what's going on? What, you thought you could just lock me out of your throne room and expect me not to be confused? I thought we agreed to not hide anything from each other when we started ruling the Horde."

Adora picks at her lip as she considers what to do. The guilt of hiding things from her closest friend gnaws at her, but so does the concern. Adora trusts Hordak with her life, and she never lies to him about important things like this. On the other hand, though, Hordak has never been a very emotion-driven person, relying more on facts to make decisions. Adora's not sure how he'd react to a child in the Fright Zone headquarters.

Looking up at his concerned face, though, Adora knows what she has to do.

She sighs again. “Come in.” Adora squeezes Finn’s hand again, which she can feel shaking just slightly in fear as the door closes again.

Hordak walks in, his concern replaced with confusion as he looks up at the closed blinds in the large room usually basked in sunlight. “Adora, what-” Once his eyes land on the kitten who has taken to hiding behind Adora’s arm, his eyes widen more than Adora’s ever seen them.

“What is that?” he asks, and Adora isn’t sure what emotions he’s feeling.

“Say hi, Finn.”

The Magicat child peeks out further from behind Adora to wave a small, clawed hand at a bewildered Hordak.

“Why is there a… child here, Adora?” His voice is practically dripping in distaste.

“Okay look, I can explain,” she says in defence.

And so, she does. After putting Finn back up on the throne, Adora tells Hordak everything. From going into the alley, to finding Finn and bringing them back to the headquarters. Once she’s done explaining, Adora stands beside the throne where Finn is sitting as the two watch Hordak pace back and forth at the bottom of the stairs.

“Our headquarters aren’t a very suitable place for a child,” he says, still pacing.

“I know.”

“This entire *kingdom* isn’t very suitable for a child.”

“I know.”

Hordak stops pacing to look up at the two on the throne. His frown softens as he notices just how similar Adora and the kitten are, a near-identical crease in between both their eyebrows while they frown down at Hordak. With a sigh, he walks up the steps to the throne to stand in front of Adora. The kitten tenses at his advance, and Adora holds their small hand in hers.

"You know what you have to do, right?" asks Hordak, resigned.

Adora looks back at Finn, hope shining bright in their eyes. No matter how much she's grown attached to Finn in the small amount of time she's known them, she can't deny that Hordak is right. The Horde isn't a good place for a child to grow up in, especially under Adora's wing. They would be better off without her, in a family that could give them everything they want or need.

She sighs in defeat. "Yes, I do. I'll call all the nearby orphanages to see if they can take Finn in."

Despite their limited vocabulary, recognition lights up in Finn's eyes at her words. "NO!" they yell before Hordak can respond, rushing to clutch onto Adora's arm as tight as they can with their head squished beside the appendage. "I wanna stay with Adora." They pout towards Hordak, and Adora fights to hide a smile at how cute they look.

Adora is having a hard time saying no to the kitten, so she doesn't. She crouches down next to them. "Well, I have a meeting to attend in Halfmoon, but you can come with me if you want."

Finn cheers, nodding and smiling up at Adora. Once Adora stands back up, Hordak levels her with a warning look.

"Oh, don't worry so much. It's not even an important meeting."

Hordak sighs, knowing there's nothing he can do to stop Adora once she's got her mind set on something.

"If you say so."

Adora opens her hand up for the kitten to hold, and the two walk down the stairs hand-in-hand. Hordak trails behind them, still concerned about how this will all go but also noticing how well Adora and the child are getting along.

While the three walk the halls, the headquarters staff—a combination of clone and non-clone vampires—stare at Finn and whisper to one another. Finn, ever so observant, notices their murmuring and moves closer to Adora, wrapping their arm around hers. Adora glares at as many of the vampires as she can, and the ones that notice the death glare turn around and stay quiet.

Adora and Finn make their way to the skiffs, while Hordak goes back to his lab since he isn't attending the meeting. "Good luck," he says when they part ways in the halls, and Adora's not sure if he's talking about the meeting or Finn.

Before Adora and Finn get to the skiff bay, Adora quickly runs to her office—the one she barely uses but still has—to grab the smallest size of Horde ring she has available. She walks back to Finn, putting the ring on their right ring finger. The metal ring is still too big on the kitten, since you'd have to get a child-sized ring custom made, so Adora holds their hand so it doesn't fall off.

Once at the large doors leading outside, Finn stops in their tracks right before walking into the sunlight. Adora smiles knowingly at Finn's fear. "The sun won't hurt you, anymore. Make sure you don't lose that ring, and you'll be okay. See?" To prove her point, Adora walks into the sunlight and shows Finn the identical, but larger ring on her finger. Hesitant, Finn inches their way into the sunlight.

Their eyes widen when the warmth of the sun touches their arm and they don't burn. They cheer, jumping up and down in their spot in pure joy, and Adora can't help but laugh at their excitement over something so trivial to her. With that, the two board the skiff and begin the ride to the Magicat kingdom.

The ride to Halfmoon is the least exciting thing to happen that day.

At first, Finn curls up in a ball on the floor of the skiff, the wind ruffling their fur too much and overwhelming them, but eventually they get the courage to stand beside the Horde Lord.

Well, Adora does make a small detour on the way to the neighboring kingdom, though. They still have some extra time before the meeting, anyway.

Adora pulls over in a small town on the outskirts of Halfmoon, jumping out of the skiff. She carries Finn off of the metal machinery and onto the rough dirt roads, but they wince at the rocks digging into their feet.

Adora, noticing their uncomfort, wordlessly crouches down. The kitten climbs up onto her back—they're so light on Adora's back she can barely feel their weight—and the two make their way into the nearest clothing store. Does the Horde Lord with the kitten on her back get odd stares from the other shoppers in the store? Maybe, but that doesn't matter. Once Adora finds the children section of the store, she picks out a simple maroon t-shirt and grey shorts for the kitten.

Happy with their new clothes, Finn walks with Adora to the cash register holding their new clothes in their arms. They pay, and the kitten insists on going back to the changing rooms to put their new clothes on. Adora, finding it hard to say no to the kid, helps them change into the outfit.

With that, the two make their way back to the skiff. Finn is too busy looking at their outfit as they walk to notice the rough dirt roads digging into their feet.

While Adora steers the skiff to Halfmoon, she can't help but notice the way the Magicat's eyes are glued to her arms; more specifically, the dark magic scars covering her arms. They have a conflicted look on their face, as if they want to ask a question but

are too afraid to. After standing beside one another for another moment, Finn lifts a hand to tug on the side of Adora's shirt to get her attention.

Adora puts the skiff on autopilot and sits down cross-legged so that she's face-to-face with the small kitten. "Hi, Finn. What's wrong?"

A tiny finger trailed over one of the dark purple scars lining Adora's arms, like a train on its tracks. "Hurt?" they ask simply, but they don't need to say anything more for Adora to understand.

"They did, but not anymore. I got these a long, long time ago." Finn hums, as if considering this, before nodding silently.

If Adora was being honest with herself, the scars still hurt sometimes. Not physically, of course—they haven't hurt physically since she first died. They just… remind her of Shadow Weaver. They're probably the last remaining trace of the masked woman on Etheria.

After Adora took over the Horde, she made sure to destroy any evidence of Shadow Weaver's existence. Any books, scrolls, spells, anything that was connected to the dark sorceress Adora made sure to destroy. She even went back to Mystacor to destroy what was left of Light Spinner's spell room.

The irony that the only piece of Shadow Weaver left is in the person who killed her is not lost on Adora.

Even after setting fire to every last piece of her old guardian, Adora could never escape what Shadow Weaver did to her, and that used to make her so angry. She could never look in the mirror without being reminded of the masked woman, or fearing that she would turn out just like her. Even now, while helping Finn, Adora can't help but worry that she could treat Finn just like Shadow Weaver treated her. She can't help but worry that the cycle of abuse will continue, even with Shadow Weaver dead.

Adora's brought out of her thoughts by two tiny hands wiping her cheeks of tears she didn't know had fallen. "Don't cry," says Finn, and they sound so worried for the blonde that Adora can't help the wet laugh that bubbles out of her.

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to cry." Adora wipes at her eyes harder than Finn did, and she's sure everyone at the meeting will know she was crying, including Catra. Though, that doesn't bother her as much as it used to.

Finn sits down beside Adora, mimicking her sitting position and looking over at her with those bright blue eyes. "It's okay," they say, and Adora could almost laugh again at how a *child* is attempting to comfort her right now. Shouldn't it be the other way around?

The two sit beside one another, watching the trees of the Whispering Woods fly past them. The silence is comfortable, and Finn eventually leans their head on Adora's shoulder. Adora can hear their breathing slowing as the rumble of the skiff engine lulls them to sleep.

"Can I-" they pause to yawn, and Adora can't get over how cute the sound is. "Can I stay with you?"

"Hm…" says Adora, humming to herself. "Well, I'd have to ask my wife, Catra, but I have a feeling she'll like you."

Finn crawls into Adora's lap, curling up into a ball there and closing their eyes. "Okay, that's good. You're so nice, I wanna stay with you and Cata…" Adora doesn't have the heart to correct them on the mispronunciation.

"Don't worry, you're going to be okay, Finn. *We're* going to be okay."

"You promise?" asks the kitten, so quiet that Adora barely hears it.

"I promise."

Their breathing evens as they fall asleep on Adora while the blonde rakes her hands through their messy mane. Along with her promise to Finn, Adora promises herself she'll do whatever it takes to protect the young Magicat.

Along with the rumbling of the skiff engine, Adora listens to the kitten's weak, high-pitched purr as the trees pass them by.

Catra

The room is loud around her, but all Catra can focus on is the sound of her foot repeatedly tapping against the marble flooring of the meeting room.

She's probably fine. Catra shouldn't be worrying so much.

There's still five minutes until the meeting begins, but Adora is always ten minutes early to every meeting. She's never been late, in all the time Catra's known her. Everyone is already here for the meeting about agriculture or kingdom borders or whatever the fuck it's about, but Catra's too busy staring at the door waiting for her wife to show up.

Glimmer and Bow move to stand beside where Catra's seated at her mother's old seat, the one she gave to Catra once she retired.

"Hey, are you okay?" asks Bow.

"Yeah, you look like you've seen a ghost," Glimmer adds unhelpfully, but Catra can see the concern shining in her eyes.

Catra turns to the Brightmoon queen and king, deciding if she should even tell them. Sure, Glimmer and Bow are two of her best friends, but is this issue even important? Looking up at their concerned faces, though, Catra decides it is.

"Adora's late."

"Oh. If that's all, then why are you worrying so much? The meeting hasn't even started yet."

Catra sighs. "I've known Adora for over fifteen years, and she's never been late to a meeting," she deadpans.

That makes Glimmer's eyes widen, and she exchanges a look with her husband. Catra can't tell if they're more surprised about Adora never having missed a meeting or her missing a meeting today.

Bow opens his mouth to say something when the door opens and a familiar blonde walks in. Catra is about to sigh in relief when she notices another, much smaller blonde standing beside her wife. She hears Bow gasp in excitement beside her, but Catra's too busy trying to figure out who the child with Adora is to notice him.

"Aw, kitty!" he says with stars in his eyes, running over to say hi to the young Magicat.

Once Bow— followed by all the other princesses—gets to the two blondes, the kitten hugs Adora's arm tightly and hides half of themself behind her.

The small crowd surrounding them quiets down once they notice the kid's fear, their too-big ears folded against their head. Adora manages to usher them forward just a little, and the kitten gives the Princess Alliance a tiny wave before hiding again. The crowd melts at the adorable action, and Adora laughs in that shining way that always makes Catra's heart soar.

Once the confusion has passed, Catra can't get over how cute Adora and the kitten are being.

"I didn't know Adora was so good with kids," Glimmer says, and Catra doesn't have to look up to see how impressed she is. Maybe she should be defending her wife's maternal skills to Glimmer, but also-

"Yeah… neither did I."

The two watch Adora and Finn interact with the group for a moment longer before Glimmer chuckles. Catra turns her head to glare at the queen.

“What are you laughing at?” she asks, knowing exactly what she’s laughing at. Or should she say who.

Glimmer grins down at her. “The look on your face right now is priceless. Go say hi to Adora and her new friend, already.”

Catra rolls her eyes at Glimmer’s teasing, but knows she should go and see who the kid is. With that, Catra stands up and makes her way over to Adora and the kitten who is holding her hand.

The group has dissipated now, deciding to give the nervous child space, which makes this a whole lot less awkward for Catra. “Hey, Adora.”

Adora whips around at her voice, bringing the kitten along with her and smiling brightly. Catra remembers when Adora rarely used to smile because she was worried she would scare people off with her sharp teeth, and can’t help the joy she feels seeing Adora not worry about that anymore.

The kitten hides again, but Catra notices how one of their ears stands upright in curiosity while they peek out from behind Adora’s arm. “Catra! Hi, I’m sorry I was late.”

Catra waves the apology off, having forgotten about that when she caught sight of the kid latched onto her wife’s arm. “Oh, don’t worry about that. Mind introducing me to your new friend?”

Adora’s smile softens into one Catra’s never seen on her, though it’s one she recognizes from somewhere. She turns her head down to Finn, and ruffles their hair with her other arm. “You don’t have to hide. This is my wife, Catra. I told you about her, remember?”

Catra takes a couple steps forward, smiling down at the Magicat child. “Hi, Finn. It’s very nice to meet you. How’d you meet Adora, huh?”

Finn peeks out, less scared now that they know who's talking to them. They keep one hand held in Adora's, and use the other to wave to Catra. The sight makes Catra's heart melt. "Hi Cata. Adora found me in a box, and then she took me back to a big house. Then we went shopping, and then Adora cried a lot-"

"I think she gets the idea, kitten," Adora says, gently interrupting their riveting story. Finn nods silently, looking back up at Catra with the smallest of smiles. Catra raises a brow at both the name mispronunciation and the… interesting story. Adora blushes in embarrassment, whispering, "I'll tell you later."

Finn takes a step towards Catra, hope shining in their eyes. "So, can I stay with you and Adora?"

Catra's eyes widen, and she looks back up at her wife for help only to notice Adora has the same hopeful look on her face. She could almost laugh at how similar the two look, staring up at her and silently begging her to say yes.

And how could she not say yes? With how these two are looking at her, it would be cruel of her to say no. Besides, Finn has already grown on her a little, and seeing how close they've become with Adora warms her heart.

"Yes, I would love to have you stay with us, Finn."

The kitten cheers in their happy, high-pitched voice, and even rushes over to hug Catra tightly. Catra laughs, crouching down to reciprocate the hug with a warm smile. While the two hug, Catra notices how everyone in the Princess Alliance is looking over at the three with bright smiles. Some of them are even a little teary-eyed at the interaction.

Looking up at Adora, who has the same new but familiar smile on her face, Catra finally realizes where she recognizes the expression from.

Adora had shown Catra an old picture of her family, the last one she had remaining. It was burned and blurry on the edges, but

the people in the picture were still clear as day. One person that had caught Catra’s sight, though, was Marlena. Adora’s mother.

She had an identical smile as she looked down at a young Adora.

Chapter End Notes

And that's the end of this fic!

I'm a little sad to see this story go, to be honest, but I've got a lot more planned for my other Catradora fic and my other fics in the future!! Thank you so, so much for all the comments on this AU! Your comments were the main reason I didn't give up on writing this, and I can't thank you enough. Your support means so much to me :)

I'd like to specifically thank humANother for being such an amazing commentor and motivating me so, so much to keep writing this fic and my other one. They've truly been a life saver!! You can check out their beautiful artwork for this fic in Chapter 13!!

I hope anyone still reading this enjoyed, and I hope you stick around to read my other fics :) You don't have to, though, and I wish you all a good day.

Bye-bye!



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